

Hears Gray Birds' Dao De Jing

With great love and honor to my mother, my father, my grandma, my grandpa, and my two best friends

Chapter 1

道可道 {也} 非常道 {也}.

Dao can/possible/permissible Dao/pathed/spoken-of/practiced not constant/enduring/ordinary Dao.

The Dao that can be traced is not the Dao that will always be.

名可名 {也} 非常名 {也}.

Name can name not constant/enduring/ordinary name.

The names that label are not permanent names.

無名天地¹之始 {也}.

Lack/without name Heaven Earth ['s]/this beginning/start.

Nameless is the beginning of Heaven and Earth.

有名萬物之母 {也}.

Has/exist name/label ten-thousand things ['s]/this mother.

What can be named is the mother of the ten-thousand things.

故常無欲² {也} 以觀³ 其妙⁴.

As-a-result constantly without desire/expectation/craving, observe its subtleties/marvels/wonder.

So, one who stays without expectations and bias observes their subtleties,

常有欲 {也} 以觀其微⁵.

Constantly exist/have desire/expectation/craving observes its outline.

And one who constantly desires and expects observes only their outlines.

此兩者同出而異名.

These two [person/phrase] same arising but/and/yet different names.

These two attributes come from the same source yet have different names.

同謂⁶之玄.

Sameness called this/['s] mystery/[murkiness].

Their sameness is called its mysteriousness.

玄之又玄.

Murkiness [mystery] also/still/again/simultaneously murky/[translucent/dark].

Mysteriousness is itself mysterious;

眾妙之門.

Multitude subtleties/(subtle-wonders) ['s] gate/gateway

It is the gateway to the multitudes of subtleties.

¹ In Mawangdui 天地 is replaced with 萬物.

² Yu4, usually translated as desire, want, craving, hope for. Linnell thinks 欲 is really desires that control decisions and thoughts. This does not refer to a “spontaneous, unattached desire”. This seems hair-splitty. Desire is not equivalent to happiness. This could also mean preference.

³ Right side is 見 (to see/look); left side originally depicted a crested waterbird or owl with huge, hyper-alert eyes.

⁴ In Mawangdui, this 妙 is 眇, meaning to squint (make one eye small), but also something so far or so small that it cannot be seen clearly, infinitesimal, subliminal, minute and muted, subtle, and exquisite. Connotations of marvel and wonder are also associated, with both 眇 and 妙/

⁵ In Mawangdui, 微 is instead 所噉, “its/that which shout/cry/wail/call out” in line 6. Still has the connotation of something more easily accessed, obvious, unhidden

⁶ In Mawangdui, 謂 is also replaced with 胃 in line 8, but this is likely a change in character structure over time than a change in meaning. It means “stomach”, 之玄 is absent afterwards, and the 而 before that is missing (“Different names, same stomach”).--> These two emerge the same. Different names, same stomach (core/essence).

Chapter 2

天下皆知美之為美斯惡⁷已。

Below Heaven all know beauty [‘s] use/do beauty, then ugly/hateful already/finish/is-apparent⁸.

Below Heaven, if all can recognize beauty, then ugliness is known.

皆知善之為善⁹斯不善已

All know good/favorable/advantageous [‘s] use/do good/favorable, then not good already/finish

If all know the favorable as good, then what is not favorable is known.

故有無{之}相生{也},

Therefore/as-a-result, non-being being each-other produce/birth/create,

Thus, non-being and being are born from each other,

難易{之}相成{也}

Difficult easy each-other complete.

The difficult and easy complete each other,

長短{之}相較¹⁰{也},

Long short each-other juxtapose,

Long and short contrast each other

高下{之}相傾¹¹{也},

High/tall low/below each-other overturn/slant toward/incline/lean-upon.,

High and low rely upon each other.

音聲¹²{之}相和{也},

Sounds voices-and-tones/music each-other harmonize,

Musical tones and sounds can harmonize with each other,

前後{之}相隨¹³{也}

Front/before behind/after each-other pursue/follow-after.

And before and after follow each other.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage

⁷ In Mawangdui this 惡 is 亞 (secondary, junior, inferior, also possibly derived from pictogram of construction). 之 (in A) and 斯 (in A and B) is also absent in the Mawangdui versions. 斯 is also missing in the first line and replaced with 訾 in line two in Mawangdui B (meaning vilify, bad-mouth, detest, reproach), but this is most likely a mistake for 此, present in Guodian, meaning “this/here”, similar to 斯 (this/then) in Wang-Bi and Mawangdui A.

⁸ This translation of 已 is from Edwin G. Pulleyblank’s “Outline of Classical Chinese”, on pages 19 and 116, where 已 is discussed as an aspect particle after a verbless noun predicate, contrasting when 已 is used before a verb as in 已经, or in expressing “very/excessive/too” of something. It also means to stop/to finish as a verb. In this ending position, Pulleyblank maintains it has a function similar to 了 in modern Chinese, giving a sense of realization. So I translate this to “apparent”, though “observable”, “known/knowable” could also work, “obvious” may be too strong a word.

⁹ “之為善” is absent in Mawangdui A and B as well as Guodian, but the impact in meaning seems to be minimal

¹⁰ 刑 in Mawangdui texts – model, form, correct, torture or disfigure, change to the right shape, mold.

¹¹ 盈 in Mawangdui – plentiful, abundant, overfilled, sufficient, enlarged. 傾 and this share the meaning “overflow

¹² Also has a connotation of noise, or anything that can be heard, music and not.

¹³ 隋 in Mawangdui—a surname, but could be 墮- to fall from, falter, or 惰-careless, indolent, dissipated, lazy

處無為之事,行不言之教

Stays/secluded¹⁴ non-action ['s] affairs, transmit/walks/move/engage no words/speak ['s] teaching(s).

Stays alone with business of non-action, transmits the teachings unspoken.

萬物作¹⁵焉而不(始¹⁶/辭)

Ten-thousand things devise/create/start/rise from-this, and/yet not (start//explain/express/refuse)

Ten-thousand things arise from this, and yet it is unexplained.¹⁷

生而不有¹⁸,為而不恃

Born and/yet not have/possessed/existing¹⁹, being/acting and/yet not confident/depending/relying,

Born but without ownership, doing but without being depended on,

功成而弗居

Work/accomplishment/excellence complete/achieve/accomplishments, and/yet not settled/dwelling.

Completing accomplishments, yet not dwelling in them.

夫唯弗居

In-any-case who/which, only not settling/dwelling,

For anyone, only those not settling in the results

是以不去

This by-means-of not leave.

By means of this have results that do not leave.

¹⁴ This 處 character is often translated as “manages”, or “lives by”, but I have seen no evidence in dictionaries or grammar books so far to suggest this character has this meaning at this time period (Warring States), though there is evidence for this meaning later. I have seen the meanings of “pause, stop, cease (from)”, and alternatively this line could be translated as “Stops without ado his affairs, implements without words their teaching(s).” The most recent form is 处 (place, to be situated at, to stay). Both the Mawangdui and Guodian instead have 居

¹⁵ 昔 in Mawangdui B, formerly, long ago, yesteryear (can also be night standing in for 夕. Can also mean rise, stand up, raise up, organize, begin, compose.

¹⁶ From Mawangdui B

¹⁷ Alternatively “The sage arises ten-thousand things, and refuses them nothing.” (similar to Chan, Wu, Waley, Lin)

¹⁸ 生而不有 only occurs in the Wang Bi.

¹⁹ Also translated as “creating but not possessing”. 生 means both “alive, to live, to exist” and “cause to live, bring into existence, give birth to.” Weirdly enough, this could kind of be translated as “born but not existing”.

Guodian (A:9)

天下皆智 (𠂔²⁰/美)之為²¹美也, (𡗗/亞²²) (已/已)

Below heaven all know finest this[‘s] do/use finest, inferior/second-rate already/finish/complete

Under heaven when all consider the finest as the finest, there is already inferior.

皆智善²³此,其²⁴不善已.

All know excellent/good/favorable this/here its/likely not favorable/skilled already/complete/finish.

(When) all know excellence here, its non-excellence is complete.²⁵

(又/有) 亡之相(𡗗²⁶/生)也

Having/existence loss/disappearance/lack [‘s]/this each-other produce/birth

Presence and absence create each other,

(𡗗/難) (𡗗/𡗗)²⁷ 之相 (𡗗/成²⁸)也

Fear/dread guardedness/anxiety/alertness [‘s]/this each-other complete.

Fear and guardedness complete each other,²⁹

(𡗗/長) (𡗗/𡗗)³⁰ 之相 (𡗗³¹/形) 也

Long/old/mature/developing and sprouting/starting [‘s] each-other mold/shape/outline/contrast/form

Maturing and sprouting shape each other,

²⁰ In zi.tools 𡗗 as 𡗗 to the left of 𡗗 (or 𡗗 to the left of 女), though Cook and Henricks put 𡗗. This character is often just treated as 美 (beauty, lovely, fine(st) of the best quality, excellent, so everywhere in this chapter there is 美, it is 𡗗. However, the Shuowen Jiezi (according to zi.tools), though 𡗗 alone is related to 美, the complete 𡗗 → 𡗗 + 𡗗 → 𡗗 (subtle, tiny, between being and non-being, secret). However, zi.tools does claim that 𡗗 → 𡗗 + 女 → 𡗗 → 美, and “beautiful” makes more sense in context here. Compare with 𡗗 → 𡗗 found in B:3, and see C:3.

²¹ 之為, taken together, is a compound in Classical Chinese, so X 之為 Y can be translated as “X’s being Y”, so in this case it would be “beauty being beauty”. Another translation of 之為 is “considered as/to be”.

²² Here, technically 亞 around 十 according to zi.tools. This character 亞 was likely originally the overhead view of construction, likely a 亞 shaped tomb. Kroll’s dictionary defines it as “next in order, secondary, junior; inferior”.

²³ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”. The moral benevolence reading came later, with Confucius, Mencius. So think of this as “skilled” or “talented”.

²⁴ Equivalent of 其 is 𡗗, how it always appears in the Guodian. Here for 此其: all other versions simply read 斯 (this), 此 may be grammatical, or it’s just “this-this” or “this itself”. This likely doesn’t change the meaning.

²⁵ Alternatively “When all know (it/ something) as good, (its) not-good (aspect) already (exists).”

²⁶ Missing middle stroke.

²⁷ Cook and Henricks, and most people assume this means 易, and the heart radical added to suggest the sense of mental/emotional states for difficult and easy. That feels like back-reading to me – the heart radical in the first character makes it “fear”. Much of the Guodian has concerned minding one’s body, one’s nature, internal and in the world. Describing the psychological and physical manifestations of the protective response does not come out of nowhere in the Guodian. While this doesn’t appear to fit the whole “opposites” pattern, that logic is not convincing enough for me to dismiss the character choice here. See A:8 as well.

²⁸ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 𡗗. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

²⁹ More specifically, psychological fear/dread and physical arousal/alertness/guard complete each other.

³⁰ Meanings include point of true beginning, end point, aspect, contingency, straight, and careful. Shuowen Jiezi says this is the “initial growth of things”, with the bottom part being roots and the top being shoots. Most translations have 短 (short, to 長 long). I’m not finding an etymology that links the two 𡗗 together—it may be phonetic.

³¹ Technically 𡗗 over 土 as listed in zi.tools, 𡗗, contrast with B:5’s 𡗗

(高)下之相(淫/盈)³²也,

High low [‘s]/this each-other fill-out/overflow/expand

High and low fill each other up,

(音)聖³⁴之相(和)也,

Tone/music sound/messages/noise/speech//paragon/sage [‘s]/this each-other harmonize

Tones of music and clear hearing³⁵ can harmonize with each other,

(先)(後/後)之相(墮/墮)³⁶也。

First/front/prior/before and rear/after [‘s] each-other collapse/drop/fall-into

Before and after collapse into each other.

是以聖人(居)亡為之事,

This by-means-of sage resides/stays/rests without use/do/manipulate [‘s]/this business/serve

By means of this the sage dwells in the business they do not do,

行不言之(教/教)³⁷。

Transmit/walks/move/engage without words [‘s]/this teachings

Transmits teachings they do not speak,

萬(勿/物)作³⁸而弗³⁹(殆/殆)⁴⁰也,

Ten- thousand things create/organize/start/arise, but not danger/peril

Lets arise the ten thousand things without danger,⁴¹

³² 淫 Literally means mud under water. In other Chu writings, 淫 has meant “expanding, filling, fill-out a space (Elsewhere in Laozi A, Hengxian, Guanzi in Zhouhe), as a stand-in for 盈 .

³³ Actually written as 立 over 田, which would mean livestock. Zi.tools has this as 音, as does everyone else.

³⁴ 聖 = 聖 This character, later “noise”, means peerless, paragon, possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. It is meant as sage, the same character, later in this very chapter. I read it as “Hear correctly” or “hearing clarity”; and so the sage (聖人) is “person who hears clearly.”

³⁵ Because 聖 also means “master practitioner of an art” (Kroll), you could read this as “music and the musician”.

³⁶ Very technically, [β to the left of (土 over 田)] all over 土, reflected by zi.tools (listed under 墮). This probably means “to destroy”, “to fall”, or “to press into the earth”, especially of a city wall or sacrifice.

³⁷ See A:6 Could also be 學 (mimic, imitate, emulate, learn), but this doesn’t change the connotation of studies/teachings. Zi.tools also has 孝. Wiktionary lists 孝 and 孝 as a variant of 教, but Shuowen Jiezi equates 孝 with 放 (release, abandon, expel, exile, cast aside, put down, fully revealed (open and expressed fully), set-free, act with no constraints), but also follow and adhere to according to 說文解字注.

³⁸ Original has 又 under right part, expressed in zi.tools as 𠂇 to the left of 𠂇. Different from A:7 and A:13, this extra 𠂇 is unique. I’m not clear on why the scribe would add it, but it may contribute to the meaning.

³⁹ In this chapter, in the form of 𠂇.

⁴⁰ 𠂇/ 𠂇? Both Henricks and Cook have this as 𠂇. Zi.tools has this as 𠂇 to the left of 𠂇 around 一 = 𠂇 (which is the most accurate in my opinion). Meanings range from 殆 (danger (危, from Shuowen Jiezi); 漢語同源詞大典: broken-down/deteriorated/decayed (Analects: doubtful), 治 (to control, to harness, to manage, to govern, to channel like water), 怠 (slow, leisurely, sluggish; 漢語同源詞大典: exhausted, fatigue; I find this one unlikely as there were already 怠 used in the Guodian and they do not look that similar: 𠂇 vs 𠂇 from here), 怡 (joyous, harmonious), 辭 (governance, to govern through law/litigation), and 貽 (to give as a gift), at least by zi.tools under 𠂇. I find 殆 or 治 most likely, and even these raise multiple possibilities. See also A:6 (𠂇)

⁴¹ Or, if 治. “The ten thousand things arise, but [the sage does] not govern/harness them” or “The ten thousand things arise, but are not controlled.” If 殆: “The ten thousand things arise, but are not endangered/deteriorated (by the process),” or “The ten thousand things arise, but [the sage does] not endanger them,” or “Creates the ten thousand things without breaking down (himself) / endangering them.”

為而弗志也，

Doing/using and/yet not intend/remember/record/command/expect/aspire

Doing, and yet not aspiring.⁴²

(埜⁴³/成)而弗居

Accomplishing/completing/becoming/developing but not resting/dwelling/inhabiting

Completing but not settling in the finished work⁴⁴.

天(隹⁴⁵)弗居也，

Heaven/sky although not rest/dwell,

Although Heaven does not settle in its actions,

是以弗(去/去)也。

This by-means-of not depart/leave/go away

By means of this, the actions do not leave.

⁴² Could alternatively be “Acting, but not expecting/intending [the results or any particular thing]. This could also be read as “Acts without intending”; this comes off as “acts carelessly” in English. The Shuowen Jiezi this “direction of the heart” is described as aspirations or ambitions rather than intentions writ large. So, “Acts without the heart pointed in any direction/ set on anything” may be more precise. “Acts but does not record” is also a reading that could stand—doing but without feeling the need to have any of it go down in history.

⁴³ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 埜. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it’s a phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁴⁴ There’s a dwelling/city theme here. “The sage builds the city walls, but does not dwell within the city” is a more imaginative way of trying to encapsulate this, but it is stretchy with the original wording.

⁴⁵ 隹 literally means short-tailed bird. This instance is faded or cut off at the bottom. Likely a phonetic loan for 唯/惟, both of which have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 惟 also means “to consider, to contemplate, think of”.

Chapter 3

不尚賢

Not exalting/surpassing worthy/admirable⁴⁶

Not idolizing the admirable

使民不爭

Causes/allows people not vie/contest/quarrel

Causes people not to become competing rivals.

不貴難得之貨

Not prizing/valuing/seeing-as-precious difficult to-obtain (rare)[‘s] goods/items

Not valuing items difficult to obtain as precious

使民不為盜

Causes/allows people not act-as/use/do thieves.

Causes people not to act as thievish.

不見可欲

Not seeing can crave/hope-for/desired

Not seeing what can be craved

使民心不亂

Causes/allows people hearts not be-confused/troubled/become-disordered/rebel.

Allows people’s minds to be free of trouble.

是以聖人之治{也}

Therefore, sage [‘s] governance/management/ordering/focus

Therefore, the sage’s governance

虛其心實其腹

Empty their heart/minds[s?], fills/full their stomach/inner-feelings

Empties their hearts and minds, fills their stomachs,

弱其志強其骨

Weakens/lessens their goals/aspirations/will/ambition, strengthens/forced/vigorous their bones,

Weakens their ambitions, strengthens their bones,

常使民無知無欲{也}

Always causing/allowing people lack/without knowledge lack/without desire/craving,

Always allowing the people to be without knowledge and cravings,

使夫智⁴⁷者不敢為⁴⁸也

Causing/allowing anyone/in-any-case wisdom⁴⁹ not dare act-as/do/use.

And causing anyone with wisdom not to dare act.

為無為⁵⁰則無不治[矣]

Act ‘non-action’, when-then lack/without/no not govern/harness/manage [!]

When acting in accordance with non-action, then nothing is ungoverned!

⁴⁶ 尚 also can translate to “surpass, go beyond in excellence”. So this could mean “not surpassing the admirable”.

This word can ALSO translate into “still, yet, even”, so “Not even admirable” is also technically possible.

⁴⁷ 知 in Mawangdui B – knowledge, I guess in this sense, intelligence in the tactical sense.

⁴⁸ 弗 in Mawangdui B- not – likely a typo?

⁴⁹ The 夫 X 者 construction, by Kroll’s dictionary, under “者”, explains this can mean “generally any instance of X”

⁵⁰ In Mawangdui B, 無為 is replaced with 而已, also adds 矣 (Act and finish, then nothing is not managed!)

Chapter 4

道冲⁵¹而用之或不⁵²盈{也}

Dao empty/sublime, and/yet use/employ ['s]/this some/sometimes/perhaps no overflow/fullness.

Dao is empty, yet in using this, perhaps, it cannot overflow.

淵兮似⁵³萬物之宗

Deep/profound/vortex/whirlpool/bottomless! Seems-like ten thousand things ['s] ancestor/venerated.

It's bottomless! Seeming like the ancestor of the ten-thousand things,

挫⁵⁴其銳

Crushing/humbling/weakening their/its⁵⁵ sharpness/precision/high-training/sharp point(s),

Weakening their sharpness,

解其紛

Unties/unknots/loosens their/its tangled-threads,

Loosening up and unbounding their tangled threads,

和其光

Harmonizes/balances their/its shining/light/luster/glory,

Balances their shining lights,

同其塵

Shares/sameness/unites/meets their/its dust/worldly/mundane.

Joins their dust.

湛兮似⁵⁶或存

Deep/motionless/crystal-clear! Like maybe/sometimes exists/survives/preserved.

Deep and still! Seeming like, maybe, it is preserved.

吾不知誰之子{也}

I not know who ['s]/this child

I don't know whose offspring

象帝之先

Imitates/resembles highest-god ['s] first/prior/priority/in-front

Can resemble the most primordial predecessor of the highest god.

⁵¹ Mawangdui has 盅 (by Linnell): goblet, cup, empty.

⁵² 或不 is 有弗 in Mawangdui B.—have/exist not

⁵³ 兮似 is replaced with 呵始/佖 (A/B respectively). Shout-start? Don't really know about this.

⁵⁴ 挫 in Mawangdui—cookpan, wok.

⁵⁵ 其 is translatable as any possessive thing, e.g. her, his, their, its, similar I guess to the Russian себе or any other marker of ownership. It's widely assumed the Dao is [verb]ing the object of the ten-thousand things, and the sage is [verb]ing the object of the people, but the Dao could be [verb]ing its own object, and same thing with the sage. It's hard to know which it is, so in my translation I try to leave room for both possibilities. The Dao is self-regulating... and when I use "their" for the sage, it is for gender neutrality.

⁵⁶ 佖 in Mawangdui B, could be 始

Chapter 5

天地不仁

Heaven Earth not humane/kind/benevolent

Heaven and Earth are not benevolent,

以萬物為芻狗

By-means-of ten-thousand things act-as/do/use straw-dogs⁵⁷

Using the ten thousand things as disposable.

聖人不仁

Sage not humane/kind/benevolent

The sage is not benevolent,

以百姓⁵⁸為芻狗

By-means-of hundred surnames⁵⁹ for/as straw-dogs.

Using the people as disposable things.

天地之間

Heaven Earth [‘s]/this space/between,

The space between Heaven and Earth,

其猶橐籥乎⁶⁰

[Is possibly/how is it]⁶¹ similar-to (bag-pipe →)bellows(that blast air) (?/!)

How can it be like a bellows?

虛而不屈⁶²

Empty yet not curled/reduced/diminished/bent/made-submissive/exhausted/wronged,

Empty, and so not diminished,

動而愈⁶³出

Moving/shifting yet/and increasingly/even-more producing/expending/put forth/leave/go-out.

Moving, and so producing even more.⁶⁴

多言⁶⁵數窮

Exceed/accrue/many/more words counts/frequently/often/figures expends/spent/to-the-end,

Many words often exhausts. / More words count only toward exhaustion/one’s limit.

不如守⁶⁶中

Not-following/inferior-to guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by inner/center/core/middle.

Not better than maintaining one’s center.

⁵⁷ Sacrificial object, disposable after use.

⁵⁸ In Mawangdui A, 省- scrutinize, discern, reflect, recall, realize, diminish, reduce, spare, save, cancel, skinny.

⁵⁹ the people, esp. common

⁶⁰ In Mawangdui and Guodian, 與, probably meant as a blend of 乎 and 也

⁶¹ 其, besides possessive nature, is used as “perhaps”, “maybe”, “likely”, or with 乎 at the end, “are likely...?” or “how...?”, indicating incredulity, subjectivity, uncertainty. 乎 itself indicates a question OR an exclamation.

⁶² 澀 in Mawangdui texts, also can mean exhausted, but also stir up, agitate, circulate, muddy, plunge into, used up

⁶³ 俞 in the Mawangdui texts,--“approved!” “agreed!”, reply.

⁶⁴ Linnell, Wu, Lau, Lin, and Feng & English have “the more it works, the more comes out of it.” Chan has “when active, it produces even more.” Henricks has “Move it and more always comes out.” Cleary has similar. Waley has “Work it, and more comes out.” Linnell has

⁶⁵ 聞 in the Mawangdui texts – hear, make heard, rumors, hearsay, reputation, renown. Similar in meaning

⁶⁶ 於 inserted in Mawangdui texts here, to/from/with regard to, or likely grammatical. 若 instead of 如 on same line

Guodian (A:12)

天地⁶⁷之外⁶⁸,

Heaven Earth [‘s]/this outside/beyond

Beyond Heaven and Earth,

其(𠂇/猷/猶)(𠂇⁶⁹/舊)(簞/簞)⁷⁰(𠂇/與)⁷¹?

Its/maybe plan/design/method/like/similar-to old loom’s-bamboo-shuttle, is-it-not/grant/join? ⁷²

Isn’t it like an old loom’s bamboo shuttle?

(𠂇/虛)而不(𠂇/屈),

Empty/depleted/stretched-thin/subtle/humble, and/yet not exhausted/used up/bent/curled

Empty, yet inexhaustible,

(𠂇/通)⁷³而(𠂇/愈)⁷⁴(𠂇/出)。

Moving, yet/and increasingly/heal go/emerge/produce/emanate/send/expel/reach-beyond/exceed.

Moving and in doing so producing even more.

⁶⁷ Technically 陀 over 土, 望

⁶⁸ 𠂇 Cook has this as 𠂇, zi.tools has 外 better and indeed they seem to mean the same things, but it is not a perfect match and zi.tools doesn’t have 𠂇 in Chu script, but lists its meaning as 外 as well.

⁶⁹ Originally 𠂇, maybe the leather bag indicated by 橐. Maybe best expressed as 𠂇? Cook and Henricks have this as 𠂇 inside 𠂇, but I honestly do not see it (𠂇=𠂇). Listed in zi.tools as 𠂇 (old (as 舊), (Wiktionary has prisoner, 囚) [Also worth mentioning that 𠂇 and 𠂇 is an alternative form of 𠂇, though most forms of this in Chu script have a cross on the first vertical, not the second as it is here, see zi.tools: 𠂇 from the 望山 is listed but it is the odd one out]. Also may related to 𠂇 (top of a baby’s head, known as fontanelle before bones fuse). I select as 𠂇 (old (as 舊, though see A:18;s 𠂇, B:1’s 𠂇), similar to 久, mostly because it makes the most sense – the character identification on this one is iffy.

⁷⁰ Maybe 管? 簞? 簞? 簞 is much closer. Couldn’t help feeling like this is 竹 over 𠂇 over 𠂇, and indeed I was close. Zi.tools has this as 簞 (𠂇 over 簞), a bamboo shuttle on an old fashioned loom.

⁷¹ Can also mean to give to/grant to, to be associated with, but also a blend of 乎 and 也 when ending sentences. Normally I translate this as “join/joining”, or “grant/give” in A:18

⁷² Very untraditional translation on my part. The 𠂇 is very ambiguous and to write it off just as 橐 seems to me a bit of a stretch, given what the character looked like in other Warring States kingdoms at the time. The definition associated with its shape that macks most sense is “old”, so we end up with “the bamboo shuttle on an old loom.”

⁷³ 𠂇 According to zi.tools, equivalent to 動, listed under 通

⁷⁴ 𠂇 In zi.tools, listed under 愉 for some reason – the heart radical is undoubtedly on the bottom. A little troubling, as the 愈 character itself is, by Wiktionary and zi.tools, an alternative form of 癒 meaning “cured (of an illness).” This line, therefore could also perhaps be translated as “Moving, and in doing so, healingly emerges/emanates.” I find this reading weaker, and not thematically different than increasing production. See also B:5 (𠂇)

Chapter 6

谷神不死

Valley/cave/chasm spirit/god/deity not dead/inert/finished.

The cave spirit is not dead and still.

是謂玄牝

This called translucent/mysterious/unknowable/dim/murky female/valley.

This is called the Mysterious Female.

玄牝之門

Mysterious female/valley [’s]/this gateway

The Mysterious Female’s gateway

是謂天地[之]根

This called Heaven Earth [’s]/this root/base.

This is called the root of Heaven and Earth.

绵绵若存

Far-and-finely-threaded/continuous/unbroken, as/like ⁷⁵ exist/survive/preserved/thought-of

Continuously, as though preserved,

用之不勤

Use/employ [’s]/this not struggling/toiling/laboring.

Employing this is not to struggle and labor.

⁷⁵ 若 has “seems” as a modern meaning, but pre-classically it meant “agree, conform to”, and as an adverb “thus”. Classically, it can mean “like” as a verb, “if”, or “that kind of”.

Chapter 7

天長地久

Heaven long/enduring, Earth enduring/longstanding,

Heaven and Earth are long enduring.

天地所以能長且久者

Heaven Earth that-which able long-enduring even/and/or/shall complete long-lasting [person/phrase]

What gives Heaven and Earth the ability to be long enduring and long lasting,

以其不自生

By-means-of not for/of themselves live/born/create.

Is that they do not live for themselves.

故能長生

Therefore can long live.

So, they can live long lives.

是以聖人

This by-means-of, the sage,

By means of this, the sage

後其身而身先

After/behind its body/person/self, yet self/body first/in-front/priority/prior

Puts themselves behind, yet ends up first,

外其身而身存

Outside/beyond its self/body, yet self/body survive/exists/sought/thought-of/preserved/kept-safe.

Puts themselves outside⁷⁶, yet is still preserved.

非以其無私邪

Not⁷⁷ by-means-of its no/lack private/personal-bias/self-interest irregular/perverse/bias/hmm?

Is it not by their lack of self-interest, hmm?

故能成其私。

Thus/therefore/as-a-result ability/capable achieve their self-interest/private?

Thus, they can achieve their self-interest.

⁷⁶ 外 is translated often as “extraneous” and “accidental”, but I can find no evidence to support this meaning.

⁷⁷ 非 I did not see a rhetorical use for this character in my reading, but nearly every translation I have seen turns this couplet into a rhetorical question. This is because of 邪, a Warring States era final interrogative particle, with a sense of a rhetorical shrug or a sarcastic, sharp “is that so?”

Chapter 8

上善若水

The high/above good/excellence/skill/virtue like water

The highest good is like water,

水善利萬物而不爭

Water excels/improves smoothly/swiftly/benefit ten-thousand things, yet not contend/quarrel/contest,

Water skillfully benefits ten-thousand things, yet does not contend.

處眾人之所惡

Staying/residing-in/occupying multitude/crowd people [’s] place(s)/that-which ugly/hateful/abhorrent

Staying in places hated by the multitudes of people,

故幾於道[矣]

So/therefore/as-a-result latent/invisible/nearly/few/imminent-danger to/from/at/regarding Dao [!]

Therefore, nearly at the Dao!

居善地

Situating/dwelling, goodness/excellence/skill Earth

To reside excellently is Earth,⁷⁸

心善淵

heart/mind, goodness/excellence/skill deep/profound/vortex/whirlpool/bottomless

To think and feel excellently is profound depth ,

與善仁

Join/give/grant/unite goodness/excellence/skill humane/benevolence

To give excellently is benevolence,

言善信

Talk/speak/words, goodness/excellence/skill trust/faith/reliable/trustworthy

To speak excellently is to be trustworthy,

正善治

Norms/correctness/rectify, goodness/excellence/skill govern/harness/control⁷⁹

To correct excellently is to govern,

事善能

Business/to-serve/matters, goodness/excellence/skill ability/competence/prowess.

To serve excellently is to be capable.

動善時

Movement/shifting/action, goodness/excellence/skill season/timeliness/opportunity/time

To move excellently is to be timely..

夫唯不爭,故無尤

In-any-case/man only not vying/contesting/quarreling, therefore/as-a-result no blame/fault/error

Wherever there is no dispute, as a result there is no blame.

⁷⁸ This is translated in quite a few ways, and it’s the same way with the rest of the lines until the end. Linnell has “In dwelling, the virtue is the land. (Henricks has very similar.)” Wu has “In choosing your dwelling, know how to keep to the ground. (Feng & English have very similar.)” Lau has “In a home it is the site that matters.” Lin has “In his dwelling (the Sage) loves the Earth. (Chan has very similar.)” Clear has “Where it [assuming this is water/the Dao?] dwells becomes good ground.”

⁷⁹ 治 means quite a bit (see Kroll): put in order, govern, heal/ cure, work, solve, organize, set right, pay attention to—nowhere do I find “just” or “honest”. The common theme is control, management

Chapter 9

持而盈之

Hold/maintain/restrain and abundant/overfull/plentiful it/['s]

To restrain and overfill something,

不如其已

Not like/(not)-better-than it/maybe complete/stopping/being-finished/already.

Is not better than stopping when completed.⁸⁰

揣而銳⁸¹之

Sharpen/hammer/measure and sharpen[ed]/acute/hone[d]/highly-precise it

Hammer and acutely sharpen it,

不可長保⁸²

Cannot long persist/protect/sustain

It cannot persist for long.

金玉滿⁸³堂⁸⁴

Gold jade full/brimming/permeate/fulfill/complete halls/dais/plateau

Halls brimming with gold and jade

莫之能守

None/in-no-case this/['s] able/capable/can guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by

No one can protect these.

富貴而驕

Opulent/rich/wealth/abundant value/costly/expensive/precious and/yet/but arrogance/haughtiness/pride

Wealthy, valued, and yet being lofty and proud,⁸⁵

自遺其咎

Itself/Naturally neglect/reject/bestow/leaves-behind their fault/calamity/blame

Itself bestows calamity.

功遂身退

Work/accomplishment/excellence progress/further/succeed/comply-with oneself/body withdraw

Upon success in one's work, one withdraws,

天之道

Heaven/sky ['s]/this way

It is the way of heaven.

⁸⁰ This couplet has been translated a number of ways: “To overfill a vessel is not better than having it unfilled” (Legge), “Rather than fill to the brim by keeping it upright, better to stop in time” (Lau), “Stretch a bow to the full and you will wish that you had stopped in time” (Waley), “Holding and filling it is not as good as stopping short” (Linnell). 已 means “already”, “stop”, “finish”, “complete”. The connotation of enough (rather than excess) as being better is lost in some translations. “Stopping early” implies abortion before completion, but 已 does not.

⁸¹ Cook points out this character was replaced in some Wang Bi versions (稅, wooden cane, club; or 銳 meaning acute) In the Mawangdui B has “掄而允之”. See Scott Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 283, and the Guodian translation below

⁸² 葆 in Mawangdui- lush, thickly growing, conceal

⁸³ 盈 in Mawangdui- abundant, overfull, overflowing

⁸⁴ 室 in Mawangdui—inner chamber, room, see Guodian below

⁸⁵ This line has a lot of variation in translations. Wu has “Set s tore by your riches and honor, and you will reap a crop of calamities.” Lau has “To be overbearing when one has wealth and position is to bring calamity upon oneself.” Chan has similar, “to be proud with honor and wealth is to cause one’s downfall”

Guodian (A:20)

(𣎵/柴/困)⁸⁶ 而 (湴/盈)⁸⁷ 之,

Bound/constricted/arduous/exhausting and/yet filling/overflow/fullness,

Constraining it and filling it up,

不不⁸⁸若⁸⁹(𠄎/已)⁹⁰。

Not(x2) like/if finishing/completing/stopping/already

Not better than being finished.

湍⁹¹ 而(𠄎/羣)之,

Rapid-waters/torrent/wave/collide/smash-into and group/crowd/gather/teeming this/[‘s]

Smashing into it and crowding it⁹²

不可⁹³長保也。

Can not long protect/guard/persist/conserve/sustain

It cannot be sustained for long⁹⁴.

金玉(湴/盈)室,

Gold jade fill/overflowed inner-chambers/room/house

Chambers overflowing with gold and jade,

(豸/莫)能(獸⁹⁵/守)也。

In-no-case/no-one can beast/wild animal/hunt//keep-safe/to-ward/maintain/protect/defend/hold-to

No one is able to defend them.⁹⁶

⁸⁶ 𣎵 Cook and Henricks has 柴; Zi.tools renders this 𣎵(之) over 木, (for zi.tools, also 持 (By the Shuowen Jiezi: 槌(strike, hammer), as mallet or horizontal beam). Received has 持 (hold in hand, support, bear up, maintain, restrain), perhaps itself in place of 序(store up, stock, reserve), but this could also be 殖 (generate, breed, cultivate, implant, trade), or 植 (plant in the ground, growth of plants, implant), and Mawangdui has 植(throw, pitch, send). Cook suggests 柴 could be an ancient form of 困. The wood component of this character is very prominent. 𣎵 being a form of 之 (to go) (and very visually similar to 止), over wood, maybe this means to support, like a wooden bridge, or restrain, like a wooden pen for livestock. This ends up looping back to 柴 being an ancient form of 困, which the Shuowen Jiezi through Zi.tools agrees with. Visual similarity supports 柴→困. (See A:14.)

⁸⁷ 湴 Literally means mud under water. In other Chu writings, 湴 has meant “expanding, filling, fill-out a space (Elsewhere in Laozi A, Hengxian, Guanzi in Zhouhe), as a stand-in for 盈.

⁸⁸ This is how it appears on the Guodian bamboo strips themselves. Scott Cook seems to believe the duplication is superfluous and without meaning, maybe a scribe’s mistake. The structure of the fourth line would support this, and the characters are written out—there is no duplication mark like =. If we read this with the double-negative, this could be “It’s not the case that this is better than being finished.” I guess it is a mistake, based on the above logic.

⁸⁹ This one looks a bit different: 𠄎, most look like 𠄎, but there are many variants of 若 so this isn’t suspicious.

⁹⁰ Listed as 巳 (6th earthly branch, snake) in zi.tools, which lists 巳 as equivalent. Some variation, but all forms look like 𠄎 or 𠄎 or the present 𠄎.

⁹¹ 湍→湍 is in the original, but 湍 or 湍(heavy dew, soaked) are both possible transformations, among yet others.

See Scott Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 283. Warring States Chu were familiar with dams and hydraulic constructions. The imagery of holding back rushing, churning waters would be familiar to a Chu scribe. Kroll has 湍 as rapids, swift water current, torrent/torrential, billow, also smash into, collide, clash, dash against.

⁹² In case it is of any value, my initial translation was “Like flood waters smashing into and gathering against it,”

⁹³ The character in here has an extra dash over it.

⁹⁴ Or, “Rushing them wildly and forcing them into a tight crowd, they cannot hold their defensive line for long.”

⁹⁵ 獸 Originally 單 to the left of 犬, almost certainly meaning 獸.

⁹⁶ Technically this could also be “no one is able to hunt them (the halls of gold and jade).” Or it could be no ruler can leave their house to hunt and expect not to be plundered?

貴(𡗗/福/備)⁹⁷(喬/驕)⁹⁸

Value/costly/precious blessings/good-fortune/favored//procure/prepare/complete high/lofty//arrogant
Valuing complete loftiness and pride⁹⁹,

自遺¹⁰⁰(𡗗/咎)¹⁰¹也。

Self/voluntarily/spontaneously neglect/ignore/reject/lose/bestow/leaves-behind calamity/unlucky/fault
Itself bestows calamity.

攻(述¹⁰²/述)身(𡗗¹⁰³/復/退),

Attack/revile/work-at-by-hitting follow/recount/rehearse/describe body/self go-back/withdraw
Strike following precedent, withdrawing oneself¹⁰⁴

天之道也。

Heaven/sky [’s]/this Way/Dao.

Is the way of Heaven.

⁹⁷ 𡗗 zi.tools has 酉 over 示, compare with A:15. In zi.tools, this is defined 福 (good fortune, favored, blessed). This lacks the roof (宀) over 酉 that comprises 富 according to the evolution of this character. 福 itself seems odd to be here, but the Shuowen Jiezi (through zi.tools) defines it not just as 祐 (blessed) but also as 備 (procure, prepare for, make ready, prudent, careful, complete, thorough, full)

⁹⁸ 𡗗 Listed as 九 over 高 in zi.tools (but only under 喬). High/tall/hook-tipped/upturning (or disguise), but often used in place or as interchangeable of 驕, which means haughty, arrogant, proud

⁹⁹ Alternatively, “Expensive [things], good fortune, and loftiness,” but this would be using 貴 in an adjective sense without having a subject. I also tried “Valuing and preparing for loftiness.” “Valuing procuring loftiness” also works grammatically.

¹⁰⁰ 𡗗 (= 遺 in Baoshan, 遺 in Tianxingguan), zi.tools, Henricks, and Cook have 遺. It looks much different than 貴, which is 貴. Its meanings are many: left undone, ignore, neglect, omit, lose, let fall, leave behind, drop, bequeath (sort of the odd one out), and to urinate involuntarily. Also send or deliver to. Shuowen Jiezi has 从辵賢聲, though inside looks like 與: 貝+與 was an early form of 貴

¹⁰¹ 𡗗 Listed in zi.tools as 咎各刃, normally 咎 looks like 咎, all of this is listed under 咎

¹⁰² 述 The Shuowen Jiezi recalls that it is used in the context “the father does, the son follows”. This word has a sense of tradition attached to it, doing what has already been done. Describing past events, following established patterns.

¹⁰³ 𡗗 Listed as 復 in zi.tools (𡗗 under 退), should be instead 𡗗 𡗗 日各(𡗗). All on the 復 page, all variants of 退.

See also B:5 (𡗗)

¹⁰⁴ This could also be “Attacking, following the body, and withdrawing”, or “Whether attacking or following, the body withdraws” or “Discredit/Attack tradition, withdraw the body.” This line can go many directions. It can alternatively go “Follow craftsmanship/workmanship, withdraw the body.” Perhaps this is more figurative, like “attack [the urge to] go along with [societal expectations], the self withdraws.”

Chapter 10

載營魄抱一

Carriage/transport/begin/record lay-out/plan/operations/build/guard body-soul/so embrace/hug One

Carrying and guarding the earthly bodily soul, embracing the One

能無離乎

Can/able/capable without/lack part-from/separate/leave/disengage/detach [?]

Can this be done without detaching?

專氣致柔

Exclusively/entirely/focus/condense qi/vital-energy/breath attain/bring-about soft/pliant/bending

Focus one's vital energy to attain softness,

能嬰兒乎

Can/able/capable [necklace/encircle/bound/surround/sustain child/youth]/newborn/infant [?]

***Can one sustain an infant?*¹⁰⁵**

滌除玄覽

Wash/rinse/purify/stables stairs/remove/besides/well-arranged/expel-unwanted murky/dim scan¹⁰⁶

Wash and clean the mysterious canvassing,

能無疵乎

Can/able/capable without/lack harm/illness/defect [?]

Can one be without defect?

愛民治國

Love/fond/begrudge/kind/pity common-people govern/harness/control country/state

Being kind to the people and governing a state,

能無為乎

Can/able/capable without/lack do/use/manipulate/act-as [?]

Can one be without doing?

天門開闔

Heaven gateway/gate open/begin/expose/spread-open/relieve door-leaf/close-up/bar/combine/all/every

***Heaven's gates open and close*¹⁰⁷**

能為雌乎

Can/able/capable do/use/manipulate/act-as feminine/female?

Can one act as feminine?

明白¹⁰⁸四達

Insight/perceptive/light/evident white/plain/clear/clarify/blank four breakthrough/insight/thoroughly

Perceptive and clear in the four directions thoroughly,

能無[以]知乎

Can/able/capable without/lack [by-means-of] know?

Can one without knowing?

¹⁰⁵ The verb “to be” is often not explicitly stated in Classical Chinese. Most translations have “be like a baby/infant”, but I don’t see a word that would give the sense of “like” or “similar to”. The construction of the other lines suggests to me there should be an explicit verb here, so I pick “sustain” as it makes more sense than “enwrap” or similar that are also definitions of 嬰, but this is an odd one out and I lack confidence in this conclusion.

¹⁰⁶ 覽: to look broadly at, canvass, scan, vista, look over, peruse

¹⁰⁷ This could also be “Heaven’s gates open its leaves.”

¹⁰⁸ 明白: I don’t know if this was compound as “understand” by the time of the Han.

生之畜之

Create/born/live ['s]/this livestock/rear/feed/nourish/train ['s]/this

Create this, rear this.

生而不有

Live/create/born and/yet/but not have/exist¹⁰⁹

Creating but not owning this,

為而不恃

Do/use/manipulate/act-as and/yet/but not confident/depending/relying

Doing but without this being depended on,

長而不宰

Long-lasting/maturing/grow/cultivate and/yet/not manage/oversee/butcher/divide

Cultivating but not butchering,

是謂玄德

This called murky/mysterious/translucent/dim virtue/power

This is called the mysterious virtue.

¹⁰⁹ Could also be “born and yet not existing” or “born and yet not having anything.” I initially had “born/living and not owned”

Chapter 11

三十輻共一轂

Thirty spokes connect/join/revere/respect/unite/provide-for one wheel-hub

Thirty spokes connect to one wheel,

當其無有車之用

At/apposite/appropriate/suitable/confront/attend-to their without have wheeled-vehicle ['s] employ

At its nothingness is where one has the carriage's usefulness.¹¹⁰

埴埴以為¹¹¹器

Limits/periphery/bounds/mud clay by-means-of use/do/manipulate/act-as instrument/vessel/capacity

Mud and clay to make into vessels,

當其無有器之用

At/apposite/appropriate/suitable their lack/without have instrument/vessel ['s]/this employ

At their nothingness is where one has the vessel's usefulness.

鑿戶牖以為室

Chisel/cut-into/hole/puncture door/hole/opening window by-means-of do/use/act-as room/house

Cut out doors and windows to make into a house

當其無有室之用

At/apposite/appropriate/suitable/confront/attend-to their without have room/house ['s] employ

At its nothingness is where one has the room's usefulness.

故有之以為利

Thus/as-a-result exist/have ['s]/this by-means-of do/use/act-as benefit/sharp/smooth

Thus, having this is made into a benefit,

無之以為用

Lack/without ['s]/this by-means-of do/use/act-as employ

Being without this is made into usefulness.

¹¹⁰ Or, put differently, "At the wheel's lack [of anything] is where one has the vehicle's application/employ."

¹¹¹ 以為 together can mean "make into", "take as", "used as", or "consider as".

Chapter 12

五色令人目盲

Five hue/color/appearance command/order/enable people eyes/point-of-view/judgment blind/dim

The five colors command people's eyes to blindness,

五音令人耳聾

Five tones/sounds/notes-of-music command/order/enable people ears/listen deaf/stupefied

The five tones command people's ears to deafness,

五味令人口爽¹¹²

Five flavors/taste/significance command/enable people mouth brisk/lively/frisky/dull/deaden/numb

The five flavors command people's mouths to dullness.

馳騁畋獵

Gallop/hurry gallop/charge/impetuous/unbridled plant/cultivate/to-hunt/to-chase hunt/scare-up/attack

Galloping and charging, chasing and hunting

令人心發狂

Orders/enables people heart/mind go-out/emit/express/breach rabid/deranged/manic/raging/violent

These command people's hearts to express violence¹¹³

難得之貨令人行妨

Difficult obtain ['s] goods/resources/items orders/enables people engage/enact/move damage/obstruct

Items difficult to obtain command people's movement to obstruction.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage,

為腹不為目

Use/do/manipulate/act-as stomach/inner-feelings not use/do/act-as eyes

Uses the stomach, and does not use the eyes.

故去彼取此

Therefore/thus/as-a-result leave/go that/others take/capture/seize this

So, they leave the others and take this.

¹¹² Also “to go against, contravene, disregard, violate, lose sight of.”

¹¹³ This is usually translated as “go mad”, but I’m not sure 發狂 was a compound phrase in the Han or before – Kroll does not list it.

Chapter 13

寵¹¹⁴辱若驚

Feel-powerful/favored (feel-)shame/disgrace like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/startled/alarm/frighten

Favor and shame are as if skittish¹¹⁵

貴大患若身

Value/costly/treat-as-expensive big troubles/worries like self/body.

Value big worries as you value your self.¹¹⁶

何¹¹⁷謂¹¹⁸寵辱若驚? 寵為下¹¹⁹

How/why called favor shame like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/alarm Favor do/use/act-as below/low/down

Why do we say that favor and shame are as if skittish? Favor is acting as lower, subservient.

得之若驚,失之若驚

Obtain/gain this/[‘s] like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/startled, Lose/loss [‘s]/this like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy

Obtaining this is like it is skittish, losing this is like it is skittish.

是謂寵辱若驚

This/indeed call favor shame like skittish/jumpy/alarm

This is called favor and shame being as if skittish.

何謂貴大患若身

How/why called value/precious/costly big/great worries/trouble like/as-if/if self/body

Why do we say to value great worries as if they are oneself?

吾所以有大患者為¹²⁰吾有身

I that-which by-means-of have/exist big/great worries/troubles [person/phrase] act-as/do/use have self

The mechanism by which I have great worries,

及吾無身吾有何患¹²¹

When/reach/arrive/catch-up-to/succeed/attain I without body I have how/why worries/troubles

When I am without a self, why would I have worries?

¹¹⁴ Mawangdui A has 龍 (dragon), B has 弄 (to be manipulated, toyed with), for this whole chapter

¹¹⁵ My translation may be unique. Linnell and Cleary have this as “Favor and disgrace seem alarming”, which has merit. Lau has “Favor and disgrace are things that startle.” Henricks has “Regard favor and disgrace with alarm.” Wu has “Welcome disgrace as a pleasant surprise.” Chan has “Be apprehensive when receiving favor or grace.” Throughout these translations, favor and shame are treated as though they make someone startled or alarmed. My issue is that 若 is not generally causative; it generally compares something to something else. So, favor being flighty and unstable seems to me a more grammatically grounded translation.

¹¹⁶ If 若 is “if” this could be “Value great troubles if (they concern the) body/self.” Comparing to the main translation, though, Chan similarly has “Regard trouble as seriously as you regard your body,” which is an elegant way to put it. Henricks has “Respect great distress as you do your own person.” Wu has the vaguer “Prize calamities as your own body.” However, Linnell treats 貴大 as “high rank” and translates “High rank brings suffering if you have a self.” Lau similarly has “High rank is, like one’s body, a source of great trouble.” Waley has “High rank hurts keenly as our bodies hurt.” Cleary has “High rank greatly afflicts your person.” Feng & English have “Accept misfortune as the human condition.”

¹¹⁷ Mawangdui A has 苛

¹¹⁸ Mawangdui have 胃 and so does Guodian -- stomach

¹¹⁹ HeShangGong has 上 here (or in some versions 辱為下), but Mawangdui does not.

¹²⁰ While I rarely translate 為 as “because” in texts this old, very little else makes sense. This is translated often as “is that” (Lau, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Cleary, and Linnell). Lin has “because”. Feng & English and Wu have “comes from” and “is the very source” respectively.

¹²¹ Mawangdui A has 梲 for most instances of this character

故貴以身為天下

Thus/therefore value/precious/costly by-means-of body/self do/use/act-as heaven under

Thus, value the self as you would the world,

若可{以}寄¹²²天下{矣}

Like/as-if/if can {by-means-of} lodge/take-refuge/impart/entrust heaven under {[!]}

If one can, one is entrusted with the world!

愛以身為天下

Greedily-protect/fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge by-means-of body use/do world;

Loathe to part with the self as you would the world;

若可{以}託¹²³天下{矣}

Like/if can {by-means-of} entrust/confide/rely-on/borrow/take-responsibility-for heaven under {[!]}

If one can, one takes responsibility for the world!¹²⁴

¹²² In Mawangdui B, this is 橐, in A it's 託 or 迺

¹²³ Mawangdui has 寄: lodge, take refuge in, attach to, stop over, entrust to, confide to, send, transfer to, impart.

¹²⁴ Translations vary widely for these last four lines. Wu has "Hence, only he who is willing to give his body for the sake of the world is fit to be entrusted with the world; Only he who can do it with love is worthy of being steward of the world." Lau has the opposite: "Hence he who values his body more than the dominion over the empire can be entrusted with the empire; he who loves his body more than the dominion over the empire can be given custody of the empire." Henricks, Lin and Chan have somewhat similar to Lau's and mine.

Guodian (B:4)

[人?]¹²⁵ (𪛗/寵) ¹²⁶ (𪛗/辱)若(𪛗/營)¹²⁷,

[People?] Feel-powerful/favored (feel-)shame/disgrace like confused/deluded;

Favor and shame are like binds of dazzling confusion;

貴¹²⁸大患若身。

Value/costly/treat-as-expensive big troubles/worries like self/body.

Value big worries as you value your self.¹²⁹

可(胃¹³⁰/謂)應辱? 應為下也。

How stomach//called power/favor shame? Power/favor use/do/act-as lower.

What can we call favor and shame? To have favor is to be subservient to those who bestow it.

(得/導)之若(𪛗/營), (𪛗¹³¹/失/逸)之若(𪛗/營)

Obtaining [‘s]/this like dazzling-confusion, Escaping/losing [‘s]/this like dazzling-confusion.

Obtaining this is like binds of dazzling confusion, this escaping is like binds of dazzling confusion.

是(胃/謂)應辱(𪛗/營)。

This called favor shame dazzling-confusion/delusion.¹³²

This is what is meant by favor and shame being dazzling confusion.

¹²⁵ Part of Guodian B:3, but may belong here instead according to some. I personally do not think it does.

¹²⁶ Could not find in dictionary but zi.tools has this as equivalent to 寵 (favor, honor, indulged). This character as written is a dragon (𪛗/龍) over a heart (signifying emotional/psychological state rather than something literal), so this could be read as a “dragon” state of mind—elevated, powerful, intense, likely untamed. This could also have the sense of favored, “loved by dragon” or “made into a dragon through love (of a ruler or the like)”. Later in this chapter, it is noted that this “is to be lower”—this suggests that this quality is not inherent—it is bestowed by a ruler or yet greater power who can on a whim give it or take it away.

¹²⁷ For whole chapter, could also be 纓 (strings, ribbons, encircle; listed under zi.tools as 𪛗 over 系), 繫 (tie up, constrain, coil around, entwine). This could be related to 瞿 (alarm) as BYL suggests, as an alternate of 營 (deceive, confuse). See Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 291. I think this is 瞿 (𪛗 over 炊 over 系 visually); zi.tools considers this to be 榮 (honor, full-flowering, florescence, glory, but also 營), but Schuessler (2007, through Wiktionary) states that 榮 is the same as 榮: glimmer, sparkle, dazzle, bewilder. “Bondage” also works if taken as 繫 or 纓. But 繫 and 瞿, maybe “to bind the eyes” could combine bondage and dazzling. Perhaps favor and shame bind the eyes in dazzling confusion.

¹²⁸ Could potentially be 遺 – bequeath, bestow, but see Guodian A:20). I don’t think so, the slips look like 貴

¹²⁹ If 若 is “if” this could be “Value great troubles if (they concern the) body/self.” Henricks has “Be wary with matters that cause great distress – treat them as if they could mean your life.” I agree with this translation.

¹³⁰ It is not very controversial that this means 謂. For mischief’s sake, if we leave this character as “stomach”, this sentence becomes “How can one stomach power/favor and shame?” (in the sense of “can the gut process/digest this”) or even “Can power/favor and shame be eaten?” (in the sense of “what good are these things”). The point, if we keep the stomach in the reading, is consistent, “Do power and shame nourish, or are they empty or even toxic to one’s being?” This messaging has the wit and sarcastic dismissal of the ego consistent through Daoism, while keeping the primal, animalistic, natural, visceral tone of early, pre-Qin Daoist thought. Feeding the stomach is necessary for survival, feeding the eyes with dazzling delusion is a deleterious distraction.

¹³¹ This resembles the second “失” in A:6 (𪛗). Zi.tools has this as 𪛗 (walk) around 止 (foot/stop) over 𪛗 (handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away (Zi.tools is very particular about this: 𪛗 𪛗 止 𪛗). This can relate to 失 (lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also relate this to escaping, or 逸 (a rabbit running, the way this was expressed west of Chu). Could be 迭, or 達/達.

¹³² Or, in my stomach mischief, “Thus, stomaching favor and shame is confusion/delusion.” They cannot be digested, they cannot be used, they are not needed for survival. It is just a drain on vital energy.

□□□□□¹³³若¹³⁴身? (可(胃/謂)貴¹³⁵大患)

_____ like body/self? (How called//stomach valuing great troubles/cares)

{What does it mean to value big worries as} oneself?

(~~受~~/虐/吾)所以¹³⁶(又/有)大患者, 為¹³⁷(虐/吾)(又/有)身。

My/I mechanism-by-which having big worries/troubles [phrase-end] do/act-as/use I have body/self

The source of my worries is because I have a self¹³⁸

(~~達~~¹³⁹/返/及)(虐/吾)亡身, 或可 □(患?)

When/reach/arrive/attain I lose-body/die¹⁴⁰, some/perhaps/someone can (worries/troubles?)

When I lose myself and so die, can someone have {worries}?

□□□□□為天下, (故貴以身¹⁴¹)

_____ do/use/act-as the world; (Thus, value by-means-of self/body)

{Thus, value the self as you} would the world;¹⁴²

若可以, (~~氏~~/厓/宅)¹⁴³天下矣。

Like/as/if, permissible by-means-of reside/be-comfortable/home with under-heaven/world

If one can, one resides comfortably in the world!

(~~受~~/惡¹⁴⁴)以身為天下,

Greedily-protect/fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge by-means-of body use/do world;

Loathe to part with the self as you would the world;

若可以, (~~達~~/達/去¹⁴⁵)天下矣。

If/like/as permissible/can by-means-of leave/depart/distance/store world.

If one can, one stores the world! / If one can, one leaves the world!

¹³³ From Cook

¹³⁴ May behave more like 而 here, see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 291

¹³⁵ Could potentially be 遺 – bequeath, bestow, but see Guodian A:20; I don't think so, this should be 貴.

¹³⁶ Everywhere, 也→目→以. In Warring States grammar, 所以 is "the means by which" or "what accounts for".

¹³⁷ Written like 𠂔, which is unusual: 為 is nearly always like 𠂔, 𠂔 or similar in the Guodian, with two thick horizontal lines BELOW, not above, if any. Signifying "because" to contrast it to the "doing"/"manipulating"? Only here I have translated 為 as "because". Kroll does list "because of, on account of" as definitions for 為.

¹³⁸ More grammatically: "As for what accounts for my having great troubles — it is because I have a body/self."

¹³⁹ This is listed as 返 in zi.tools (through the 及 page) but bears resemblance to the character we've been using as 失/逸, to lose/to escape. It probably isn't and is almost certainly 返, but I wanted to note this in case I'm wrong.

¹⁴⁰ 亡身 is a well known Warring States way of saying "to die" in a more literary way, from the Zuo Zhuan, Xunzi, and Lvshi Chunqiu. I keep the biting, sarcastic bluntness of tone rather than suggest that losing one's body is some favorable outcome. Put more modernly, "You can't be worried if you're dead; You want to be free of worries? Die."

¹⁴¹ Cook: may end with 於. Zhuangzi has 於 here and "愛以身於為天下". Also, 以 X 為 Y means "take X as Y"

¹⁴² Also, 以 X 為 Y means "take X as Y", so "Value self as the world."

¹⁴³ 氏 in zi.tools, listed under 宅. Usually translated as "entrust" by 託, but the resemblance is stronger with 宅.

¹⁴⁴ 𠂔 In the Warring states period, 惡 (愛) more so had the sense of "to begrudge", "to protect greedily from loss or harm", or "to hoard" than the modern sense of the word "love". Its components mean "saturated heart". I initially saw it as 父 over 心, which has the sense of pacing over something in a guarding manner. See A:18 (𠂔). This form specifically looks a bit like 𠂔 (𠂔女心)→ 恕 (compassion, forgive, excuse, show mercy). This could also be read as "be kind to the self/body as though it is the world," but this is less consistent.

¹⁴⁵ Original is rendered as 達 in zi.tools and elsewhere, as a variant of 去, to go, or even a loan for 弄, to store. 弄 honestly makes more sense in context in my opinion, and "store up" is listed under 去 in Kroll. The structure of the character itself, though the structure itself, including 𠂔 (walk), suggests "depart." I present both options.

Chapter 14

視之不見名曰夷

Look ['s]/this/it not see name says/called barbarian/crude/level/calm/wounded/faint/common

Looking at it but not seeing it, this is called “faint”.

聽之不聞名曰希

Listen-closely/heed/obey ['s]/this/it not hear/inform name says/called rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to

Listening for it but not hearing it, this is called “dilute”.

搏之不得名曰微

Put-hand-to/claw-at/grasp-at/strike/assault ['s]/it/this but not obtain/gain name says/called subtle/tiny

Putting one's hands on it but not gaining it, this is called “subtle”.

此三者不可致詰

These three [person/phrase] not can/possible attain/bring-about investigate/interrogate/scrutinize

These three, one cannot attain an investigation of them.

故混而為一

Therefore/as-a-result muddy/murky/jumbled/confused and/yet/but use/do/manipulate/act-as one

Therefore they are confused and act as one.¹⁴⁶

其¹⁴⁷上不皦,其下不昧

Their high not white/shining/clear/understandable/pure, their low/below not dim/indistinct/obscure

Their high up is not bright and clear, their low down is not dim and indistinct,

繩繩{兮}不可名

Rope/string/cord(x2)//cautious/prudent/boundless/limitless {!} not can/possible name/label

Boundless! They cannot be named.

復歸於無物•

Return go-home/restore/refuge-with in/at/from/than/regard without/lack things

Returning by restoring its state as nothingness¹⁴⁸

是謂無狀之狀

This called without/lack form/shape/condition/describe ['s]/this form/shape/condition/describe

This is called the form of the formless.

無物之象,是謂惚恍

Lack/without thing ['s] image/imitation/replica, this called dazed-&-distracted/muddled-&-murky¹⁴⁹

The image of nothingness, this is called muddled and murky

迎之不見其首

Receive/accept/welcome/comply/echo/turn-toward ['s]/this not see their head/foremost/first/beginning

Turning toward this, one cannot see its head,

隨之不見其後

Pursue/follow-after ['s]/this not see their behind/after

Following after this, one cannot see its back.

¹⁴⁶ As Lau translates “They are confused and looked upon as one”, perhaps meaning they are conflated with each other, rather than fusing or actually acting in concert.

¹⁴⁷ Before this, Mawangdui has 一者 (One [person/phrase])

¹⁴⁸ More literally, “Returning by restoring (being) at nothingness”

¹⁴⁹ Also distracted-and-delirious, muddled-and-murky, blurred-and-smeared

執古之道，

Seize/grasp/capture ancient [‘s]/this Dao,

Grasp the ancient Dao.

以御今之有，能知古始

By-means-of steer/direct/drive present/now [‘s] have/exist able/capable know ancient begin/start

By directing what the present time has, one can know the ancient beginnings¹⁵⁰

是謂道紀

This called Dao strand/unravel/arrange/rule/principle/main-point

This is called the strand of the Dao.

¹⁵⁰ I translate 以 as “by means of”, or in an instrumental sense. 以 X verb Y, the way I translate it throughout this project, is Verb Y through/by X. I think Waley agrees with my translation (“Yet by seizing on the way that was, you can ride the things that are now for to know what once there was, in the beginning.”) However, one can also translate this as “by means of this, direct ...” most translations instead have “In order to manage/direct/move/master/control” what exists in the present. Looking in Kroll, it may be my own deficiency, but I cannot find justification for this way of translating it, and it is inconsistent with how I have done it throughout the project. That being said, the insight of the Dao may allow for forensic insight, through evidence of the now to know what was long before.

Chapter 15

古之善為士者

Old/ancient ['s] skilled/good/advantageous do/act-as/use nobles/knights

The skilled nobles of old,

微妙玄通

Subtle/tiny/secret/barely-there subtleties/marvels/wonder murkiness/mystery/dim pass-through

Were wondrously subtle, penetrating through murky mysteries.

深不可識

Depth not able/can record/informed-about/aware-of/familiar-with

Their depth cannot be known.

夫唯¹⁵¹不可識

In-any-case only not permissible/able/possible informed-about/aware-of/familiar-with/record

It is that they are unknowable,

故強為之容

As-a-result/thus strong/try-hard do/use/act-as ['s] appearance/permit/receive/tolerate/pardon

So we forcibly put effort into acting as they appeared.

豫¹⁵²兮¹⁵³若冬涉川

Happy/content/comfortable/preparatory [!] like/as winter wading-through river/stream

Prepared! Like winter wading through a river,

猶兮若畏四鄰

Hesitant/planning/yet [!] like/as fear four neighbors,

Hesitant! Like being in fear of neighbors on all sides,

儼兮其若(客/容¹⁵⁴)

Serious/grave/solemn/ceremonious/neat [!] it/its like/as stranger/guest//appearance/permit/pardon

Solemn! They are like being a guest.

涣兮若冰¹⁵⁵之將釋

Disperse/diffuse/dissolve [!] Like/as ice ['s] bring release/expel/explain/set-free/discard

Dissolving! Like the breaking free of ice.

敦¹⁵⁶兮其若樸

Thick/genuine/sincere/generous/honor [!] It/its like/as unworked-wood/adhere/simple/honest/rough

Genuine! They are as if simple (uncarved wood).

曠兮其若谷

Brilliant/clear/vivid/bright/vast/unrestricted/expansive/barren/bleak [!] it/its like/as valley/cave

Vast and barren! They are like a valley.

¹⁵¹ This 夫唯 seems to be a fixed phrase, meaning “It is this that does/causes...” As well as “Only this explains ...”

¹⁵² In Kroll, Wiktionary nor in zi.tools can I find a meaning of “cautious” or “circumspect” specifically for 豫; the Shuowen Jiezi offers a large elephant that does not harm things. Most definitions, in fact, point to joy, generosity, being relaxed, and comfortable. In both Mawangdui, this is 與, (give, grant, assist, join with, unite with, participate in, from Kroll; by zi.tools, deliver, “fellow partisans”). In Mawangdui B, 川 is 水.

¹⁵³ For this line only, for the Wang Bi, Henricks has 焉 instead, and both Mawangdui have 呵 for every 兮.

¹⁵⁴ Only WangBi has 容 here.

¹⁵⁵ In Mawangdui, 冰 is 凌, and 之 將 is not there.

¹⁵⁶ Mawangdui B has 沌: uneducated, unaware, ignorant, and benighted

混兮其若濁

Muddy/murky/confused/jumbled [!] its/it like/as muddied/turbid/murky/confused/corrupt/defiled
Confused! They are as if turbid.

孰能¹⁵⁷濁以靜之徐清

Who/which capable/able/arrive turbid/confused/defiled by-means of motionless/stillness ['s]/this calmly/leisurely/dignified clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent

Who is able to, through stillness, calmly bring turbidity to clarity?

孰能安以久¹⁵⁸動之徐生

Who/which able/capable peace/quiet/stable/install by-means-of long-standing/old/enduring/familiar move/shift/act ['s]/this calmly/leisurely/dignified life/born/create

Who is able to, through long enduring movement, calmly bring what is stable to life?

保¹⁵⁹此道者不欲盈

Protect/sustain/persist this Dao/way people, not want/desire/crave fullness/filled-up

Those who persist in this Dao do not desire to be filled up.

夫唯不盈¹⁶⁰

In-any-case only not filled-up/fullness

It is that they are not filled up,

故¹⁶¹能蔽{而}不新¹⁶²成

Thus/as-a-result can/able/capable conceal/hide/camouflage/protect/mask/shelter/decide and/yet not new/fresh achievement/accomplishment/complete

So they are able to be covered, and yet not freshly accomplished.

¹⁵⁷ In both instances, Mawangdui do not have 孰能 or 竺能

¹⁵⁸ Only WangBi has this 久

¹⁵⁹ Mawangdui has 葆 instead.

¹⁶⁰ Mawangdui A has 欲 before 盈 here.

¹⁶¹ Mawangdui B (and likely A) have 是以 instead of 故

¹⁶² Only in WangBi.

Guodian (A:5)

[長¹⁶³](古/故)¹⁶⁴之善¹⁶⁵為士者,

[Long] old [‘s]/this skilled act-as/do/use adept/knight/man

As a result, these who are skilled at acting as nobles

必非溺¹⁶⁶玄達,

Certainly not sink/drown/flood translucent/mystery/dim breakthrough/insight/remove-blockage

Were certainly not drowning in mysterious insight

(深)不可¹⁶⁷(志)¹⁶⁸,

Deep not permitted/possible to-record/remember/intend/aim/aspired-toward.

So deep that it cannot be a target of aspiration.

是以為之(頌):

These/this [by-means-of do/use/act]/regard-as/take-as/make-into [‘s/it/this] praise/oracles

*This is used as their praise.*¹⁶⁹

夜¹⁷⁰(虐/乎)(奴/如¹⁷¹)(各/冬)¹⁷²涉¹⁷³川,

Night in/at/perhaps/’!’/’?’ slave/enslave//like winter wade-though/experience/enter-into river/stream

In the night, perhaps as if in winter wading through a river,

¹⁶³ Looking at the strips, this looks like it should be part of this chapter, and not A:4, due to a dash mark. However, the context suggests that maybe it does actually belong to A:4. I discuss both scenarios below.

¹⁶⁴ I normally translate this as “therefore, thus, as a result”, but in this case it may be “ancient.”. I note the inconsistency. Alternatively, this could be “therefore” following A:4’s critique of war and greed. In this case, the last line of A:4 would become “Its conduct is excellently enduring.” A:5 would then start with “Therefore, the skilled noblemen...” However, the 之 (a possessive particle, it/this) suggests to me that 古 is a noun/adjective. If 長 belongs in A:5 and 古 is meant as “ancient” this line becomes: “For a long time these skilled at acting as nobles” or “For a long time the ancient nobleman of talent.” If 長 is in A:5 and 古 is meant as 故 “therefore, thus” (as it normally does), the grammar becomes very awkward: “Long/enduring/maturing, as a result, these skilled at acting as nobles.” If we leave 長 in A:4 despite the mark on the slips, take 之 in the sense of “these”, and have 古 as 故, this line becomes “Therefore, these who are skilled at acting as nobles,” which is the best I can come up with trying to keep everything consistent.

¹⁶⁵ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”. The moral benevolence reading came later, with Confucius, Mencius. So think of this as “skilled” or “talented”.

¹⁶⁶ Technically 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Could be 弱 (weak and frail)? (See also A:17 and A:19)

¹⁶⁷ On the strips, has an extra line above it

¹⁶⁸ My translation of 志 is a little complex. Its common translation is aspiration, ambition, will. However, this character is also a variant form of 誌 (Wiktionary). The etymology of the character is essentially “What is proceeded to”, by Schuessler, 2007. I was tempted to translate 志 as “recorded as an accomplishment” to capture both the sense of recording and ambition, but both readings work. The mysterious insights are too deep to be the target of ambition or will, because these deep mysteries exist outside of the activities that entail ambition.

¹⁶⁹ Based on recordable achievements, not any actual deep thing. The deep understanding of the Dao is not recordable, and so does not offer the praise they sought, so that they are not soaked in Dao allows them to collect achievements. It is possible that the scribe meant that the following rather unflattering images (at least by my translation) are taken as praise, but it still stands that the way toward this praise, these hymns, is not the way of the Dao, not the way of closing one’s gates.

¹⁷⁰ 𠂔 Technically 亦 over 夕 as in zi.tools, but still meaning 夜

¹⁷¹ 𠂔 The slips unambiguously read 奴, but this is harder to make sense of than just using 如. It could be a pun, describing the nobles as enslaved by all of these things.

¹⁷² 𠂔 Original character has a sun under it, reflecting an early form of the character.

¹⁷³ 𠂔 In zi.tools, technically 𠂔止𠂔𠂔八少, in the 涉 entry, but without its own page.

(猷/猷/猶) (虐¹⁷⁴/乎)其¹⁷⁵(奴/如) (𢇛/悞¹⁷⁶/畏)四(叟/鄰),

Similar-to/like/plan/hesitant/still in/perhaps/“!” its/their/maybe slaves//like afraid four neighbors

Scheming¹⁷⁷, perhaps maybe as if haunted by fear of neighbors on all sides,

敢¹⁷⁸(虐/乎)其(奴/如)客,

Dare/how-dare in/at/perhaps/“!” its/their/maybe slave/enslave guests/clients/stranger

Bold, perhaps maybe as if merely a stranger,

(𢇛/震)¹⁷⁹ (虐/乎)其(奴/如) (𢇛/懌¹⁸⁰/釋),

Looking-with-fear in/at/perhaps/“!” their/maybe slaves//like happiness/joyful//explain/dispel/release

Watching in horror, perhaps maybe as if experiencing true happiness,

屯¹⁸¹(虐/乎)其(奴/如)樸¹⁸²,

Difficulty/hardship/gather/guard, perhaps its/maybe slaves//like simple/unworked-wood/unaffected

Struggling, perhaps maybe as if unprocessed wood¹⁸³

(沌¹⁸⁴) (虐/乎)其(奴/如)(𦉳/濁)。

Blocked up/ignorant, perhaps its/maybe slaves//like turbid/murky/impure/confused/corrupt/defiled

Obstructed, perhaps maybe as if defiled.

¹⁷⁴ This particular 虐 is pretty reduced: 𢇛 compared to something more like 𢇛 or 𢇛, so sad I cannot even find it on zi.tools, which makes me wonder if it's not 虐. It is the only one like this out of the entire chapter.

¹⁷⁵ 其 is usually a third-person possessive, however, it appears to be working in the capacity of an indicator of doubt, incredulity, or speculation (see Kroll).

¹⁷⁶ 心 under 鬼 to mean 畏 (but listed under zi.tools as to mean 媿→悞), but could be read 畏 over 心 (→悞; ashamed, embarrassed). Cook has this as supposed to mean 畏. In C:1, I have this as “induce fear and dread”.

¹⁷⁷ Elsewhere in my translation of the Guodian, I have taken 猷 as 猶, meaning similar to/like, or “designed/planned”. Here, I actually think that the original character's definition of scheming or planning works better in the pattern. Shuowen Jiezi also lists “hesitant, timid, doubtful and cautious” as meanings of 猶, even relating the “like/similar to” to the act of planning and designing. Inconsistency in my own translation, so I note.

¹⁷⁸ 敢 Zi.tools has this under 敢, this is a variant of 敢

¹⁷⁹ Zi.tools results match more to 遠 (but matches better with 見+袁 all over 止 (from 震). There's not a lot of info on old versions of 渙. May actually be closest to 還, which is also huan, but zi.tools matches most closely with the samples from 震 (which can be pronounced qiong but also huan). Zi.tools lists as 𢇛見袁止.

¹⁸⁰ 𢇛 over 心, as listed in zi.tools, leading to 懌. 𢇛 used to stand in for 澤, but also meant “big white”, but also marsh, pool, pond, moist, brilliance, luster, shine, and grace. Wiktionary lists 釋 as a variant of 懌, which honestly does not make things much clearer. 𢇛 (𢇛), for its part, means “detect”, “observe”, or “use eyes to put someone under arrest” according to the Shuowen Jiezi. Perhaps, this over heart (心) could mean having one's intentions or mind “found out”, if an abbreviated form of 𢇛 is in play. I default to 懌 due to the shared heart component.

¹⁸¹ Shuowen Jiezi has this as “hardship”, the sprout breaking out of the ground. Difficulty and hardship.

¹⁸² 𢇛 Originally 𢇛 over 臣 over 木. In zi.tools listed under 樸, meaning jujube, or dense or clustered growth, or firm/sturdy. The original form of 樸 was expressed as 𢇛 with 臣, meaning servant or slave. Given the prominence of the 木 radical and that 樸 means jujube, “unworked material” of 樸 probably fits best. (Compare to A:16: 𢇛)

¹⁸³ The uncarved block is usually positive in Daoism. It may be that the nobles are pretending, seeming raw but just struggling. “Uncarved block” as early as the Guodian may not have acquired its positive connotation yet.

¹⁸⁴ Hard to find history on this character: It seems to mean “stop, plug, bagged soil and grass to hold back water, ridge between fields” – definitely a sense of obstruction. 沌 is defined by Kroll as “uneducated, unaware, ignorant, and “benighted”, a intellectual, moral, or social deficiency of contemptible degree. So, obstructed or oblivious.

竺¹⁸⁵能濁以(𦵏/束/刺)者,

Thick/devoted capability/able/harmony/arrive muddied/corrupted by-means-of spike/thorn//to-pierce,

Genuine ability to pierce through the defilement

(廛/將) 舍¹⁸⁶清¹⁸⁷。

Hold/support/use/bring/will guest-house/cottage/dwell/save clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent

Brings one to dwell in clarity.

竺能(𠂔/𠂔¹⁸⁸/𠂔¹⁸⁸/𠂔)以(𠂔/𠂔¹⁸⁹/往)者¹⁹⁰,

Genuine ability duck-under(?) by-means-of moving-(directionally)

Genuine ability to move through bending and leaning

(廛/將) 舍生。

Brings/will dwell/save living/nature.

Brings one to dwell in survival.

保此(術/道)者不(谷¹⁹¹/欲) (𦵏/黨)¹⁹² 呈¹⁹³。

Preserve/protect this/those way/path [person] no desire clan/faction/side-with presented/manifest

These who preserve this way do not want to take sides with factions and present themselves.

¹⁸⁵ Kroll's dictionary has both 竺 and 篤 as “genuine, devoted, honest, single-mindedly, faithful, dedicated, loyal, or to an extreme degree. Zi.tools has these both as “thick” and “heavy”, by 《漢語同源詞大典》.

¹⁸⁶ Listed under 舍 in zi.tools. 舍. Sometimes used in the sense of 捨(to release, relinquish). Second instance 舍.

¹⁸⁷ Originally, actually 青 over 水

¹⁸⁸ Originally 𠂔, which zi.tools renders 𠂔 to the left of 𠂔 (under its 𠂔 listing, but under both entries, variation is considerable). Cook says 𠂔 but I don't see it, unless the 𠂔 was just not duplicated. There may be evidence for 𠂔 or 𠂔 but visually both are only a little convincing. Li Tianhong argues this is Chu shorthand for 𠂔 (hide, conceal). To me, this looks like 𠂔 (tilt, lean/ duck under), a man under an overhang/cliff for shelter. Or this could be the Spring and Autumn or Warring states version of 𠂔 under this overhang, though it would be facing the wrong direction. Undoubtedly this is a backward person under an overhang. Possibly, this means to duck down or duck under something, lean or tilt, in the sense of 𠂔

¹⁸⁹ Originally 𠂔 definitely 𠂔 with another component like 𠂔 or 𠂔 (𠂔? or 行 above 𠂔/止?), these components all give a sense of marching, movement, probably most similar now to 往; Cook calls this 往→動. This also may look like 迂 (tortuous avoidance). Zi.tools does not have this character under any of these things or anything I've searched up – the only safe guess is that it is movement of some kind.

¹⁹⁰ This is a perhaps creative alternative to how this line is normally rendered. Murkiness, by stillness, is made clear—particles settling out of churning waters. Tilting/leaning/ducking, by movement, makes survival/life, a successfully maneuvering organism traveling through the structures of the environment. This is not a translation totally out of the tradition of Daoism, see commentary.

¹⁹¹ Literally means valley, likely a loan or original form of 欲; the Chu variant of 欲 listed under zi.tools is 谷 + 次.

¹⁹² Cook has this as 尚, but zi.tools has as 堂, meaning 黨

¹⁹³ Technically 口 over 土 by zi.tools, under 呈

Chapter 16

致虛極，守靜篤。

Attain/bring-about empty standard/zenith/supreme/utmost, Defend/preserve stillness thick/devoted
Attain the pinnacle of emptiness, defend stillness with devotion.

萬物並¹⁹⁴作，

Ten thousand things side-by-side/coordinate/equally/altogether/uniformly arise/begin/create
Ten thousand things arise with coordination,

吾以觀[其]復

I by-means-of observe/display/ behold/watch-intently [it/its] return/revert/go-back/repeat
And I, through observation, return [them],¹⁹⁵

夫物芸芸各復歸其根

In-any-case/these things manifold/plentiful each return go-home/restore/refuge-with it/its root/base
These things, manifold – each of them return by restoring their roots.

歸根曰靜

Restoring/go-home/refuge root/base says/called stillness/motionless
Restoring one's roots is called stillness,

[靜]是謂復命

[stillness] this called return/revert/go-back command/orders/name/heavenly-ordained-command
This is called returning to one's orders,

復命曰常

Return/revert/go-back command/orders/heavenly-ordained-command says/called constant/persistent
Returning to one's orders is called constant.

知常曰明

Know constant/persistent called/says luminous/light/evident/illuminate/perceptive
Knowing constancy is called perceptive;

不知常妄作凶

Not/no know constant/persistent careless/unseemly/absurd arise/begin/create ill-omen/deadly/lethal
Not knowing constancy is careless, and misfortune arises.

知常容，容乃公

Know constant appearance/permit/tolerate/pardon, “” then/indeed impartial/common/public
Knowing constancy is tolerant, tolerance is indeed impartial,

公乃王，王乃天

Impartial/common/public then/indeed king, king then/indeed heaven
Impartiality is indeed kingly, kings are indeed heavenly,

天乃道，道乃久

Heaven then/indeed Dao/way, Dao/way indeed/then long-lasting/enduring/familiar
Heaven is indeed like the Dao, the Dao is indeed long-enduring and familiar,

沒¹⁹⁶身不殆

Sink/dissolve/disappear/submerge/overcome body/self not/no danger/peril
Such that dissolving oneself is not dangerous.

¹⁹⁴ In both Mawangdui, this is 旁

¹⁹⁵ Linnell translates this as “And thus I observe their return,” and Lau, Chan, Henricks, Cleary, and Feng & English have very similar. Wu has “While all things are stirring together, I only contemplate their return.”

¹⁹⁶ 沒 later meant “not have”, “to be not so...” (Wiktionary), but Kroll doesn't list these for Classical Chinese

Guodian (A:13)

(𠂔/至)虚(𣦵/互)¹⁹⁷也;

Arrive-at/with regard/ultimate/utmost to/utmost empty/diminished constant/eternal

To arrive at emptiness constantly,¹⁹⁸

(𠂔/獸¹⁹⁹/守)(𠂔/中)²⁰⁰(𠂔/管)²⁰¹也。

Hunt/beast//protect center/middle/core thick/devoted

Defend the core with devotion;

萬(勿/物)²⁰²(𠂔/方)(𠂔/作)²⁰³

Ten-thousand things only-then/just-then/means/direction/proper/square arise/begin/create

When the ten thousand things are just now arising;

居以須²⁰⁴(𠂔²⁰⁵/復)也。

Dwell/rest by-means-of need-to/require/want/wait for/stay for/slow return/go-back/repeat/revert/reply

Dwell through needing to go back.

天道(員員/圓圓)²⁰⁶,

Heaven way is round/circular x2

Heaven's way is truly circular;

各(𠂔/復)其(𠂔²⁰⁷/堇)。

Each/in-each-case return/retreats/repeats to its scarcely?/clay/soil

Everything reverts to its soil.

¹⁹⁷ Technically 𣦵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𣦵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 極 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

¹⁹⁸ Keep in mind, this chapter appears right after A:12, which discusses the ability of emptiness to create without being exhausted. This does not necessarily mean the erasure of the self, but just allowing oneself the capacity within to allow work to move through. A:12 is on one slip and A:13 on another, but I really believe they connect.

¹⁹⁹ Zi.tools says this means 獸

²⁰⁰ 冲/盅 is suggested here by Yan LingFeng (through Cook), to mean “void” or “empty”

²⁰¹ See also A:18. This character could be a synonym of 𠂔 (genuine) and so therefore 篤 (all of which are du3) thick, relentless, genuine, which I am hesitant about because this character 𠂔 already appears, but the Shuowen Jiezi, by zi.tools, seems to also say this means “thick.” It appears the thick/devoted meaning is more likely. Shuowen Jiezi says “thick and winter-poisonous”, but the poisonous bit may be pronunciation. This may be a Chu version for 孰, meaning “in which cases, which, who, what”, according to zi.tools.

²⁰² Treated like 物 because 勿 means no, do not, and doesn’t make sense here.

²⁰³ 𠂔 → 𠂔 Original was 𠂔 with a 又 under it, unlike Chapter 2 (Guodian A:9); there is a stray vertical mark to the left of the character: 𠂔, but it bears enough resemblance to other examples of 𠂔 (for instance 𠂔). Compare to A:7

²⁰⁴ 𠂔 Controversial, usually rendered 寡, sometimes rendered to 須 (await) which is most supported by zi.tools, but may be an abbreviation of 寡. Maybe should be read as 顧. (See A:1)

²⁰⁵ 𠂔 Robert Henricks has this as 𠂔 inside 𠂔.

²⁰⁶ Controversial. 𠂔 → 𠂔 Anyways, This is usually rendered as 員, which zi.tools supports, Mawangdui has two different things, see above. Some others have just 云云, or 圓圓, as 員 was 圓’s original form. Henricks has 員 over 火, which is closest to what I see, but renders it as 云 without explaining why. The confidence seems to stem from the fact that this should sound like yun/yuan, but this is not particularly convincing to me

²⁰⁷ Cook, Henricks, + Zi.tools list as 堇 but it’s 黄 over 土, so 堇. Shuowen Jiezi defines this as soil. See B:5 (堇)

Chapter 17 +18

太²⁰⁸ 上 下 知 有 之²⁰⁹

Great/grand top/above/higher/supreme below/lowly know exist/have this[‘s]

Those below the greatest superiors know they exist.

其 次 親 而 譽 之

Their next-in-sequence parents/kin/intimate and/yet/but acclaim/commend/reputation/applaud this/[‘s]

Their next²¹⁰ below are cherished like kin and praised.

其 次 畏 之

Their next-in-sequence dreadful/frighten/shrink-from/awe-inducing/exorcise this/[‘s]

Their next below are feared and dreaded.

其 次 侮²¹¹ 之

Their next-in-sequence offend/humiliate/disrespect this/[‘s]

Their next below are humiliated and disrespected.

信 不 足 焉 有 不 信 焉

Trust/faith/reliable/pledge not sufficient/leg how/than/from-this exist/have no trust/pledge from-this

Trust is not enough, and from this there is distrust.²¹²

悠²¹³ 兮 其 貴 言

Pensive/thoughtful/drawn-out/relaxed/wistful/uncertain [!] their value/prized/expensive words/speech

Wistful! Their value is words.²¹⁴

功 成 事 遂

Work/accomplishment/excellence complete/achieve/accomplish matters progress/succeed/respond

When work is completed, and matters are successful,

百 姓 皆 謂 我 自 然²¹⁵

Hundred surnames all called/say I/we self nature/so

The people all say “we are this way on our own.”²¹⁶

²⁰⁸ 大 in both Mawangdui and Guodian, but this is normally interchangeable

²⁰⁹ Linnell has this as “The existence of the best ruler is barely known to the people”. Chinese often uses 下 to be an indicator of “those below X”. Even 天下 (world) is literally a noun “under heaven”, so I don’t think that 下 can be used to mean “barely” directly. It could be implied that this knowing is the only way people are affected, though

²¹⁰ Most translations have “the next one down [below the greatest superiors]”, but MAYBE it’s a time sequence?

²¹¹ Both Mawangdui have 毋

²¹² Lau has “When there is not enough faith, there is a lack of good faith”, and Wu and Chan has similar. Henricks has “When trust is insufficient, there will be no trust in return.” Waley has “Truly, it is by not believing people that you turn them into liars,” Lin has “When they do not command the people’s faith, some will lose faith in them.”

²¹³ Mawangdui has 猷

²¹⁴ Linnell has “Thoughtful! He values his words.” Lau has “Hesitant, he does not utter words lightly.” Chan has “[The great rules] value their words highly.” Henricks has “Hesitant! Undecided! Like this is his respect for speaking.” Waley has “But from the Sage it is so hard at any price to get a single word.” Lin has “And then they resort to oaths!” Wu has “The sage is self-effacing and scanty of words,” which I don’t follow. Cleary is somewhat similar to mine with this line and the one before” Therefore when faith is insufficient and there is disbelief, it is from the high value placed on words.”

²¹⁵ In the received, Chapter 17 ends here.

²¹⁶ Linnell words this slightly differently but with essentially the same meaning: “We are naturally so”. Wu has “We ourselves have achieved it!” Lau has “It happened to us naturally.” Chan has “[we] just follow Nature.” Henricks has “These things all happened by nature.” Honestly, these are essentially saying the same thing, that the result of the work is that people think it is just naturally so, whether that be how they are or what their circumstance is.

大道廢 有仁義

Big Dao discard/abandon/abolish/neglect/disabled have/exist humane/kind/benevolent proper/dutiful
When the Great Dao was abandoned, there existed benevolence and dutifulness.

慧智出, 有大偽

Intelligence/discerning wisdom go/emerge/produce/send/exceed have big fabricate/artificial/deception
When intelligence and wisdom emerge, there is great fabrication.

六親²¹⁷不和, 有孝慈

Six/house parents/kin/intimate not harmonious have filial-piety tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence
When the six relationships are not harmonious, there is filial piety and merciful care.

國家昏亂, 有忠臣

State family incompetent confused/disordered have wholehearted/dedicated/loyal servant/submission
When the state's officials are incompetent and disordered, there is loyalty and submission.

²¹⁷ According to Cook (from notes in the Guodian), “六親: refers to father and mother, elder and younger brothers, and wife and son(s).”

Guodian (C:1)

大上下²¹⁸智(又/有)之。

Great/big top/above/higher/supreme below/lowly know exist/have this[‘s]

Those below the greatest superiors know they exist.

其²¹⁹即, (𠄎/新)²²⁰(𠄎/譽)之。

Its/their exactly/if/instantly/take-over new/fresh/recently acclaim/commend/reputation/applause this.

Their taking over is met with fresh praise of them,

其既²²¹, (𠄎/畏)²²²之;

Its/their wholly/totally/completely/just-after dreadful/frighten/shrink-from/awe-inducing/exorcise this

Their completion is met with haunting them with fear,

其即, (𠄎/侮)²²³之。

Its/they exactly/if/instantly/take-over offend/humiliate/disrespect them.

Their taking over is met with humiliation for them.

(𠄎/信)²²⁴不足²²⁵

Trust/faith/reliable/pledge not sufficient/enough.

Trust is not enough;

(𠄎/安/焉)²²⁶ (有/又)不信。

Peace/quiet/how/where/than/[interrogative-pronoun] exist/have no trust/faith/reliable

From this, distrust exists,

(𠄎/猷/猶) (虐/乎), 其貴言也。

Design/similar to perhaps/at/in/“!” their cost/value words/speech

Yet still²²⁷ it seems that their value is words.

²¹⁸ Both of these in Guodian have an extra line below and above them, respectively, but this does not change their meaning. See zi.tools for 上 and 下.

²¹⁹ In the Guodian, this is always 𠄎 but the meaning is the same.

²²⁰ 𠄎 Technically 木 over 辛 to the left of 斤 under zi.tools, listed under 新 with many similar examples in zi.tools

²²¹ 𠄎 If this is 即, this character is abnormal (usually expressed as 𠄎). This particular character is listed under 巳 to the left of 丶 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also "just after" or "upon completion" or "as soon as". See also A:10

²²² 𠄎, 心 under 鬼 to mean 畏 (but listed under zi.tools as to mean 媿→悞), but could be read 畏 over 心 (→悞; ashamed, embarrassed). Cook has this as supposed to mean 畏. In A:5, I have this as “haunted”.

²²³ 𠄎 Originally 𠄎 (矛 over 人). Zi.tools lists it under 侮 (offend, insult). Other entries under 柔(𠄎) are consistent with 𠄎(𠄎). 柔 means pliant, bendable, springy, or gentle, soften, tender, or placate, pacify, mollify, soften. It could be 侮, maybe a phonetic loan. Holding a spear to someone is a good way to insult or disgrace them, maybe.

²²⁴ 𠄎 Technically 言 to the left of 人, listed as 信 in zi.tools under (𠄎言千, which is kind of wrong).

²²⁵ Literally, this means “not feet”, but it really means it’s not enough. 足, in oracle bone, was a marching human leg, toward a destination. That your feet marched all the way to the destination, it became in the Zhou an abstract measurement meaning “full, complete, satisfied, sufficient”. Perhaps more viscerally this can be translated as “do not make it there”, or, more literally “has no legs (and thus cannot go)”.

²²⁶ Originally like 𠄎 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 𠄎. This one instance on the strips are faded.

²²⁷ Elsewhere in my translation of the Guodian, I have taken 猷 as 猶, meaning similar to/like, or “designed/plan”. Here, I actually think that the original character’s definition of still/yet works best here. Shuowen Jiezi also lists “hesitant, timid, doubtful and cautious” as meanings of 猶, even relating the “like/similar to” to the act of planning and designing. I do not love the inconsistency in my own translation, so I note it here.

(堊/成)²²⁸事(述/述)(社²²⁹/功),

Complete business/serve recount/rehearse/describe/follow merit/labor/work/achievement/excellence

Complete affairs, follow excellence,²³⁰

而百眚²³¹曰

Yet/but/and hundred eye-cataract/shroud/aberration/ flaw/imperfection say/says:

Yet a hundred cloudy-eyed will say:

我自然²³²也。

“I/we natural/self-nature/self-determined/spontaneously/so-because-so.”²³³

“We are this way on our own.”

(古/故)大道(𡗗/發²³⁴),

Ancient/old//thus Great/big Dao stomps-down//shoots//abandons

Therefore, the great Dao is stomped down,

(安/焉)(有/又)(急/仁)義。

Peace/quiet//how/where/than/[interrogative-pronoun] has benevolence/empathy proper/dutiful²³⁵

From this, compassion and dutifulness exists.

(六/六)²³⁶(𡗗/新/親)不和,

Six/houses(?) new/fresh//parents/kin/intimate/close-to not harmonious

Houses that are new are not harmonious,²³⁷

²²⁸ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 堊. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it’s a phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城.

²²⁹ 元工 originally, where zi.tools lists it. Zi.tools says this is the Chu form of 攻, a sacrificial name, but this character occurs next to 述 in A:20 – why use a totally different character. What we have, it is probably 攻 or 功 based on later versions, which is a deduction I’m hesitant to use. I have done this transcription and translation trying to stay as blind to WangBi, Mawangdui, and anything later as possible, but here I think I’ve hit a dead end. Visually it looks similar to 社 (god of the soil, sacrifices to this god, and sacred), but the element to the right on the slips is pretty unambiguously 工. Shuowen Jiezi is clear about 攻 having a strike/attacking meaning. Probably 功.

²³⁰ Alternatively, “Complete business, record excellence”

²³¹ As 眚, and there are a few in zi.tools under 眚 that look like this too (and others that look normal).

²³² Actually 然, being 然 without the fire radical on bottom. As natural as a dog eating meat. Later Han dynasty scribes added fire because dog-meat didn’t feel great for an abstract philosophical concept.

²³³ Cook has this as “We did it ourselves.”

²³⁴ See A:4. 𡗗 according to Henricks, and I agree this is four feet over a hand. 𡗗, zi.tools agrees (𡗗 | 𡗗一址又), under 發 as “tread on grass, stomp down or cut grass”, used in place for 發 (shoot (like an arrow), go out, set forth, emit, effuse, express, breach) 廢 (discard, abandon, abolish, remove, neglect, disabled) or 伐 (Hack, lop, strike, attack, denounce, condemn, boast; not likely this as this occurs in the Guodian in a much simpler form 𡗗)

²³⁵ 義: right-mindedness, proper, appropriate, dutiful and responsible, but all of these with special attention to one’s own clan or social group. Social consciousness.

²³⁶ Shuowen Jiezi discusses this in terms of the Zhouyi/Yijing, where six is the most yin that is turning into yang. Wiktionary and zi.tools say 六 may have originally meant house or shed, though Kroll only lists “six” and greatest yin. Cook thinks its “六新(親): referring to father and mother, elder and younger brothers, and wife and son(s).”

²³⁷ This is literally “Six new not harmonious”. The received has “六親不和”; the six relationships are not harmonious (see two footnotes above). The characters for occurs several times in the Laozi Guodian in the form right here, including in this very chapter. 親 does not occur in the Laozi Guodian, but still occurs in the Guodian (𡗗). I negotiate by translating this as “houses that are new”, but it very well could match that of the received: “The six relationships are not harmonious.”

(安/焉)(有/又)孝(孳²³⁸/孳)。

Peace/quiet/how/where/than/from-this have/exist filial-devotion multiply/breeding

From this, filial piety and produce children exists.

邦家²³⁹(緡²⁴⁰/昏)(□/亂²⁴¹)

State family fishing-line/coin-string/deploy//twilight/incompetent be-confused/troubled/disordered.

The state's officials are incompetent and disordered,

(安/焉)(有/又)正²⁴²臣。

[Interrogative-pronoun] have/exist proper/correct/rectify subject/servant/anger/submission

From this, correct conduct and submission exists.

²³⁸ 孳 Zi.tools has this as 孳 (propagate, multiply, breed)

²³⁹ Originally 𡩺 over 家 (as listed in zi.tools), sometimes written as 蒙: 𡩺

²⁴⁰ 緡, listed under zi.tools as 緡 → 緡, meaning fishing line, cord for stringing coins, and potentially “to cover”. It is unusual to add a radical to a character for decorative reasons, and 昏 on its own is used in B:5. By context, defaulting to meanings under 昏.

²⁴¹ Partially missing, Henricks reports 𡩺 Maybe originally 𡩺 → 𡩺 (in zi.tools, listed under 吕 to the left of 𡩺 to the left of 吕). 亂 means disordered or rebellious

²⁴² 正, technically 正

Chapter 19

絕聖棄智

Sever/leave-behind/renounce sagacity/virtuousness/mastery, abandon knowledge/wisdom

Leave behind sagacity, abandon wisdom

民利百倍

Common-people benefit hundredfold/[multiply].

The people's benefit will multiply a hundredfold.

絕仁棄義

Sever/leave-behind/renounce humane/kind/benevolent abandon proper/dutiful/responsible²⁴³

Leave behind benevolence, abandon responsibility,

民復孝慈

Common-people return filial-piety tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence

The people will return to filial devotion and loving care of the young.

絕巧棄利

Sever/leave-behind/renounce skill/craftsmanship, abandon benefit/sharp/profit/smooth

Leave behind skill, abandon benefit,

盜賊無有。

Thievishness/stealing outlaw/villainy/murder not/lack/without have/existing

And there will be no stealing or villainy.

此三²⁴⁴者以為文²⁴⁵不足

This/these three, [by-means-of use/act]/serve-as pattern/literature/writing [no-legs]/insufficient

These three things, treated as text, are insufficient.

故令{之}有所屬

Thus/therefore, command/respected/enable have/exist place/that-which attach/connect/follow/category

Therefore, command there to be a place to belong,²⁴⁶

見素抱樸

See/look plain-silk/plain/blank/innocent embrace/hug/enwrap/surround unworked-wood/simple

Look at the plain silk, embrace the unworked wood,

少私²⁴⁷寡欲

Few/reduce/minimize private/personal-bias/self-interest, few/scanty/lessen/widow desire

Reduce one's social ego, lessen one's desires.

²⁴³ 義: right-mindedness, proper, appropriate, dutiful and responsible, but all of these with special attention to one's own clan or social group. Social consciousness.

²⁴⁴ Both Mawangdui insert 言 here.

²⁴⁵ For some reason, it appears that Lindell translates 文 as “civilized society”, and Feng & English, Lin seem to translate this as “external forms”, and Lau, Chan, Waley, and Cleary associate it with “adornments” or “embellishments”. I’m honestly not sure why. Perhaps the next line about plain silk and unworked wood is integrated that way.

²⁴⁶ Alternatively, “Therefore, enable the people to attach themselves to the following”, in the style of Lau, or “Thus, enable the following to be appended [to the three statements],” in the style of Henricks.

²⁴⁷ Mawangdui B has 而 here.

Guodian (A:1)

繼²⁴⁸ 智(弃²⁴⁹/棄)(𦣻/辨)²⁵⁰,

Continue knowledge/wisdom, abandon (artificial) differentiation/discrimination

Keep true knowledge²⁵¹, but abandon artificial classification,

民²⁵²(𠂔/利/利)百(𠂔/倍)²⁵³。

Common-people sharp/smooth/benefit/abundance/cleverness/swift/profit robust/hundredfold/multiply.

And the people's benefit will increase a hundredfold.

繼(𠂔/攷)²⁵⁴ (弃/棄)利,

Continue knock/strike/examine/analyze/research abandon abundance/sharp/benefit

Continue analyzing, but abandon seeking further benefit,

覯(𠂔/惻)²⁵⁵亡(又/有)。

Gazing-from-a-far sorrow/pain/grief not exist/have.

And gazing from afar in sorrow vanishes.

²⁴⁸ Originally 𦣻 throughout chapter, more specifically 𦣻. This was an old form of 繼, though zi.tools claims this is also an old form of 絕 (but this could be due to the assumption that the Guodian slips HAD to match the WangBi, and the sampling from projects that made that assumption). Worth noting: 𦣻 = Left-Facing Skein, means SEVER (絕); 𦣻 = Right-Facing Skein Means CONTINUE (繼). For my translation of the Guodian, we treat it as 繼. Direct visual analysis of the brush paths rejects the standard filing. The graph displays a strict left-anchored vertical thread spine (𠂔/糸) paired with a rightward hand frame (𠂔), matching the precise orthographic blueprint of 繼 (jì - to continue/inherit). By removing this artificial textual editing, the opening philosophy of the manuscript shifts dramatically: it does not recommend an anti-intellectual destruction of knowledge, but rather a developmental mandate to inherit true wisdom (繼智) while abandoning artificial, institutional debate tactics, or arguing (棄辯).

²⁴⁹ 𦣻 Worth noting the etymology of this character is throwing a child into a waste basket, something done to deformed babies or during famine: this is permanent, absolute rejection, illustrated by a visceral cultural horror.

²⁵⁰ 𦣻 Expressed in Cook as 𦣻. (𠂔 over 又). Could be 辨 (discrimination, differentiation, (ultimately artificial classifications), could be 𦣻→鞭 (whip) read (because of shared phonetics and a cut/boundary/dispute connotation) as 辯 (Confucian debate tactics, argumentation, (institutional) disputes) or 辨. By Cook, also could be 二 over 支, could be 便. In zi.tools, 鞭 contains 𦣻, but its page leads to 辨.

²⁵¹ This could be translated as “insight”, as this really has the feeling of perception, observing the patterns of the natural world (自然), and thus the Dao; very much NOT the “cleverness”, or accumulated institutional traditions or accepted interpretations. This is not institutional or traditional judgments of right and wrong, or collection of “established” facts and definitions that should be trusted because everyone else / “smart” people do. This “insight” is the un-labeled, direct, observational understanding of the natural world, not conventional “knowledge”.

²⁵² 𠂔 A proposed etymology for this character is a needle going into an eye, how early rulers blinded slaves to gain their compliance. Eerie how 民 came to mean the “people” or the “masses”, perhaps by compliance with authority.

²⁵³ 𠂔: Zi.tools has this under 𠂔. 𠂔 (robust and stout). It has been suggested that 𠂔 was used in place of 倍 in late Chu writing for mathematical increases, though I have not found a primary source confirming this usage. The reading 倍 as hundredfold is found in later versions of the Laozi, and “hundred robust” is not as intelligible.

²⁵⁴ 𠂔 Right side is definitely 𠂔 (the old version that looked like 𠂔 over the trident that is hand 又. The left is probably 𠂔. Zi.tools indeed has this as 攷 (knock, strike, examine, analyze, research). 𠂔 refers to the experiential skill of an artisan, craftsmanship. This character *could* be 攷 (with 𠂔 = 支 as it always does), meaning wash, cleanse, sometimes in Chu for 修 (to cultivate, cleanse (especially internally), or let flow naturally). See B:7 (攷)

²⁵⁵ With these two characters, my translation is a bit unique. I keep 覯 (technically 見 to the left of 兆, reflected by zi.tools) as “to gaze far away” (perhaps with envy or ambition, also means a lord’s audience), and I keep 惻 (as on zi.tools, but technically 𠂔) as “sorrow, grief, suffering”, or literally, as it is a ding-cauldron above a heart.

繼愚²⁵⁶(弃/棄)慮²⁵⁷,

Continue intentional-action/changing abandon calculated-anxiety/strategic-worry

Continue intentional action and abandon strategic anxiety,

民(复/復)季²⁵⁸子。

Common-people return/revert/cycle-back baby/newborn.

People will go back to being young.

三言以為史²⁵⁹不足,

Three statements, [by-means-of use/do]/taken-as through-records/decrees, not enough/sufficient²⁶⁰

Three statements used as written decrees are insufficient,

或(命/令)之或(虐/乎)(豎/豎²⁶¹/屬)。

In-some-cases commanding, in-some-cases perhaps/“!”/in-containers/bean/[see footnote]

When one sometimes commands it, and sometimes perhaps forces it into containers.

(豎²⁶²/視)(索/索)保(豎²⁶³/僕)²⁶³

Look/view/compare/regard rope/norm/force-to-do/unstrung/unconnected protect servant/attached-to

Look at the ropes, protect the bound dependent.

少(△/私)(須²⁶⁴/欲²⁶⁵)。

Few/reduce/minimize private/personal-bias/self-interest, need/slow/need-to/wait-for desire.

Reduce your self-interest, limit your cravings to what you need.

²⁵⁶ Originally 爲 over 心 → 愚 (which zi.tools agrees with), which may be a phonetic loan word for 化 (change) but I can't find a source for this. It could be 偽 (harmonious accord), or this for 偽 (artificiality, deception, departure from the uncarved wood). But see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 226: I actually agree with him, that this is 爲 (to do, to act) with the heart radical giving a sense of emotional/mental aspect: intentional action

²⁵⁷ Could be in the place of 詐 (deception, fakery), 怙 (pride), or 虐 (cruelty, autocratic abuse), but see Cook (page 226). The original 慮 (ponder, anticipate, reflect, infer, probably strategic worry/ calculated anxiety) works well.

²⁵⁸ 季子, newborn, baby son (See the Mawangdui medical manual 脈法 (Mai Fa). 季 itself originally meant young grain, but was extended to mean youngest brother, and generally as a connotation of young.

²⁵⁹ Originally 史, which is technically 卜 over 日 over 又, how it is rendered in zi.tools, where it is listed under 史 (policy (especially written), scribe, historian, ritualists decrees, employment). However, zi.tools also lists this character to mean 事, which I find less convincing, as this character appears elsewhere in another form. (See A:17)

²⁶⁰ 足, in oracle bone, was a marching human leg, toward a destination. That your feet marched all the way to the destination, it became in the Zhou an abstract measurement meaning “full, complete, satisfied, sufficient”. Perhaps more viscerally this can be translated as “do not make it there”, or, more literally “has no legs (so cannot go)”.

²⁶¹ 豎 → 豆. This means food container (a shallow round container on stems with a lid, sometimes used in ritual sacrifice) or beans/legumes, so probably a loan. Cook has many suggestions. 屬 (categories, different-but-the-same in the Shuowen Jiezi), used in the Mawangdui and WangBi. 樹 (plant, set upright, of plants; interesting because 豆 was part of its ancient character according to the Shuowen Jiezi, with an impression of straightness; but, a different character in the Guodian already exists for this character.) I favor this reading partially on thematic grounds, risking confirmation bias; fitting people into bean-pods or containers fits themes of the Guodian. The received has 屬.

²⁶² Technically 目 over 人

²⁶³ Originally 僕: 羹 (thicket, dense uncontrolled wild undergrowth) or 犇 (cluster of grass) over 臣 (minister, slave). May be 僕 → 僕 = servant (unsophisticated, “ignorant”, uncorrupted person, attached to or connected with); this servant reading matches zi.tools better. 《漢語同源詞大典》 claims that 僕 and 僕 mean “attachment” or “dependence”. Zi.tools has under 僕: I don't think it is accurate, should be 犇 over 臣 or similar: there's no man.

²⁶⁴ 須 Controversial, usually rendered 寡, sometimes rendered to 須 (beard → need, await, require/ stay for) which is most supported by zi.tools, but may be an abbreviation of 寡. Maybe should be read as 顧. (See A:13)

²⁶⁵ Chu variant of 欲 listed under zi.tools is 谷 + 次

Chapter 20

絕學無憂

Sever/leave-behind learn/mimic without/lack worry/anxiety/grief

Leave behind learning without worry.

唯之與阿

Only/accept/agree ['s]/this join/unite/grant/give slope/brace/strut/support/biased-to/pander/flatter²⁶⁶

Agreement is together with pandering,

相去幾何

Each-other go/leave latent/invisible/faint/omen/stirring/almost/how-much how/why?

How much can these leave each other?

善²⁶⁷之與惡

Good/skilled/excellence ['s]/this and/join/unite/grant/give ugly/hateful

Excellence is together with hatefulness,

相去若何²⁶⁸

Each-other leave like/as-for how/why

How can these depart from being like each other?

人之所畏不可不畏

People ['s] that-which/place fear not able/possible not fear

What people fear, one cannot avoid fear of it.

荒兮其未央哉

Weed-choked/neglected/barren/self-indulgent [!] Their not-yet center/to-end/inside exclamation!

Neglected! They are not yet finished!²⁶⁹

眾人熙熙,

Multitude/crowd people shine/glitter/radiant/serene x2

The crowds of people are radiant and shining,

如享²⁷⁰太牢²⁷¹

Like/if offer-sacrifice/sacrificial-feast/relish/enjoy-gift great/grand/extreme pen/sacrificial-animal

Like enjoying a grand sacrificial feast,

如春登臺,

Like springtime/vigor/vitality climb/ascend/advance tower/terrace

Like in springtime ascending terraces;

²⁶⁶ Mawangdui has 訶 (A) and 呵 (B). Legge has the translation I understand the most, with “The (ready) ‘yes’ and (flattering) ‘yea’,” but this line has a lot of variation.

²⁶⁷ Mawangdui has 美, see Guodian

²⁶⁸ Mawangdui has the last two characters in the opposite order.

²⁶⁹ Mawangdui has 壘 for 荒 and 才 for 哉. There’s a lot of variation in how this line is translated. Linnell has “How ridiculous! They are not yet centered,” but Kroll does not mention an exclamatory or scolding flavor to 荒. Wu has “what abysmal nonsense this is!” Lau has “And wax without having reached the limit,” which I also struggle to understand. Chan has “But, alas, how confused, and the end is not yet.” Henricks has “Wild, unrestrained! It will never come to an end.” Waley has “How false and superficial it is!”, Lin has “Ah, distant yet is the dawn (of awakening)!”, Cleary has “Wild indeed the uncentered!” Feng & English simply have “What nonsense!” Honestly I find the range of this variation kind of bizarre, and I really am not sure how some got to “nonsense” – there has to be something I’m missing.

²⁷⁰ Mawangdui has 鄉 instead.

²⁷¹ 太牢, Lau considers this to refer to the Tai Lao sacrifice/festival

我獨泊兮

I/me solitary/alone/unique moor-boat/pause/rest/sedate/tranquil/ripple [!]

I, alone, pause!

其未兆

Their/perhaps not-yet omen/sign/origin/begin

Perhaps not yet divining an omen,²⁷²

如嬰兒²⁷³之未孩

Like/if baby/child ['s]/this not-yet infant-smile

Like an infant's not yet smiling.

僂僂²⁷⁴兮若無所歸

Tired-&-overtaxed/fatigued/worn-out [!] like without/lack that-which/place go-home/restore/refuge

Fatigued and exhausted, like one without a place to go home or take refuge.

眾人皆有餘

Multitude/crowd people all have/exist surplus/remainder

The crowds of people all have surplus,

而我獨若遺

And/but/yet I alone/unique/solitary like neglect/ignore/reject/lose/bestow/leaves-behind

Yet I alone am as if I left everything behind.

我愚人之心也哉, 沌沌兮

I ignorant/untaught people ['s]/this heart/mind [!] Uneducated/unaware/ignorant/benighted x2 [!]

Mine are the heart and mind of an ignorant person, indeed! So unaware and uneducated!

俗²⁷⁵人昭昭, 我獨昏昏²⁷⁶

Popular/simple/vulgar/usual-actions people radiant/display/perceptive/astute, I alone dusk/incompetent

Normal people are bright and perceptive, I alone am dim and confused.

俗人察察, 我獨悶悶

Popular/simple/vulgar people scrutinize/pristine-purity, I alone gloomy/despondent/stupid-seeming

Normal people are pristinely white, I alone am gloomily dull.

澹兮其若海

Placid/tranquil/mild [!] Their/perhaps like sea

Placid, perhaps like the sea!²⁷⁷

²⁷² 其 is not a first-person possessive. Linnell has “Like one who has not given any sign,” but there is no 如 in this line. Wu has “I alone am placid and give no sign,” and Lau and has essentially the same, and so does Chan, though adds the sign is of desires. Henricks has very similar to Wu, only with “not yet having given any sign”. 兆 as sign refers to a prophetic sign, as one in divination, not a signal in the human communicative sense.

²⁷³ 嬰 means “encircle, sustain, enwrap;” and 兒 means “youth, child”

²⁷⁴ In place of both of these characters, Mawangdui has 累

²⁷⁵ Everywhere this occurs, Mawangdui has 鬻, “peddle, hawk, vend, or sell.”

²⁷⁶ Mawangdui has 我獨若悶呵, “I alone am as though troubled/gloomy/despondent/stupid-seeming/stuffy.”

²⁷⁷ Perhaps I am biased by a life of familiarity with swimming and observing the Atlantic Ocean, but “tranquil” and “placid” would only describe it on some days, probably not even most. The South China Sea may be different, but given that it births monsoons and typhoons, I still can’t help but be skeptical about this.

漂²⁷⁸ 兮 若 無 止

Gust/blow/drift-on-wind/glide [!] like without/lack limit/end/stop/halt

Drifting in the wind! As though without stopping.

眾 人 皆 有 以

Crowd/multitude people all have/exist by-means-of/use

The crowds of people all have a use,

而 我 獨 頑 似 鄙

And/yet/but I alone coarse/unpolished/crude/stupid/stubborn, seems-like low/mean/vulgar/vilipend

And yet I, alone, am coarse, seeming as though vulgar.

我 獨 異 於 人, 而 貴 食 母

I alone different at/in/from/than/regarding people, and/yet value/precious food/eat/nourish mother

I, alone, am different from people, and value being nourished of the mother.

²⁷⁸ Mawangdui has 𩇑, HeShangGong has 漂. Wang Bi has 颿 (when reduplicated, rush and gust, rush and roar, like high wind, or blank and empty, according to Kroll; Wiktionary has “to drift”. In this case, I use the character from HeShangGong (漂, which by Kroll and Wiktionary is an alternate form of 飄: to gust, blow, float or toss on the wind, flutter, glide.)

Guodian (B:3)

(𠄎²⁷⁹/繼)學亡(𠄎/𠄎/憂)²⁸⁰,

Continue learning/mimicry without/no/lose anxiety/worrying

Continue learning without worrying.

唯²⁸¹(𠄎/與)²⁸²可,

Only/agree/assent/accept give/grant/associate/unite/and/join able/can/permissible/possible/how

Agreement grants permission,

相去幾 可?

Each-other go/leave latent/invisible/faint/omen/stirring/almost/how-much able/possible/can?

How much can these leave each other?

美²⁸³(𠄎/与)²⁸⁴(𠄎/亞²⁸⁵),

Beauty/finest bestows/gives/grants inferiority.

The finest bestows inferiority,

相去可?

Each other go/leave possible/able/permissible?

How can these go from each other?

若²⁸⁶人之所²⁸⁷(𠄎/魂/畏),

If/like/as-for people that-which/place ghost/demon/secret/spirit/fear

As for that which haunts people,

亦不可以不(魂/畏)人²⁸⁸。

In-that-case not permissible/can by-means-of not fear people.

They too cannot, by means of this, not be haunted by people.

²⁷⁹ 𠄎→繼, where it is listed in zi.tools. (Compare with 𠄎 from A:1). Both are considered to be old forms of 繼, to continue/inherit. These are both with the vertical line on the left, so clearly “continue” and not “sever”.

²⁸⁰ 𠄎, Originally 頁+心 (listed as 愼 in zi.tools but similar characters are found under 愼, both listed under 愼). 愼→憂 (anxious, burdened with care, constantly worried, grief, afflicted; 愼→愼→憂.) 愼→順 (compliance, agreeable, to follow/go along with, conforming, accommodating). See A:17 𠄎

²⁸¹ 唯; in zi.tools found under 隹. 隹 literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom would lead me to support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 隹, to sell, is unlikely.

²⁸² Can also mean to give to/grant to, to be associated with, and, also a blend of 乎 and 也 when ending sentences.

²⁸³ Originally a person in a fancy feathered hat, 𠄎, 美 is the front profile used today. 𠄎 is a typing placeholder. yet zi.tools lists this character here, but maintaining that it is still 羽 (feather) over 亻 (a person).

²⁸⁴ 𠄎 This is not 與 (𠄎)— it is not shaped the way 與 is in any other part of the text (but see A:2 and A:10 𠄎).

Henricks has 与 over 𠄎, zi.tools has this just under 与. This difference is not arbitrary: The Shuowen Jiezi has 与 to mean unidirectional giving (one person giving/bestowing a scoop to another), and 與 is communal or mutual giving with multiple parties working to lift and carry together. In the Han, these collapsed into the 與.

²⁸⁵ Here, technically 亞 around 十 according to zi.tools. Kroll’s dictionary defines it as “secondary, junior; inferior”.

²⁸⁶ 𠄎 Looks closer to 𠄎/都 (which it can’t be), or 𠄎 (How) or even 𠄎 (to assent, agree), or 𠄎, or 𠄎 (interrogative particle that may work), or something else with 乃 or 又 on the right? (若+乃)??? I cannot find this character at all on zi.tools. It does almost look like 若 (𠄎 or 𠄎) but with 乃 or 𠄎 next to it. I must default to 若.

²⁸⁷ 之所 is represented by one, fused character on the actual Guodian slips(𠄎), but this visually checks out and is confirmed by a = mark below it (also repetition of a character but used a different way for contractions).

²⁸⁸ May actually not be here, but part of B:4 of Guodian

Chapter 21

孔 德 之 容

Small-hole/penetrate/broad/affect virtue/power [‘s] appearance/permit/tolerate/accept/pardon/receive

Broad virtue is allowed,

唯 道 是 從

Only/agree/assent Dao this/truly follow/join

When only the Dao is truly followed.²⁸⁹

道 之 為 物 唯 恍²⁹⁰ 唯²⁹¹ 惚²⁹²

Dao [‘s]/this do/act-as/use thing only dazed/confused/blurred only distracted/unclear/murky/smudged

The Dao’s use of things is only confusing, only unclear.

惚 兮 恍 兮 其 中 有 象

Confused/dazed/blurred [!] distracted/unclear/murky [!] their center/middle has/exists image/imitate

Confusing! Unclear! Its core has images.

恍 兮 惚 兮 其 中 有 物

Distracted/unclear/murky [!] Confused/dazed/blurred [!] their center has/exists things

Unclear! Confusing! Its core has things.

窈 兮 冥 兮 其 中 有 精²⁹³

Removed/secluded [!] dark/gloomy/unseen/faint [!] its center/middle/core has essence/pure

Secluded! Unseen! Its core has essence.

其 精 甚 真, 其 中 有 信

Its essence excessive/too-much real/true/authentic/pure, its center has/exists trust/faith/evidence/proof

Its essence is too real, its core has evidence.

自 古²⁹⁴ 及 今, 其 名 不 去

Self/spontaneously/from ancient/old reach/arrive/if now/present its name no leave/depart

From ancient times, reaching the present, its name does not depart

以 閱²⁹⁵ 眾 甫²⁹⁶

By-means-of scrutinize/inspect/search/experience/pass-through multitudes for-first-time/just-now/large

By means of this, it experiences the first times of the multitudes.

²⁸⁹ More literally: “The Allowing of the Broad Virtue, is only (through) truly following the Dao”. Alternatively, “The countenance of the Broad Virtue; Only the Dao does this follow.” Linnell has “The Greatest De (virtue) is possible only when Dao is followed.” Wu has “It lies in the nature of Grand Virtue to follow the Dao and the Dao alone.” Lau has “In his every moment a man of great virtue follows the Way and the Way only.” Henricks has “The character of great virtue follows along from the Way.” Feng & English have “The greatest Virtue is to follow Dao and Dao alone.” All agree that broad virtue comes from following the Dao.

²⁹⁰ Mawangdui has 𠄎, this occurs everywhere WangBI has 恍 in this chapter. 恍惚 itself means dazed and distracted, confused and unclear, muddled and murky, blurred and smudged. 惚恍 means the same.

²⁹¹ Wang Bi has 惟, but HeShangGong and Mawangdui (both A, and B) both have 唯

²⁹² In this chapter, wherever this character occurs, HeShangGong has 忽

²⁹³ Mawangdui has 請 for both occurrences of this character

²⁹⁴ For 古, Mawangdui have the opposite: 今. For instances of 今, Mawangdui has 古

²⁹⁵ Mawangdui has 順

²⁹⁶ For both instances, Mawangdui has 父, father. However, while this is sometimes written as 甫, 甫 does not itself mean this. I’m not convinced this is what is meant, though maybe it is; if so, then this would become “By means of this we experience the multitudes’ father.” The reason I doubt this is because the Dao is most often referred to as a mother, so the shift here would be strange.

吾何以知眾甫之然²⁹⁷哉

I how/why by-means-of know multitudes/crowd first-time ['s] nature/self-so [!]

How do I know the first times of the multitudes is like this? ²⁹⁸

以此

By-means-of this.

Through this.

²⁹⁷ Wang Bi has 狀, but HeShangGong and both Mawangdui have 然 (naturally, self-so).

²⁹⁸ Again, if we take 甫 as 父 (father); “How do I know the father of the multitudes is like this?”

Chapter 22

曲則²⁹⁹全, 枉則直

Bent/twist/intricate when-then/rule whole/perfect, bent/crooked/perverse when-then straight/upright

If bent, then perfect; if crooked, then straight;

窪³⁰⁰則盈, 敝則新

Puddle when/then full/overfilled, deteriorated/badly-used/worn-out/destroy when-then new/fresh

If there is a sink in the ground, then full; if worn out, then new.

少則得, 多則惑

Reduce/few when-then obtain, many/much/exceed when-then deceived/delude/fool/mislead/perplex

If few, then gain; if many, then perplexity.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the Sage

抱一{以}為天下³⁰¹式

Embrace/hug/enwrap/surround one do/use/act-as world model/pattern/paradigm/emulate/config/use

Embraces the One, acting as the model of the world.

不自見故明

Not self see/perceive therefore perceptive/bright/illuminate

Not seeing for oneself, therefore perceptive³⁰²

不自是故彰

Not self this/affirm/prove/support therefore decorated/signal/display

Not affirming oneself, therefore decorated for distinguishing merits.

不自伐故有功

Not self hack-at/attack/condemn/boast therefore has work/accomplishment/excellence

Not boasting of oneself, therefore having accomplishments.

不自矜故長

Not self flaunt/brag/sympathy/peril/important therefore long-standing/enduring/mature/old/long

Not flaunting oneself, therefore long-lasting.

夫唯不爭

In-any-case only not compete/contend/vie/quarrel

For anyone, only by not competing,

²⁹⁹ This word is often in the “if X, then Y” sense, but in speaking in generalities, not for specific situations. I translate it as “when”, like in “When there’s smoke, there’s fire.” The variation for these phrases is much. Linnell has “What is wrong then becomes whole [...]”, But Wu has “Bend and you will be whole, curl and you will be straight [...]”, and Henricks, and Waley have similar, as does Chan somewhat. Lau just has “Bowed down then preserved; bent then straight” which is most literal.

³⁰⁰ I can’t help wondering if 窞 (small hollow, depression, hole, cavity, excavate) would make more sense here? According to my sources, no versions have 窞. Linnell puts “hollow” for 窪, though Kroll has this as a “still pond, puddle, stagnant water, sink.” Wu, has “keep empty”, Lau has “Hollow” as well, Chan has “empty, Henricks has “hollowed out.” Is there a typo in Kroll?

³⁰¹ I translate this as “world”, but technically this is “Heaven under” → under Heaven.

³⁰² See Chapter 24. This is often translated as something like “He doesn’t make a show of himself, therefore he shines/perceives.” This “appear, show forth, be seen” definition is actually a loan from 現, according to Kroll.

故天下莫能與之爭

Therefore Heaven under in-no-case/nobody can/able/capable join/grant/give/unite ['s]/this compete
As a result, in the world there is nobody able to join the competition.

古之所謂

Ancient/old ['s]/this that-which/place called/say

That which the ancients said:

曲則全者

Bend/twist when-then whole [person/phrase]

“What is bent is then perfect,”

豈虛言哉

Is-it-really-(rhetorical)(?) empty/diminished words/speech [!]

Are these truly empty words?!

誠全而歸之

Sincere/really/verily/actually/if-really whole/perfect/complete and/yet/but return/go-home ['s]/this

Actually be perfect, and return to this. ³⁰³

³⁰³ This is another line with lots of variation. Linnell has “Be truly whole and perfect, and return to it.” Wu has “Nay, if you have really attained wholeness, everything will flock to you.” I guess this “flock to” comes from the “take refuge with” meaning of 歸. Lau has “Truly it enables one to be preserved to the end.” Chan ahs “Truly he will be preserved and (prominence, etc.) will come to him.” Henricks has “Truly “wholeness” will belong to him.” Waley has “True wholeness can only be achieved by return.” Cleary has “When truthfulness is complete, it still resorts to this.” Feng & English have “Be really whole, and all things will come to you.” Lin has “Thus he is preserved and the world does him homage.” Linnell openly states that what “this” is, is not clear in the text. Perhaps returning to being bent?

Chapter 23

希言自然

Rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to reach/arrive/catch-up-to/succeed/attain words/speech self nature/so

Sparse words are natural,

故飄風不終³⁰⁴ 朝

Therefore/as-a-result whirlwind/tempest/flutter/glide wind not finish/end/finally morning/whole-day

Thus, as tempest winds do not finish³⁰⁵ the morning,

驟雨不終日

Quick-onset/galloping/headstrong/recurrent rain not finish/end/finally day

And sudden downpours do not finish the day.

孰為此者天地

Who/which do/use/act-as/manipulate this/these [‘s]/this Heaven Earth

Who manipulates these? Heaven and Earth.

天地尚不能久

Heaven Earth exalt/surpass/even/venerable/manage not able/capable old/endure/long-standing

Heaven and Earth, even they cannot make these last long,³⁰⁶

而況於人乎

And/but/yet equal-to/even-more/how-much-more(?) at/in/regard/than people [?]

Yet how much more than people?

故從事於道者

Thus/therefore follow/join matters/to-serve in/at/than Dao [person/phrase]

Therefore, those that follow matters are in the Dao.

道者³⁰⁷ 同於道

Dao [person/phrase] unite/join/same at/in/than/regarding Dao

One who does Dao is united with the Dao.

德者同於德

Virtue/power [person/phrase] unite/join/same at/in/than/regarding virtue/power

One who does virtue is united with virtue.

失者同於失

Lose [person/phrase] unite/join/same in/at/than/regarding lose/loss

One who loses is united with the loss.

同於道者, 道亦樂得之

Unite/join/same in/at/than Dao [person/phrase], Dao too/in-that-case music/glee obtain [‘s]/this

Those who are united with the Dao, the Dao too is happy to obtain them.

同於德者, 德亦樂得之

Unite/join/same in/at/than virtue [person/phrase], virtue too/in-that-case music/glee obtain [‘s]/this

Those who are united with virtue, virtue too is happy to obtain them

³⁰⁴ In this chapter, everywhere 終 occurs, Mawangdui has 冬 (winter)

³⁰⁵ In the sense of “make it to the end of”, in both this line and the next

³⁰⁶ Literally, this could be read “Heaven and Earth, even they cannot endure”, but this would contradict the enduring nature that is actually consistent elsewhere in the Dao De Jing.

³⁰⁷ This repeated 道者 is not repeated in the Mawangdui

同於失者,失亦樂得之³⁰⁸

Unite/join/same in/at/than lose [person/phrase], lose too/in-that-case music/glee obtain ['s]/this

Those who are united with the loss, the loss too is happy to obtain them.

信不足焉有不信焉

Trust/faith/reliable not sufficient/leg of-this/from-this, exist/have not trust/faith/reliable from-this

If trust is insufficient, then distrust will exist³⁰⁹.

³⁰⁸ Instead of 失亦樂得之, Mawangdui has 道亦失之 – The Dao too loses them/him.

³⁰⁹ Many translations render this instead as “One who does not trust/have faith will not be trusted/believed in”, such as Feng & English, Lin, Chan, Linnell, and maybe Wu.

Chapter 24

企³¹⁰者不立

Stand-on-tiptoe/stand-straight/anticipate [person/phrase] no/do-not stand-straight/install/instantly

Those standing on their tiptoes do not stand straight,

跨者不行

Straddle/overstep/ride [person/phrase] not engage/enact/move/walk

Those with an overstepping gait do not walk,

自見者不明

Self see/perceive [person/phrase] not perceptive/bright/illuminate/clear

Those who see for themselves are not perceptive,³¹¹

自是者不彰³¹²

Self this/any/affirm/prove/support/true [person/phrase] not evident/decorated/signal/display

Those who affirm themselves are not decorated for distinguishing merits.

自伐者無功

Self hack-at/attack/condemn/boast [person/phrase] without/lack work/accomplishment/excellence

Those who boast of themselves lack accomplishments.

自矜者不長

Self flaunt/brag/sympathy/peril/important [person/phrase] not long-standing/enduring/mature/old/long

Those who flaunt themselves do not last long.

其在道也

Their position/be-at Dao

Those whose positions are with the Dao

曰餘食贅行

Say remainder/surplus food/eat/take-in collateral/freeload/parasite/tumor/superfluous enact/move

Call these leftover food and superfluous movements.

物或惡之

Thing/creature some/perhaps/sometimes/someone ugly/hateful/abhorrent [‘s]/this

Some things hate these.

故有道者不處

Therefore/as-a-result have/exist Dao [person/phrase] not stay/reside/occupy

Therefore, one who has the Dao will not dwell with these.

³¹⁰ Mawangdui has 吹 (blow, gust, puff), and Henricks has “One who boasts is not established.” But I don’t know if this is related – he’s an odd one out.

³¹¹ See Chapter 22. This is also often translated as “one who displays/shows/displays/reveals himself is not luminous/shining/conspicuous/enlightened.” (Wu, Lau, Chan, Henricks, Lin, Feng & English, Linnell.) Waley has “He who does his own looking sees little.” Cleary has “Those who see themselves are not perceptive.” This “appear, show forth, be seen” definition is actually a loan from 現, according to Kroll.

³¹² Mawangdui has 自視者不章

Chapter 25

有物混³¹³成, 先天地生

Have/exist things murky/confused/inchoate-chaos complete/achieve first/prior Heaven Earth born/live
There existed disorganized, complete things, before heaven and earth were created.

寂³¹⁴兮寥兮, 獨立不改

Silent/still/forlorn [!] deserted/empty [!] solitary/alone/unique stand/confirm/install not change/modify
Silent! Deserted! Standing alone, not altered.

周行而不殆

Dense/thick/thorough/encircle/encompass transmit/walks/move/engage and/yet/but not danger/peril
Thoroughly transmitted, but not dangerous.

可以為天下母

Permissible/possible by-means-of use/do/act-as under-heaven mother
It can be used as the mother of everything in the world.³¹⁵

吾不知其名, 字之曰道

I not know it/its name, procreate/foster/love/name ['s]/this/it say/called Dao/way
I do not know its name, the name I call it by is "Dao."

強為之名曰大

Strong/try-hard/dominate do/use/act-as ['s]/this name says/called big/great
Forced to use a name, we call it "great."

大曰逝³¹⁶

Great/big says/called go-away/pass-away/die/depart
Greatness is called departing,

逝曰遠

Depart/go-away/pass-away/die says/called distant/far/separated/estranged/far-reaching
Departing is called distant,

遠曰反

Distant/far/separated says/called turn-back/reverse/invert/oppose
Distant is called turning back.

故道大, 天大, 地大, 王亦大

Thus, Dao/way big/great, Heaven big/great, Earth big/great, King too/for-his-part big/great
Thus, the Dao is great, Heaven is great, Earth is great, and the King, too, is great.

域中有四大, 而王居其一焉

Territory/state center/middle exist/has four big/great, and/but king dwells it/its one of-them
The territory center has four greats, and the king dwells as one of them.

人法地, 地法天, 天法道, 道法自然

People lawful/rules/norm Earth, "" rules/norm heaven, "" rules/norm Dao, "" rules/norm self-nature
People are ruled by Earth, Earth is ruled by Heaven, Heaven is ruled by Dao, and Dao rules itself.

³¹³ Both Mawangdui have 昆 here (together, mass, unified, numerous, sameness, worm.)

³¹⁴ For 寂, Mawangdui A has 繡 (embroider, gorgeous, colorful) and B has 蕭 (untouched by outside influences, somber, grave, sedate, cool, brisk; for 寥, A has 繆 (silk, entwine, solemn, reverent, interlock) and B has 漻 (clear, pure, limpid, transparent, flow through, run through, saddened, disturbed).

³¹⁵ Or, "It can be considered the mother of (everything in) the world."

³¹⁶ Mawangdui has 筮

Guodian (A:11)

(又/有)(𠂔/狀)³¹⁷(𧈧/蟲³¹⁸/昆)(壁³¹⁹/成)(𠂔/先)天地³²⁰生,

Have/exist form/shape/condition/describe insects//togetherness complete

Having a form, a swarm was whole before Heaven and Earth first came into being,

(𠂔/斂)(𠂔/穆)³²¹, (𧈧/蜀³²²/獨)立, 不(𧈧/亥)³²³,

Take-by-force/seize/lose generosity/harmony/tranquility stand-straight/confirm/install not boar

Abducting full harmony, solitarily standing, not hoarding itself away.³²⁴

(𧈧/𠂔³²⁵)以為天下母。

Impossible/thereupon [by-means-of act-as]/make-into/use-as all under heaven mother/source

Impossible to be used as the mother of all under heaven³²⁶.

³¹⁷ Originally 𠂔+首 according to Cook and Henricks, the reality looks like this: 𠂔, however I have not seen many other Chu characters with 𠂔 in this spot that look like this, even if this character is faded, and 首 has a similar problem unless you rotate it but it doesn't open at the top. Specifically 𠂔 𠂔首 in Zi.tools (𠂔) This character is one even the experts argue about. While I'm iffy on it, Cook's notes convinced me and I default to 狀.

³¹⁸ 蟲 Literally means insects, bugs, creepy-crawlies in general, and the graph is three (many) bugs together. However, by the ShuowenJiezi listing in zi.tools (段玉裁 commentary), this may have connotations of multitude (眾) Mawangdui has 昆 (together, mass, last in a sequence, numerous, sameness, unified-as-one, posterity, but also worm). Capturing the bug and togetherness meanings, both having connotations of mass and multitude, I translate this as “swarming” or “swarm” – multiple small individuals in a mass, not necessarily coordinated in any way.

³¹⁹ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 壁. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

³²⁰ Originally 陀 with 土 under, but original fits perfect for the Chu silk script rendering of 地, derived from 墜

³²¹ 𠂔 Honestly I'm having a hard time parsing this personally, but apparently the original was 穆 over 糸 and reflected like this in zi.tools (a full ear of grain hanging downward in the sunlight →harmony, beauty, well-ordered, generous, tranquil, friendly ...then over silk? Cook has 𠂔 糸穆). Looking at other samples in zi.tools, this could just be 穆 itself without silk. Maybe could be 𠂔- fly high (see Mawangdui) → empty/silent/profound (𠂔), though I still see the grain element in 𠂔. The oracle bone and bronze script versions of 穆 bear resemblance to this character.

³²² 𧈧 Original appears to lack 𠂔: Huge eye 目 over the up-arrow that is 虫, representing a large-eyed insect, a caterpillar (variant of 蠅, in zi.tools and Wiktionary) or a silkworm in a flower (Shuowen Jiezi). This came to have the meaning of solitary, maybe because caterpillars live alone, isolated, sometimes in cocoons. In zi.tools as 蜀.

³²³ This literally means the 12th branch of the earthly branches, associated with boars (and pigs). Han texts also describe this as blocking or closing off (Han Shu, section on Astronomy and Calendars), and storing up all things (Shiming, Explaining names). This COULD be a phonetic loan for 改 (changing).

³²⁴ Or, “Forcibly taking full harmony, solitarily standing like a caterpillar, but not hoarding itself away in a cocoon.”

³²⁵ This is not just backwards 可; this is listed as 𠂔 in zi.tools, the Shuowen Jiezi (and San Cang) defines this as 不可, “cannot do”. This means impossible. (Kroll also lists “thereupon,” but I cannot find this use before the Han.)

³²⁶ The Guodian slip unmistakably has 𠂔 (cannot/impossible, inversion of 可). Crucially, this negation modifies the compound verb 以為 (used as, make into, take as, consider to be). In Warring States syntax, 以 functions as an instrumental verb (by means of, use X for) and 為 can occasionally be translated as “to act as”, in addition to “to manipulate, use, do.” On this reading the swarm cannot be used as (or taken as) “mother”. 以為 is critical in this sentence. I reckon (and this is speculative) the swarm probably IS the source of life (and in this sense a mother), but you cannot harness or utilize this to make a comforting power structure with a maternal flavor. Alternatively, 𠂔

未智其(明³²⁷/名),

Still not/not/haven't knowledge its/their name

Their name is still not known.

(𦉰/絳/茲)³²⁸之曰道,

This says/call Way/Dao/path

This here we call “the Dao”.³²⁹

(虐/吾)(𠂔/騁)³³⁰為之名曰大。

I/we powerful/forced/vigorous use/do [‘s]/it name say/call big/great

We forcefully use this name and call it “great.”

大曰(𦉰/逝/濫)³³¹, (逝/濫)曰(𠂔/連/轉), (連/轉)曰反。

Great/big calls overflow/surge, “” calls turn/roll/change/rotate, “” calls turn-back/reverse/invert/oppose

Great is called overflowing, overflowing is called rolling, rolling is called turning back.

天大, 地大, 道大, 王亦大。

Heaven great, Earth great, Dao great, king for-his-part/too great.

Heaven is great, Earth is great, the Dao is great, and the king too is great.

(國³³²/域)(𡗗/中)(又/有)四大(𡗗/焉)³³³ 王(尻/居³³⁴)-(𡗗/焉)。

Territory/capital-city core/middle has/exists four great/big there, King rests/lives/sits one from-them.

A territory's center has four greats there, the king dwells as one of them.

人灋³³⁵地, 地灋天,

People model/ruled-by earth, earth model/ruled-by heaven

People are ruled by the Earth, the Earth is ruled by Heaven,

can be used for 'thereupon', so this can be translated as “Thereupon this acts as the mother of all under heaven,” or “Thereupon this is taken as the world's mother.” But then we risk ignoring or flattening the 以 or 為.

³²⁷ From zi.tools, on the origin of 明/名, describing the act of using the mouth to announce oneself in the dark when people cannot see each other. This is establishing of one's identity, to distinguish oneself from foes and danger.

³²⁸ Zi.tools lists this as 絳, as do Henricks and Cook, as 絳 over 才, but it technically looks like 絳. Two threads over “talent (grass growing on soil).” According to zi.tools, could be 災 (calamity, disaster; phonetic loan), 蕙 (afraid; unclear connection), or 茲 (this, visual similarity), or 哉 (used for question or rhetorically).

³²⁹ Alternatively, “This calamity we call the Dao.” A swarm of forces and spirits and everything can look disastrous and scary, even if it is sacred and the origin of all things. Perhaps what cannot be utilized, what is untamable, is scary and formidable. But the dry, drawly, “this here we call the Dao” honestly resonates with me a bit more.

³³⁰ In zi.tools as 𠂔 over 力, under 騁. This is a Warring States form of 騁. See A:17, and A:4 (rigid-power). The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 但 (𠂔), a variant of 𠂔 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong) → “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

³³¹ Originally 𦉰 → 潛 → 𦉰, see Cook's “Bamboo Texts of Guodian”, page 258. Bottom is probably 水 above 曰. With maybe 𦉰 above that? I wasn't able to confirm with zi.tools and get a match, so I defaulted to Cook's 逝, which many paleographers appear to have agreed on, but with the sense of 濫 and 涵, flooding and overflowing, following Zhao JianWei, Hantang Di, Liu Zhao, and Harold Roth.

³³² 𡗗: Rounder than the other samples for Chu script I've seen on zi.tools so wanted to flag it, but likely this is 國.

³³³ Originally 𡗗 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安.

³³⁴ 尻 means sit leisurely at a table, idle, at ease, to live somewhere; considered a synonym for 居 and 处 (zi.tools)

³³⁵ Technically 灋 to the left of 夫 all over 水 (in zi.tools: 𡗗𡗗夫水). Most of the entries there are from here.

天灋道，道灋自(𤔪/𤔪/然)³³⁶。

Heaven model/ruled-by Dao/way, Dao ruled-by what-is-naturally-so/itself/its-own-nature.

Heaven is ruled by the Dao, and the Dao is ruled by its own nature.

³³⁶ Actually 𤔪, which is 然 without the fire radical on bottom. This is the case for the entirety of the Guodian.

Chapter 26

重為輕根

Heavy/significant/grave/respect do/act-as/use/manipulate light/frivolous/superficial/shallow root/base
Graveness acts as the root of frivolousness³³⁷

靜為躁君

Stillness-motionless do/act-as/use/manipulate restless/agitated/impulsive/rash/disturb ruler/sovereign
Stillness acts as the ruler of agitation

是以聖人³³⁸終日

This by-means-of sage finish day
By means of this, the sage, all day long,

行不離{其}輜

Enacts/moves/walk/engage not part-from/separate/leave/disengage/detach {their} covered-carriage
Moves but not separating from their covered carriage

重³³⁹雖有榮觀

Heavy/grave/respect despite/although have honor/glory/glimmer/dazzle observe/behold
Grave, despite having dazzling sights to behold,³⁴⁰

燕處{則}超然

At-ease³⁴¹ Stay/reside-in {when-then} leap/vault-over/traverse/surpass/outdo/transcend self-so/-ly
Resides at ease, transcendently.³⁴²

奈何萬乘之主

What-is-it-like?/why/how/what-ought-be-done ten-thousand ascend/ride/use [‘s]/this lord/ruler/host
Why would the lord of ten-thousand rides,

而以身輕天下

And/yet/but by-means-of body/self light/frivolous/superficial/shallow heaven under
Yet through himself treat the world frivolously?

輕則失本, 躁則失君

light/frivolous/superficial/shallow when-then lose root/base, agitation/disturb when-then lose ruler
When frivolous, lose the foundation; when agitated, lose sovereignty.

³³⁷ I initially translated this as “Heavily using shallow roots”

³³⁸ Mawangdui has 君子 instead of sage.

³³⁹ Most translations treat this as the last character of the first line, but Mawangdui has 畱 (cultivated ground) rather than 輜, and “heavy field” does not make sense.

³⁴⁰ Because of how 重 is placed, this translation is an odd one out. Linnell has “He is serious, even though glorious sights and feasts exist.” But Wu has “Though there may be gorgeous sights to see”, Lau has (including the line before) “never lets the heavily laden carts out of his sight”, Chan has “Even at the sight of magnificent scenes” and Waley has similar, Henricks seems to just skip this line from what I can tell, Lin has “In the midst of honor and glory”, Cleary has “though they have a look of prosperity”, and Feng & English have “though there are beautiful sights to be seen.” Only Linell treats 燕 as banquet, placing it in this line rather than the next/

³⁴¹ Also swallow or martin (Hirundinidae), repose(ful), at ease, serve wine and meat to guests, feast, banquet, revel, carouse, be familiar with, be close to, be intimate

³⁴² I’m odd one out again. Linnell has “He lives above them, like this”, Wu has “He stays at ease in his own home,” Lau has “It is only when he is safely behind walls and watch-towers that he rests peacefully and is above worries,” Chan has “he remains leisurely and indifferent” and Feng & English and Lin have similar, Henricks has “When he’s safely inside a walled-in protected hostel and resting at ease, only then does he transcend all concern”, Waley has “he sits quiet and dispassionate.” Cleary has “their resting place is transcendent.” Taking into account Mawangdui’s 則, perhaps this is more like “When residing at ease, then they are transcendent.”

Chapter 27

善行無轍迹

Good/favorable/skilled move/enact/engage without wheel-tracks/carriage-tracks/path footprints/track
Skilled movement lacks tracks to follow.

善言無瑕謫

Good/favorable/skilled words/speech without flaw/defect/scratch/scar censure/blame/punish/degrade
Skilled speech is without flaw or condemnation.

善數不用籌策

Good/favorable/skilled counts/figures not employ counting-rods/tally/devise bamboo-slips/whip/staff
Skilled calculation does not use tallying slips.

善閉無關楗

Good/skilled close/close-off/obstruct without bar/barrier/juncture/connect/notify door-bar/posts/dam
Skilled closing off is without door bars and lock bolts,

而不可開

And/yet/but not able/possible open/begin/spread-open/expose.
Yet it cannot be opened up.

善結無繆約

Good/favorable/skilled knot/intertwine lack/without cord/ligature/rope bind/tie/fasten/restrain/restrict
Skilled intertwining is without restraining with ropes,

而不可解

And/yet/but not able/possible untie/unknot/loosen.
And yet it cannot be untied.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage
By means of this, the sage,

常善救人

Constantly/persistently skilled/good/favorable relieved/rescue/save/cure/prevent people
Persistently is skilled in rescuing the people,

故無棄人

Therefore/thus/as-a-result not abandon people.
And as a result, does not abandon people.

常善救物

Constantly skilled/good/favorable relieved/rescue/save/cure/prevent things/creatures
Persistently is skilled in rescuing things,

故無棄物

Therefore/thus/as-a-result not abandon things/creatures.
And as a result, does not abandon things.

是謂襲明

This called/say cover/overcoat/repeat/dress/inherit/accept insight/perceptive/light/evident
This is called covered illumination.³⁴³

³⁴³ Linnell translates this as “This is called following your insight”, and this agrees with Wu, Lau, Chan, and Feng & English, and while it could be this based on definitions in Kroll, this word has more connotations of to cover, dress, etc. Henricks has “doubly bright”, Waley has “resorting to the light”, and Lin has “stealing the light”. I’ll take the odd-one-out on this one.

故善人者不善人之師

Therefore skilled/good people {person/phrase} not skilled/good people ['s]/this troops/master/teacher
Therefore, skilled people are the teachers of those who are not skilled.

不善人者善人之資

Not skilled people {person/phrase} good/skilled people ['s]/this resource/wealth/property/supply/rely
Those who are not skilled are the resources of the skilled people.

不貴其師

Not value/prized/costly their teacher/master/troops,
Not to value the teacher,

不愛其資

Not to love/fond/begrudge/kind/pity resources/wealth/property/supply/rely
Not to be fond of the resources,

雖智大迷

Despite/although know big/great possessed-by/bewilderment/lose-one's-way
Is, despite knowledge, majorly losing one's way.

是謂要妙

This called waist/cinch/bind/restrain/require/need/compel/crucial subtleties/marvels/wonder
This is called the essential and subtle.

Chapter 28

知其雄守其雌

Know their male/masculine/valiant/robust/full/egregious guard/maintain/defend their female/feminine

Know one's masculinity, defend one's femininity,

為天下谿

Do/act-as/use heaven under stream-bed-in-mountain/narrow-valley/gorge

Act as the world's gorge,

為天下谿, 常德不離

Do/act-as/use heaven under gorge constantly/persistently virtue/power not part-from/separate/leave

Acting as the world's gorge, constantly virtue will not leave,

復歸於嬰兒³⁴⁴

Return go-home/restore/refuge-with in/at/from/regarding/than encircle/sustain/enwrap youth/child

Returning to restore the state of an infant.

知其白守其黑

Know their white/blank/plain, guard/maintain/defend their black/darkness/abstruse

Know one's white, defend one's black.

為天下式,

Do/act-as/use heaven under model/pattern/paradigm/emulate/config/use

Act as the world's model

為天下式, 常德不忒

Act-as/do/use world model/config/pattern, constantly virtue not change/modify/err/fault/deviate

Acting as the world's model, constantly virtue will not err,

復歸於無極

Return go-home/restore/refuge-with in/at/from/regarding without zenith/pinnacle/culmination/farthest

Returning to restore the state of limitlessness.

知其榮守其辱

Know their honor/glory/glimmer/dazzle, guard/maintain/defend their humiliating/disgrace/unworthy

Know one's glory, defend one's disgrace³⁴⁵

為天下谷,

Use/do/act-as heaven under cave/valley

Act as the world's valley

為天下谷, 常德乃足

Use/do/act-as heaven under valley/cave, constantly/persistently virtue/power then/indeed leg/sufficient

Acting as the world's valley, constantly virtue is then sufficient,

復歸於樸

Return go-home/restore/refuge-with in/at/from/regarding unworked-wood/simplicity/plain/sincere

Returning to restore the state of being unworked wood.

樸散則為器

Unworked-wood/plain/sincere scatter/turn-loose/disperse when-then do/act-as/use instrument/vessel

When the unworked wood scatters, then it acts as tools.

³⁴⁴ These two together mean newborn child, baby, infant

³⁴⁵ I take this to instruct one to be humble, to have humility, rather than maintain potentially destructive habits or behaviors or actively refuse to improve. Henricks has "When you know the pure yet hold on to the soiled, you'll be the valley of the country."

聖人用之則為官長

Sage employs/use this/['s] when-then do/act-as/use office/official/bureaucracy/public long/chief

When the sage employs them, then they act as a government official.

故大制不割

Therefore/thus/as-a-result big/great cut/fabricate/arrange/craft/regulate not cut/carve/sever/split

Therefore, great conforming things to design is not carving them.

Chapter 29

將欲取天下而為之

Bring-about/will desire take/capture heaven under and/yet/but use/do/act-as/manipulate this/['s]

If one will want to take the world and use it,

吾見其不得已

I see their not-obtaining-way-to-stop/cannot-avoid

I see their not having a way to stop.³⁴⁶

{夫} 天下神器, 不可為也

{In-any-case} heaven under spirit/god/deity/soul instrument/capacity/vessel, not possible/able use/do

The world is a spiritual instrument; One cannot use it.

為者敗之

Use/do/manipulate {phrase/person} ruin/destroy/corrupts this/['s]

Those who use this, ruin this.

執者失之

Seize/capture/grasp {person/phrase} lose this/['s]

Those who seize this, lose this.

故物

Thus/therefore/as-a-result things/creatures

Therefore, things

或行或隨

Sometimes/perhaps/some engage/move/enact(?) sometimes/perhaps/some pursue/follow-after

Sometimes enact, sometimes follow

或歔³⁴⁷或吹

Sometimes exhale/exhale-deeply/breathe/snort/breathe-hard, sometimes blow/gust/play-flute-or-pipe

Sometimes with labored breathing, sometimes with breath strong enough to play a flute.³⁴⁸

或強或羸

Sometimes strong/forced/vigorous sometimes emaciated/gaunt/feeble/weak/exhausted/outworn

Sometimes strong, sometimes feeble.

或挫或隳

Sometimes crushing/humbling/weakening, sometimes bring-down/overthrow/ruin/destroy

Sometimes crushing, sometimes destroyed.

³⁴⁶ Linnell has “I see you have no choice.” Wu has “I don’t see how he can succeed”, and Henricks, Chan, Waley, and Lin have similar. Lau has “I see will have no respite.” Cleary has “I see you won’t manage to finish”, which I think is closest to mine. Feng & English have “I do not believe it can be done.”

³⁴⁷ Everyone has something different here. HeShangGong has 噓 (exhaling serenely, sigh of ease), Mawangdui A has 炁 (radiant, brilliant, blaze, resplendent, sunshine) and Mawangdui B has 熱 (hot, heated, fever, excited, aroused, inflamed, vehement, ardent)

³⁴⁸ This is a somewhat creative translation on my part. Linnell has “sometimes breathe heavy, sometimes breathe easy” (maybe influenced by HeShangGong?), Feng & English have “Sometimes breathing is hard, sometimes it comes easily”, which may be most similar to mine. Wu has “A time for slow breathing and a time for fast breathing”, Lau has “some breathe gently and some breathe hard” (almost certainly influenced by HeShangGong), Cleary has “Sometimes puff and sometimes blow.” However, Chan, Waley, Lin, and Henricks have “Some blow/are(Henricks) hot, some blow cold.”

是以聖人

This by-means-of Sage

By means of this, the sage,

去甚,

Leave/go/depart excessive/too-much,

Leaves the excessive,

去奢,

Leave/go/depart wasteful/extravagant/lavish/excessive/immoderate/superfluous

Leaves the extravagant,

去泰

Leave/go/depart majestic/arrogant/generous/calm/composed/sublime/lordly/benefit/contented

Leaves the arrogant.

Chapter 30

以道佐人主者

By-means-of Dao assist/support/uphold people lord/king/rulers/host [person/phrase-end]

Those who, through the Dao, assist the rulers of people

不以兵強天下

Not/no by-means-of weapons/warfare/military dominate/strong/firm/powerful under-heaven

Do not use warfare to dominate the world.

其事好還

It/its matters/affairs good/excellent/pleasant/to-like come-round/go-back/send-back/redeem

Matters of warfare are good at coming back around.

師之所處荊棘生

Troops/army/learn-from/crowd³⁴⁹ [‘s] place stay/reside thorns/difficulty thorny/harsh live/born

In the places where armies reside, thorny plants are born,

焉大軍之後必有凶年

From-it big/great armed-forces/soldiers [‘s] behind/after certainly has/exist ill-omened/deadly year

So, after great armies there are certainly inauspicious, deathly years.

善者果而已

Skilled/good/benevolent people fruit/reality/execution and/yet stops/finishes/already

Good people reap the fruits of their labor and yet are finished there,

不敢以取強

Not dare/bold by-means-of take/acquire/seize/capture dominate/strong/firm/powerful

Not daring to further dominate by means of capture.³⁵⁰

果而勿矜

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and not flaunt/prag/sympathy/peril/important

They reap the fruits of their labor yet do not flaunt them,

果而勿伐

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not hack-at/attack/condemn/boast

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not boast of them,

果而勿驕

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not arrogant/haughty

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not become arrogant,

果而不得已

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and not-obtaining-way-to-stop/cannot-avoid

Reap the fruits of their labor when it cannot be avoided.

果而勿強

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not dominate/powerful/strong/firm

Reap the fruit of their labor, yet not dominating.

物壯則老

Things robust/in-their-prime/mighty/healthy when-then age/old/decay/wane

When things are robust and at their prime, then they age and wane.

³⁴⁹ Also master, tutor, counselor, crowd, multitude, learn from, skilled person (craftsman, virtuous).

³⁵⁰ Or, in the style of Cleary, Waley, Henricks, Feng & English, and to a degree Chan, “not daring to take advantage of victory”, or Linnell’s “take using strength”.

是謂不道

This called not Dao

This is called not with the Dao.

不道早已

Not Dao early/ahead-of-time/morning already/stop/finish

What is not with the Dao has an early end.

Guodian (A:4)

以(衍³⁵¹/道)(𢇛/差³⁵²)人(室³⁵³/主)者,

By-means-of path/Dao, difference/recover/mistake people ruler/host/dominant [person]

Those who, through the path, deviate from the rulers of people,³⁵⁴

不(谷/欲)以兵(𢇛/𢇛)³⁵⁵於³⁵⁶天下。

Not want/desire by-means-of weapons/warfare strong/dominance//firm/rigid in/at/than world

Do not want to use weapons to harden the world.

善³⁵⁷者果而已,

Skilled/good people fruit/reality/execution and/yet stops/finishes/already.

Skilled people reap the fruits of their labor and yet are finished there,

不以取𢇛。

Not by-means-of seize/capture/acquire dominate/powerful/rigid/firm.

Not through seizing and rigidifying.

果而(𢇛/弗)(發/發)³⁵⁸,

Fruition but/yet/and not weeding-with-feet//shoot/emit/broach

They reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not trample further,

果而(𢇛/弗)(喬/驕)³⁵⁹,

Fruition but/yet/and not lofty/high/tall//arrogant/proud

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not become lofty and proud,

果而弗(𢇛/矜)³⁶⁰,

Fruition but/yet/and not flaunt/prag/sympathy/peril/important

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not flaunt them.

³⁵¹ Refers to walking, jogging, or striding (small steps). On slips, look like 衍 to me; but both are old forms of 行

³⁵² 𢇛 Originally 來 over 左 according to CRY, but listed in zi.tools under 差 as 來 over 右 as ZLW would (see Cook for both). I can see either being the case. Whether 右 or 左, these are both hands, and the original meaning of this character was “to rub” (put hands to wheat), but came to mean “difference”, “proportion(ate)”, “mistake/error,” and also “choose,” “send”, and, in Chu regional dialect, “to recover from illness”, according to Kroll.

³⁵³ Original is 𡩺, but this is indeed listed under 室 in zi.tools,. According to Duan Yucai through zi.tools, 主 was the ancient form of 室 (ruler or master). The character is constructed as a canopy/roof (人/宀) over a pillar, now represented as 主. See also A:3’s “crushing” pillar and stone.

³⁵⁴ Or, alternatively “Those who through the path create a gap between people and rulers.”

³⁵⁵ Slips have 𢇛, probably equivalent to 𢇛. Compare to the 𢇛 character in A:11 (𢇛). Zi.tools lists this similarly under 强, having the bottom 力 missing. The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 𢇛 (𢇛), a variant of 𢇛 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong). This visual resemblance is stronger to me. A:11 and A:17 would be “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

³⁵⁶ Originally 𢇛 → 𢇛 → 烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ↔ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

³⁵⁷ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”.

³⁵⁸ 𢇛 → 𢇛 The repeated 止止 got reduced to the “footprints” roof 𢇛. A bow 弓 and 𢇛 was added to keep martial meaning. (in zi.tools: 𢇛 | 𢇛 址一址又, under 發). Maybe → 發 (send, shoot, express, launch, announce, broach)

³⁵⁹ 𢇛 Listed as 九 over 高 in zi.tools (but only under 喬). High/tall/hook-tipped/upturning (or disguise), but often used in place or as interchangeable of 驕, which means haughty, arrogant, proud

³⁶⁰ 𢇛 listed in zi.tools as 矜. Originally 矛+(命 or 令), flattened over time by abbreviation. Keeps the weapon + order/command/fate – intimidate or boast? By Kroll, sympathy, compassion, uncomfortable, respect, emphasize, cautious, prudent, solemn, grim, but also danger, peril and to hold oneself above or aloof, self-important, flaunt.

是(胃/謂)果而不弭。

These/this stomach//called/speak fruition/fruit but and/not dominate/powerful/rigid/firm

This is what is called reaping fruits of labor without hardness.

其事好[長³⁶¹].

Its/their/it/they business/to-serve good/attractive/excellent/pleasing/to-like [long-lasting/endure].

Its service is excellently enduring³⁶².

³⁶¹ On the slips, this looks like it should be part of the next chapter, A:5, instead, due to section markers. However, context of A:5 convinces me that maybe it is better suited here.

³⁶² Or, if I am wrong about the placement of 長, “Its conduct is excellent.”

Chapter 31

夫佳兵者

In-any-case/man seemly/pleasing/attractive/gratifying weapons/warfare {person/phrase}

In any case, attractive weapons –

不祥之器

Not favorable-omen/auspicious/lucky ['s]/this instrument/tools/vessel/capacity

These are inauspicious instruments;

物或惡之

Thing/creature some/perhaps/sometimes/someone ugly/hateful/abhorrent ['s]/this

Some things hate these.³⁶³

故有道者不處

Therefore/as-a-result exist/have Dao/way {person/phrase} not stay/occupy/reside

Therefore, one who has the Dao does not dwell with these.

君子居則貴左

Noble/gentlemen dwell/rest/reside norm/standard/rule/when-then expensive/costly/value-highly left

When the nobleman are at rest, then values highly the left,

用兵則貴右

Bell//use/employ weapons norm/standard/when-them expensive/costly/value right

When using weapons, then values highly the right.

兵者不祥之器

Weapons/warfare {person/phrase} not favorable-omen/auspicious ['s] tools/instruments/capacity

As for weapons, they are inauspicious instruments.

非君子之器

Not gentleman/noble ['s]/this instruments

Not a gentleman's instruments.

不得已而用之

Not-obtaining-way-to-stop/cannot-avoid and/yet/but employ/use this/['s]

When one cannot find another way to end things, only then they are used.

恬淡³⁶⁴為上

Tranquil/quiet/carefree/content/unambitious/alooft/negligent bland/mild/insipid/pale/faded do/use up

Carefree and mild is superior action;

勝而不³⁶⁵美 {也}

Competence/overcome/conquer and/yet/but not beautiful/attractive/finest

Conquer and not regard it as beautiful.

³⁶³ Linnell translates this as “Creatures detest them, no matter what”, but this reading is not supported by the definitions found in Kroll for 或 (or anywhere else I could find). Wu has “Even things seem to hate them.” Lau has “It is because arms are instruments of ill omen and there are things that detest them that one who has the way does not abide by their use.” Chan has “They are hated by men” (Lin has similar), and Cleary has “People may despise them.” Henricks has “And among things there are those that hate them.” Only Feng & English have “all creatures hate them”, similar to Linnell.

³⁶⁴ Mawangdui has 銛襲 (A) or 銛戇 (with heart radical to the left on the latter, B).

³⁶⁵ Mawangdui has 勿, and not 勝而 before this, meaning “Do not regard as beautiful”, in my opinion.

而美之者是樂殺人

And/yet/but beauty ['s]/this, this music/glee kill/cut-down people

And to regard them as beautiful is to find glee in killing people.

夫樂殺人者

In-any-case/man music/glee kill/cut-down people {people/phrase},

In any case those that find glee in killing people,

則不可以得志於天下矣

When-then not possible/can by-means-of obtain/gain aspiration/intention in/at/regarding world[!]

Then cannot obtain their aspirations of the world.

吉³⁶⁶ 事尚左

Auspicious/benign/favorable matters/serve exalt/surpass/even/venerable/manage left

Benign matters are venerated on the left,

凶事尚右

Ill-omen/deadly/lethal matters/serve exalt/surpass/even/venerable/manage right

Lethal matters are venerated on the right.

偏³⁶⁷ 將軍³⁶⁸ 居左

Slanted/off-center/eccentric/sideways/sweep-aside/division will/bring-about/leader army dwell left

Division generals dwell on the left,

上將軍居右

High/above/up bring-about/will/leader army dwell right

High generals dwell on the right.

言以喪禮處之

Words by-means-of grief rich/abundance/fullness/pleasing//rites/rituals/formality dwells ['s]/this

Words dwell in this warfare through grieving rituals.

殺人之眾

Kill/cut-down people ['s]/this multitude/crowd

The crowds of people killed,

以哀悲泣之

By-means-of mourn/grieve sadness/yearning/pity weep/shed-tears this/['s]

Through mourning pity and weep for them.

戰勝以喪禮處之

Combat/struggle/tremble competence/overcome/conquer by-means-of grief rites dwell this.

Conquering and overcoming through combat, one dwells through mourning rituals.

³⁶⁶ Mawangdui has 是以 before this word.

³⁶⁷ Mawangdui has 是以 before this word.

³⁶⁸ 將軍 together means leader of an army, general.

Guodian (C:3)

君³⁶⁹子居則³⁷⁰貴左³⁷¹,

Noble/gentlemen dwell/rest/reside norm/standard/rule/when-then expensive/costly/value-highly left

When the nobleman are at rest, then values highly the left,

(甬/用)(𠂔/兵)則貴右。

Bell//use/employ weapons norm/standard/when-them expensive/costly/value right

When using weapons, then values highly the right.

(古/故)曰：兵者，□□□□□ (不祥之器也。³⁷²)

Ancient/old//thus says, “Weapons □□□□□ ([phrase] not favorable-omen [’s] instrument)

Therefore it is said, “As for weapons, they are {inauspicious instruments.}

□(得/得)已³⁷³而(甬/用)之[。](不)

Obtaining finishing/already/stop and/but employing it. (Not)

When one {cannot} find another way to end things, only then they are used.”

(鏃/鋸)³⁷⁴(𠂔/𠂔/襲)³⁷⁵為上，(弗/弗)(𠂔/𠂔/美)³⁷⁶也。

Sharp-tool/sharp/keen respect//cover/dress/attack do/use/act-as above/top, not beautiful/praise.

Covering weapons is superior action, not regarding them as beautiful.

(𠂔/美)³⁷⁷之，是樂³⁷⁸(𠂔/殺/殺)人。

Beauty(?) [’s]/this, this music/glee kill/cut-down people

To regard them as beautiful is to find glee in killing people.

³⁶⁹ In the photographs I have, this character is obscured and darkened, but I can make out 𠂔 or something very similar, so I am fairly confident in 君.

³⁷⁰ 𠂔, so more accurately, 鼎 to the left of 刀, as it is listed on zi.tools, under 則. Can mean norm, standard, law, what is carved into the bronze ding cauldron, but also can mean if...then, and when...then, and also but/whereas

³⁷¹ Left and right could be read literally, or left has associations with heterodoxy, deviance, sinisterness, but also auspiciousness, as the sun rises in the east and the king often faces south. Right has connotations of honor, but also war, as the warrior sits on the right side of the chariot, and is associated with the west, the setting sun.

³⁷² From Cook, same with 不 on the next line.

³⁷³ 不得已 is a fixed phrase meaning “not obtaining (a way to) stop.” → cannot avoid.

³⁷⁴ 鏃 on the slips. 鏃 or 鏃. Under 鋸, zi.tools lists 金 to the left of 千 over 𠂔, which I cannot find fault in, but wonder about the stray vertical line between the two sides. Zi.tools has this defined as “ancient weapon” and “sharp tool.” More often, it is translated as simply “sharp”, or to sharpen.

³⁷⁵ 𠂔 Originally 𠂔+𠂔, supported by zi.tools. 𠂔 means “equal, fair, neat” as 𠂔 by zi.tools but it is not clear to me why. 𠂔 is respect, reverence, supply, by 襲, in turn by 恭. Mawangdui A has 襲 (raid, attack, invade, but also overcoat, to dress, to put a second layer of clothing, repeat, double, inherit, perpetuate, conform-to accept, follow along), Mawangdui B has 𠂔. I adopt 襲, as it contains 衣 (kind of similar to 𠂔), and makes sense in context.

³⁷⁶ 𠂔 → 𠂔 + 女 → 𠂔 → 美. See A:9 (𠂔). Originally I had “Sharpening and raiding acts as superior, not beautiful.”

³⁷⁷ 𠂔 Under 𠂔 to the left of 女 in zi.tools, but written as 𠂔 over 𠂔, all next to probably 女. I am uncomfortable calling this 美: This does not look like the other instances of this character (though it could be a moment of bad handwriting). In the most technical sense, this is 羽 (as 习) over 𠂔, next to maybe 女. Cook mentions GR suggests this variant may convey a causative version, but Cook thinks this is already accomplished through the 弗 in the line above. The bottom box is like a mouth (𠂔), so perhaps this is to call something beautiful? But this is only for the second instance. Cook and Henricks also treat these two differently but translates both “modern equivalents” as 美.

³⁷⁸ For both instances of this character, the left side appears to be faded, so that only one string is visible on the right. However, zi.tools gives enough examples that I’m fairly confident both characters in question are indeed 樂.

夫樂□□□□以(導/得)志(怡/於)天下。(殺者不可)³⁷⁹

Adult/in-any-case/husband glee □□□□ by-means-of obtain aspiration/intention in/at under heaven

Whoever is gleeful {in killing cannot} obtain their aspirations of the world.

(古/故)吉事上左,

Old/ancient//thus/so auspicious/benign/favorable matters/serve above/foremost/high left

So, benign matters are high priority on the left,

喪³⁸⁰事上右。

Grief/crying/loss/suffer/death matters/serve above/foremost/high right

And matters causing grief are high priority on the right.

是以(支³⁸¹/辨)(酒/將)(軍/軍)居左,

This by-means-of artificial-differentiation, brings/will/lead armies dwell left

By means of this, artificial differentiation brings the armies to dwell on the left,³⁸²

上(酒/將)軍居右,

Foremost/High bring/leader armies dwell right,

Primarily, one brings the armies to dwell on the right.

言以喪(豐³⁸³/禮)居之也。

Words by-means-of grief rich/abundance/fullness/pleasing//rites/rituals/formality dwells [‘s]/this

Words dwell in this warfare through grieving rituals.

(古/故)殺³⁸⁴□□則以(參/恣/衰)(參/悲)³⁸⁵位之;(人眾)³⁸⁶

Old//thus killing □□ when-then by-means-of mourn/grieve sadness/yearning/pity seat/position this

So, when killing {multitudes of people}, then one should sit with mourning and sadness.

(戰/戰)(參/勝)³⁸⁷, 則以喪(豐/禮)居之。

Combat/struggle/tremble competence/overcome/conquer when-then by-means-of grief rites dwell this.

When one conquers and overcomes through combat, then one should dwell in mourning rituals.

³⁷⁹ From Cook again.

³⁸⁰ 𣦵, then 𣦵, then 𣦵 in this chapter, getting simpler each time but still having at least one of all of the components, seeming to differ mostly in the number of mouths. Zi.tools has all of these under 喪 (as 𣦵 𣦵 土 𣦵 死) In Henricks, 𣦵, same thing three lines below and the two lines below that. Photos of the slips support this, looking at the Chu slip version of 死 under 哭 (which apparently can look like 九, with more mouths sometimes between. Cry and death seems to signify grief at least, and the Shuowen through zi.tools describes this as a “mournful sound”

³⁸¹ 𣦵 Originally 𣦵, approximately. (𣦵 over 又). Could be 辨 (discrimination, differentiation, (ultimately artificial classifications), could be 𣦵→鞭 (whip) read (because of shared phonetics and a cut/boundary/dispute connotation) as 辯 (Confucian debate tactics, argumentation, (institutional) disputes) or 辨. By Cook, also could be 二 over 支, could be 便. In zi.tools, 鞭 contains 𣦵, but its page leads to 辨. This is usually treated like 偏 in this chapter. See Cook “Bamboo Texts of Guodian”,

³⁸² As 將軍 together can mean “leader of the army, general”, this could also be: “By means of this, artificial (???) generals dwell on the left, and high generals dwell on the right”.

³⁸³ According to zi.tools and Wiktionary 豐 is the original form of 禮, though it may be a variant of 豐 (luxuriant)

³⁸⁴ The bottom two thirds of this character are lost, but the top that remains is consistent with 殺.

³⁸⁵ Cook and Henricks swapped these, but looking at the photos of the slips, it should be 恣悲, not 悲恣.

³⁸⁶ Again from Cook.

³⁸⁷ By zi.tools, technically 𣦵 over 力

Chapter 32

道常無名

Dao/way constantly/persistently without/lack/no name

The Dao constantly lacks a name.

樸³⁸⁸雖小

Unworked-wood/simplicity/plain/sincere despite/even-though/although small/little

Although the unworked wood is small,

天下莫能臣也

Under-heaven in-no-case can/able/capable minister/treat-as-inferior/subject/slave

Nothing under heaven can rule over it as a subject.

侯王若能守之

Marquis/mark/target king like/if can/able/capable defend/maintain/preserve it/this/[‘s]

If the marquis and kings preserve it,

萬物將自賓

Ten-thousand things bring/will self/naturally behave-as-guests/submit/guest

The ten-thousand things would bring themselves to behave as well-mannered guests.

天地相合

Heaven Earth each-other combine/fit/meet/close

Heaven and Earth combine with each other

以降³⁸⁹甘露³⁹⁰

By-means-of fall/descend/drop/bring-down/deign-to-give sweet dew

Through bringing down sweet dew³⁹¹;

民莫之令

Common-people in-no-case [‘s]/this/it command/order/enable

The people (would be) under no one’s mandate³⁹²

而自均

And/but/yet itself/naturally equal/uniform/regulated

And yet, by itself, things would be uniform.

{焉}始制³⁹³有名

[So/therefore/how?/where?] start/begin/initiate cut/fabricate/arrange/craft/regulate has/exists name

So, start conforming things to a design, and names will exist;

³⁸⁸ Mawangdui A has 樸 (house-tent, with wooden roof)

³⁸⁹ Mawangdui A and B have 俞 (respond, satisfied)

³⁹⁰ Mawangdui A and B have 洛 (tributary of the Yellow River)

³⁹¹ I seem to be in the minority in how this is translated, Linnell has “Heaven and Earth would join each other, *thus* dropping sweet dew.” Henricks has “Heaven and Earth would unite to send forth sweet dew,” and Lau, Chan, Wu, Waley has very similar. Even Cook for the Guodian has “Heaven and Earth join together, so as to send down sweet dew.” The character 以 can be used as “by means of this”, and perhaps that is their reasoning, but the image of dew condensing from air (heaven) onto the earth makes it seem to me like this is the form of their union, not the result.

³⁹² This follows my, and Cook’s, translation of the Guodian; Feng & English, Waley has a translation that somewhat agrees, but Cleary, Lin, Henricks, Chan, Lau, and Linnell all translate to the effect of “no person commands [the dew to fall uniformly].

³⁹³ This 制 has interesting connotations. By Kroll, the definitions are: cut to measure (as in tailoring), work from plan or pattern to make fit, complete a design, fabricate, craft, compose (writing), arrange, control, regulate, make conform, restrain, prohibit, subdue.

名亦既有

Name in-this-case completely/just-now exist/have.

For its part, the name only just now came into existence,

夫亦將知止

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case-too bring/will know stop/cease/halt

And anyone, for their part, would know when to stop.³⁹⁴

知止(所)以不殆

Know stop [place/that-which by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which no/not danger/peril

Knowing when to stop is the mechanism by which there will be no danger.

譬道之在天下{也}

Draw-a-parallel Dao/way ['s]/it/this position/be-at under-heaven

As an analogy, the Dao's position under heaven

猶川谷之(與)江海{也}.

Similar-to/hesitant/scheming stream/small-river valley/cave ['s]/this/it (join/share) river sea

Is like that of valley rivers joining into rivers and seas.

³⁹⁴ Henricks, Chan, Lau, Wu (kind of), Waley, Cleary, Feng & English (kind of), and Linnell all have some form of “When names appear, know that it is time to stop.”

Guodian (A:10)

道(𣦵/瓦)³⁹⁵亡名,

Dao/path constantly/persistently lacks name,

The Dao constantly lacks a name.

僕³⁹⁶(唯³⁹⁷)妻³⁹⁸,

Servant only/concur/assent/approve wife/get-wife

As a servant agrees with his wife,³⁹⁹

天(𡗗/地)(𡗗/弗)敢⁴⁰⁰臣。

Heaven Earth not dare minister/treat-as-inferior/subject/slave

Heaven and Earth do not dare treat it as their ruled-over subject.

(侯/侯)王(女/如)能(𡗗⁴⁰¹/守)之,

Marquis/Mark/scope/title king woman/maiden//like/if can/able/ability hunt//defend it,

If marquis and kings were able defend it,⁴⁰²

萬(勿/物)(𡗗/酒/將)自(𡗗/置)⁴⁰³。⁴⁰⁴

Ten-thousand things bring themselves be-installed/be-established.

Ten thousand things would bring themselves to be installed.

天地相(𡗗/會/合⁴⁰⁵)也,

Heaven Earth combine/fit/meet/close-with each-other

Heaven and Earth combine and fit with each other,

以逾⁴⁰⁶甘⁴⁰⁷(𡗗/零/露)。

By-means-of even-more/additionally sweet/pleasant/willingly drizzle///dew/reveal/moisten/nectar

By means of the exceedingly sweet falling dew.

³⁹⁵ Technically 𣦵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary). However, 𣦵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆.

³⁹⁶ 僕, so originally 𡗗 on the left of 𡗗 over 臣. May be 僕 where zi.tools lists it especially given the two radicals associated with people (𡗗 and 臣). see Guodian A:1: 𡗗 or A:5: 𡗗

³⁹⁷ 唯; in zi.tools under 隹, literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom may support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though/if). 售 means to sell. See B:1 and B:3. I usually translate this as only, but assent/approve/agree are the only alternative that makes sense in this context.

³⁹⁸ 妻, listed in zi.tools as 妻 but looks to me more like the top part of 貴 on 女, but the fellow examples in zi.tools share strong resemblance, and the Shuowen entry on zi.tools explains that one form was 貴 (as 𡗗) over 女. The Shuowen Jiezi describes the early forms of this character as a hand holding a woman’s hair, signifying (potentially forced) marriage, meaning wife, though also mentions links to the word 貴. Maybe technically 娶?

³⁹⁹ By Cook, LXF reads “(as) a servant agrees with his wife”, taking 唯 as “agree, concur, approve” rather than “only”; better than my initial tries “like a servant, or only a wife” and “A servant only then finds a wife.”

⁴⁰⁰ 𡗗 Zi.tools has this under 𡗗, this is a variant of 敢. See also A:5

⁴⁰¹ 𡗗 → 𡗗 A bit blurry. Enough resemblance to 𡗗 → 𡗗 (𡗗) for me not to challenge it

⁴⁰² Or if 女, “Marquis and kings femininely can preserve it”, “softly can preserve it”, or “vulnerably can preserve it.”

⁴⁰³ 𡗗 Originally 貝 under 𡗗 → 寘 in zi.tools, but it looks different from other Chu comrades under 寘. Could be 冥 (dark, gloomy, unseen, deep and dark, faint, far, undercover, mental dullness), as zi.tools also seems to suggest. Zi.tools also suggests 寘 → 置, meaning “to install, to establish,” and this makes more sense to me than either.

⁴⁰⁴ Some start (A:11) here due to a passage marker between these lines. So my chapter count differs from Cook’s.

⁴⁰⁵ Compare to A:17, A:14. Might be 會 (combine, gather, meet), or 答 (respond)

⁴⁰⁶ 𡗗 zi.tools lists this as 俞 over 止, though technically the knife is on the wrong side (or it may be a person).

⁴⁰⁷ 𡗗 looks like 回 to me (zi.tools for 回 = 𡗗; for 甘 nearly all look like 𡗗.) Also like what is listed under 昌 (𡗗).

民莫之命(𠂔/而)自(𠂔/均)(𠂔/玄/焉)⁴⁰⁸。

People in-no-case it/its command and/but itself equal/uniform/regulated [interrogative-pronoun]/by-it
The people (would be) under no one's mandate, yet balance themselves by it.⁴⁰⁹

(𠂔/詢⁴¹⁰/辭)(𠂔/折)(又/有)名。

Explain break/twist/bend/analyze/determine/decide have/exist name.

Explain and determine something, and it will have a name;

名亦(𠂔/既⁴¹¹/既)(又/有),

Name in-this-case completely/just-now exist/have.

For its part, the name only just now came into existence.

夫亦(𠂔/將)智(𠂔⁴¹²/止),

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case bring knowledge/wisdom limit/end-of

And anyone for their part can bring themselves to knowing to stop,

智(𠂔/止)⁴¹³(𠂔⁴¹⁴/所)以不(詢/辭)。

Wisdom limit/end-of mechanism-by-which not govern//start//danger/be-close//explain

Knowing to stop is the mechanism by which things are not explained.

(𠂔/卑)道之才天下也,

Low/vulgar/decline Dao/way ['s]/this talent/genius/ability/just-then under heaven

The lowly Dao's talents⁴¹⁵ under heaven,

(𠂔/猷/猶)少(𠂔/浴)之(𠂔/昇/與)⁴¹⁶(𠂔/江)(𠂔/海)。

Similar-to/design/plan few/slightly purify/wash/bathe/swoop/stream it['s] join/give/grant river sea.

Are like a few streams joining rivers and seas.

⁴⁰⁸ Originally like 𠂔 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 玄..

⁴⁰⁹ Alternatively, like Harold Roth, "[Falling rain] is under no one's mandate, by itself it falls equally on the people." His version: "No one causes this to be so; of itself it falls equally on them."

⁴¹⁰ 𠂔 Listed under zi.tools as 言 to the left of 𠂔; on page 詞. See A:6 and A:9. Could be 詢, I suspect it may be 詞.

Zi.tools says this may be 詞, or Chu for 治 (govern), 始 (start, only now), 殆 (danger, be close to, had better), or 辭 (words, explain, decline). This goes for both instances in this chapter. Given the clear inclusion of 言, I opt for 辭.

See also C:4 (𠂔)

⁴¹¹ See C:1 and A:10. This instance, in zi.tools, is listed under 巳 to the left of 丶 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also "just after" or "upon completion" or "as soon as".

⁴¹² 𠂔 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 𠂔 or 𠂔, or 𠂔. 𠂔 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 走 (止 over 止). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean "to go." To reach limit?

⁴¹³ This double-character repeat is indicated by = next to both characters on the slips. But while we're here, 智𠂔 may be "the edge of knowledge", but also "knowing when to stop/halt."

⁴¹⁴ Atypical form of 所, usually like 𠂔

⁴¹⁵ Or, if equivalent to 在, "position", "placement". See A:2

⁴¹⁶ 𠂔 Henricks has 与 over 𠂔, zi.tools has 昇 which is more accurate. The Shuowen, through zi.tools, insists this is an old form of 與, but then why use both? A:2 also has 𠂔 (join). 𠂔 (rhetorical) from A:12, and from B:3 𠂔 (communal giving); Also from B:3 𠂔/与 (bestow). See also A:18 (grant)

Chapter 33

知人者智

Know people [person] wise/wisdom

Those who know people are wise,

自知者明

Self/natural know [person] luminous/light/evident/illuminate/perceptive

Those who know the self are perceptive

勝人者有力

Competence/overcome/conquer people [person] has/exists strength/power/might

Those who overcome people have might,

自勝者強

Self/natural competence/overcome/conquer [person] dominate/strong/firm/powerful

Those who overcome the self are dominant.

知足者富

Know sufficiency/foot/leg [person] abundant/opulent/wealthy

Those who know sufficiency are wealthy,

強行者有志

dominate/strong/firm/powerful walk/transmit/enact [person] has/exists ambition/aspirations

Those who enact their dominance have ambitions.

不失其所者久

Not lose its/it place/that-which [person] long-enduring/old-and-familiar

Those who do not lose their place are long lasting,

死而不亡者壽

Die and/yet/but not no/without/gone/lost/missing [person] longevity/long-life

Those who die and yet are not lost and forgotten are long-lived.

Chapter 34

大道汜兮,其可左右

Big/Great Dao overflow/flood/inundate/float/widespread, It/its can/possible/permissible left right
The Great Dao is widespread flood, it can be left or right.

萬物恃之(以/而)生

Ten-thousand things rely-on/depend-on it/['s]/this (by-means-of//and/but/yet) life/alive/born
Ten-thousand things rely on it to live,

而不辭•

And/but/yet not/no explain/express/refused
And yet it is unexplained.

功成遂

Work/accomplishment/excellence complete/achieve progress/succeed/achieve/respond/comply
Work is completed successfully,

[而]不名有

[And/but/yet] not/no name exist/have
And yet it is unnamed.

衣養萬物

Jacket/clothes/clothe/wear nurture/rear/raise/train/maintain/support/nurse ten-thousand things
It clothes and nurtures the ten-thousand things,

而不為主

And/yet/but not do/use/act-as/manipulate ruler/host/dominant
And yet it does not rule over them.

[故]常無欲

[Therefore/thus/as-a-result] constant/persistent without/no desire/want/crave
Therefore, constantly without desire,

可名於小

Possible/permissible/can name in/at/regard-as/from little/small
It is possible to name this “{from} small”.

萬物歸焉

Ten-thousand things return/give-back from-this/by-it/here/in-it
Ten-thousand things return by it,

而不為主

And/yet/but not do/use/act-as/manipulate ruler/host/dominant
And yet it does not rule over them

可名(於)大

Possible/permissible/can name (in/at/from/regarding) big/great
It is possible to name this “{from} great”.

以其不為大⁴¹⁷故能成其大

By-means-of it/its not/no use/do/act-as/manipulate big/great, Thus/ able/can complete it/its big/great.
By means of it, do not do great actions, and as a result one can complete great things.

⁴¹⁷ By Linnell, in Mawangdui, “(是以聖人之能成大)” = by means of this, the sage’s ability to accomplish is great.”

Chapter 35

執大象，天下往

Grasp/seize/capture big/great replica/imitation/image, world go/move/go-towards/takes-refuge-with
What grasps the Great Image, the world will move toward.

往而不害

Go/move/gone/go-towards/takes-refuge-with and/yet/but not harm/abuse/destroy/misuse
Go toward, yet there is no harm;

安平太

Peace/quiet/stable/install flatten//tranquil/flat great/grand
Peace, tranquility, and grandness.

樂與餌過客⁴¹⁸止

Music/glee and/join/grant/give cake/bait, pass-through/trespass strangers/guests stop/cease/halt
For music and cake, passing guests halt.

道之出口⁴¹⁹淡乎⁴²⁰

Dao ['s]/this produce/put-out/arise/emerge mouth/taste/opening mild/bland/tasteless/insipid/mild [?!]
The Dao's emergent taste is tasteless!

其無味

Their lack/without flavor/taste/significance
Its lack of flavor:

視之不足見

Look ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough look.
Look at it but seeing it does not work.

聽之不足聞

Noise//Sage/virtue/hear-correctly ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough hear/inform/reputation
Listen closely for it but hearing it does not work.

用之不足既

But cannot upon-completion/wholly/just-now.
But it cannot be spent completely.

⁴¹⁸ Mawangdui has 格

⁴¹⁹ Mawangdui has 言也 曰

⁴²⁰ Mawangdui has 呵

Guodian (C:2)

(𢇛/𢇛/𢇛)⁴²¹ 大象⁴²²,

Arrive/devoting-oneself/gift-to-elder//uphold/set-forth great replica/imitation/image

What aligns oneself with the Great Image

天下(往/往)⁴²³。

Under heaven go/move/gone/go-towards/takes-refuge-with.

The world goes toward;

往而不(𢇛/𢇛)⁴²⁴害),

Go/move/gone but not harm/abuse/destroy/misuse

They go toward it but there is no harm.

(𢇛/焉)⁴²⁵ (𢇛/𢇛)⁴²⁶坪)大。

How/where/from-this/[interrogative-pronoun] flat-land/level/flatten//tranquil/flat big/great.

Thereupon, the flatland great

樂(𢇛/與)⁴²⁷ 餌⁴²⁸, (𢇛/恠)⁴²⁹ (𢇛/客)(𢇛/止)⁴³⁰止)。

Music/glee, mutual-sharing/unite/giving/joining/and cake/bait change-(minds?) guests/strangers limit

Gleefully grants cake – these influence the guests to halt⁴³¹.

⁴²¹ 𢇛 on the slips, zi.tools has under 𢇛, listed under 𢇛, which Cook has. Henricks has 𢇛 (arrive/devotion), which is more supported by the slip images. I see 𢇛 to the left of maybe 用 over surely 𢇛. Cook says maybe 𢇛 or 設.

⁴²² 𢇛 on the slips, Zi.tools has 𢇛 over 胃. 象 originally means “elephant” (which was mostly imagined based on bones by the time of the Warring states – elephants had shifted their range due to habitat loss and climate change; refer to Han Fei’s description of them) or “ivory”, and by extension “image, representation, icon, effigy, replica, apparition, figure”. It is indeed an image, but how realistic it is, how faithful to the truth it is, is such an open question that this word also refers to illusion. The character itself may be 胃 over 肉 but that may be redundant.

⁴²³ Duplication mark here. 往 also can mean both going and move toward. I choose move toward for ease of reading, and that it seems to be most supported by other more experienced translators, but it could be “leaving” too.

⁴²⁴ In zi.tools, listed as 𢇛害又, which I honestly don’t see. (Hand on top, or 夕?) It also does not resemble the other examples on the page or on the 害 page. Cook makes no mention of this abnormality, Henricks does not either. I am deeply uncomfortable assuming this character is just 害. 宜 by zi.tools looks closer but isn’t it (𢇛). See also A:2. Maybe contains 肉(𢇛)? Maybe also related to 蓋→盍(𢇛) but this is a stretch. I put 宜 or 害, uneasily. I default to 害, but I cannot help but wonder if this is something else.

⁴²⁵ Originally 𢇛→焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 𢇛.

⁴²⁶ Itself meaning flat land, from 《漢語變調構詞考辨》 through zi.tools under 平.

⁴²⁷ This may just be “and” rather than mutual giving, granting, rhetorical functions, etc.

⁴²⁸ 𢇛 in the slips. Henricks has this as 餌, preserved in Korean and Kanji fonts. Means cake, eat with pleasure, bait

⁴²⁹ 𢇛 in the slips, maybe 𢇛 but the Chu put extra strokes sometimes. (Normal form is like 𢇛) According to zi.tools, could be 過 (pass by, go beyond, excessive, trespass), 禍 (unblessed, divine misfortune), 化 (change, transform), 訛 (misspeak, blackmail). Maybe to change minds or hearts, given the heart radical, or change of heart, influence or convince?

⁴³⁰ 𢇛 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 𢇛 or 𢇛, or 𢇛. 𢇛 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 走 (止 over 𢇛). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean “to go.” To reach limit?

⁴³¹ I normally translate 𢇛 as “edge of” or “to the limit”, where one must stop. Here, guests stop as they are drawn in. This line could alternatively be “Music and cake – these influence the guests to halt.”

(古/故)道⁴³²□□(𠂔/談)⁴³³可其(𠂔/無)(𠂔/味)也。(之出)

Old//thus Dao/way talk/converse can/possible/able their lack/without taste/significance (['s] emerge)

Thus the Dao{'s emerging'} talk can be its flavorlessness.

(𠂔/視)之不足(𠂔/見)⁴³⁴,

Look ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough look.

Look at it but seeing it does not work.

聖⁴³⁵之不足(𠂔/聞/聞),

Noise//Sage/virtue/hear-correctly ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough hear/inform/reputation

Listen closely for it but hearing it does not work.

而不可(𠂔/既/既)⁴³⁶也。

But cannot upon-completion/wholly/just-now.

But it cannot be spent completely.

⁴³² Partly cut off but what is visible is consistent – missing characters from Cook, though see my note below. It could be 言 is not actually there, although Cook places it there, thinking there are three missing characters. I'm operating as though there are only two – the spacing on the slips I feel could go either way.

⁴³³ Partially obscured but it's not water to the left, though Henricks and Cook say it is. Could be 赤 or 光 or 炎 on the right? 吓 (frighten)? 黏 (flash)? 談 (talk, chat, converse?) 啖 (to eat with pleasure, taste, feed)? 燻? Not finding this in zi.tools. It looks most like 談, and it might be Cook was wrong about how many characters were missing? As it happens, Mawangdui A also has 談.

⁴³⁴ These characters look slightly different on the slip: 𠂔 under 視 and 𠂔 for 見

⁴³⁵ 聖 = 聖 This character means possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. I read it as "Hear correctly" or "hearing clearly"; so sage (聖人) is "person who hears clearly."

⁴³⁶ See A:10 and C:1. This particular character is listed under 巳 to the left of 丿 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also "just after" or "upon completion" or "as soon as".

Chapter 36

將欲歛之

Bring-about/will desire breathe-in/inhale/collect/narrow-down/pleased/catch ['s]/this

If one will want to gather⁴³⁷ this together,

必固張之

Certainly firm/solid draw-bow/open-out ['s]/this

Surely of course this was stretched out.⁴³⁸

將欲弱之

Bring/will desire weak/frail ['s]/this

If one will want to weaken this,

必固強之

Certainly firm/solid strong/dominate/forced ['s]/this

Surely of course this was strong.

將欲廢之

Bring/will desire discard/abandon/abolish/remove/neglect/disabled ['s]/this

If one will want to neglect this,

必固興之

Certainly firm/solid raise/lift/exalt/support/prosper/excite ['s]/this

Surely of course this was supported.

將欲奪之

Bring/will desire take-by-force/confiscate/abduct/lose/forfeit ['s]/this

If one will want to confiscate this,

必固與之

Certainly firm/solid join/share/grant/give ['s]/this

Surely of course this was granted.

是謂微明

This called/say subtle/tiny/secret/barely-there insight/perceptive/light/evident

This is called subtle insight.

柔弱勝剛強

Pliant/flexible/soft weak/frail overcomes strong/forced/rigid strong/forced/vigorous/dominant

The soft and weak overcomes the rigid and strong,

魚不可脫於淵

Fish not possible/able strip-off/shed/extricate/remove in/at/from deep/profound/vortex/whirlpool

Fish are not able to extricate themselves from the deep.

⁴³⁷ 歛, Kroll does not give a definition of shrink or diminish, yet for some reason, Wu, Lau, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Lin, and Feng & English ALL have this. Shuowen Jiezi has “縮鼻”, shrink nose, perhaps what happens to nostrils on a big inhale? Perhaps this has a connotation of “contract”, squeeze together?

⁴³⁸ Wu maybe agrees with me here “Begins by being first stretched out.” Other translations (Lau, Chan, Henricks, Linnell) seem to assume that before doing the first thing, one must be the one to do the second (opposite) thing. However, to gather things together, they cannot be originally bunched up to the maximum degree; they need to be spread, or stretched out, at least to some degree. To become bigger, one must start out smaller, not necessarily shrink. I hold this pattern throughout. While the other translations are not grammatically wrong, this idea that one must be in one form to become another is common in the Dao De Jing, and is honestly more sensible.

國之利器

State/country ['s]/this benefit/sharp/smooth instrument/vessel/capacity

The state's sharp instruments

不可以示人

Not able/possible by-means-of reveal/reveal-numinously/show/display/divulge/notify people

Cannot be revealed to the people.

Chapter 37

道常無為

Dao/way constantly/persistently lacks/without use/do/manipulate/act

The Dao is constantly without doing

而無不為⁴³⁹

And/yet lacks/without not do/use/act/manipulate

Yet nothing is left undone.

侯王若能守之

Marquis kings like/as/similar-to/if able/capable guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by

The marquis and kings, if they were able to maintain it,

萬物將自化

Ten-thousand things bring themselves change/transform/convert

The ten-thousand things would bring themselves to transformation.

化而欲作

Change/transform/convert and/yet want/desire rise/create/organize/start

Transforming, yet desire arises,

吾將鎮⁴⁴⁰之

I/we bring/will weighed-down/quell/suppress/restrain/defend ['s]/this/it

I will bring it to be quelled

以無名之樸

By-means-of without/no name ['s]/this unworked-wood/simple/sincere

Through the simplicity (unworked wood) of the nameless

無名之樸⁴⁴¹

No/without name ['s]/this/it unworked-wood/simple/sincere

The nameless one's simplicity (unworked wood)

夫亦將無欲

Anyone too/as-well/in-this-case bring/will no/without desire/want

Anyone, too, will be brought into lacking desires

不欲以靜

Not/no desire/want by-means-of stillness/motionless

Not desiring by means of stillness.

天下將自定

Under-heaven bring self stability

The world will bring itself to stability.

⁴³⁹ This line only occurs in the Wang Bi.

⁴⁴⁰ Originally 鎮 in Wang Bi and Mawangdui B, though A has 聞

⁴⁴¹ Mawangdui A has 握 here and in the line above

Guodian (A:7)

(術/道) (恒/互) 亡為也,

Way/Dao constantly/persistently without/not do/act/manipulate

The way is constantly without manipulative action.

(侯/侯)王能(𠂔/宥)⁴⁴²之,

Marquis/mark/target/scope/title king able be-magnanimous-toward/forgive [‘s]/this

Marquis and kings are capable of forgiving this,

而萬(勿/物) (𠂔/將)自(𠂔/愚)⁴⁴³。

And/but/yet ten-thousand things bring themselves/naturally intentional-action

And ten thousand things bring themselves to intentional action.

愚⁴⁴⁴而𠂔⁴⁴⁵作⁴⁴⁶,

Intentional-action and/but/yet transgressing arises

Intentional action, and yet transgression arises;

(𠂔/將) (𠂔/貞)之以亡(明/名)之僕⁴⁴⁷。

Bring divination-result/steadfast/chaste by-means-of without/no name [‘s] manual-work

Bringing respectable firmness to them is the manual work of the nameless.

夫亦(𠂔/將) 智,

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case will/bring knowledge/wisdom

Anyone for their part can bring themselves wisdom,

智足⁴⁴⁸以(束/刺),

Wisdom/knowledge foot/go/is-sufficient by-means-of spike/thorn//to-pierce

The wisdom is sufficient by piercing.

萬(勿/物) (𠂔/將)自定。

Ten-thousand things bring themselves/naturally settle-down/set-in-place/decide/secure/stabilize

The ten thousand things bring themselves to stability.

⁴⁴² Looks to me like 虫 over 又; but Cook merely calls this a variant of 守. It is listed in zi.tools under 守, with the up-arrow being 𠂔 rather than 虫. This is not how 守 is normally expressed in the Guodian: 獸 (hunt, beast).

Perhaps a synonym, but it is odd. If it is really 爻, then it may be a form of 宥 (generous, to pardon, magnanimous)

⁴⁴³ Originally 𠂔 over 心 → 愚 (which zi.tools agrees with), which may be a phonetic loan word for 化 (change) but I can't find a source for this. It could be 偽 (harmonious accord), or this for 偽 (artificiality, deception, departure from the uncarved wood). But see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 226: I actually agree with him, that this is 爲 (to do, to act) with the heart radical giving a sense of emotional/mental aspect: intentional action.

⁴⁴⁴ On the actual strips, the character is not duplicated but there's a = mark below it, signifying duplication.

⁴⁴⁵ Associated also with 鵠, a mynah bird, most likely the crested mynah. 鵠. This bird is recorded as not crossing the Ji river, and then doing so. It is associated with barbarians and powers shifting according to the Shuowen Jiezi. This bird was also a very capable vocal mimic (comparable to parrots), and were often caged for this reason. At least in later traditions, they are associated with independent thinking, honesty, and resistance to conformity. Keeping in the connotation of the mynah as expressed in the Shuowen Jiezi on Zi.tools and the Zuozhuan, of this bird crossing a boundary, I translate this as "transgression"

⁴⁴⁶ 𠂔 → 𠂔. Original was 𠂔 with a 又 under it, unlike Chapter 2 (Guodian A:9), more similar to the one in A:13.

⁴⁴⁷ 𠂔 Originally 又 below 𠂔 over 臣, apparently, according to Cook and Henricks. Zi.tools has this listed under 僕, apparently not acknowledging the hand on the bottom. Could be to do servant work with the hands? Or to physical hold someone captive? Maybe 朴, but see Guodian A:1 and A:5 – if this were wood, I'd expect that radical.

⁴⁴⁸ There's a repetition mark after 智, some think that 足 should have occurred after both.

Chapter 38

上德不德是以有德

Above/over/high virtue/power not virtue/power this by-means-of have/exist virtue/power

High virtue is not virtuous, and by means of this has virtue

下德不失德是以無德

Low/below/down virtue/power not lose virtue/power this by-means-of lack/without/no virtue

Low virtue does not lose⁴⁴⁹ virtue, and by means of this lacks virtue.

上德無為而無以為

Above/high virtue/power lack/without do/act/use and/yet/but without/lack by-means-of do/use

High virtue is non-manipulative, yet without using manipulation,⁴⁵⁰

下德為之而有以為

Low/below/down virtue/power do/use/manipulate ['s]/this and/yet/but has/exist by-means-of do/use

Low virtue manipulates this, yet has the use of manipulation.

上仁為之而無以為

High humane/kind/benevolent use/manipulate ['s]/this and/yet/but lack by-means-of do/use

High benevolence manipulates this, and yet without using manipulation,

上義為之而有以為

High proper/dutiful/responsible use/manipulate ['s]/this and/yet/but has/exist by-means-of/use

High propriety manipulates this, and yet has the use of manipulation.

上禮為之

High ritual/rites/formality/ceremony do/use ['s]/it

High formality manipulates this

而莫之以應,則攘臂

And in-no-case this/['s]/to-go by-means-of reply/fulfill/accept, when-then roll-up-sleeves⁴⁵¹ forearm

And, when no one uses a response to this, then high formality rolls up its sleeves,

而扔⁴⁵²之

And/yet pull/tow/haul/destroy/wreck this/['s]

And pulls this.⁴⁵³

⁴⁴⁹ Lau, Chan, Henricks, Waley (I think), Lin, Cleary, and to a degree Feng & English translate this as “not losing sight of” or “keeps intent on” or “never frees itself”, or “set on reward”. It could be this is snarky, implying that those with little virtue don’t lose what they don’t have.

⁴⁵⁰ This is a clumsy translation on my part and I will call it out. 以為 together can mean “make into, take as, consider to be X”. Wiktionary holds that it may be also regard (see also Waley), opinion (though this meaning can be much newer). Linnell and Lin and Chan (motive), Cleary (uncontrived/contrived), Henricks (reason) and Wu (private ends to serve) translate this as some kind of aim or intention. Consulting Kroll and Wiktionary, I’m not sure why there is such confidence in this wording, though I should assume they are right and I am wrong. By-means-of using/doing could be “by doing something”, implying intent? My understanding is this: High virtue uses non-manipulation, but does not do this with the intention to manipulate; high virtue does not use WuWei in order to influence or bring about an outcome, it is being natural vs acting natural.

⁴⁵¹ Can also mean extract, expel.

⁴⁵² Mawangdui has 仍 (repeats, carry on as before, reiterate, follow, meanwhile)

⁴⁵³ This is normally translated in some form of forcing compliance on others (Feng & English “enforce order” Wu “enforce itself”, Cleary “forceful repetition” (probably working form 仍), Lin/Chan “force it on others/them” and Henricks “forces people to comply”, Waley “advance upon them,” Lau “resorts to persuasion by force”). Unless I’m missing something, none of these forcing enforcement translations are literal.

故失道而後德

As-a-result/therefore lose Dao/way and/but/yet rear/after virtue/power

Therefore, lose the Dao and behind is virtue,

失德而後仁

Lose virtue/power and/yet/but rear/after benevolence/humane/kind

Lose virtue and behind is benevolence,

失仁而後義

Lose benevolence/kind/humane and/yet/but rear/after proper/dutiful/responsible

Lose benevolence, and behind is propriety,

失義而後禮

Lose proper/dutiful/responsible and/yet/but rear/after rites/rituals/formality

Lose propriety and behind is formality.

夫禮者忠信之薄⁴⁵⁴

In-any-case formality [person/phrase-end] wholehearted/dedicated/loyal trust/faith/reliable ['s] trace

In any case, formality is the thin traces of loyalty and reliability,

而亂之首

and/yet/but confused/rebel/troubled/disordered ['s] head/foremost/first/beginning-of/apex

And the head of troubledness.

前識者道之華

Before/front aware-of/record [person/phrase] Dao ['s]/this splendor/showy/superficial/brilliant/beauty

Awareness before something happens is the superficial beauty of the Dao,

而愚之始

And/yet/but ignorant/untaught ['s]/this start/beginning

And the start of ignorance.

是以大丈夫

This by-means-of great/big elders

By means of this, the great elders

處其厚不居其薄

Stays/resides/occupies/sequestered its thick/deep/authentic not settle/dwell its thin/trace

Reside in its thickness and do not dwell in its thinness,

處其實不居其華

Stays/resides/occupies its fruit/full/honest/reality not dwell/settle its splendor/showy/superficial/beauty

Stay in its full reality and do not dwell in its superficial beauty.

故去彼取此

Therefore/thus/as-a-result leave/go that/others take/capture/seize this

So, they leave the others and take this.

⁴⁵⁴ Also means thicket/dense undergrowth, crowd/press in against/push near to, thin, weak, diffuse, shabby, negligible, inferior, disapproval.

Chapter 39

昔之得一者

Formerly/long-ago/yesteryear ['s]/this obtain/gain one [person/phrase]

Those who gained oneness long ago:

天得一以清

Heaven obtains/gains one by-means-of clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent

Heaven gained oneness by means of clarity

地得一以寧

Earth gain/obtain one by-means-of peace/tranquil/calm/pacify

Earth gained oneness by means of tranquility

神得一以靈

Spirits/gods/deities obtain/gain one by-means-of numinous/sacred/life-principle/ethereal/supernatural

The spirits and gods gained oneness by means of numinosity.

谷得一以盈

Valley obtain/gain one by-means-of fill/expand/overflow/plentiful

The valley gained oneness by means of fullness.

萬物得一以生

Ten-thousand things gain one by-means-of life/born/create.

Ten thousand things gained oneness by means of life.

侯王得一以為天下貞

Marquis kings obtain one by-means-of use/do/manipulate heaven earth steadfast/chaste/divination

Marquis and kings gained oneness by means of acting as the steadfastness for the world.

其致之

Its attain/bring-about ['s]/this

They brought this about.

天無以清將恐裂

Heaven lack by-means-of clear/pure/lucent, will/bring fear/probably rip-apart/tear/split-open/burst

Heaven lacking the means of clarity brings fear it will split apart.

地無以寧將恐發

Earth lack by-means-of tranquil/peace/calm will/bring fear/probably go-out/emit/effuse/express/breach

Earth lacking the means of tranquility brings fear it will explode.

神無以靈將恐歇

Spirits/gods/entities lack by-means-of numinous/sacred/ethereal will/bring fear/probably cease/desist

The spirits and gods lacking the means of numinosity brings fear they will cease to be.

谷無以盈將恐竭

Valley lack by-means-of full/overfilled/expand bring/will fear/probably dry-up/parched/run-dry/utterly

The valley lacking the means of fullness brings fear it will run dry.

萬物無以生將恐滅

Ten-thousand things lack by-means-of life/born will/bring snuff-out/extinguish/exterminate/vanish

The ten-thousand things lacking the means of life brings fear they will be exterminated.

侯王無以貴高將恐蹶

Marquis kings lack by-means-of value/expense/costly tall/high/loftiness will/bring stumble/tumble

The marquis and kings lacking the means of value and loftiness brings fear they will tumble down.

故貴以賤為本

As-a-result value/expensive by-means-of cheap/lowly/insignificant/lacking/disrespect use/do root/base
So, value uses cheap as its foundation,

高以下為基

High/tall/lofty by-means-of low do/act-as/use base/platform/foundation/undertake
High uses low as a platform,

是以侯王自謂孤寡不穀

This by-means-of marquis kings self call orphan/unworthy few/scant/widow no/not nourishment
By means of this, marquis and kings call themselves orphaned, widower, not having nourishment.

此非以賤為本耶⁴⁵⁵?

This not/no by-means-of cheap do/use/act-as root/foundation/base/source hmm?
Is this not the means by which cheapness acts as a foundation, hmm?

非乎?

Not/no [interrogative-particle]?
No?

故致數輿⁴⁵⁶無輿

As-a-result bring-about/attain counts/frequently/figures vehicle/lift/menial/multitudes lack vehicle
So they bring about their high count of carriages as being without carriages,

不欲碌碌如玉

Not desire/expecting/craving polished-luster like jade
Not desiring to be shiny as jade;⁴⁵⁷

珞珞如石

Hard-as-stone/sound-of-stone-chimes like stone
Hard as stone.

⁴⁵⁵ Mawangdui has 邪- irregular, biased, perverse, heterodox, strange, but also “hmm” or “is it that...?”

⁴⁵⁶ Usually a carriage

⁴⁵⁷ Some translators have this as the tinkle or jingle of jade bells (paired with the onomatopoeia of stone chimes in the line after, I suppose), but this is not supported by Kroll

Chapter 40

反 {也} 者道之動 {也}

Return/go-back/oppose [phrase/person], Dao ['s]/this movement

Returning is the Dao's movement.

弱 {也} 者道之用 {也}

Weak/frail [phrase/person], Dao ['s]/this employ/use

Weakness is the Dao's mode of operation.

天下萬物生於有

Under heaven ten-thousand things born/create/live at/from/regarding has/exist.

Under heaven ten thousand things are born from existence,

有生於無

Has/exist born/create/live at/from/regarding not/lack.

Existence is born from not existing.

Commentary: (keywords: youth, movement)

Guodian (A:19)

(返/返)⁴⁵⁸也者, 道(還/僮)也。

Return/revert/turn-back/repeat as-for/[phrase/person], Dao/way boy/youth.

As for returning, the Dao is a youth.

溺⁴⁵⁹也者, 道之(甬/用)也。

Sinking/flooding/drowning as-for/[phrase/person], Dao/way ['s]/this Bell//use/employ

As for sinking, it is the Dao's mode of operation.

天下之(勿/物)生於⁴⁶⁰(又/有),

Under heaven ['s]/this things born/live/produce in/at/regarding/than have/exist

Under heaven things are born from existing,

生於亡。

Born/live/produce in/at/regard/than not/lacking/lost.

Born from not existing.⁴⁶¹

⁴⁵⁸ A synonym with 還? 還 is used much more often in the Guodian. An abbreviation? Worth noting.

⁴⁵⁹ Technically 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Could be 弱 (weak and frail)? See also A:5 and A:17

⁴⁶⁰ Originally 𠂔 → 𠂔 → 烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ↔ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁴⁶¹ To explain a bit, “under heaven” everything comes into being through what already exists, but the state of existing comes from absence. Things that are now were not always. So things are born from existence, and that existence is born from non-existence. 亡 → 有 → 物 Put another way “Under heaven things are born from existing, which in turn is born from not existing.”

Chapter 41

上士聞道勤而行之

High/above nobles hear/inform Dao struggling/toiling/laboring and/yet/but engage/enact/move this/['s]

The high nobles, hearing of the Dao, struggle yet enact it.

中士聞道若存若亡

Middle/center/core nobles hear/inform Dao like/if exist/preserved/survive like/if gone/not

The middle nobles, hearing of the Dao, are as if preserving it and as if losing it.

下士聞道大笑之

Low/down/below noble hear/inform Dao, big/great laugh/smile ['s]/this

The low nobles, hearing of the Dao, laugh greatly at it.

不笑不足以為道

Not laugh/smile not sufficient/leg [by-means-of do/act-as/use]/taken-as/made-into Dao

If there was no laughter from him, it would be insufficient to take as the Dao.

故建言有之 [曰]

Therefore/thus/as-a-result establish/found/propose/build/enact/determine words have/exist this/['s] say

Thus, established sayings have this said:

明道若昧

Bright/perceptive/light/evident/insight Dao like/if dim/indistinct/obscure

The bright Dao is like dimness,

進道若退

Go-forward/advance Dao, like/if withdrawing/receding/go-back

The advancing Dao is like withdrawing,

夷道若類

Barbarian/crude/level/flatland/even/faint Dao like/if knotty/kink/rough/defect/deform/perverse

The level Dao is like unevenness.

上德若谷

High/above virtue/power like/if valley/cave/chasm

High virtue is like a valley.

大白若辱

Great/big white/plain/clear/blank like shame/dishonor/humiliation

Great whiteness is like humiliation.

廣德若不足

Broad/wide/spacious/accepting/widespread virtue like not sufficient/leg

Broad virtue is like insufficiency.

建德若偷⁴⁶²

Establish/found virtue/power like undignified/nonchalant/dis-esteem

Establishing virtue is like negligence.

質真若渝

Substance/genuine/aiming real/true/authentic/pure like/if change/alter/abandon/renounce/overflow

Genuine authenticity is like alteration.

⁴⁶² HeShangGong has 偷 (pull out, draw out). This character is missing in both Mawangdui.

大方無隅

Great/big only-then/means/direction/proper/square/earth lack/without niches/corners

The great square of earth lacks corners,

大器晚⁴⁶³成

Great/big instrument/tool/capacity evening/late/night/belated/tardy complete/accomplished

Great instruments are late to completion.⁴⁶⁴

大音希聲

Great/big sound/tone rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to sound/tone

Great tones are sparse sounds.

大象無形⁴⁶⁵

Great/big image/replica/imitate without/lack mold/shape/outline/contrast/form

Great images are without form,

道隱無名

The Dao cover/hidden/obscure lack name.

The Dao, obscure, lacks a name.

夫唯道善貸⁴⁶⁶且成

In-any-case only Dao skilled/excellent lend/provide/borrow/absolve even/and/or/shall complete

In any case, only the Dao is skilled at providing and completing.

⁴⁶³ Mawangdui B has 免 – avoid, escape, remove

⁴⁶⁴ Linnell says this is a euphemism for “Great talents mature slowly.”

⁴⁶⁵ Mawangdui B has 刑 – model, form, correct, torture, disfigure.

⁴⁶⁶ Mawangdui B has 始, and inserts 善 after 且, good at starting and finishing.

Guodian (B:5)

上士(昏)⁴⁶⁷道,

Above/high nobles sunset/dusk/incompetent Dao/way,

The high nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

(堇)⁴⁶⁸/堇/僅能行於⁴⁶⁹其(中)⁴⁷⁰。

Scarcely?/clay/soil//hardly/barely able enact/transmit/engage in their core/center/middle

Barely able to engage at their core.

中士昏道,

Middle/center nobles sunset/dusk/incompetent Dao/way

The middle nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

若昏若亡。

If/like/thus twilight/dusk/incompetent/blurry/dimmed if/like/thus gone/not/lost.

Like it is blurry, like it is gone.

下士昏道,

Below/low twilight/dusk/incompetent Dao/way

The low nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

大(笑)⁴⁷¹之。

Big/great smile/laugh this/[‘s].

They laugh greatly at it.

(弗)大(笑), 不足以爲道矣。

Not big/great smile/laugh, Not-work [by-means-of do/manipulating]/taken-as/used-as) Dao/way [!]

If there wasn’t great laughter at it, it would be insufficient to be taken as the Dao!

是以(建)⁴⁷²言(又/有)之:

This by-means-of establish/found/propose/build/enact/determine words have/exist this

By means of this, established words exist for this:

(明)道(女/如)亨,

Luminous/light/evident/illuminate/perceptive Dao/way woman//like/as burst-out/explode/puff/comet

The brightness of the Dao is like an explosion;

(遲)⁴⁷³道□□⁴⁷⁴ ((女/如)(續/繪))

Slowly/tedious/procrastinate/wait/tardy/backward Dao (woman/like fabric-fringe//paint/embroider)

The tediousness of the Dao {is like color-coordinated embroidery;}

⁴⁶⁷ In C:1, 昏 was used to mean 昏 in the sense of “incompetent”. See also A:16 (昏)

⁴⁶⁸ Cook, Henricks, + Zi.tools list as 堇 but it’s clearly 黃 over 土, so 堇. See A:13 (堇). In this case it is impossible to get soil/clay to work. Kroll holds that this character also is borrowed for 僅 (hardly, barely, only just manage), though usually as reduplicated. Lau and Cook both prefer using this character instead.

⁴⁶⁹ Originally 烏 → 烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ↔ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁴⁷⁰ Duplication mark here

⁴⁷¹ In zi.tools, Henricks and Cook, 笑. It is this character in every instance in this chapter.

⁴⁷² Listed in zi.tools as 建. To me, looks like 建 over 木 over 止. Cook and Henricks just have 建. 建言, which also occurs in the received, may refer to a specific work, or just established sayings in general (Linnell, Cook)

⁴⁷³ Cook and Henricks has 遲, zi.tools has this listed under 遲. In zi.tools, these are treated as equivalent.

⁴⁷⁴ On the slips, long large gap after 道, but no one says the strip is broken, the Jingmen photos in the section lack it.

Cook and Henricks have (女/如)續 next, apparently based on fragment 20 – consistent with 續.

□ 475 (𡗗/道)⁴⁷⁶ 若⁴⁷⁷(𡗗/退)⁴⁷⁸。(進)

□ Dao, like withdrawing/receding/go-back (go-forward/advance)

The {advancement of the} Dao is like withdrawal.

上(𡗗/惠/德)⁴⁷⁹ (女/如)(𡗗/浴)⁴⁸⁰,

Above/top/high/foremost upright-heart/virtue/power woman/like a bath/wash/purify/swoop/stream

High virtue is like a stream.

大(白/白) (女/如)(𡗗/辱),

Great white/plain/clear/blank woman/like shame/dishonor/humiliation

Great whiteness is like humiliation.⁴⁸¹

(𡗗/𡗗/往)⁴⁸² (惠/德) (女/如)不足,

Mound/bestow/sealed-up/border//turn-toward virtue/power woman/like not-foot/insufficient,

Moving⁴⁸³ virtue is like being insufficient,

(𡗗/建)(惠/德) (女/如)⁴⁸⁴ □ (𡗗/偷/偷/輸)⁴⁸⁵

Establish/found virtue/power woman/like (negligent/enjoy//pulling-out//transfer)

Establishing virtue is like {negligence}.

□ 貞⁴⁸⁶ (女/如) 愈⁴⁸⁷。(質)

□ steadfast/chaste/divination woman/like increasingly/heal. (substance/genuine/ground/aiming)

{Aiming for} respectable firmness is like surpassing.

⁴⁷⁵ There is room for about three characters in that gap, Cook supplies 進 here.

⁴⁷⁶ From what I can tell, Cook, Henricks, and zi.tools treats this like 道. The previous instance appears as 𡗗, and the one before that as 𡗗 (both of which are listed in zi.tools), so it's likely this was just a strangely faded version.

⁴⁷⁷ Unlike other instances, this is indeed 若 and not 女/如 like in the rest of the chapter apart from the fourth line.

⁴⁷⁸ Also listed under 復 on zi.tools: 𡗗 See also A:20 (𡗗)

⁴⁷⁹ Or 惠. 𡗗 on the slips everywhere it occurs in this chapter.

⁴⁸⁰ In A:10, this character was treated as “stream(s)” 𡗗, and in A:2 (𡗗, the only time this form occurs). I originally had “The greatest virtue is like bathing, greatly blank, like societal shame”, as the cleansing process would make one clean, or “blank”, unadorned. However, consistency favors the translation of “stream”, and so “clear” for 白, even if this is really more like white.

⁴⁸¹ I read this initially as referring to the stream above, “Greatly clear, like societal shame.” This may also be an independent line, “Great whiteness is like humiliation.”

⁴⁸² Can also probably be expressed as 𡗗. Cook asserts that this is the ancient form of 往, but that seems to be 往, and this is already in C:2 as 𡗗. Top more like 之 on the slips, but the mountain shape is sometimes a form of it. By zi.tools, 𡗗 is like 封 (border, mound, boundary, entomb/seal off) but Wiktionary has “to grow wildly” or as the original form of 往. Zi.tools, citing the 漢多, 𡗗 originally means to go or arrive, like 往. If we think of this as 往 without the step 辵, it is foot over earth (or king). If 往 is move toward/directionally, perhaps turn/orient? Stand?

⁴⁸³ Because of uncertainty of 𡗗, this may be: arriving moving, turning, sealed, entombed, going, bestowed, standing.

⁴⁸⁴ Partially cut off, but remainder is consistent with the character.

⁴⁸⁵ Supplied by Cook, as well as 質 on the next line. Cook gives options: 偷 (negligent, undignified, nonchalant, dis-esteem), 𡗗 (happiness, enjoy; possibly stealthy/cunning), 𡗗 (pull out, draw out) or 輸 (transport, deliver, destroy).

⁴⁸⁶ Originally was 直 without the 亠, written a bit strange: 𡗗 → 𡗗

⁴⁸⁷ Photo is blurry but consistent with 𡗗, listed under 偷 in zi.tools. The heart radical is undoubtedly on the bottom. A little troubling, as the 愈 character itself is, by Wiktionary and zi.tools, an alternative form of 癒 meaning “cured (of an illness).” I take surpassing here, as correction making it better than the original. See also A:12 (𡗗)

大(ㄉㄜ/方)亡(𡗗/禺⁴⁸⁸/隅),

Great/big only-then/means/direction/proper/square/earth no/gone/lost land-plot/simian//niches/corners

The great square of earth lacks corners,

大(𡗗/器)⁴⁸⁹(𡗗/曼) (𡗗/埜/成⁴⁹⁰),

Great/big instruments/capacity extend/stretch/slender/diffuse/graceful complete/enclosed

Big instruments are completely stretched to the thinnest.⁴⁹¹

大音(𡗗/祗)⁴⁹² 聖⁴⁹³,

Big sound respect/honor/only/barely/still/as-before sound/noise//listen-clearly/sagely/virtue

Great sounds are barely heard clearly,⁴⁹⁴

天(𡗗/象)⁴⁹⁵亡(𡗗/埜⁴⁹⁶/垠),

Heaven image/replica/imagination lack/no/gone boundaries/territories/limits

The image of Heaven lacks boundaries.

道⁴⁹⁷□□□ (隱亡名)

The Dao (cover/hidden/obscure lack name)

The Dao, {obscure, lacks a name.}

⁴⁸⁸ This character alone means plot of land, tract, or simian, monkey-like, or macaque-like monster. Mawangdui B has 愚 (ignorant, untaught), Cook suggests 隅 (niche, corners, thorough) as in the other received versions, or 偶 (human-figurine/statuette, pair/counterpart/mate/partner, jibe with, or accidentally/perchance.)

⁴⁸⁹ Not the clearest in the photos, nor is the next few characters. Zi.tools equivalent pasted next to these. For 器 compared with C:3/4's 喪 (𡗗), which also has a dog and mouths/boxes.

⁴⁹⁰ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 埜. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁴⁹¹ Like an atmosphere, becoming so big it becomes invisible, Or “Great capacity is completely stretched.”

⁴⁹² 𡗗 on the slips, listed as 𡗗 on zi.tools on the 祗 page but it is the only instance. To me looks like the top part of 事 (𡗗) over 而. I'm having trouble understanding the derivation and structure of this character, but 𡗗 from the Late Warring States period is described like 𡗗 meaning 祗 as well, and they are reasonably similar.

⁴⁹³ 聖 = 聖 This character, later “noise”, means peerless, paragon, possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. It is meant as sage, the same character, later in this very chapter. I read it as “Hear correctly” or “hearing clarity”; and so the sage (聖人) is “person who hears clearly.”

⁴⁹⁴ Originally, I had here “Great sounds honor careful listening.” This may also be paradoxical like the other lines.

⁴⁹⁵ 𡗗 on the slips, Zi.tools has 𡗗 over 胃. 象 originally means “elephant” (which was mostly imagined based on bones by the time of the Warring states – elephants had shifted their range due to habitat loss and climate change; refer to Han Fei's description of them) or “ivory”, and by extension “image, representation, icon, effigy, replica, apparition, figure”. It is indeed an image, but how realistic it is, how faithful to the truth it is, is such an open question that this word has also come to refer to illusion. The character itself could by my eye be 冒 over 肉 but that may be redundant. Compare with 𡗗, which is 為: 𡗗 has an open bottom.

⁴⁹⁶ 埜 By Wiktionary and zi.tools, this character leads to 阱 (pitfall, trap), or 型 (mold, but see A:9: 埜). It could be A:9's instance has the knife radical, conveying an active shaping/molding, whereas this may just be shape? Or, this could be a form of 垠→境 (end-point, limit, boundary, territory).

⁴⁹⁷ Bottom of the character got cut off, but still consistent with 道. Suggested fill-in from Cook.

Chapter 42

道生一，一生二，二生三，三生萬物

Dao born/life/creates one, “” create/born two, “” create/born three, “” create ten-thousand things

Dao creates one, One creates two, Two creates three, Three creates the ten-thousand things.

萬物負陰而抱陽

Ten-thousand things carry-on-back/bear/ignore/turn-from yin/shade and/but/yet embrace/hug yang/sun

The ten thousand things carry Yin on their backs and hug Yang to their bellies,⁴⁹⁸

沖氣以為和

Surge/rush-up/swell/saturate vital-energy/breath/air [by-means-of do/use] make-into/take-as harmony

Swelling their vital energy by using harmony.⁴⁹⁹

人之所惡

People [‘s]/this place/that-which ugly/hateful/abhorrent

That which people hate,

唯孤寡不穀

Only orphan/alone/unworthy/disengaged few/scant/lessen/widow no/not nourishment/life/nipple/grain

Nothing but being orphaned, widowed, not having nourishment,

而王公以為⁵⁰⁰稱

And/yet/but king duke/impartial [by-means-of do/use]/make-into weigh/praise/raise/esteem/name

Yet kings and dukes make these into what they call themselves.

故物或損之而益

Therefore/thus/as-a-result things sometimes de cease/diminish/damage [‘s]/it, and/yet increase/benefit

Therefore, things sometimes are diminished and yet benefit,

或益之而損

Sometimes/in-some-cases increase/augment/benefit and/yet diminished/damaged/restrained/decrease

Sometimes are benefitted and yet diminished.

人之所教我亦教之

People [‘s]/this that-which teachings/teach/instruct I in-this-case/too teach/instruct [‘s]/this

That which people teach, I too teach.

強梁者不得其死

[Strong/dominate/forced foxtail-millet/beam]/ strong-and-violent people not obtain its/it death

Strong and violent people do not obtain their deaths⁵⁰¹

吾將以為教父

I bring/will [by-means-of make/use/do]/make-into/take-as teach/instruct father/veteran/elder

I will be taken as a veteran teacher.

⁴⁹⁸ Yang is associated with the back, where the sun beats down, whereas Yin is associated with the belly, shaded by the body. Feng & English (and Chan) have “carry Yin and embrace Yang” (Cleary has similar), Lin has “carries the yin at its back and the yang in front,” and Henricks has “carry Yin on their backs and wrap their arms around Yang,” and Lau and Wu have similar. Waley has “cannot turn their back to the shade without having the sun on their bellies”.

⁴⁹⁹ This could also be translated as “Swelling their vital energy, making it into harmony.” Wu has “Deriving their vital harmony from the proper blending of the two vital breaths.” Lau has “and are the blending of the generative forces of the two.” Henricks has “and through the blending of qi they arrive at a state of harmony” (Chan has very similar).

⁵⁰⁰ Mawangdui has 自

⁵⁰¹ This is usually translated as “do not die natural/good deaths” or “come to violent deaths”

Chapter 43

天下之至柔

Under-heaven [‘s arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost pliant/soft/bending

Under heaven, the ultimate softness

馳騁天下之至堅

Gallop/hurry/flee gallop/dash/charge/impetuous/unbridled under-heaven [‘s] ultimate solid/firm/hard

Gallops charging at the ultimate hardness under heaven.

無有入無間

Lack/no/without exist/have enter/accept/adopt lack/no/without between/interval/opening/space

Non-existence enters without being between.

吾是以知無為之有益 •

I this by-means-of know not act-as/do/use/manipulate [‘s]/this exist/have increase

I, by means of this, know there exist benefits to not doing.

不言之教, 無為之益

Not talk/speech/words [‘s]/this teach/instruct, not act-as/do/manipulate/use [‘s] increase/benefit,

The teachings without words, the benefits of not doing –

天下希及之

Under-heaven rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to reach/arrive/catch-up-to/succeed/attain [‘s]/this

In the world, it is rare to reach this.

Chapter 44

名與身孰親

Name/reputation/label and/give/grant/join/share self/body who/which parents/kin/intimate

Name and self, which is close?

身與貨孰多

Self/body and/give/join resources/goods/property/money who/which many/much/exceed/multiply

Self and resources, which is many?

得與亡孰病

Gain/obtain and/give/join loss/disappearance/lack who/which illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by

Gaining and losing, which is the disease?

甚愛必大費

Excessive/too-much fond/love/kind/begrudge/stingy certainly big/great expense/waste/consume

Excessive stinginess is certainly a great expense,

多藏必厚亡

Many/much/multiply/exceed store/storehouse/hide-away/cover-up thick/deep/authentic/richly loss/lack

Much storage certainly makes for deep loss⁵⁰²

知足不辱

Know sufficiency/enough/leg not humiliating/disgrace/unworthy/insult

Knowing sufficiency is not humiliating,

知止不殆

Know stop/limit/halt not danger/peril

Knowing when to stop is having no danger.

可以長久

Possible/can/permissible by-means-of long/enduring/mature long/long-standing/enduring/old

One can endure for a long time.

⁵⁰² Often translated as “leads to deep loss” Additionally 愛 is translated as “desires” by some translators (Wu, Chan, Henricks, Lin, Cleary, maybe Feng & English), but the old sense of this word does not necessarily support that.

Guodian (A:18)

名與⁵⁰³ 身管⁵⁰⁴ 新⁵⁰⁵

Name give/associate/unite/and/join/share body/self devotion/relentless new

Names grant selves relentless freshness,

身⁵⁰⁶(𠂔/與)(𠂔/貨)管多

Body/self give/and/unite goods/property/money/resources devotion/relentless many/exceed/multiply

Selves grant resources relentless multitudes,⁵⁰⁷

(𠂔/貢/得)⁵⁰⁸(𠂔/與)(𠂔/貢/亡) 管(𠂔/病)⁵⁰⁹.

Gaining/seeking(?) give/grant/unite/and losing/gone relentless damage/impede//illness/disease/fault.

Gain of value grants loss of value relentless capacity for damage.

(𠂔/甚)(𠂔/𦵏⁵¹⁰)(𦵏/必)大(𦵏/費)⁵¹¹,

Excessive fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge certainly great waste/expend/consume

Excessive stinginess is certainly a great expense,⁵¹²

⁵⁰³ 𠂔 A bit blurry, but this doesn't totally match entries in zi.tools under 與. It certainly has the two hands on the bottom, and it bears decent resemblance to the seal script 𠂔, so I do not challenge it. However, the next two instances of this character in this chapter looks totally normal: 𠂔, 𠂔. In this chapter I translate this as “grant” – what Shuowen Jiezi calls the older form (𠂔) is used in A:2 and A:10 (share), and this form is in A:12 (rhetorical).

⁵⁰⁴ 𠂔, listed under zi.tools as 管 Early form of 簫. All three are pronounced du3. See A:13 and A:5(𠂔). This character could be a synonym of 𠂔 (which I have been translating as genuine) and so therefore 簫 (thick, relentless, genuine), which I am hesitant about because this character 𠂔 already appears, but the Shuowen Jiezi, by zi.tools, seems to also say this means “thick.” It appears the thick/devoted meaning is more likely. Shuowen Jiezi says “thick and winter-poisonous”, but the poisonous bit may be pronunciation. This may be a Chu version for 孰, meaning “in which cases, which, who, what”, according to zi.tools.

⁵⁰⁵ Really 𠂔 (technically 𠂔 over 辛 to the left of 斤). C:1 has this neater as 𠂔. This is listed under 新 in both cases.

⁵⁰⁶ Strange underline on the slips.

⁵⁰⁷ 多 can also refer to superior-to/more, exceed, highly esteem, and multiply. So this could read “Bodies grant resources relentless high-value/superiority”. But “bodies” transform raw materials into resources.

⁵⁰⁸ 𠂔 Cook renders as 𠂔 (a form of 之) over 貝, (zi.tools: 𠂔 over 貝) but to me looks like 之 over 貝, (Henricks often expresses 之 component as 止. Cook says could be 得 (zi.tools agrees, but usually rendered as 𠂔 from B:4 or 𠂔 from C:3/4), or 持 (but see A:20 𠂔). Wiktionary claims 貢 is a variant of 𠂔 (like B:4 and C:3/4). I suppose they could be synonyms, but maybe, as a foot or “to go” is involved, it is to seek gain, vs. gain “in the hand”? Conversely, just after is 𠂔 → 亡 over 貝 → 貢, to be without or to lose. This echoes the gaining/losing favor in B:4.

Cook mentions that some consider to be a variant of 覓 (to seek). In this case it would be that gaining grants seeking the capacity for harm. This interpretation is not unfeasible, but I clearly see 亡 at the top.

⁵⁰⁹ Cook and Henricks have 𠂔, zi.tools lists under 𠂔 𠂔, leading to 病 (illness, sickness, disease, defect, troubledness). I think there is a small chance this instance may be 妨 (damaging, impeding, obstruct, cause difficulty). 病 or 妨: the meaning is some kind of “damaging” or harm either way.

⁵¹⁰ 𠂔 Looking at the slip photos, looks more like 𠂔 over 心 (which gives the sense of pacing over something in a guarding manner), but is listed as 𦵏 in zi.tools, Henricks, and Cook. In the Warring states period, 𦵏 (𦵏) more so had the sense of “to begrudge”, “to protect greedily from loss or harm” than the modern sense of the word “love”. Its components may mean “saturated/choking heart.” See B:4 (𦵏).

⁵¹¹ 𦵏, 𦵏 (assist, straighten, technically 𦵏 (𦵏; heavy,) but not listed this way) over 貝 (listed as such in zi.tools), top part as in Shuowen Jiezi. Means to waste, squander, but also expend, consume, sometimes until nothing left.

⁵¹² Alternatively, “excessive fondness is certainly a big expense.”

(𪔐/唇)⁵¹³(𪔐/贊/贓)⁵¹⁴必⁵¹⁵多(賁/亡)。

Terrified/tremble/shake plunder/spoils/embezzle/stolen-goods certainly many/exceed lose-value
Terrifying plunder is certainly much loss of value.

(古/故)(智/知)足不(𪔐/辱)⁵¹⁶;

Old/ancient//thus knowledge/wisdom foot/sufficiency/adequacy not dishonor/disgrace/humiliate/insult
Thus, knowing sufficiency is not humiliating.

智(止⁵¹⁷ 止⁵¹⁸/止)不怠⁵¹⁹:

Knowledge limit/halt not idle/negligent/indifferent/disrespectful/fatigued
Knowing to stop is not idleness,

可⁵²⁰以長(𪔐/舊)。

Possible/can by-means-of long/mature old/familiar/dear-old-friend/long-existing/former.
By means of this one can endure for a long time and become familiar.

⁵¹³ Originally 厂 (cliff, but there are at least two lines in the character) + 句 (phrase, hook, ensnared, linger) in Cook and Henricks (局), treated as 厚 (But see 𪔐 in A:17 and A:2). Zi.tools has 𪔐石句 (I would agree with this if there were a third box, but there's not). The truth may be somewhere in the middle. Wiktionary describes the etymology of 厚 as a cliff 厂 over an upside down 高 (as 亭, jug). Alternatively the top part could be the same top part as in 辰 (hoe, shake, time, celestial body) (see 唇, 𪔐), see below. I initially speculated that 厂/石 (cliff/stone) + 句 (hook/curved/ensnaring) depicts something like a curved/hooked grip clinging onto a cliff face, and may mean something like “clinging, holding on for dear life;” as it turns out this is the etymology for this character if taken as the original form of 振 (Shang/ (商承祚) (1983): 說文中之古文考, through Wiktionary). I default to 唇, which, according to Wiktionary, means “terrified” or “trembling, sound of fear.”

⁵¹⁴ Listed in zi.tools under 贊 ← 𪔐 Shares the same components as 贓, so I'll go ahead and say it is most likely this.

⁵¹⁵ Slightly faded but still clearly 必

⁵¹⁶ 𪔐: literally 𪔐 (from the line before) over 又. Z.tools lists this as 辱 and Henricks and Cook both agree – this is also in the received. This does not match how 辱 occurs in B:4 (𪔐, 𪔐, 𪔐) or B:5 (𪔐), which removes the bottom mouth component of 𪔐/唇. This may reflect different ages/scribes between Guodian A and B, or reflect meaning. I settle on “humiliating/humiliation.”

⁵¹⁷ 𪔐 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 𪔐 or 𪔐, or 𪔐. 𪔐 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 走 (止 over 止). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean “to go.” To reach limit?

⁵¹⁸ 智𪔐 may be “the edge of knowledge”, but also “knowing when to stop/halt.”

⁵¹⁹ 怠 partially faded. Probably partially cut off 𪔐 → 𪔐. To me this looks like 𪔐 over 𪔐 on the slips, very unlikely.

⁵²⁰ Significantly faded, but still clearly 可

Chapter 45

大成若缺

Great accomplishment/completion like smashed/in-pieces/defective/splintered/in-shreds/incomplete

Great completion is like being in shreds,

其用不弊

Their/its employ/use not destroyed/ruin/wasted/detriment/fall-down/abused

Its use does not ruin it.

大盈若冲

Big/great filling is like an empty/sublime

Great filling is like emptiness,

其用不窮

Their use/employ not spent/depleted/reach-an-end/cease/failure

Its use does not deplete it.

大直若屈⁵²¹

Great straight/upright/confront/on-duty similar-to/like curl/bend/do-wrong/humiliate

Great straightness is like being bent.

大巧若拙

Big/great craftsmanship/skill like unskilled/awkward/clumsy/inept

Great craftsmanship is like being inept.

大辯若訥

Big/great argue/debate/quarrel/eloquence like stutter/stammer

Great debating is like stammering.

躁勝寒

Restless/agitated/impulsive/impetuous/rash/disturb overcomes cold/frigid/lacking/alooof/ignoble

Agitation overcomes freezing

靜勝熱

Stillness/motionless overcomes hot/heated/fever/excited/aroused/inflamed/vehement/ardent

Stillness overcomes heatedness

清靜為天下正

Clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent/clarity stillness do/use/act-as heaven under proper/correct/rectify

Clear stillness acts as the world's correction.

⁵²¹ Mawangdui B has 掘, apparently, Mawangdui A has 誡

Guodian (B:7)

大(𡗗/壑/成⁵²²)若(夬⁵²³/決),

Big/great completion/containment like/similar to dividing/breaking-through/resoluteness

Great completion is like breaching through⁵²⁴

其(甬⁵²⁵/用)不(𦉳⁵²⁶/敝)。

Its/it employ/use not deteriorated/badly-used/worn-out/destroy/discard

Its use does not deteriorate it.

大(湍/盈)若(𡗗/中),

Great/big filling/overflow/fill-to-brim like middle/core/center

Great filling is like the middle,⁵²⁷

其(甬/用)不(𦉳⁵²⁸)。

Its/it employ/use not spent/depleted/reach-an-end/cease/failure

Its use does not deplete it.

大(𡗗/攷⁵²⁹)若(𡗗⁵³⁰/𡗗),

Great/big strike/examine/research like short

Great examining is like being short,⁵³¹

⁵²² In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 壑. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁵²³ This character is cut off a bit but still definitely 若 (𡗗 vs 𡗗). The character after is blurry, but still probably 夬 (夬 vs 夬). 夬 in Kroll means to divide/break-through, and resoluteness. These are like those of 決 (as mentioned in Shuowen Jiezi, “分決也”), which means break through, flow out, break off, and decidedly/decisive, determined.

⁵²⁴ There are some contradictions “X like Y” in the Guodian, but this may be one, given 壑's feeling of “contain”.

⁵²⁵ In this chapter, first the left line is cut off, then the right, but they are all consistent with the shape of 甬 → 甬

⁵²⁶ 𦉳 Zi.tools lists this under 𦉳 (𦉳)(and 采 over 市 → 𦉳), but the entries in each page look essentially identical. Zi.tools holds that 𦉳 represents a tattered towel or worn-out clothes, and was the old form of 敝.

⁵²⁷ Filling to somewhere in the middle, not to the edge – if you fill past the edge it is overflowed and wasted. A vessel is full before it overflows, when the meniscus is between the bottom and the top—the middle. This could also be “empty vessel” (盂), but “to the middle” should at least be considered.

⁵²⁸ Originally 身 under 𡗗 according to Henricks, Cook, zi.tools and the slips. Zi.tools lists this under 窮 → 窮 (go to the end of, spent, thoroughly studied, depleted, last resort, to be trapped/cornered, failure, cease), other Chu characters agree better with these, though it could be an abbreviation. There is also 穿 (穿) → 穿 (cave (穴) + tooth (牙); to penetrate, pass through; later to put on clothes (cover the body)). A roof (宀) over a body (身) lends itself to the idea of clothing oneself, and I wonder if the similarity visually between a character meaning to make a cave/hole with teeth (bite through, penetrate) and a character meaning to cover put a “roof” over one's body (wear clothes) would result in our modern understanding of 穿. Zi.tools has 躬 and 躬 as meaning 身, so I favor 窮 → 窮

⁵²⁹ 𡗗 Right side is definitely 攷. The left is probably 𡗗. Zi.tools has this as 攷 (knock, strike, examine, analyze, research). 𡗗 means the experiential skill of an artisan, craftsmanship. This *could* be 攷 (with 攷 = 攷 as usual), meaning wash, cleanse, sometimes in Chu for 修 (to cultivate, cleanse (esp. internally), or let flow). See A:1 (攷)

⁵³⁰ I would have said 𡗗 left of 止 (止) or 之 (之) but 出 (出) works better. Zi.tools and Wiktionary both mention that this character is a variant of the Wu (吳, kingdom east of Chu) dialectal character 𡗗 (short in length or height), (<https://dict.variants.moe.edu.tw/dictView.jsp?ID=80344>). But maybe 𡗗 → 𡗗 → ancient form of 拙 (clumsy).

⁵³¹ Not in the sense of brevity or time, but in terms of height or length. Perhaps seeing things from a different point of view, like a short child? Or bending over to get a better look at something, to really examine it in detail? If this is great striking, perhaps this advocates for striking in a low stance?

大(茲/盛/成)若(𪔐/𪔐)⁵³²,

Great completion/containment like obtuse/dull-witted/rude/bent/bend/subdue/humiliate/diminish

Great completion is like being bent,

大(𪔐/植)若⁵³³(𪔐/屈)。⁵³⁴

Great/big plant-in-ground/embed/implant/organize/growth(plants) like bend/curl/do-wrong/humiliate

Great planting is like curling over.

梟(𪔐⁵³⁵/勝)(𪔐/蒼⁵³⁶/滄),

Birds-chirping/cicadas-buzzing/clamor/din overcomes/excels green-gray/grizzled/shadowy-and-distant

Birdsong and buzzes overcomes the shadowy and distant.

(𪔐/青)(𪔐/勝)(𪔐⁵³⁷/燃),

Green(Of plants?) overcomes burning,

Living green overcomes the burn.⁵³⁸

清清⁵³⁹(𪔐⁵⁴⁰/為)天下(𪔐/定)。

Clear/pure/evident/honest(x2; the highest clarity?) do/use world settle-down/decide/secure/stabilize.

Highest clarity enforces stability under heaven.

⁵³² May be 𪔐 in meaning, but slips, Henricks, and Cook agree.

⁵³³ Blurry, but consistent with 若

⁵³⁴ According to Cook, B:7 ends here, and so my count and Cook's get thrown off here.

⁵³⁵ Technically, zi.tools has 𪔐 over 力, Cook has 𪔐, which probably should be 乘 over 力. Most accurate would probably have been 𪔐 over 力. 𪔐 and 𪔐 seem to be an ancient form of 乘 (ascend, go up, according to Wiktionary.) It seems that regardless, this character combination was a Chu way to express 勝 (excel, overcome, prevail, superlative, totally). This fits with rise and power (力) components well enough that I don't challenge it.

⁵³⁶ Clearly has the grass component on top, and not the water component. This 蒼 refers to green-gray, the color of far off mountain forests and undergrowth, but also gray-black in the sense of "grizzled" like farmers, and also silver, shadowy and faint, like the pale moon. 滄 has a sense of iron-gray-blue, like the cold or deep water.

⁵³⁷ 𪔐 Cook has this as 然, as does zi.tools, but consistently, this character is expressed as (𪔐/𪔐) in the Guodian. It could be as in Korean 𪔐 (to burn), or the sense of 然 in the Shuowen Jiezi, which is also to burn.

⁵³⁸ In the WuXing, Wood generates fire (not really overcoming it), so this is a bit interesting. According to the Shuowen, 青 is associated with wood ("東方色也。木生火".)

⁵³⁹ 𪔐 Appears to have a duplication mark, but Cook treats this as 清清 or the reverse, to be read as 清靜

⁵⁴⁰ The form of 為 in Laozi B looks more similar to 象 with two lines above it, and a boxed-off bottom. (𪔐 vs 𪔐), Laozi A tends to express 為 like 𪔐, more horizontal, sometimes underlined.

Chapter 46

天下有道

Under-heaven has/exists Dao/way

When the world has the Dao,

卻走馬以糞

Step-back/withdraw/pardon [walk/go horses]/galloping-horses by-means-of defecation/fertilization.

Galloping horses are pardoned to be used to fertilize fields

天下無道

Under-heaven lack/no Dao/way

When the world lacks the Dao,

戎馬生於郊

Warfare/army/military/soldier/assault/assist horses born/live in/at/than suburbs/meadows/outlands

War horses are born in the meadows.

[罪莫大於可欲]⁵⁴¹

Crime/sin/vice in-no-case great/big in/at/than/regarding possible/permissible/can desire/craving

There is no crime greater than the capacity for desire

禍⁵⁴²莫大於不知足

Divine-misfortune in-no-case great/big in/at/than not/no know foot/leg/sufficiency

There is no divine misfortune greater than not knowing sufficiency.

咎莫大⁵⁴³於欲得

Fault/error/calamity/blame in-no-case great/big in/at/than desire gain/obtain/get

There is no blame greater than the desire to obtain more.

故知足之足常足矣

Therefore/thus/as-a-result know foot/sufficiency [‘s] leg/foot/sufficiency always/constant sufficiency!

Therefore, knowing the sufficiency of sufficiency is always sufficient!

⁵⁴¹ From Mawangdui only, Mawangdui B lacks 於.

⁵⁴² Mawangdui A has 𨾏

⁵⁴³ Mawangdui A has 𨾏

Guodian (A:3)

(𠂔/辜/罪) 莫 (𠂔/重)⁵⁴⁴ (虐/乎)⁵⁴⁵ (𠂔/甚) (𠂔/欲)⁵⁴⁶,

Breaking-the-law/crime no-one/in-no-case heavy/crushing perhaps/than too-much/excess want/desire

No crime is more crushing than excessive desire.

(𠂔/咎) 莫 (𠂔/會)⁵⁴⁷ (虐/乎) (𠂔/谷/欲)⁵⁴⁸ (𠂔/得),

Calamity/disaster/blame no-one/in-no-case universally-welcomed(?) perhaps want gain/obtain

No disaster is more unanimously welcomed than the want of gain.

(𠂔/化)⁵⁴⁹ 莫大 (虐/乎) 不智足。

Transform/change/convert no-one/in-no-case greater perhaps not know/wisdom foot/sufficiency

No conversion is greater than not knowing sufficiency.

智足之 (𠂔/為)⁵⁵⁰ 足, (𠂔/此) (𠂔/死/瓦)⁵⁵¹ 足矣。

Knowing sufficiency [consider-as] sufficiency, this/these constantly/persistently sufficient [!]

Knowing sufficiency as sufficiency: this will always be sufficient!

⁵⁴⁴ 𠂔 Cook has 𠂔 to become 重 (but the Guodian has this and it looks nothing like this: 𠂔). Zi.tools lists under 石 over 主, but see also 石 over 臺 for 厚: in A:2 (𠂔) and A:17 (𠂔). Heavy, thick, perhaps the meaning is “serious”?

Compare to the mystery characters in A:18 (𠂔). Due to the resemblance of the 主 component in 𠂔 (See A:4), this would be stone (石) over pillar (主), two heavy things that give a sense of crushing weight, or at least something very heavy to bear. Based on that, I favor some meaning of “heavy, crushing”, similar in sense to 重.

⁵⁴⁵ 乎 never occurs in the Guodian, it is always 𠂔, written 虐. This can mean tiger 虎, but in the Guodian, it often stands in for 乎. (interrogative, rhetorical, exclamation, imperative, speculative). Instead of the usual “perhaps” meaning, 虐 is acting as “than”.

⁵⁴⁶ the Chu variant of 欲 listed under zi.tools is 谷 + 次

⁵⁴⁷ 𠂔 Zi.tools has this as 會 (as 兪 over 日/甘), under the page 兪. Cook has 井 between 兪 and 日, which may be more accurate. May be 𠂔 (as early form of 痛 (Pain) or 甚 (too much/ severe, but see 𠂔)) or 險 (dreadful). Zi.tools suggests 斂 (gathering) but a character from the Guodian already exists under this, similar if not for the right part. 兪 means all, everybody, together, unanimous. Not for nothing, this character also bears some resemblance to the Zhou dynasty form of 龠 → 龠 → (龠), a musical instrument. If the bottom of this character really is 甘 (甘, sweet) or even 昌 (昌, sunlight, flourishing, lovely), we have “everyone/unanimous” (兪) over these positive things (sweetness of food is pleasurable, sunlight and the songs and shouts of the morning are favorable, perhaps there is a sense of “universally welcomed” here? Something everyone seems to think is favorable or at least in some way auspicious or beneficial? This is speculative for sure.

⁵⁴⁸ 谷 and 欲: both are used in this chapter. Here and throughout, I translate 欲 as desire, craving, an urge to obtain, possess, or consume something. 谷 is expressed as want, an inclination, usually in terms of what to do, or to avoid.

⁵⁴⁹ The slips are unambiguously 化, but others say it could be in place of 禍 (unblessed, divine misfortune)

⁵⁵⁰ Abnormal form of 為: usually 𠂔, 𠂔, or 𠂔, (or in parts of Laozi B, 𠂔) but still within the variation listed by zi.tools that I am not very suspicious. 之為 as a compound means “consider(ed) as”.

⁵⁵¹ Technically 𠂔, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𠂔 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 恆 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

Chapter 47

不出戶 {以} 知天下

Not produce/put-out/arise/emerge door/opening/hole/obstruct {by-means-of} know world

Not emerging through one's doors, one can know all under heaven

不闚⁵⁵²牖 {以} 見⁵⁵³天道

Not look-through-small-opening/peep/spy-on/glimpse window see/look Heaven Dao

Not peering through the window, one can see Heaven's Dao

其出彌遠

Their/its emerge/produce/put-out permeate/complete/spread-out/even-more distant/far/estranged

Their emerging is increasingly far.

其知彌少

Their/its know permeate/complete/spread-out/even-more few/reduce/minimize

Their knowing is increasingly few.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage

不行而知, 不見而名

Not enact/engage/walk/move and/yet/but know, not see/look and/yet/but name/label

Not moving yet knowing, not seeing yet identifying⁵⁵⁴

不為而成

Not doing/using/manipulating and/yet/but accomplishments/completing/achieving

Not doing and yet achieving.

⁵⁵² A variant of 窺

⁵⁵³ Mawangdui has 知 (know)

⁵⁵⁴ Linnell has "Does not display himself, yet has a reputation", but he is the odd one out this time.

Chapter 48

為學[者]日益

Do/use/manipulate/act-as learn/mimic [[person/phrase]] day increase/advance/accumulate

Use learning to increase daily,

為道[者]日損

Do/use/manipulate Dao [[person/phrase]] day decrease/reduce

Use the Dao to decrease daily.

損之又損

Decrease/reduce [‘s]/this also/still/again/simultaneously decrease/reduce

Decreasing this, still decreasing

以至於無為

By-means-of arriving/utmost in/at/from/regarding/than lack/without do/act-as/use/manipulate

By arriving at not doing.⁵⁵⁵

無為而無不為

Without/lack act-as/do/use/manipulate and/yet/but without/lack not do/use/manipulate/act-as

Not doing, yet nothing is not done.

取天下常以無事

Capture/take/seize heaven under constantly/persistently by-means-of lack/without matters/to-serve

Capture the world constantly through a lack of business,

及其有事不足以取天下

When/reach/arrive/attain their has/exist affairs/to-serve, not sufficient by-means-of capture world

When one’s matters exist, they are insufficient to capture the world this way.

⁵⁵⁵ I’m the odd one out again. Most translate this as “until one reaches no-action”. It could be my translation of 以 is too strict. I translate it as “by means of” and “by means of this”, if after something that can be referred to.

Guodian (B:2)

(𠂔/學)者日(𠂔/𦰩/益)⁵⁵⁶,

Learn/mimic people day throat/communicate//increasing/advancing/accumulating(?)

Scholars increase what they have daily,

為⁵⁵⁷道者日(員/圓)⁵⁵⁸。

Do/use/manipulate Dao/way people day circular/round

Those who operate with the Dao circle⁵⁵⁹ daily.

(員/圓)之(𦰩/或)(員/圓),

Round/circular this['s] some/sometimes/perhaps/someone personnel/member//round/circular

Someone of circling does circles

以(𠂔/至)亡為也,

By-means-of arriving/utmost not/lose/gone to-do/use,

By arriving at not actively doing.

亡為而亡不為。

Not/without/gone Dao/way and/yet/but not/without not doing/using.

Not actively doing, but not leaving anything undone.

⁵⁵⁶ 𠂔 (according to zi.tools/ Shuowen Jiezi: depicting the mouth above the veins of the throat/neck.) Very clearly 𦰩, where it is listed in zi.tools under 益. Zi.tools itself considers 𦰩 to be a form of 𦰩, based on apparently the Shuowen Jiezi. Wiktionary considers 𦰩 a variant of both 𦰩 (throat, choke, gasp out (Kroll), vital communication line, flattery (Wiktionary) by the Jiyun (集韻) dictionary) and 益 (abundant, increase, by the ShiGu (師古) Dictionary). Cook has 益 (Henricks has 益) and neither makes mention of the form being different. There is a Chu form of 益 (𦰩) but it does not occur in the Guodian, so this character could still plausibly mean 益.

⁵⁵⁷ 𠂔, another weird variant, with two lines above. The next 為 is also like this, but the two following are more like 𠂔, as seen in Laozi A. This switch happens between slips (not within), suggesting a potential scramble that would put the last line in this chapter, somehow, somewhere else. As of right now, I'm not confident to even hazard a guess as to the intended order of the slips based on just this

⁵⁵⁸ 𦰩 Henricks has this as 員 over 大, maybe like 𦰩. This is for every instance in this chapter. Cook mentions could be 異 (differ, dissimilar, differentiate, unusual, erratic, bizarre; 𦰩, but the top circle is not empty as in B:2's 𦰩) Zi.tools lists it as 員(𦰩, though more usually it looks like 𦰩; perhaps the former is a form like 𦰩. Both instances from this chapter are in zi.tools as odd-ones-out). As it is, we adopt the meaning circular (圓), round: As it is, Wiktionary considers 員 to be the original form of 圓 (circular, round). The received having 損, conserving the 員 element, is reassuring.

⁵⁵⁹ One could read this like “completing a circuit”, “revolving”, or, perhaps, like a bird of prey, “circling”, “going in circles”. A bird of prey circling, sustained, staying over the same territory, moving yet staying in one place, unhurried and floating, watching intently below without affecting it (or at least not yet). Those who are learning are constantly on to the next thing, advancing, accumulating, but those who are “doing Dao” are circling, maintaining, sustaining, repeating, and through that, knowing full well what is below. However, birds circling is expressed in classical Chinese usually with 翔 (soar/circle) or 旋 (revolve/circle back), so this may be an interpretive stretch.

Chapter 49

聖人無常心

Sage without/lack constantly/persistently mind/heart/think/feel

The sage lacks a persistent mind and heart,

以百姓心為心

By-means-of hundred surnames mind/heart do/act-as/use heart/mind

Taking the mind and heart of the hundred surnames as a mind and heart.

善者吾善之

Skilled/excellent/good [person/phrase] I/me skilled/excellent/good ['s]/this

Those who are excellent, I treat as⁵⁶⁰ excellent

不善者吾亦善之

Not skilled/excellent/good I too/in-that-case skilled/excellent/good ['s]/this

Those who are not excellent, I too treat as excellent.

德善

Virtue/power skilled/excellent/good

Virtue is excellence.⁵⁶¹

信者吾信之

Trust/faith/reliable/pledge [person/phrase] I trust/faith/reliable/pledge ['s]/this

Those who are trustworthy, I treat as trustworthy,

不信者吾亦信之

Not trust/faith/reliable/pledge [person/phrase] I too/in-that-case trust/faith/reliable ['s]/this

Those who are not trustworthy, I too treat as trustworthy.

德信

Virtue/power trust/faith/reliable/pledge.

Virtue is trustworthiness.

聖人在天下歛歛

Sage position/be-at heaven under unbiased-and-impartial/mutually-amenable/equitable

The sage being in the world is unbiased and impartial,⁵⁶²

{焉} 為天下渾其心

{who/there} do/act-as/use world agitated-waves/murky/stirred-up/uncut/jumbled their heart/mind

Using the world to roil and lurch his mind and heart.⁵⁶³

⁵⁶⁰ There's no verb here. Wu has "kind to the kind" (not using a first-person pronoun for some reason) and Feng & English, Linnell, and Chan have similar (using the first person pronoun), Lau has "Those who are good I treat as good." My gut prefers Lau's interpretation, and apparently Henricks and Lin also agree with it. Cleary has "improve the good", which is interesting. Waley has "Of the good man I approve."

⁵⁶¹ This line (and the one like it below) also has some variation in translation. Linnell has "Because De is X (Feng & English have similar)", X being the last character in the phrase. Wu has "For Virtue is X", Lau has "In doing so I gain in X, (Henricks has similar)" and Chan has "Thus X is attained." The problem is that I do not see a verb for "attained." This De is for virtue/power, NOT obtaining or gaining. I default to this very simple translation.

⁵⁶² Linnell has "gathering it all in", leaning on 歛's meaning of inhale, draw together, collect; but Kroll has the reduplicated version (歛歛) to mean "unbiased and impartial, equitable, mutually amenable."

⁵⁶³ This is another line with a lot of variation. Linnell has "So he serves the world, merging with their heart/minds." Lau has "The sage in his attempt to distract the mind of the empire seeks urgently to muddle it." Henricks has "As for the sage's presence in the world –he is one with it. And with the world he merges his mind." Kroll does not list "merge" as a definition of 渾, the closest we get is "whole, undivided, integral, all-encompassing, mixed together." My translation is unique, but I stay closer to the definitions listed in Kroll.

百 姓 皆 注 其 耳 目

Hundred surnames all pour-out/gush/drench/miasma/gather-together/concentrate their ear eye

The hundred surnames all concentrate their ears and eyes.

聖 人 皆 孩 之

Sage all infant-smile [‘s]/this

The sage smiles like an infant at all of this.⁵⁶⁴

⁵⁶⁴ Most translations treat 孩 as “children”, although Kroll specifically has the meaning for “infant, child” to be dated to the medieval period, not before then. Before, this is for an infant’s smile. So, Lau, Chan, Henricks, Linnell, and Lin all have that the sage treats them as (his) children. Wu has “The sage only smiles like an amused infant,” which is close to what I have. Waley has “The sage all the time sees and hears no more than an infant sees or hears.” Cleary has “the sage renders them innocent.” Feng & English have “[the sage] behaves like a little child.”

Chapter 50

出生入死

Produce/put-out/arise/emerge life/born/create enter/accept/adopt dead/inert/finished

Emerging into life, entering into death,

生之徒十有三

Life/born/create ['s]/this go-on-foot/pawn/conscript/in-vain ten have/exist three

Life's adherents, in ten there exist three.

死之徒十有三

Death/inert/finished ['s]/this go-on-foot/pawn/conscript/in-vain ten have/exist three

Death's adherents, in ten there exist three.⁵⁶⁵

人之生動之死地亦十有三

People ['s]/this move/shift ['s]/this death earth too/in-this-case ten exist/have three

People's lives moving this to death's grounds, too, are three of ten.⁵⁶⁶

夫何故

Anyone/in-any-case how/why therefore/thus/as-a-result

In any case, why is this so?

以其生生之厚

By-means-of their life/born/create, life/born/create ['s]/this thick/deep/authentic/richly

By means of their lives, they live this deeply.

蓋聞善攝⁵⁶⁷生者

Undoubtedly/respect/cover hear/inform skilled/excellent pull-in/grasp/capture life [person/phrase]

Undoubtedly one is informed about those who excellently grasp life.

陸⁵⁶⁸行不遇兕虎

Flatland/roadway/leap enact/engage/walk not come-upon/meet-unplanned rhino/water-buffalo tiger

Walking the roadways and not encounter water buffalo or tigers

入軍不被甲兵

Enter/accept armed-forces/soldiers not blanket/cape/cloak/reach/receive/suffer armor/shell weapons

Entering armed forces without being covered by armor or weapons.

兕無所投其角

Rhino/water-buffalo lack/without that-which/place throw/cast/join/give-as-gift/drop-down their horn

Water buffalos have nowhere to throw their horn.

虎無所措其爪⁵⁶⁹

Tiger lack/without that-which/place place/dispose/reject/manage/force/press their claw/talon/scratch

Tigers have nowhere to place their claws.

⁵⁶⁵ Henricks, Wu, Waley, and Lin have this as “thirteen” rather than three in ten.

⁵⁶⁶ My confidence in this line is low. Linnell has “People whose lives are merely moving towards the place of death are also 3 in 10.” Wu has “and, when a living person moves into the Realm of Death, his companions are also thirteen” despite 徒 not being in that sentence. Lau has “There are those who value life and as a result move into the realm of death, and these number three in ten.” Chan has “And three out of ten in their lives lead from activity to death.”

⁵⁶⁷ Mawangdui has 執 (seize, grasp, capture)

⁵⁶⁸ Mawangdui has 陵 (slope, earthen-mound, ascend, mount, climb past, cross-over, transgress, insult, strict, severe)
HeShangGong has 路 (road, travel, course, route)

⁵⁶⁹ Mawangdui has 蚤 (flea)

兵無所容其刃

Weapons lack/without that-which/place appearance/permit/receive/tolerate their blade/knife-edge

Weapons have nowhere to receive their blades.

夫何故

Anyone/in-any-case how/why therefore/thus/as-a-result

In any case, why is this so?

以其無死地

By-means-of their lack/without death earth

Through their lack of death's grounds for them.

Chapter 51

道生之，德畜之

Dao live/born/create ['s]/this, virtue/power livestock/rear/feed/nourish/train ['s]/this

The Dao creates these, virtue rears these,

物形之，勢成之

Things outline/shape/form this, influence/authority/structure/circumstances/momentum complete this

Things shape these, circumstances complete these.

是以萬物

This by-means-of ten-thousand things

By means of this, the ten-thousand things,

莫不尊道而貴德

None/in-no-case not honored/venerated/goblet Dao and/yet/but value/precious/expensive virtue/power

None among them do not venerate the Dao and prize virtue

道之尊，德之貴

Dao ['s]/this honor/veneration/goblet, virtue/power ['s]/this value/precious/expensive

The Dao's veneration, virtue's prizing –

夫莫之命⁵⁷⁰

In-any-case/anyone in-no-case/none ['s]/this command/orders/name/heavenly-ordained-command

In any case, nothing commands this,

而常自然

And/yet/but constantly/persistently itself/naturally/self-so

And yet constantly, naturally this is so.

故道生之德畜之

Thus/as-a-result Dao live/born/create ['s]/this, virtue/power rear/raise/nourish/feed/train ['s]/this

Thus, the Dao creates these, and virtue rears these;

長之育之

Long-lasting/maturing/grow/cultivate ['s]/this, nurture/rear/foster/train/develop/educate/produce this

Growing these, nurturing these,

亭之毒⁵⁷¹之

Watchtower/tall-upright/rear/raise/ensure-proper-shape/balance ['s]/this, poison/abuse ['s]/this

Raising these, healing these,

養之覆之

Nurture/rear/maintain/support/nurse this, cover/extend-over/turn-over/overwhelm/hide/examine this

Supporting these, covering over these.

⁵⁷⁰ Mawangdui has 爵

⁵⁷¹ HeShangGong has 孰, but Mawangdui also has 毒. 毒 means poison, venom, baneful, noxious, endanger, imperil, maltreat, abuse, deplore, loathe. I'm honestly VERY confused why this is here, and why. Lau translates this to "[bringing them to] maturity," Chan has "give them peace," Wu has "comfort them", Henricks seems to have "rests them". I can find no definition for 毒 that reflects anything like this. Linnell's explanation to put "heal", referencing 覆, makes no sense to me. Shuowen Jiezi has 厚, "thick" but then says "害人之艸，往往而生" – harmful person's growing (plants), also just grows around." Poisons can be used in medicines, so I guess "heal" as Linnell has it, makes some sense, and University of Buffalo's Yan Liu's "Poisons in the premodern world" (<https://ethos.lps.library.cmu.edu/article/id/468/>) also seems to support the meaning of heal. (See also the work of Binli Dai from the University of Oxford, UK). Because it fits the rest of the chapter, and has at least this much support, I settle for "healing".

生而不有

Life/born/create and/yet/but not exist/have

Creating but not possessing them

為而不恃

Do/use/manipulate/act-as and/yet/but not confident/depending/relying

Using but without depending on them,

長而不宰

Long-lasting/maturing/grow/cultivate and/yet/not manage/oversee/butcher/divide

Cultivating but not butchering,

是謂玄德

This called murky/mysterious/translucent/dim virtue/power

This is called the mysterious virtue.

Chapter 52

天下有始以為天下母

Heaven under has/exists start/begin by-means-of do/act-as/use Heaven under mother/source

The world has a beginning, considered as the mother of the world.

既得其母以知其子

Wholly/totally/completely/just-after obtain/gain their mother/source by-means-of knowing their child

Just after gaining the mother, one by means of this know her children.

既知其子復守其母

Completely/just-after knowing their children, return/go-back/revert guard/maintain/defend mother

Just after knowing her children, go back to guarding their mother,

沒⁵⁷²身不殆⁵⁷³

Sink/dissolve/disappear/submerge/overcome body/self not/no danger/peril

So that dissolving oneself is not dangerous.

塞其兌⁵⁷⁴, 閉其門

Block it/its open-passages/joy/delight, close/obstruct it/its gates

Block one's open passages, close one's gates,

終身不勤⁵⁷⁵

Finish/end/finally body/self not struggle/toil/labor

In the end one does not struggle and labor.

開其兌, 濟其事

Open/expose their open-passages/joy/delight, cross-over-river/cross/arrive/succeed/help their affairs

Expose one's open passages, arriving to success in one's affairs,

終身不救⁵⁷⁶

Finish/end/finally body/self not relieved/rescue/save/cure/prevent

In the end one does not find relief.

見小曰明

See small/little say/called insight/perceptive/light/evident

Seeing the small is called perceptive,

守柔曰強

Guard/protect/maintain pliant/bending/soft called dominate/strong/firm/powerful/forced

Protecting the soft is called strong

用其光復歸其明

Employ their light/glow/illuminate return go-home/restore/refuge-with their perceptive/bright

Employ their light, return to restore their brightness

無遺身殃, 是謂習常

Without neglect/bestow/reject/lose self/body die-early/tragedy, this called practice/train/repeat constant

Without bestowing oneself tragedy; this is called practicing the constant.

⁵⁷² 沒 later meant “not have”, “to be not so...” (Wiktionary), but Kroll doesn't list these for Classical Chinese

⁵⁷³ See also Chapter 16. Linnell translates this as “When the self disappears, there can be no danger.”

⁵⁷⁴ Mawangdui A has 悶 with 二 over the heart, B has 堯.

⁵⁷⁵ Mawangdui has 董

⁵⁷⁶ Mawangdui B has 棘

Guodian (B:6)

闕⁵⁷⁷(元⁵⁷⁸/其)門,

Close-gate/shut-in/conclude/private/closed/still its/it gate/key/access/orifice/sect/section

Close one's gates,

(賽⁵⁷⁹/塞)其(逸⁵⁸⁰/兑)

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its/it cave/mouth//progress/channel

Block one's open passages

(夊⁵⁸¹/夊/終)身不(夊/岑)⁵⁸²。

Finish/end/finally body/self not sharp-peak/high/at-the-pinnacle.

In the end oneself is not somewhere sharp and steep.

(啓/啟)其(兑/兌),

Open/start/announce its cave/mouth/

Announce one's open passages,

(賽/塞)其事,

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its affairs/matters/business/to-serve

Obstruct one's affairs⁵⁸³,

(夊/終)身不(夊⁵⁸⁴/來)。

Finish/end/finally body/self not come/approach/arrive

In the end oneself does not arrive.⁵⁸⁵

⁵⁷⁷ Both Cook and Henricks has this. Slips have this 闕, which is consistent.

⁵⁷⁸ In truth, every instance of 其 is 元 or 兀 in the Guodian

⁵⁷⁹ 冫 To me looks like 冫 over 工 over 貝, zi.tools has this listed as 賽 (as do Cook and Henricks), though most

examples have two 工. (i.e. 冫) Originally referred to a ritual/offering of thanks to the spirits or tutelary deity for prosperity, but could also mean compete, rival. 塞, the precursor to 塞, means to obstruct, stop-up, restrain, fill, supply, compensate, or fortress. I default to the meanings of 塞, but perhaps someone more knowledgeable than I should revisit this.

⁵⁸⁰ Happy (𡗗)(man with a smiling mouth) within 辵 (walking/moving). According to Chinese Text Project, has a connotation of moving swiftly, at least with a horse example. Zi.tools is under the impression this means 稅 (taxes) Has been read as 穴 (cave, hollow) and 遂 (progress, channels, administrative processes, institutional conduits, responses). I wonder if it could be 逸 (to flee). 兑/兌 means joy, delight, open a passage, hole/cave. I struggle to understand why the walking radical would be here if cave were meant. I speculate that maybe on its own, this running happy talker is enthusiasm, outward-seeking adventure? “Open passages”, through which one could walk, be it a hole or some sort of entrance/exit, resonates most convincingly with the 辵 radical. See also A:15.

⁵⁸¹ This is not 冬. In Chu, 冬 ← 各 ← 𠂔.

⁵⁸² 𡗗, listed under 夊 in zi.tools. Old form of 嵒, which is the name of a mountain. Could be 瞽 (bewildered), 瘡, 侮 (disgrace, but see C:1, 𡗗), 務 (strive, focus on, apply oneself to, requisite, pursuit), 瘳 (sick from worry), 矜 (peril/brag), 教. See Cook pg 300. Inspired by the suggestion of BYL through Cook, 岑 in neighboring Qin looked like 𡗗, which is similar to what we see here, meaning peak, sharp and steep, pinnacle, lofty/high. Sharp, steep peaks are precarious, dangerous, harsh places: this doesn't have a connotation of victory, as far as I can see. The suggested characters mostly have connotations of hardship and toil, so I decide to take a literal approach here.

⁵⁸³ Or, “Obstruct oneself with affairs”, though the grammar may not support this.

⁵⁸⁴ 夊 → 來 according to zi.tools. The foot (止) was added to 來 (later 麥, to mean wheat), to mean “come”.

⁵⁸⁵ Or, put more plainly, “The self/body does not come to (reach, arrive at) the end.” You don't make it there.

Chapter 53

使我介⁵⁸⁶ 然有知

Cause/allow/dispatch/employ I/me boundary/separate/messenger/mediator/aid nature/self-so know
Allow me unwavering possession of knowledge, ⁵⁸⁷

行於大道

Enact/engage/walk in/at/from/regarding big/great Dao

In engaging in the Great Dao.

唯迤是畏

Only move-awry/deviate/oblique/slanted this fear

Only deviating from it, this one should fear.

大道甚夷,

Great/big Dao excessive/too-much barbarian/crude/level/calm/wounded/faint/common

The Great Dao is excessively level and even,

而民好徑

And/yet/but common-people good/pleasant/to-like footpath/pathways/take-most-direct-route/via

And yet people like direct pathways.

朝甚除

Morning/whole-day/court/pay-court excessive/too-much remove/well-arranged/expel-unwanted

The court is excessively well arranged,

田甚蕪

Farmland/cultivated-field/open-field excessive/too-much weed-choked/unkempt/overgrown/neglected

The farmlands are excessively weed-choked,

倉甚虛

Granary/storehouse excessive/too-much empty/diminished

The granaries are excessively empty.

服文綵

Undertake/submit-to/harness/garment/ingest/take-medicine pattern/literature/writing multi-colored-silk

Wearing patterned multi-colored silks,

帶利劍

Belt/sash/hang-on-belt/involve/include/draw-into/zone benefit/sharp/smooth double-edge-sword/kill

Sharp swords hanging on their belts,

厭飲食

Satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted drink/swallow/stifle/hide/permeate eat/consume/take-in/accept/feed

Bored of drinking and eating

財貨有餘

Material-resources/property/wealth goods/items exist/have surplus/remainder

Wealth and goods they have in surplus.

⁵⁸⁶ This is a word with a lot of meanings: boundary, separate, positioned between two things (messenger, mediator, intermediary, herald, harbinger), aid, help, assist, depend on, isolated, aloof, set-apart, single, integrity, resolute, principled, shell, carapace, armor. 介然 together I could not find in Kroll or Wiktionary. Baidu cites the Xunzi (pre-Qin) as it meaning a firm, persistent state as “unmoved” or “unwavering.”

⁵⁸⁷ This is translated as some variation of “Were I to have the least bit of knowledge” (Henricks, Lau, Wu, Chan, Waley, Feng & English, Linnell). My original was “Dispatch me as a messenger, naturally there is knowledge,” before I looked into 介然 as a compound.

是謂盜夸

This called thievishness/stealing excessive/overdone/exaggerated/boastful/flaunt

This is called thievishness and extravagant.

非道也哉

Not Dao, [!]

Not Dao at all!

Chapter 54

善建者不拔

Skilled/favorable establish/found/propose/enact {person/phrase} not uprooted/drawn-out/capture/molt
Those skilled at establishing are not uprooted,

善抱者不脫

Skilled/favorable embrace/hug/enwrap {person} not strip-off/shed/peel-away/fall-off/extricate/remove
Those skilled at enwrapping are not shed away,

子孫以祭祀不輟

Children grandchildren by-means-of their sacrifice sacrifice/year not stop/suspend/interrupt
Children and grandchildren, by means of their sacrifices and ceremonies, go on uninterrupted.⁵⁸⁸

修之於身其德乃真⁵⁸⁹

Refine/cultivate/prepare/tapering this in/at body/self, their virtue/power then true/authentic/pure
Cultivating this in the self, its virtue is then authentic.

修之於家其德乃餘

Refine/cultivate/prepare this in/at family/home/household, their virtue/power then surplus/remainder
Cultivating this in the home, its virtue is then more than sufficient.

修之於鄉其德乃長

Refine/cultivate/prepare this in/at countryside/hometown, their virtue/power then long-lasting/mature
Cultivating it in the hometown, its virtue is then long enduring.

修之於國其德乃豐

Refine/cultivate this in/at country/state, their virtue/power then abundant/luxuriant/rich/serving-tray
Cultivating it in the state, its virtue is then luxuriant.

修之於天下其德乃普

Refine/cultivate this in/at heaven under, their virtue/power then pervasive/universal/impartial
Cultivating it in the world, its virtue is then pervasive.

故以身觀身

Thus/therefore by-means-of body observe/display/behold/watch-intently body
Thus, observe the self through the self,

以家觀家

By-means-of home/family/household observe/display/behold/watch-intently home/family/household
Observe the home through the home,

以鄉觀鄉

By-means-of countryside/hometown observe/display/behold/watch-intently countryside/hometown
Observe the hometown through the hometown,

⁵⁸⁸ Linnell is close to my translation, with “Thus children and grandchildren offer sacrifices, and so sacrifices do not stop.” However, both of us are kind of odd one’s out. Wu has “your descendants will carry on the ancestral sacrifice for generations without end.” Lau has “Through this the offering of sacrifice by descendants will never come to an end.” Chan has similar: “Thus from generation to generation his ancestral sacrifice will never be suspended.”

Henricks has “And your sons and grandsons, as a result, will sacrifice without end.” My hesitation to treat 以 as “thus/as a result” is because it is not 故 and more often is translated as “through/by means of”, so I’d try harder to make it translate as the latter.

⁵⁸⁹ Variant of 真

以國觀國

By means of state/country observe/display/behold/watch-intently state/country

Observe the state through the state,

以天下觀天下

By means of heaven under observe/display/behold/watch-intently heaven under

Observe the world through the world.

吾何以知天下然哉,以此

I how/why by-means-of know heaven under thus/this-way/to-be-so/burn indeed/[!] By-means-of this

How do I know the world is this way? Through this.

Guodian (B:8)

(𠄎/善)⁵⁹⁰(𠄎/建)⁵⁹¹者不(𠄎/拔)⁵⁹²,

Skilled/favorable establish/found/propose/enact {person/phrase} not uprooted/drawn-out/capture/molt

Those skilled at establishing are not uprooted,

善(𠄎/休)⁵⁹³者不兌⁵⁹⁴,

Skilled/favorable resting/take-break/blessing/fortunate {person} do not delight/opening/mouth/cave

Those skilled at resting do not open passages,

子孫⁵⁹⁵以其(𠄎/祭)⁵⁹⁶(𠄎/祀)⁵⁹⁷不(𠄎/毛)⁵⁹⁸。

Children grandchildren by-means-of their sacrifice sacrifice/year not leaf/branch/cut(?)/divide(?)

Children and grandchildren, by means of their sacrifices and ceremonies, do not branch away.

𠄎/攸⁵⁹⁹之身, 其(惠/德)⁶⁰⁰乃貞⁶⁰¹。

That-which/swift this/['s]/to-go body/self, their virtue/power indeed/then steadfast/chaste/correct

That which goes to the self, its virtue will then be steadfast.

攸之(𠄎/家)⁶⁰², 其(惠/德)(又/有)(𠄎/舍)⁶⁰³。

That-which/swift this/['s]/to-go home/family/household, their virtue/power has/exists dwell/save

That which goes to the home, its virtue will have a dwelling.

⁵⁹⁰ 8 characters from the bottom of strip 15 of Laozi B, according to the Jingmen Museum photos. I don't know what the DaoisOpen facsimile is doing. This character is faded but still consistent with 善.

⁵⁹¹ In zi.tools and in reality, technically 𠄎, listed under 建

⁵⁹² 𠄎 over 木 in both Cook and Henricks, zi.tools lists this as 𠄎申入, under 拔, Liushutong script agrees.

⁵⁹³ 𠄎 This is not 保. Cook has 𠄎 + 𠄎, and I agree. Zi.tools has this as 𠄎. This does not match the 保 in A:1 𠄎 A:5 𠄎 A:20 𠄎. Zi.tools describes both as hands protecting a baby. Maybe this is a variation between Laozi A and Laozi C in selected character variants, maybe an abbreviation. This also resembles the Chu entry in zi.tools of 休 (𠄎), though somewhat less well. Zi.tools and CRY (through Cook) has 𠄎 as equivalent to 休, so I accept 休.

⁵⁹⁴ 𠄎: weird line, but consistent with 兌. Because this lacks 𠄎, this “open passages” I’m treating as a verb, not a noun (See B:6 and A:15). While this could be “delight”, it would be strange for resting would deprive joy. Even if 𠄎 is 保, protecting/guarding should also result in happiness, though it would prevent open passages.

⁵⁹⁵ 𠄎 The = here likely represents a combined character. 𠄎 = 孫 according to zi.tools, 𠄎 is 子. Neither Cook nor Henricks mention this is a split character. I guess this works, I don't know enough to be suspicious of it.

⁵⁹⁶ Zi.tools lists this under zi/𠄎/𠄎夕欠示 and this is more accurate, but it is still listed under 祭.

⁵⁹⁷ 祭祀 is a paired phrase according to Wiktionary, meaning “to offer sacrifices to gods/spirits/ancestors” or honor or worship by rite. 祭 has a connotation of sacrifices with meat (and possibly wine)

⁵⁹⁸ 𠄎=毛, meaning growing leaf or blade of grass according to Wiktionary and Shuowen through Zi.tools.

Wiktionary also considers this a variant of 託, entrust. See Cook pg 305; this could be read as to “cease” or “sever”.

⁵⁹⁹ Listed under zi.tools as 攸, what I see is closer to 𠄎 to the left of 攸. Made of similar components there is 攸, which zi.tools calls a variant form of 赴 (to go to, proceed to, throw oneself into (a task), carry out and follow through on). The crossroad/step radical (𠄎) next to the hand-holding-something meaning hit or tap radical (攸/攸) lends itself more readily to mean moving to do something. 攸, for its part, means “move swiftly, smoothly slipping by, rushing, place, place where, or “that which”/ “they who”. I favor 攸 based on the other examples in zi.tools.

⁶⁰⁰ Or 惠. 𠄎 on the slips everywhere it occurs in this chapter.

⁶⁰¹ Originally was 𠄎 without 𠄎, written a bit strange: 𠄎→𠄎. Zi.tools has this as 貞, but it is an odd one out, most look like 𠄎, but I have not found anything that resembles 𠄎 over 田 more. 貞 in Chu is often expressed as 𠄎.

⁶⁰² There's a fair amount of variation in this character as listed by zi.tools, this one happens to be 𠄎, the next is 𠄎

⁶⁰³ Technically listed under 舍 in zi.tools.

攸之(𠂔⁶⁰⁴/皆), 其(惠/德)乃(𠂔/長)。

That-which/swift this/['s]/to-go back/north/departed/earlier, their virtue/power then mature/long
That which goes to the departed, its virtue will then mature and last long.

攸之邦, 其(惠/德)乃(𠂔/奉)。

That-which this/['s]/to-go state, their virtue/power then received-with-respect/offered/respected
That which goes to the state, its virtue will then be offered up.

攸之天下⁶⁰⁵□□□□ (其德乃溥)

That-which this/['s]/to-go under-heaven/world □□□□ (one's virtue will then large/vast)

That which goes to the world, {its virtue will then be vast.}

□□□□ (以身觀身)

By-means-of self observe/display/ behold/watch-intently self

{Intently observe the self through the self,}

□□□(爰/家), (以家觀)

□□□ family/household, (by-means of family/household observe/display/ behold/watch-intently)

***{Intently observe} the home { through the home,}*⁶⁰⁶**

以𠂔(𠂔/觀)⁶⁰⁷𠂔,

By-means of back/north/departed/earlier observe/display/ behold/watch-intently back/departed/earlier.

Intently observe the departed through the departed,⁶⁰⁸

以邦觀邦,

By-means-of state observe/display/ behold/watch-intently state

Intently observe the state through the state,

⁶⁰⁴ Zi.tools and Cook have this under 向, Henricks has 𠂔, possibly with 𠂔 on the bottom: the closest I could find sort of like this was 𠂔, which in the Guodian according to zi.tools presents as 𠂔. The etymology of 向 depicts a mouth (口) under a roof at home (宀), meaning an echo in place, but the Chu form has a top that looks almost like that of 𠂔/善, really suggesting that this is indeed really 𠂔 (by zi.tools a variant of 背 or 皆 (all, every), by 北 (𠂔) over 日/甘 (𠂔). 北 originally had a meaning of depart or separate, from two people facing opposite directions; it later came to mean “north”, the direction one faces away from. In the Songs of Chu, it is mentioned in 招魂, “Summoning the Soul” and 大招 “great Summons” that north is a dark, dangerous place from which death emerges and toward which dead souls depart. 𠂔 could represent 北 over 𠂔, speech toward the departed: prayers for them or memories of their words. If it is the sun on the bottom (日), it could be literally “put your back to the sun → north itself”. If the bottom is 甘, it could also be “turning away from sweetness” or “sweetness for the departed”, but this is even more of a reach. 𠂔 also resembles 背, meaning “the back of a vertebrate, back of an object, north side, behind, secret” or to turn one’s back on someone or something, reject and disobey. 向 can have a meaning of direction, “Toward, inline toward,” but also “earlier, formerly, recently, just-now.” This character is unsure and much of this footnote is speculation, but given the mention of sacrifices for the ancestors earlier in the chapter, I am comfortable translating this in some way “toward the departed”, especially in some honoring, memorial, or thanksgiving way (but also tutelary or as prayer).

⁶⁰⁵ Honestly this character doesn’t survive and very little of it is seen, not enough for me to confirm it is even 下.

Missing characters in Italics from Cook.

⁶⁰⁶ Perhaps “home” in this sense carries a connotation of family and kin – those you live with. Observe your kin through no outside lens, just from one’s experience and theirs.

⁶⁰⁷ By zi.tools, and actually on the slips, 見 to the left of 𠂔. This 𠂔 literally means stork or heron, a bird that stands very still in shallow waters, watching intently, striking when a fish comes into view. This is a very intent watching. In the images from the Jingmen Museum that I have, these are mostly hard to make out, but the shapes are consistent from what I do see.

⁶⁰⁸ Perhaps “observe the departed” refers to one’s memories and honoring them, rather than societal constructions.

以天下觀天下。

By-means-of under-heaven/world observe/display/behold/watch-intently under-heaven/world

Intently observe the world through the world.

(虛/吾) 可以智天□□□□ (下然? 以此。)

I/me possible by-means-of know heaven (*under thus/this-way/to-be-so/burn? By-means-of this.*)

How is it possible that I know {the world is like this? Through this.}

Chapter 55

含德之厚⁶⁰⁹

Hold-in-mouth/hold-in/enclose/withhold/full-of/embody virtue/power ['s] thick/deep/authentic/richly
Embodying virtue's thickness⁶¹⁰

比於赤子

Compare/parallel/duplicate/alike/align/close-to at/in/than [blood-red/exposed child]/newborn⁶¹¹
Is alike to newborn baby.

蜂虿虺蛇不螫

Wasp/hive/bees scorpions venomous-snakes snake not sting/bite
Wasps, scorpions, and venomous snakes do not bite or sting,

猛獸不據

Brute/fierce/savage/severe/staunch beast/wild-animal not rely-on/evidence/seize/grasp/take-over
Savage beasts do not snatch,

攫鳥不搏

Seize/catch bird not knead/bundle/round/circle/rely-on
Birds of prey do not circle.⁶¹²

骨弱筋柔而握固

Bone tender/weak/frail/inexperienced tendon/sinew/muscle pliant/soft/bending but/yet grasp firm/solid
Bones tender, muscles soft, yet the grip is firm,

未知牝牡之合而全作⁶¹³

Not-yet know female-male ['s] combine/meet/fit and/yet/but complete/be-whole/perfect create/arise
Not yet knowing the meeting of female and male, yet completely arises.

精之至也

Essence/purest ['s arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost.
This is ultimate purity.

終日號而不嘎

End/finish/finally/whole day announce/command/call-out/shout/cry/keen and/yet/but not hoarse/raspy
The whole day crying, yet never getting hoarse,

和之至也

Harmony/peace/balancing ['s arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost
This is ultimate harmony.

⁶⁰⁹ Mawangdui has 者 here, as does Guodian

⁶¹⁰ Other translations vary widely for this line: Linnel has “he who embodies the substance of De (virtue)”, Wu has “One who is steeped in virtue” (maybe closer to the Guodian strangely enough), Lau and Chan have “One who possesses virtue in abundance”, Lin has similar with “He who is rich in virtue,” and Feng & English is also alike with “he who is filled with virtue.” Henricks (from the Mawangdui, presumably) has “One who embraces the fullness of virtue.” Waley has “the impunity of things fraught with the ‘power’,” and Cleary has “The richness of subliminal virtue.”

⁶¹¹ 赤子 together means “newborn child”, according to Kroll and Wiktionary.

⁶¹² I cannot find a definition of this character that means claw or grab, and yet Wu, Chan, Waley, Lin, Cleary, Feng & English, and Linnell ALL translate this as some form of “birds of prey do not maul/attack/claw/grab him.” For all of these lines, all of these other translations assume a direct object, which would be the one embodying virtue richly.

⁶¹³ Mawangdui has 媿怒, the penis of a young boy becoming “angry” (aroused). Despite this, many translations of the received also mention the sexual organ becoming aroused or working. Heshang Gong’s version of the Laozi has 媿作 (young boy’s penis arising), so many modern translations preserve this meaning.

知和曰常

Know harmony/peace/balancing called persistent/constant/enduring

Knowing harmony is called enduring,

知常曰明

Know enduring/constant/persistent called bright/perceptive/luminosity

Knowing endurance is called perceptive.

益生曰祥

Increasing/advance/accumulate/benefit life/born/create called favorable-omen

Benefitting one's life is called a good omen,

心使氣曰強

Heart/mind cause/allow/dispatch/employ qi/vital-energy/breath called dominate/strong/forced

The mind and heart authorizing the vital energy is called forced⁶¹⁴,

物壯則老

Things robust/in-their-prime/mighty/healthy when-then age/old/decay/wane

When things are robust and at their prime, then they age and wane.

是謂不道

This called not Dao

This is called not with the Dao.

不道早已

Not Dao early/ahead-of-time/morning already/stop/finish

What is not with the Dao has an early end.

⁶¹⁴ This line can be translated in a number of ways. I opted to translate 使 as “authorize” to preserve the allowing, sending one forth aspect while not removing the commanded, dispatching element of the word. Linell translates this as “Heart/mind making Qi speaks of strength,” and Cleary has “The mind mastering energy is called strong.” However Wu translates “To control the breath by will is to overstrain it” (Feng & English have similar) and Lau has “For the mind to egg on the breath is called violent.” Chan has “for the mind to employ the force without restraint means violence.” Henricks has “For the mind to control the breath—that’s called ‘forcing things’.” Waley has “If the heart makes calls upon the life-breath, rigidity follows.”

Guodian (A:17)

(𩚑/含⁶¹⁵)(𩚑/惠⁶¹⁶/德)之(𩚑/厚)⁶¹⁷(𩚑/者)⁶¹⁸,

Bitter/drinking virtue/power [‘s]/this thick/deep/sincere [person/phrase-end],

Someone who drinks the thickness of virtue⁶¹⁹

(𩚑/比)(𩚑/於)⁶²⁰(𩚑/赤)⁶²¹子,

Compare/parallel/duplicate/alike/align/close-to at/in/than [blood-red/exposed child]/newborn⁶²²

Is alike to a newborn baby.

𩚑⁶²³(𩚑/萬蟲)⁶²⁴(𩚑⁶²⁵/它)(𩚑/弗)(𩚑/蝮⁶²⁶/蠱),

Venomous(snake?) ten-thousand swarming other/another/snake not sting/venom/pain

Venomous, myriad, swarming bugs and snakes do not sting or bite,

(𩚑⁶²⁷/攫)(𩚑/鳥)(𩚑/獸)⁶²⁸(𩚑/獸/守)弗(𩚑/扣)⁶²⁹,

Seize/catch//fearfully-vigilant bird satisfied/sated beast/wild-animal/hunt//defend(ers) not strike

Birds of prey and well-fed guardians do not strike,

⁶¹⁵ 𩚑 Zi.tools has “bitter alcohol” or “bitter”. I’m not convinced that 含 is meant, as this shows up in the Guodian in a much different form 𩚑. Through Cook, LRH explains that 含 can be read as “strong” or “full” of alcohol, and suggests that this character, as well as 含, and 飲, may mean “full” or “deep”. 今, according to Wiktionary, means “something in mouth” or “not to speak”, and zi.tools has it as the initial form of chanting (bitterly?), or a bowed head with the tongue sticking out. This could be is an early form of 飲 (drink), evidence is convincing.

⁶¹⁶ 𩚑. 惠 according to Henricks, see B:8

⁶¹⁷ 𩚑, in zi.tools as 石 over 臺 for 厚, just as in A:2 (𩚑). Compare to A:3 (𩚑→heavy), and the mystery character pair in A:18 (𩚑/𩚑). Originally 石 over 毛 by Cook (and I agree) (zi.tools redirects this to 石 over 臺 for 厚—Henricks has 厚. 石 (stone) over 臺 (fortified wall, city wall, outline), or 石 over 毛 (fur). Meaning thick, deep, richly, etc.

⁶¹⁸ There is a lot of variation in this 者 character. Perhaps the shape indicates something specific? (𩚑, 𩚑)

⁶¹⁹ More gracefully, perhaps “One who drinks of virtue deeply.” Virtue is drunk, absorbed, taken in, rather than simply owned or stored. One drinks (water or alcohol), and either made hydrated or intoxicated.

⁶²⁰ 𩚑→𩚑→鳥 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ←→於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁶²¹ Extra line (𩚑 vs 𩚑), probably nothing

⁶²² 赤子 together means “newborn child”, according to Kroll and Wiktionary.

⁶²³ 𩚑. 由 over 虫 according to Cook and Henricks. Bizarrely, zi.tools has this under 胃 over 虫 (I think it should be 鬼 or 禺 over 虫.) Cook says could be 蠅 (pupa, chrysalis), 蠅 (→𩚑, venomous snake) 蝟 (hedgehog), 蜂 (bee/wasp, hive/swarm). Given the union of ghost and creature, I lean toward “crawling thing that makes ghosts.”

⁶²⁴ 𩚑. This character has a = character combination mark, or some think it is a duplication mark. Some read this as 蠱蟲 (scorpion (and) insects/snakes/creeping animals) or 毒蟲 (poisonous creeping animals). 蠱 itself is “scorpion.” 𩚑 in Chu script is 萬 (scorpion → thousand), 𩚑 in Chu script is 蟲 (insects/mass, together → swarm)

⁶²⁵ The ancient meaning of 它 is “snake”: not hard to see the cobra resemblance: 𩚑

⁶²⁶ 𩚑 Rendered this way because of 若 over 虫, see the 𩚑→若 in A:20—this is a unique variant.

⁶²⁷ Zi.tools has this as 攫 (seize, catch), as Cook and Henricks, with this image only: 𩚑. In truth, the hand component is on the bottom, like 攫 itself, but also on the side. In either case, the resemblance is weak. There appear to eye structures stacked in the middle, a hand on the bottom. Hand catching a bird could be depicted this way, but I’m not entirely convinced—then it would be 攫, to look back and forth in fear or alarm. I default to 攫, but I urge more experienced eyes to reconsider, though the longer I stare at it, the more I think I see 攫.

⁶²⁸ 𩚑 Henricks and zi.tools put 丙 over 口 left of 犬; I agree. Cook has 心 for 口. Maybe 𩚑→獸 (satisfied)? 内?

⁶²⁹ 𩚑 (zi.tools has 扣). CRY, through Cook has 哺 (feed). I think 甬+口→哺→噎 (unable to speak) Or 吮→啞 (birdsong/cry). The original transcription had 扣 (strike, restrain) for 敏 (attack). Right consistent with 扌, see 捉.

(參/骨)(參/溺)⁶³⁰ 董⁶³¹ (參/柔)⁶³²而(參/捉)固。

Bone sinking/flooding/drowning medicinal-flower pliant, yet grasp/catch firmly/steadfast/solid

Bones sinking, a pliant violet, yet the grasp is firm.

(參/未)智(參/牝)⁶³³戊⁶³⁴之(參/會/合)⁶³⁵(參⁶³⁶/脰) (參⁶³⁷/妄),

Not-yet/still-not know female/valley/yin halberd/5th [‘s] combine/fit/meet penis/male(?) blossom

Not yet knowing the combination of the valley and the halberd, the young penis blossoms;

(參/精)之(參/至)也。

Essence/purest [[‘s] arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost.

This is ultimate purity.

(戾/終)日(戾/虐/乎)而不(戾/慰/憂)⁶³⁸,

Finished/finally/end day/daily in/at/perhaps yet not sorrow/worry/troubled

The whole day perhaps yet without sorrow or worry,

和之至也,

Harmony/peace/balancing [[‘s] arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost

This is ultimate harmony.

和曰(參/常)⁶³⁹,

Harmony/balance says/called commonplace/ordinary/normal

Harmony is called commonplace,

⁶³⁰ Actually 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Maybe 弱 (weak)? Maybe bones drown in all the infant flesh?

⁶³¹ 董, in zi.tools 董, a violet, buttercup, or as a lime-rich soil, Or aconite, a violet-blue plant that is toxic but can be used in medicine, or another violet used medicinally. Possibly 僅 (only, merely)??? see zi.tools 董/董 (soil, clay), and B:5 and A:13 here these appear.

⁶³² 矛 over 求 in zi.tools and by Henricks; possibly a three-pronged spear according to MPS through Cook. This may be a phonetic loan for 柔(pliant, bending, soft, placate, etc), but why change the radical? Handwriting? See C:1.

⁶³³ Zi.tools and Henricks has 牝. The left part could be 牛 (𠂔). Cook has 牝 but it tends to look like 𠂔 in zi.tools.

牝 means “female animal”, usually the antonym of 牡; used to describe “femaleness” in general, the yin qualities of receptivity and fertility, and yet also means “ravine, valley”, which I think is euphemistic given female connotation.

⁶³⁴ This is the 5th Heavenly stem of 10, called (and looks like) halberd or axe. It has connotations of being in the center. Mawangdui and WangBi have replaced this with 牡, maleness. While “axe” wouldn’t be my choice of euphemistic reference to male genitalia (and why be euphemistic?) context clues seem to point this way. Even if we do read 戊 as center, I would expect 中 (core, middle) to refer to the innermost depths of the female “valley”.

⁶³⁵ Missing the top line under the roof, compared to A:10. Might be 會 (combine, gather, meet), or 答 (respond)

⁶³⁶ 參. Henricks has the original as 勿 under 丩, as does Cook. I cannot find this in zi.tools anywhere. Henricks mentions this could be penis, as 脰 occurs in Mawangdui. There’s an erect, upward line over 勿 (thing) or 夕 (flesh). Wiktionary lists 脰 found in Mawangdui as “penis of a young boy”, so this may be specifically the penis of an infant, which can get engorged even in the absence of arousal or sexual function.

⁶³⁷ Zi.tools accurately has this as 忝 over 忝 (forgive (恕) or anger (怒), variant for both by Wiktionary). In chũ Nôm Vietnamese, 妄 has meanings of “blossom, willing to”, zdic.net lists it here: <https://zdic.net/hans/%F0%A6%AC%91/chuwenzi>.

Adding the heart radical at the bottom may indicate psychological state but I doubt it in this case; this may just be how this kind of “blossoming” is expressed. An erection is not so different from a blossoming flower: petals or flesh that was closed open, fluid pressure causes rigidity and expansion, and color changes (in this case reddening).

⁶³⁸ Originally 頁+心 (listed as 愼 in zi.tools but similar characters are found under 愼, both listed under 愼). 愼→憂 (anxious, burdened with care, constantly worried, grief, afflicted; 愼→愼→憂.) 愼→順 (compliance, agreeable, to follow/go along with, conforming, accommodating). See B:3’s notes, 𠂔.

⁶³⁹ 同 over 示, in Cook and Zi.tools. Originally this meant lower garment. While it can mean constant, persistent, usually this is 亓→亓→恆 in the Guodian. Another meaning is ordinary, normal, conventional, so I adopt this.

智和曰明。

Knowing harmony called brightness/luminosity/insight(ful),

Knowing harmony is called insightful.

(𧰨/益)⁶⁴⁰生曰(𧰨/兼⁶⁴¹),

Increase(value-of?) live/born/living/create called long-term/long-river

Increasing the value of life is called long-term,

心(𧰨/史)⁶⁴²(𧰨/氣)⁶⁴³曰(𧰨/𧰨⁶⁴⁴),

Heart/mind records/decrees/historians vital-energy/qi/fumes/air/breath called powerful/forced/vigorous

The heart and mind recording vital energy is called forced.⁶⁴⁵

(勿/物)(𧰨/𧰨⁶⁴⁶)(𧰨/鼎)⁶⁴⁷(𧰨/老),

Things prized/stored(?), royal-cauldrons elder/waning/obsolete

The things that are prized are obsolete cauldrons⁶⁴⁸ –

是(胃/謂)不道。

This stomach//speak-of/talk-about/called not Dao/way.

This is spoken of as not with the Dao.⁶⁴⁹

⁶⁴⁰ 𧰨 by Cook and zi.tools (zi.tools technically has 𧰨 over 貝). Henricks has 貝 below 益. Zi.tools has 𧰨 as a variant of 𧰨, a measurement of weight. The top part of this character resembles 𧰨 (𧰨) more, listed as a variant of 𧰨 (throat/choke/passing-through → increase) under zi.tools. (See B:2). This would be increase over cowry shell (貝), essentially money. Perhaps “increase the value of”?

⁶⁴¹ Apparently meant a long deep river, or the appearance of one, or a long period of time.

⁶⁴² Originally 𧰨, which is technically 卜 over 日 over 又, how it is rendered in zi.tools, where it is listed under 史 (policy (especially written), scribe, decrees, employment). However, zi.tools also lists this character as meaning 事, which I find less convincing, as this character appears elsewhere in another form. (See also A:1).

⁶⁴³ In zi.tools, Cook, and Henricks as 𧰨. Evidently this refers to qi(氣)

⁶⁴⁴ Expressed in zi.tools as 𧰨 over 力, under 𧰨. This is a Warring States form of 𧰨. The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 𧰨 (𧰨), a variant of 𧰨 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong). This visual resemblance is stronger to me. A:11 and A:17 would be “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

⁶⁴⁵ This could also be translated as “The heart and mind ordering by written decree vital energy is called forced.”

⁶⁴⁶ In zi.tools as 𧰨 over 土, which evidently is just a variant of 𧰨 itself. Shuowen Jiezi calls this “good”, like 善. Kroll calls this 𧰨 “prized, favorable”, and also “slave”. 藏 means to store, or storehouse. Perhaps this could refer to land that is favored, rather than favor that is hidden under grass?

⁶⁴⁷ 𧰨 --so reduced! The top part of this character resembles the Chu version of 貝 (𧰨) as much as 鼎(𧰨), but this is not for sure 則 as Cook, Henricks, and Zi.tools label it. For one thing, all but two other instances of the character on zi.tools, the closest thing is this 𧰨 (from the Guodian!), with the knife clearly visible. I must default to 鼎. There are other instances under 則 with the 火 (fire) under it 𧰨 -- I think these also may be 鼎, especially as this variant also shows up in the Guodian with a knife (or maybe 勿) next to it (𧰨)! See also B:1.

This is not cooking pots referred to here. The Ding cauldrons were a symbol of legitimate power, royalty, and rule. The Zhou bronze cauldrons were actively fought and died over during the Warring States period because of their being tokens of political legitimacy—these were not used as cauldrons anymore.

⁶⁴⁸ Alternatively “Things are stored/prized, cauldrons are obsolete.”

⁶⁴⁹ Or, back to my stomach mischief, “Stomaching this is not with the Dao.”

Chapter 56

知者不言,

Know people not speak/words, Speak/words people not know

People of knowing do not speak, people of words do not know.

塞其兌, 閉其門⁶⁵⁰

Block it/its open-passages/joy/delight, close/obstruct it/its gates

Block one's open passages, close one's gates,

挫其銳, 解其紛

Crush/humble/weaken its sharpness/ precision, Untie/loosen/release one's tangled-threads/confusion

Crush one's precision, release one's confusing knotted threads,

和其光, 同其塵

Harmonize/balance/peace one's brightness/glory/luster joins/sameness/unites its dust/mundane/worldly

Balance one's brightness, unite with one's dust.

是謂玄同⁶⁵¹

This is-called mysterious sameness/join/unite/share

This is called mysterious joining.

故不可得而親

Therefore not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/but/yet parents/kin/intimate

Therefore it is not possible to gain and be close like family

不可得而疏

Not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/yet/but wide-apart/separated/estranged/ignore

It is not possible to gain and be estranged.

不可得而利

Not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/yet benefit/sharp/smooth/abundance

It is not possible to gain and have benefit,

不可得而害

Not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/yet harm/destroy

It is not possible to gain and have harm.

不可得而貴

Not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/yet/but value/costly/precious

It is not possible to gain and be valuable,

不可得而賤⁶⁵²

Not possible/missible/can obtain/gain and/yet cheap/lowly/insignificant/lacking/disrespect

It is not possible to gain and be cheap.

故為天下貴⁶⁵³

Thus/therefore/as-a-result for/use/act-as under-heaven/world precious/costly/valuable

Therefore for the world it is valuable.

⁶⁵⁰ After this until the next 故, Mawangdui's order resembles the Guodian more—see the footnotes for that section.

⁶⁵¹ Mawangdui aligns with Wang Bi again after this point.

⁶⁵² Mawangdui A has 淺 (shallow, superficial)

⁶⁵³ Linnell translates this to “Therefore, you become valuable to the world.” Lau, Chan, Henricks, Lin, and Cleary all translate similarly. Waley, Feng & English, Wu, and Henricks (“noblest”) translates “highest” thing in the world.

Guodian (A:15)

智之(𠄎/者)(𠄎/弗)言⁶⁵⁴,

Knowledge/wisdom [‘s]/this people do not words/talk/speak

People of knowing do not speak,

言之(𠄎/者)(𠄎/弗)智。

Speaking/talking/word [‘s]/this people do not know.

People of words do not know.

(𠄎/閔⁶⁵⁵/閉)其(𠄎/逆⁶⁵⁶/兌),

Close-off its/their open-passages

Close off one’s open passages,

(𠄎/賽/塞⁶⁵⁷)其門,

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its/their gates,

Block one’s gates,

和其(𠄎⁶⁵⁸/光),

Harmonize/balance/peace its/their brightness/glory/luster

Balance one’s brightness,

(𠄎/迴⁶⁵⁹/通)其(𠄎=𠄎⁶⁶⁰),

Pass-through/unobstructed-access/thoroughly-understand its/their caution/vigilance/attention x2

Pass through one’s extreme caution,⁶⁶¹

⁶⁵⁴ There’s a = duplication mark here.

⁶⁵⁵ Written like 𠄎, zi.tools has this under 閔. (𠄎 and similar have been used to express 戈 in Chu script). This is not the same as 閔(𠄎) in B:6, meaning shut or close. Zi.tools has 閔 as the same as 閔, which both zi.tools and Wiktionary call a “test hammer”, used to test the arm strength of a strong man. A weapon like a dagger-axe 戈 connected to a gate 門 may have a similar meaning of “close off”, to guard with weapons. Cook and others think this is in some way 閉, also “to close, to shut, obstruct”. It could be these are all synonyms with different connotations or stresses by way of swapped components. Either way, “close off” would be consistent here.

⁶⁵⁶ 𠄎 Happy (𠄎)(man with a smiling mouth) within 𠄎 (walking/moving). Zi.tools is under the impression this means 稅 (taxes) Has been read as 穴 (cave, hollow) and 遂 (progress, channels, administrative processes, institutional conduits, responses). I wonder if it could be 逸 (to flee). 兌/兌 means joy, delight, open a passage, hole/cave. I speculate that this running happy talker is enthusiasm, outward-seeking adventure? “Open passages”, through which one could walk, be it a hole or some sort of entrance/exit, resonates most convincingly with 𠄎. See B:6. I treat this as “open passages.” Character is damaged but still definitely 𠄎.

⁶⁵⁷ zi.tools has this as 賽, though see B:6. Originally a ritual/offering of thanks to the spirits or tutelary deity for prosperity, but also “compete, rival”. 賽, the precursor to 塞, means “to obstruct, stop-up, restrain, fill, supply.”

⁶⁵⁸ 𠄎 Fire over something, may just be 光. Wiktionary lists several plausible variants (𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎)

⁶⁵⁹ 同(𠄎) in 𠄎, precisely how zi.tools has it. Wiktionary has 迴 as synonymous with 通 (pass through, pass along, thoroughly, unobstructed, transmit, communicate, have access to). Zi.tools, citing the Shuowen Jiezi, defines this as 迭 (to alternate, change), but also as meaning “通達” (to understand, be reasonable, thoroughly understand).

⁶⁶⁰ 𠄎. Duplication mark (=) present, though some think this is an error. This duplication can be for emphasis, which is how I translate it. Usually translated to 慎 (cautious, quiet, vigilant, attentive). However, 𠄎 → 𠄎 in the Shuowen is the same as 慎. The only evidence I’ve seen so far that 𠄎=慎 is from Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓 (to swear; but see 𠄎 in Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎斤言女). 𠄎 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I use 慎; the etymology is not very convincing to me, but “happiness” doesn’t make sense. (See also A:6/C:4).

⁶⁶¹ Or, “Thoroughly understand one’s vigilance” or “Alternate one’s attention.”

(劉)⁶⁶²其(紉)⁶⁶³,

Slaughter/kill its/their entanglements/binds/strings

Slaughter one's entangling,

(解)⁶⁶⁴其(紛)⁶⁶⁵,

Untie/loosen/release/dissect/remove/liberate/dissolve its/their tangled-threads/bewilderment/confusion

Release one's confusing knotted threads,

是(胃/謂)玄同。

This stomach//called translucent/mysterious/unknowable/dim/murky sharing/sameness/join

This is called mysterious joining.⁶⁶⁵

(古/故)不可(得/得)(天/而)⁶⁶⁶新⁶⁶⁷,

Old/ancient//thus not possible obtain/gain heaven//yet/and/but/?? new/fresh

As a result, it is not possible to obtain and yet be new,

亦不可(得/得)而(足/足)⁶⁶⁸;

In-this-case/too/then not possible obtain/gain legs/sufficiency/match/equal/correct/upright

And it is also not possible to obtain and yet be sufficient.

不可(得/得)(天/而)(利/利)⁶⁶⁹,

Not possible obtain heaven//yet/and/but sharp/smooth/benefit/abundance/cleverness/swift/profit

It is not possible to obtain and yet have benefit,

亦不可(得/得)而(害/害)⁶⁷⁰;

In-this-case/too/then not possible obtain yet/and/but misuse/abuse/harm/destroy

And it is also not possible to obtain and yet be abused.

⁶⁶² 劉 Zi.tools and Henricks has 畜 to the left of 刀. Domestic animals / livestock next to a knife: perhaps

“slaughter”? May be equivalent to 劉 (kill, slaughter), though perhaps 留 (remain; 留) should be considered, probably not. WangBi and DaoIsOpen has 挫, zi.tools agrees, but evidence for this seems to be the Mawangdui.

⁶⁶³ Original appears to be 尔 over 賁, Cook, Henricks and zi.tools agree. (The top part should perhaps be 尔 instead, but this is equivalent). Cook lists that it could be equivalent to 嬰(necklace→encircle, bound, surround, suffer) or 櫻(damage, harm, unsettle, attack) or 纓(strings, cords, enwrap). It bears the same components as 賁 over 爾 (though in the wrong orientation), seeming to mean 遂 (progress, to further, succeed, achieve, respond, comply). 賁 itself means a string of beads. From here some that Cook cite relate this to “entanglement” (like 縈 from CRY, 嬰 from LXF) WQP sees this as a variant of 覲 (who has the components in reverse); they think it is a variant for 邇 (nearby, easy, simple, read as “advancement” (?)) but following this thread I would have looked at 覲 (considered variant of 診 (medically examine/diagnose, investigate) or 覲/覲 (painstaking detail)). Going by the graphical evidence, I will not speculate which of these characters this is, but will translate it as “entanglements/binds/strings”

⁶⁶⁴ Technically 隹 left of 刀 in zi.tools, a rearrangement of components

⁶⁶⁵ By isolating oneself, one becomes mysterious, and thus shares commonalities with the Dao? Or joins with it?

⁶⁶⁶ In this section, 天 and 而 look VERY similar. 天 tends to be less curly or less angled down. However, I use 而 throughout due to grammar.

⁶⁶⁷ Technically 木 over 辛 to the left of 斤 under zi.tools and actually: 𣎵

⁶⁶⁸ I initially called this 足, but Cook renders 疋 and it's nearly the same, thankfully also likely right to mean leg/foot. These look identical to me outside of the fact that this character's top part is more rounded off. (彳 vs 彳)

⁶⁶⁹ Not the same form as A:1, see also A:13, where the notch is on the bottom.

⁶⁷⁰ Technically 害 above-ish 又, according to zi.tools, and I agree: 𠂔. This does not resemble the character in C:1 at all. Neither Cook nor Henricks mention this hand component. Perhaps the hand component signifies direct action

不可(得/得)而(貴/貴),

Not possible obtain yet/and/but expensive/valuable/costly/value

It is not possible to obtain and yet be valued,

亦可⁶⁷¹不可(得/得)而(殺/殺⁶⁷²/殘)。

In-this-case/too/then possible not possible obtain yet/and/but tiny-tiny//kill/wipe-out/decay/ruthless

And yet, is it possible or not to obtain and yet be utterly destroyed?

(古/故)為天下(貴/貴)⁶⁷³。

Old/ancient//Therefore, manipulate/use/act-as/do under-heaven expensive/costly/valuable/valued.

So, using the world is costly.⁶⁷⁴

⁶⁷¹ It's on the slips. Not sure why it is often left off. Cook seems to think this was an accident. This could, instead, pose a strong rhetorical question for the finale of the chapter.

⁶⁷² Really the 戈 are to the left and right of each other, not stacked up-down. This can mean tiny, or apparent if reduplicated, but it was also the original form of 殘: destroy, wipe out, kill, harm, injure, damage, ruthless, merciless, cruel, and also fade away, wither, decompose, dim, incomplete.

⁶⁷³ The first instance had wings on the middle component, this one does not.

⁶⁷⁴ 為 can also be used as a ditransitive beneficiary construction, according to Kroll, making this sentence, “Therefore, [this] for the world is valuable/precious.” For the received, Linnell translates this to “Therefore, you become valuable to the world.” Lau, Chan, Henricks, Lin, and Cleary all translate similarly. Waley, Feng & English, Wu, and Henricks (“noblest”) translates “highest” thing in the world. However, this is inconsistent with how I’ve used 為 in the rest of the project. Both could work: This could be an argument on how valuable the “mysterious joining” is to the world, but I find it more convincing that, especially for the Guodian, this is more of an argument that going after “gain”, the achievements and disaster, is costly, not only to oneself, but to the whole world that it runs. My initial translation was “Therefore, using the world is costly”, and hesitantly, I choose to keep it.

Chapter 57

以正治國⁶⁷⁵, 以奇⁶⁷⁶用兵

By-means-of correct/proper govern/control/harness country, by-means-of strange/rare employ weapons
Govern the country through propriety, use weapons through strangeness.

以無事取天下

By-means-of no/lack matters/business/to-serve take/seize/capture under-heaven

Take the world through a lack of affairs.

吾何以知其然{也}哉⁶⁷⁷, 以此

I/my [how/why by-means-of]/how know its/it be-like-this/be-so? [Emphasis] By-means-of this/these:

How do I know it is like this? By means of this:

天⁶⁷⁸下多忌諱

Under-heaven many/exceeds/multiply antipathy/aversion/taboo/hostile/hateful avoid/taboo/avoid-word

The world has many aversions and taboos,

而民彌貧

And/yet/but common-people permeate/complete/spread-out/even-more poor/impoorished/scarce

And the common people are even more poor.⁶⁷⁹

民多利⁶⁸⁰器

Common-people many/much/exceed sharp/smooth/beneficial instruments

The common people have many beneficial tools,

{而}國家滋⁶⁸¹昏

[And/yet/but] country (and) family (or state-people) / increase/moist confused-and-dim

And the governing people become increasingly dim and confused.

人多伎⁶⁸²巧

Common-people much/many/exceed skill/craft/geisha/perform skill/craftsmanship

The common people have many crafts and skills,

{而}奇物滋起

[And/yet/but] strange/rare/heterodox things increase/moist rise/get-up/helped

And strange things increasingly rise up.

法令⁶⁸³滋彰

Law/standard/rule command/respected/enable/order increase/moist evident/decorated/signal/display

Rules and orders are increasingly signaled,

⁶⁷⁵ Mawangdui A has 邦, state.

⁶⁷⁶ Both Mawangdui have 畸

⁶⁷⁷ Mawangdui A has the current character without 口, Mawangdui B has 才

⁶⁷⁸ Both Mawangdui have 夫 in front of this line.

⁶⁷⁹ Most translations translate this as “The more [avoidances/taboo/etc.] in the world there are, the poorer the people will become” or some form of this (Waley, Lin, Cleary, Feng & English, Wu, Lau, Chan, Henricks). Only Linnell and I, to my knowledge, translate this as parallel statements rather than causative or correlative. This pattern persists throughout so that by most translations, the increased skill and crafts of the people lead to the rise of strange/rare things, the sharp/beneficial tools cause the dimness of the government, rules and orders cause crime.

⁶⁸⁰ Only Cleary, to my knowledge, translates this as “crafts”, I put “beneficial tools”. Lau and Linnell have “sharpened tools”. Nearly all others put “sharp weapons” (Wu, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Lin, Feng & English)

⁶⁸¹ Mawangdui A has 茲 everywhere this occurs.

⁶⁸² Mawangdui A has 知 and lacks 巧

⁶⁸³ Mawangdui B has 物, and 章 in place of 彰

盜賊多有

Thievishness/stealing outlaw/villainy/murder many/more/exceed have/exist

Thievery and villainy increasingly exist.

故聖人云

Therefore sage says

Therefore the sage says

我無為而民自化

I lack/without/no act/do/use/manipulate and/yet common-people self transform/change/convert

“I lack manipulation, and the people convert themselves

我好⁶⁸⁴靜而民自正

I excellent/pleasant/to-like still/motionless and/yet/but common-people self correct/rectify

I am excellently still, and the people correct themselves.

我無事而民自富

I lack/without business/to-serve/matters yet/but common-people self abundant/wealthy/rich

I have no matters, and the people are rich by themselves.

我無欲而民自樸

I lack/without desire yet/but common-people self unworked-wood/simple/plain/honest

I lack desires, and the people are genuine by themselves.”

Commentary: (keywords: the sage, knowledge, skill, opposites, WuWei, governing, unworked-wood, desire, stillness/movement, command, warfare, change)

⁶⁸⁴ Most translators (Linnell, Henricks, Wu, Lau, Chan, Waley, Lin, Cleary, and Feng & English) all translated this as “to like, to prefer, fond of”. I translate it as excellent, pleasant, agreeable, consistent with my translation in Chapter 30 “excellent at” or “does [verb] well.”

Guodian (A:16)

以(𠄎/正)之⁶⁸⁵邦,

By-means-of correct/proper/rectify [‘s]/this/to-go state/country

Go to the state by means of correctness,

以(𠄎/奇)⁶⁸⁶(甬/用)(𠄎/兵),

By-means-of uncommon-warfare(?) bell//employ weapons

Employ weapons by means of strangeness.

以(𠄎/亡)⁶⁸⁷事(𠄎/使)⁶⁸⁸天下

By-means-of lack/no business/serve/matters employ/dispatch/allow-action under heaven.

Authorize the world by means of lacking affairs,⁶⁸⁹

(虐/吾)可以智其然⁶⁹⁰也。

I/me possible by-means-of know its be-like-this/be-so

It is possible for me to know the natural way of these things.

夫天多(𠄎/期)⁶⁹¹(𠄎/韋/違)⁶⁹²,

Anyone/in-any-case heaven many/much/exceed term/date/promise/expect/certainly leather//wayward

In any case, Heaven has much waywardness with its appointments,

而民(𠄎/爾)(𠄎/畔/叛)⁶⁹³。

And/yet/but people such/you/that/so⁶⁹⁴ boundaries/limit/alongside//betray/contradict/rebel

And the people are that rebellious.⁶⁹⁵

⁶⁸⁵ I nearly never translate 之 as a verb, but there's no choice here. This means "to go" (Cook has "manage").

⁶⁸⁶ 奇 to the left of 戈 this goes for the whole chapter (zi.tools agrees). 奇 itself means singular, uncommon, strange, rare, remarkable, deviating (as the antonym of 正). With the dagger-axe component, perhaps there is something weird in a combat or military sense, just as 畸 means irregular plot of land, 倚 is to lean against, incline, or rely on, 謔 means playful or false talk, and 畸 means limping, lame, or one-legged.

⁶⁸⁷ Normally looks like 𠄎. No one mentions the cross abnormality (accident?). This may be 甲 (𠄎, 𠄎) (meaning "Sheath/shell/armor/first-rate/first-in-sequence", but elsewhere in the Guodian (A:14) it is expressed as 𠄎).

⁶⁸⁸ Listed in zi.tools under 取, under 取 (take ear (of enemy) → seize/capture/acquire; which zi.tools says is the Chu meaning), possibly meaning 取→使 (dispatch, commission, send on an errand, carry a message, cause, employ, allow unrestricted action), or 聚 (gather, assemble). Shuowen jiezi, through zi.tools, defines 取 as 使.

⁶⁸⁹ Alternatively, taking 𠄎 as 甲 "By means of first affairs, allow freedom of action to the world," or taking 甲 as a metonymy for soldiers (see Kroll) and 取 instead of 使, "By means of soldier matters take the world." I think this reading is unlikely because weapons were mentioned in the line above, and correctness, strangeness, and absentness make three distinct categories. While 𠄎, depicting an ear, a hand, and lines above it representing a stick or tool, could be "take", I think it is more likely this is 使 (carrying something to an ear, maybe?) in the messenger or agent sense of the word "dispatch" (not to kill). With "dispatch" having some meanings of killing, and "sending off/sending forth" or "allow unrestricted action" potentially being vague, I translate as "authorize". While I am reluctant to assume 𠄎 is just 亡, 亡 would be consistent with other parts of the Guodian, and "shell/armor matters" or "sheath matters" or "first (in a sequence) matters" is harder to understand. Additionally, the stroke order and orientation makes it plausible to produce 𠄎 trying to write 𠄎, if one started the horizontal stroke too far back.

⁶⁹⁰ Actually 𠄎, which is 然 without the fire radical on bottom. This is the case for the entirety of the Guodian.

⁶⁹¹ Technically 日 over 丌 by zi.tools, under 期 (𠄎). Wiktionary has this, as 𠄎, a variant of 光 (so does zi.tools 𠄎).

⁶⁹² The original form of 圍 (circumference, surround, enclosure) may be 韋 (Wiktionary), though Baoshan Chu has 𠄎. By Kroll, 韋 was also used in place of 違 (turn against, wayward, disobey)

⁶⁹³ Technically 半 over 田, zi.tools agrees. An early form of 叛, could also be 𠄎.

⁶⁹⁴ See Pulleyblank's "Outline of Classical Chinese Grammar," page 90.

⁶⁹⁵ Or, reading 畔 as is instead of as an early form of 叛, "And the people are so limited/within-boundaries."

民多(𠂔/利⁶⁹⁶)(𠂔/器)

Common-people many/exceed benefit/smooth/sharp instruments

The common people have many beneficial instruments,

而邦(𡇗/慈⁶⁹⁷)(𡇗/昏⁶⁹⁸)。

And/yet/but state/country tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence dim-and-confused

And yet the state is dim and confused from loving kindness.

人多智而(𡇗/奇⁶⁹⁹)(勿/物)(慈)(𡇗/起⁷⁰⁰)。

People exceed/many knowledge and/yet/but strange/uncommon things merciful-care rise/help-up/raise

People know much and yet weird things are raised up by loving kindness.

(𡇗/灋⁷⁰¹/法)(勿/物)(慈)(𡇗/章)

Lawful/rules/normal things benevolent/loving decoration/insignia/illustrate/model

Lawful things are emblazoned with loving kindness,

(𡇗/覩)(𡇗⁷⁰²/惻)多(又/有)。

Gazing-from-afar sorrow/pain exceed/many have/exist

Gazing from afar in sorrow is plenty.

是以聖人之(𡇗/言)曰：

This by-means-of sage [’s]/this words say

By means of this, the sage’s words are said:

我(𡇗/無)事而民自(𡇗/福/富)⁷⁰³。

I no/lack affairs/serve yet/but/and people themselves rich/wealthy

“I have no matters, yet the people are rich by themselves.

我亡為而民自(𡇗/逵)⁷⁰⁴。

I lack/no do/use/manipulate and/yet/but people themselves curve/wind/meander/approach-indirectly

I lack manipulation, and yet the people themselves wind their way there.

我好(𡇗/青)而民自正。

I good/excellent/agreeable/to-like green and/yet/but people themselves correct/proper/rectify

I’m agreeably green as a thriving plant, and yet the people correct themselves.

我(谷/欲)不(谷/欲)而民自(𡇗/樸)⁷⁰⁵。

I want not want yet/but/and people themselves plain/sincere/honest/unpolished/unworked-wood

I want the unwanted, and yet the people themselves are unadulterated.”

⁶⁹⁶ See A:15, where the notch is on top, not the same form of 利 found in A:1. This could be translated as “sharp”, meaning the people have many/ too many sharp instruments, but 利 is almost always translated as “benefit.”

⁶⁹⁷ Technically 𡇗 over 心. Usually translated as 慈 (tenderness, loving-kindness, merciful care, benevolence)

⁶⁹⁸ See B:5, I translate this as dim and confused

⁶⁹⁹ Different: the top left component is reduced to a horizontal line. In zi.tools this is 𡇗→𡇗, a wooden stake

⁷⁰⁰ Actually 𡇗 around 己, confirmed by zi.tools. Both Henricks and Cook have 𡇗 below 己, probably a different form of the same. On the slips it superficially already looks like 起: rise, stand up, prosper, begin, help up, lift, heal.

⁷⁰¹ Technically 夫 to the left of 𡇗 all over 水

⁷⁰² See A:1. Listed as 鼎 to the left of 𡇗 in 𡇗 all over 心 in zi.tools, though it’s technically 鼎 over 心.

⁷⁰³ 𡇗 Listed in zi.tools as 𡇗 over 酉 over 示. Could be 備, could be 福. 福 seems to also mean 福 or 富. The 富 in A:20 (𡇗) meaning “opulence” only lacks 𡇗 on top. The older meaning is “rich/wealthy”, which supports the roof.

⁷⁰⁴ 為 over 𡇗 (by both Henricks and Cook. Zi.tools has 為(same as 為) over 𡇗, → 逵. Shuowen Jiezi supports.

⁷⁰⁵ 𡇗 Compare with A:5 (𡇗), not the same Originally 木 to the left of 𡇗 over 臣.

Chapter 58

其政悶悶

Its/it government/authority/regulations troubled/gloomy/despondent/stupid-seeming/stuffy

If its authority is despondent/seems-stupid,

其民淳淳

Its common-people pure/soaked/untainted/uncorrupted/of-one-kind/enriched

Its people are pure.

其政察察

It/its authority/government/regulations scrutinize/investigate/pristine-purity

If its authority is extremely scrutinizing,

其民缺缺

It/its people smashed/in-pieces/defective/decifient/splintered/in-shreds/incomplete/discarded

Its people are imperfect and incomplete.

禍兮福之所倚

Divine-misfortune [!] blessings/good-fortune [s]/this that-which lean-on/rely-on/incline-to

Curses! That which blessings lean on.

福兮禍之所伏

Blessings/good-fortune [!] divine-misfortune [s] that-which prostrate/cower/crouch/submit/hide

Blessings! That which curses crouch within.⁷⁰⁶

孰知其極，其無正

Who/which know it/its standard/zenith/supreme/utmost, It/its lack/without correct/rectify/proper/norm

Who knows their peak? They are without a normal.

正復為奇

Correctness/rectify/proper return/revert/go-back do/use/act-as/manipulate strange/rare

Normal reverts to acting as strange⁷⁰⁷.

善復為妖

Good/favorable reverts/returns/go-back act-as/use/do bewitching/captivating/irresistible/monstrous

Favorable reverts to acting as monstrous.

人之迷，其日固久

People [s] possessed-by/bewilderment/lose-one's-way its day firmly/steadfast/solid enduring/old

This perplexity of the people, its days are firmly longstanding.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage

方而不割

Direction/proper/square and/yet/but not cut/carve/sever/split

Is square but does not cut,

⁷⁰⁶ Linnell has “lies on”, and similarly Waley has “upon good fortune that bad fortune rests”. Wu has “hides in” (Henricks, Lin have similar), Lau has “It is on disaster that good fortune perches, it is beneath good fortune that disaster crouches”, and Feng & Englis have “Misery lurks beneath happiness.” Chan has “in which calamity is latent” Only Cleary has “fortune is what calamity subdues.” My initial reading was “Blessings! That which curses cower before,” but “crouches within” is more parallel with the leaning on of the previous line.

⁷⁰⁷ 正 and 奇 are considered antonyms: Regular and irregular. This can be read as “correct” and “deviant”, as Henricks has it.

廉而不劌

Incorruptible/blameless/pointed/sharp(intelligence/observant) but/and/yet not wound/stab/puncture

Is sharply attentive but does not puncture,

直而不肆

Straight/upright/confront/on-duty yet/but not display/expose/arrange/perform/exhaust/uncontrollable

Is straight but not unrestrained,

光而不耀

Bright/insight/glory/luster but/yet/and not sparkle/dazzle/glorious/resplendent

Is bright, but not sparkling.

Chapter 59

治人事天,莫若嗇

Govern people matters/to-serve heaven, In-no-case like/as/better-than frugal/sparing/harvest/save-up
In governing people and serving Heaven, nothing is better than saving up.

夫唯嗇

In-any-case only/accept/assent thrifty/frugal/sparing/economical/miserly/harvest/save-up
Anyone only saving up,

是謂早服

This called early undertake/accept-responsibility/submit-to/harness/garment/ingest/take-medicine
This is called early undertaking of responsibility⁷⁰⁸

早服謂之重積德

Early accept-responsibility/submit-to/harness called ['s]/this heavy/significant accumulation virtue
Early undertaking of responsibility is called “heavy” accumulation virtue⁷⁰⁹.

重積德則無不克

Heavy accumulation virtue when-then/rule no/lack/without not overcome/subordinate/agree-on
When there is heavy accumulation virtue, then there is nothing that cannot be overcome.

無不克則莫知其極

Without/lack not overcome/subordinate when-then in-no-case know their zenith/supreme/utmost
When there is nothing that cannot be overcome, then no one knows their peak.

莫知其極可以有國

In-no-case know their zenith/supreme/utmost can/possible/permissible by-means-of have/exist state
When no one knows their peak, then one can have a state.

有國之母可以長久

Have/exist state/country ['s]/this mother/source can/permissible/possible by-means-of long-lasting(x2)
Having a state's mother, one can last a long time.

是謂深根固柢

This called deep root/base solid/firm base root/base/foundation
This is called “deep roots and solid foundation.”

長生久視之道

Long-lasting/long life/born/create long-lasting/enduring/old look/see ['s]/this Dao
This is the Dao of long life and enduring vision.

Commentary: (keywords: preparation, governing, virtue)

⁷⁰⁸ This line has a lot of variation in how it is translated. Wu has “to be frugal is to return before straying” (???). Lau has “It is because he is sparing that he may be said to follow the way from the start.” (唯, according to Wiktionary, has the meaning of “because” dating from the 4th century, but Kroll does not reflect this and this may be a borrowing from 惟). Chan has “Only by being frugal can one recover quickly,” and Cleary has similar. Henricks has “For only if you are sparing can you, therefore, early submit to the Way.” Waley has “This laying up a store means quickly absorbing” (???). Lin has “To be sparing is to forestall.” Feng & Englis has “Restraint begins with giving up one’s own ideas.” Linnell has “This is called early acceptance.”

⁷⁰⁹ Most translate 重 in the sense of double, repeat – I keep it heavy for consistency within my translation. The meaning does not change much in my opinion.

Guodian (B:1)

(𦉑/緡)⁷¹⁰ 人事天，莫若(𦉑/齋)。

Overseeing(?) people matters/serve heaven, in-no-case like frugal/sparing/economical/harvest/save-up
In overseeing the people and serving Heaven, nothing is like saving.

夫(𦉑/唯)⁷¹¹齋，是以早⁷¹²

For-anyone/in-any-case only frugal/sparing/save, this by-means-of morning/early

Only whoever saves up is, by means of this, ready ahead of time.

是以早(𦉑/備)⁷¹³，是(胃/謂)⁷¹⁴□□□(重⁷¹⁵積⁷¹⁶德)⁷¹⁷

This by-means-of early/ahead-of-time preparation, this stomach/is-called (heavy accumulation power)

Through this being early prepared, this is called {the virtue of heavy storage}

□□□, □□不⁷¹⁸(𦉑⁷¹⁹/克)(重積德(鼎/則)無)

□not overcome/subordinate/agree-on (heavy storage power, royal-cauldron//rule/regulations lack)

{The virtue of heavy storage, royal-cauldrons} have nothing they cannot overcome.

(𦉑/鼎)⁷²⁰莫⁷²¹智其(𦉑/互)⁷²²。

Royal-cauldron in-no-case know its eternal/persistence

No one knows the persistence of a royal cauldron.⁷²³

⁷¹⁰ 𦉑 Cook says this could be 給 or 緡. Zi.tools has this under 緡, which honestly while a little funny is understandable. In my opinion this is 緡 (which zi.tools defines as “repair”, but may be from the Song period.) Zi.tools suggests 治 (govern, control, harness), 始 (start, beginning), or 怡 (joyful, happy, convenient) for 緡.

Given 司 itself means “oversee, supervise, inspect, examine” I opt for something like that. See also A:14 (𦉑)

⁷¹¹ 𦉑 in zi.tools found under 隹. 隹 literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom would lead me to support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 售, to sell, is unlikely.

⁷¹² 𦉑 in both cases. 𦉑 in zi.tools, under 早.

⁷¹³ This character is faded. 𦉑 (under zi.tools with 備) Henricks writes this with 𠂇, which the slips support, but variants in zi.tools would cover this (𠂇 + 菑). See 𦉑 in A:20, translated as 備 (prepared, complete, maybe procure).

⁷¹⁴ Bottom part of this character totally cut off, but maybe consistent if it were 胃—it could be fading, but there are usually two lines in the top circle, not just one. (𦉑 vs 𦉑 or 𦉑 or 𦉑, but see 𦉑, 𦉑)

⁷¹⁵ 重: In addition to heavy, weighty, grave, significant, this can also mean double(d), add(ed), repeat(ed).

⁷¹⁶ 積: Also pile-up grain, heap, store-up, accumulate, collect, gather, entrenched, frequent, obstruct, block

⁷¹⁷ From Cook, suggesting duplication marks on all three (like =). Next line is also Cook, with duplication applied.

⁷¹⁸ May be repeated? =? After 莫 there is a heavy black mark probably meant to be another duplication mark

⁷¹⁹ In zi.tools under 克. To me this looks like 𦉑/貞 over 𦉑/支. Strong resemblance to 事’s bottom two thirds.

⁷²⁰ 𦉑 --” so reduced! The top part of this character resembles the Chu version of 貝 (𦉑) as much as 鼎 (𦉑), but this is not for sure 則 as Cook, Henricks, and Zi.tools label it. For one thing, all but two other instances of the character on zi.tools, the closest thing is this 𦉑 (from the Guodian!), with the knife clearly visible. I must default to 鼎.

There are other instances under 則 with the 火 (fire) under it 𦉑 -- I think these also may be 鼎, especially as this variant also shows up in the Guodian with a knife (or maybe 勿) next to it (𦉑)! See also A:17

⁷²¹ Duplication mark = here, and for 智其𦉑, all have a singular – mark under each.

⁷²² Technically 𦉑, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𦉑 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆

⁷²³ Or, less literally, “no one knows how long a ruling power will last.”

莫智其(死/互), 可以(又/有)(𠂔/郾)⁷²⁴。

In-no-case know its/their/maybe persistence/eternal, possible by-means-of have territory/capital-city

If no one knows its persistence, then it is possible through this to have a territory.

(又/有)郾之(𠂔/母)⁷²⁵, 可以長⁷²⁶□□ (生(舊/久))⁷²⁷

Having territory ['s] mother possible by-means-of long/mature/long-lasting (life/birth old/familiar)

Having the territory's mother⁷²⁸, one may, by long {life, be familiar}

(是(胃/謂)深根固柢)

{“This is called deep roots and firm base.”}

長生(𠂔/舊⁷²⁹)(𠂔/視)之道也。

Long/mature/long-lasting life/birth/create long/familiar/long-lasting look/stare ['s]/this Dao/way.

This is the Dao of long life and enduring sight.

⁷²⁴ 又 郾 (in zi.tools as 郾) both have those single – lines that may indicate duplication, and I treat it this way.

⁷²⁵ 𠂔 Cook and Henricks read this as 母 (zi.tools has), which normally looks like 𠂔, whereas 女 looks like 𠂔

⁷²⁶ Cut off, but still consistent with 長

⁷²⁷ This line filled in through Cook. He also adds 是(胃/謂)深根固柢: **“This is called deep roots and firm base.”**

⁷²⁸ One can understand this to be the nurturing, generative force of the territory, not literally a mother.

⁷²⁹ 𠂔 Zi.tools lists this under 舊 (owl, borrowed as “old, long-standing, dear friend, familiar”), but it’s an odd-one-out. truly this is 隹 over 臼 (Cook and Henricks agree). Compare with A:18 (𠂔). Zi.tools holds that they still both refer to “owl/old”. See also A:12’s 𠂔 → 𠂔? --> 舊?

Chapter 60

治大國若烹小鮮

Governing the Great territory is-like cook/boil/forgo small fresh-fish

Governing the Great State is like cooking a small fish,

以道莅⁷³⁰天下

By means of the Dao/way manage/attend//drying-up under-heaven

Through the Dao managing the world,

其鬼不神

Its ghosts/demons/spirits no spirits/souls/spiritual/godly

Its ghosts are not godly,

非其鬼不神

Not its/it demons don't spirits/souls/spiritual/godly

It is not that its ghosts are not godly,

其神不傷人

Their souls/spirits/godly not wound/grieve-for/hurt-by people.

Their godliness does not wound the people.⁷³¹

非其神不傷人

Not their godly/souls/spirits not wound/grieve-for/hurt-by people,

It is not that their godliness does not wound the people,

聖人亦不傷人

The sage in-this-case/too does-not wound/grieve-for/hurt-by people

The sage, too, does not wound the people.

夫兩不相傷

In-any-case/anyone two cannot each-other wound/grieve-for/hurt-by.

Any of these, in this case, would not wound the others.

故德交歸焉

Therefore, virtue/power intersect/contacts/exchange/mutually return/give-back from-this

Thus, virtue is mutually exchanged by this.

⁷³⁰ This is a variant of 蒞 (attend, arrange, manage) and a simplified form of 涸 (dry up, of water) according to Wiktionary, though it puzzles me how this is a simplification.

⁷³¹ I am translating this as it is normally translated, but playing around, if we take 傷 as “hurt-by”, we have “[The ghosts’] godliness is not hurt by people. It’s not that their godliness is not hurt by people; the sage, too/in-any-case is not hurt by people.” This is less likely, but it is interesting to explore.

Chapter 61

大國者下流

Big/great state/territory phrase/person down/below/lowest flows

The great territory flows below

天下之交,天下之牝

Under-heaven ['s]/this/it intersect/contacts/exchange/mutually, Under-heaven ['s] female/valley/yin

To the intersection of the world, the world's female.

牝常以靜勝牡

Valley/female constant/persistent by-means-of stillness competence/overcome/conquer maleness

Females constantly use stillness to overcome males,

以靜為下

By-means-of stillness use/do/act-as down/below/lower

Using stillness to act as lower.

故大國以下小國

Thus/therefore great/big state/territory by-means-of below/lower small/little state/territory

Thus, great territories, by means of being lower than small territories,

則取小國

When-then take/acquire/seize/capture small/little territory/state

Then capture the small territories.

小國以下大國

Small/little territories/state by-means-of lower/below great/big territories/states

Small territories, by means of being lower than great territories,

則取[於]⁷³²大國

When-then capture [in/at/from/regarding] big/great territories.

Then capture the great territories.

故或下以取,或下而取

Thus sometimes lower by-means-of capture/take, sometimes lower/below and/yet/but capture/take

Thus, sometimes being lower through capturing, sometimes being low and yet capturing.

大國不過欲兼畜人

Big/great state not passed-over/excess/trespass want/desire simultaneously/double livestock people

Great territories do not exceed wanting⁷³³ to double livestock and people,

小國不過欲入事人

Small/little state not passed-over/excess want enter/engage-in/accept business/to-serve people

Small territories do not exceed wanting to enter into business with people.

夫兩者各得[其]所欲

In-any-case/anyone two person/phrase each obtain [it/its] place/that-which want/desire

For either of the two to each obtain what they want,

大者宜為下

Great/big person/phrase proper/suitable/likely/probably use/do/act-as low/below/under/down

The Great of them should act as lower.

⁷³² From Mawangdui, may change the meaning to “Smaller territories, by being lower than greater territories, are then captured in greater territories.” See Henricks.

⁷³³ Or, put more simply, “merely want”

Chapter 62

道者萬物之奧

Dao/way [phrase/people] ten-thousand things ['s]/this profound/esoteric/obscure/secluded/inner-room

The Dao is the inner recesses of the ten thousand things,

善人之寶

Skilled/favorable/good person ['s]/this/it treasure/jewel

The skilled person's treasure,

不善人之所保

Not skilled/favorable/good person ['s]/this/it that-which/place protect/preserve/guard

The unskilled person's thing of preservation.

美言可以市

Beautiful words/speech possible/can/permissible by-means-of market/trade/buy-and-sell/bribe

Beautiful words can be marketed.

尊行可以加人

Honored/venerated/goblet walk/transmit/engage/move possible/can by-means-of add/augment person

Honorable engagement can add to a person.

人之不善，何棄之有

People ['s]/this/it not favorable/skilled/good, why/how abandon/forsake it/this/['s] exist/have?

The people's lack of skill, why abandon having it?

故立天子，置三公

Thus stand-straight/install/instantly heaven son/master, be-established three dukes/public/impartial

Thus, when installing the son of heaven (emperor/king), and establishing three lords,

雖有拱璧以先駟⁷³⁴馬

Although have encircle/surround/salute jade-circle by-means-of first/supreme/prior drive/ride horse

Even if there is saluting and jade disks drawn forward by vehicle horses

不如坐進此道。

Not like/as-good-as sit advance/move-forward/present/improve this/these Dao

It is not as good as sitting and presenting this Dao.

古之所以貴此道者何?

Old/ancient ['s]/this mechanism-by-which/reason-for expensive/value/costly this Dao person why/how

What was the ancient reason one valued this Dao?

不曰，以求得

Not say/call, by-means-of seek/solicit/search/explore/demand/beseech gain/obtain

They did not say, "by means of this, seek and gain,

有罪以免邪。

Have crime/sin/vice by-means-of avoid/evade/escape/relieve/remove irregular/perverse/bias/hmm?

Have sins and, by means of this, escape them," hmm?⁷³⁵

故為天下貴

Therefore use/do/act-as under-heaven expensive/costly/value

Thus, manipulating the world has value.

⁷³⁴ Technically, a vehicle drawn by four horses

⁷³⁵ 邪 is a Warring States era final interrogative particle, with a sense of a rhetorical shrug or a sarcastic, sharp “is that so?”

Chapter 63

為無為, 事無事, 味無味

Do/act/use without/not do, matters/serve without matters/serve, taste/significance without taste

Do without doing, have business without business, taste what is without flavor

大小多少

Big/great small/little many/exceed few/reduce

The great is small, the many are reduced.⁷³⁶

報怨以德

Repay/reward/retribution/vengeance/judge/reply complaint/grudge/resent/hate by innate-power/virtue

Respond to complaint and resentment with virtue

圖難於其易

Design/illustrate/devise/plot/draw-up/evaluate difficulty in/at/from it/its easy/change

Draw up plans for difficulty at its easiest.

為大於其細

Do/act/use big/great in/at/from its minimal/miniscule/slight/thin/fine/delicate/precise

Act on the great at its tiniest.

天下難事必作於易

Under-heaven difficulty matters/business/serve certainly arise/create/organize/start from easy/change

In the world, difficult matters certainly arise from easiness.

天下大事必作於細

Under-heaven great/big matters/business/serve certainly arise/create/organize/start from miniscule

In the world, great matters certainly arise from miniscule ones.

是以聖人終不為大

This by-means-of sage finish/end/finally not/no do/act/use great

By means of this, the sage in the end does not act on the great,

故能成其大

Thus/therefore/as-a-result able/capable achievement/accomplishment/complete its/it great

And as a result, is able to achieve its greatness.

夫輕諾必寡信

Anyone light/frivolous/superficial/shallow assent/agree certainly few/scanty/lessen trustworthy/trust

Anyone who agrees superficially certainly is scarcely trustworthy.

多易必多難

Many/exceed easy/change certainly many/excess difficult

And anyone who considers many things easy certainly will find many things to be difficult.

是以聖人猶難之

This by-means-of sage plans/schemes/hesitant difficulties this/it/[‘s]

By means of this, the sage plans for difficulty,

⁷³⁶ The variation in how this line is translated is considerable. Linnell: “Greatness is insignificant, too much is less.” Henricks: “Regard the small as large and the few as many.” Lau, and also Waley: “Make the small big and the few many.” Chan and also Lin: “whether it is big or small, many or few, ...” Feng & English: “Magnify the small, increase the few.” Following the grammar in A:8 of the Guodian, I treat 少 as “reduce”, and match the logic from there.

故終無難矣

As-a-result/thus end-finish-finally no/lack/without difficult [!]

And so, in the end, has no difficulty!

Guodian (A:8)

為亡為，事亡事，

Do/use/manipulate lack/not do/use, business/serve/matters lack/not business/serve/matters

Do without doing, have business without business,

未⁷³⁷亡未。

Still-not/not/haven't lack/not still-not/not/haven't

Not yet there without being not yet there.

大，少之；

Great, reduce/few [this/its]

*The Great, reduce it.*⁷³⁸

多⁷³⁹必多(𠄎/難)⁷⁴⁰。

Much/many/excess guardedness/anxiety/alertness certainly much/many/excess difficult-terrain(?)

Exceeding guardedness is certainly exceedingly difficult to navigate.

是以聖人(𠄎/猷/猶)(𠄎/難)之，

This by-means-of, sage plan/design/method/like/similar-to difficult-terrain(?) its/it

By means of this, the sage plans for difficulty navigating,

(古/故)(𠄎/終)亡(𠄎/難)。

Therefore/as-a-result, end-finish-finally lack/gone difficult-terrain(?)

As a result, in the end there is no difficulty navigating.

⁷³⁷ 未 This is the normal form of 未, as it occurs throughout the Guodian as meaning not yet, still not, haven't. Here, the grammar suffers for it. I just don't think it's 味 (elsewhere in the Guodian). According to Cook, the *Wenzi* cites this line with this character as “知”, so Gao Heng and Zhu Qianzhi at some point thought this was 知 (according to Cook). Being as faithful to the text as I can be, I'll put “not yet there without being not yet there”.

⁷³⁸ This could also be translated as “The Great reduces it”, but what “it” is, is not clear.

⁷³⁹ 𠄎: Unusual compared to its comrades (𠄎), but under 𠄎 in zi.tools, and with Henricks and Cook. I don't know if I trust this, and encourage more educated and skilled eyes than mine to reconsider. I default to 𠄎, maybe idiosyncratically. Cook and Henricks, and most people assume this means 易, and the heart radical added to suggest the sense of mental/emotional states for difficult and easy. That feels like back-reading to me, and the scribe had other characters they could use to convey hard and easy. Much of the Guodian has concerned minding one's body, one's nature, internal and in the world. Describing the psychological and physical manifestations of the protective response does not come out of nowhere in the Guodian. While this doesn't appear to fit the whole “opposites” pattern, that logic is not convincing enough for me to dismiss the character choice here.

⁷⁴⁰ Original had 土 under it, for whole chapter. Zi.tools has this under 𠄎莫 𠄎佳土. Difficult over ground, “difficult terrain?” Tricky to navigate or get through? The scribe, however, may just like to put 土 under the rest of this character for some reason: see A:9's 𠄎, where you can kind of make it out over the heart component.

Chapter 64

其安易⁷⁴¹持

Its peaceful/stable/quiet/calm/install change/exchange/easy/relieved hold/restrain/maintain

That which is stable is easy to hold on to,

其未兆易謀

Its not-yet omen/sign change/exchange/easy/relieved consult/advise/counsel/strategize/scheme/plan

That which has not yet been augured is easy to advise,

其脆易泮

Its brittle/frail/fragile change/exchange/easy/relieved dissolve/melt-away/break-apart

That which is fragile is easy to break apart,

其微易散

Its subtle/tiny/secret change/exchange/easy/relieved scatter/give-up/turn-loose/disperse/divert

That which is subtle is easy to scatter,

為之於未有

Do/use/act-as/manipulate [‘s]/this in/at/from/regarding not-yet exist/have

Do things when they do not yet exist,

治之於未亂

Govern/harness/control this/[‘s] in/at/from/regarding not-yet disordered/rebellious

Govern things when they are not yet disordered.

合抱之木

Combine/fit/box/unite/join/meet embrace/encircle/put-arms-around [‘s]/this tree

A tree huge enough to get one’s arms completely around

生於毫末

Born/alive/create in/at/from fine-hair/slightest-bit/plant-fuzz tree-branch/tip/peripheral

Was born from a hairlike branch.

九層之臺

Nine layered/tiered [‘s]/this tower/terrace

The tower of nine floors,

起於累土

Rise/help-up/raise in/at/from/regarding pile-up/heap/mound/gather earth

Was risen from a mound of earth.

千里之行

Thousand li(measure-of-distance) [‘s]/this transmit/walk/move/engage

A walk of a thousand li

始於足下

Begins/starts/initiate foot/leg down

Begins with dropping one’s foot.

(cont.)

⁷⁴¹ Despite the various definitions this character could have, every translation I have read treats this as “easy”.

為 {之} 者 敗 之 執 {之} 者 失 之

Act/do/use [person] corrupts/ruins/destroys ['s]/this, seize/capture/grasp [person] loses ['s]/this

Those who manipulate it ruin it, those who seize onto it lose it.

是以 聖 人 無 為 {也} 故 無 敗

This by-means-of sage no/without act/do/use thus/as-a-result no/without ruin/destroy/corrupt

By means of this, the sage does not manipulate, and so does not ruin.

無 執 故 無 失

No/without seize/grasp/capture thus/as-a-result no/without lose

Does not seize, and so does not lose.

民 之 從 事 {也} 常 於 幾 成

People ['s]/this follow/join matters constant/persistent in/at/from almost/how-much complete/achieve

The followed matters of the people are constantly almost complete,

而 敗 之

And/yet/but ruin/destroy/corrupt ['s]/this

And yet they become ruined.

{故} 慎 終 如 始

Cautious/vigilant/attentive finish/end/finally like/as/similar-to start/initiate/begin

When one is cautious at the end as one is at the start,

則 無 敗 事

when-then no/without ruin/destroy/corrupt matters/affairs/to-serve

Then matters will not be ruined.

是以 聖 人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage

欲 不 欲

Want/desire not/no desire/want

Desires the undesired⁷⁴²

不 貴 難 得 之 貨

Not prizing/valuing/ seeing as precious difficult-to-obtain/(rare) ['s]/this goods/items

Not valuing rare items as precious

學 不 學

Learn/mimic/emulate not learned/mimic/emulated

Learns the unlearned,

復 眾 人 之 所 過

Return multitudes/crowd people ['s] place passed-over/through/excess/go-beyond/trespass/mistake

Returning to the place the multitudes of people passed over.

以 輔 萬 物 之 自 然

By-means-of carriage-stabilizer/jawbone/stabilize/aid ten-thousand things ['s]/this self-so/self-nature

By means of stabilizing the true nature of the ten-thousand things,

而 不 敢 為

And/yet/but not dare/bold use/do/act-as/manipulate

Yet not daring to manipulate them.

⁷⁴² Nearly all translations outside of Waley have this line as some form of “desires not to desire”, and, take 學 不 學 to be “learn to unlearn”, though Lin switches to “learns the unlearned” (Waley keeps “teaches things untaught”).

Guodian (A:14)

其⁷⁴³(𢇛⁷⁴⁴/安)也, (𢇛/易)(𢇛/柴/困)⁷⁴⁵也;

Its stability/safe/calm/install, change/exchange/easy/relieved bound/constricted/arduous/exhausting

Those that are stable, they transform into being constrained,

其未(𢇛⁷⁴⁶/兆)也, 易(𢇛⁷⁴⁷/誨)也;

Its not-yet/hasn't peach//omen/origin(ate), change/easy motherly-love(?)/nurture(?)/instruct/guide

Those that are not yet begun, they transform into being nurtured.

其(𢇛/脆)⁷⁴⁸也, 易(𢇛/畔⁷⁴⁹/叛)也;

Its drizzle/misty-rain//weak/frail/delicate, change boundaries/alongside//betray/contradict/rebel

Those that are delicate like misty rain, they transform into being rebellious.

其(𢇛/幾)也, 易(𢇛/踐/踐)也。

It/its latent/invisible/nearly/few/imminent-danger change trample/tread/walk-to/climb-to/carry-out

Those issues that are tiny, they transform into being tread on.

為之於其亡(又/有)也。

Do/use/manipulate this/[‘s] in/at/than/to/regarding its lack/no have/exist.

Use this at its not-existing.

(𢇛/絢)⁷⁵⁰之於其未(𢇛/亂)⁷⁵¹。

Oversee this/[‘s] in/at/regarding/to/than its not-yet disordered.

Oversee this at its not-yet disordered.

⁷⁴³ 其 is often a 3rd person possessive, but can be “of those/these”, making subjects a subpart of something (Kroll).

⁷⁴⁴ 安 in zi.tools; very variable in Chu script, but this feels like it may be a different character to me. Probably nothing, but I wanted to note it just in case. It does not resemble the 𢇛 of suspected 焉.

⁷⁴⁵ Cook and Henricks has 柴; Zi.tools renders this 𢇛(之) over 木, (for zi.tools, also 持 (By the Shuowen Jiezi: 槌 (strike, hammer), as mallet or horizontal beam). Received has 持 (hold in hand, support, bear up, maintain, restrain), perhaps itself in place of 序(store up, stock, reserve), but this could also be 殖 (generate, breed, cultivate, implant, trade), or 植 (plant in the ground, growth of plants, implant), and Mawangdui has 植(throw, pitch, send). Cook suggests 柴 could be an ancient form of 困. The wood component of this character is very prominent. 𢇛 being a form of 之 (to go) (and very visually similar to 止), over wood, maybe this means to support, like a wooden bridge, or restrain, like a wooden pen for livestock. This ends up looping back to 柴 being an ancient form of 困, which the Shuowen Jiezi through Zi.tools agrees with. Visual similarity supports 柴→困. (See A:20)

⁷⁴⁶ Zi.tools, Cook, and Henricks have 𢇛. May mean 桃 (peach, though see from Baoshan Chu 𢇛) according to zi.tools. 兆, by the Shuowen Jiezi, referred to the cracks on the tortoise shell used for divination, as 𢇛; took on the later meaning of omen and sign. As it is, 未𢇛 I originally translated as “unripe peach”

⁷⁴⁷ Listed in zi.tools as 𢇛, mother over heart (motherly love?). Henricks agrees. according to zi.tools may be equivalent to 誨 (instruct, guide). Cook has 𢇛. Zi.tools mentions that 𢇛 and 𢇛 (insult) may be for 𢇛 over 心.

⁷⁴⁸ As listed in zi.tools and Cook, Originally 雨 over 𢇛 (maybe something like 用 on top?) Could be an early form of 𢇛, itself an alt. form of 脆. 𢇛 is also an alternative form of 脆 (weak, frail, fragile, dainty), but also means bird down, downy, wooly. I’m tempted to think about this as soft, delicate, misty rain, and apparently so was Cook, speculating it could be an early form of 𢇛. 𢇛 seems to mean the uropygial oil birds use to preen their feathers.

⁷⁴⁹ Technically 半 over 田, 𢇛. Was taken in the sense of “rebellion” 叛 in A;16. Could also mean 離, or 叛

⁷⁵⁰ In zitools under 𢇛, looks very close to 𢇛 (listed 絢 in zi.tools) See B:1 (𢇛) In my opinion this is 𢇛 (which zi.tools defines as “repair” from a Song dynasty text) Zi.tools suggests 治 (govern, control, harness), 始 (start, beginning), or 怡 (joyful, happy, convenient) for 𢇛. Given 司 means “oversee, supervise, examine” I opt for that.

⁷⁵¹ 𢇛→𢇛 as Henricks. (in zi.tools, listed under 吕 left of 𢇛 left of 吕, but it is the odd one out. Probably still 亂.

(會/合⁷⁵²)□□□ (抱之木)⁷⁵³,

Combine/fit/meet/close □ (*embrace/hug/enwrap/surround* [*'s*]/*this tree*)

{The tree one can} fit {their arms around in a hug.}

□□□(𦵏/末)⁷⁵⁴, (生於毫)

Tree-Branch/tip/peripheral, (*born/alive/create in/at/to/regarding/than fine-hair/slightest-bit/plant-fuzz*)

{Was born in a hairlike} branch.

九(盛/成)⁷⁵⁵之(臺/臺)⁷⁵⁶,

Nine completion/containment/accomplishment [*'s*]/*this terrace/lowly-official/raised-platform*,

The nine completed terraces,

(𠄎⁷⁵⁷/甲)□□ (於募土)

Sheath/shell/armor/first-rate/first-in-sequence □ ⁷⁵⁸(*at/in/to baskets-for-dirt earth*)

Were first {in baskets of dirt}.

□□□□ (百仞之高)

(*Hundred [length-of-distance,-approx-267-meters] [*'s*]/this high/tall/ascent*)

{A 26.700 meter /16.5 mile ascent,}

□□□足下。(始於)

Step/foot/leg down/below/under □ (*starts in/at/regarding/to*)

{Begins in} single steps.

⁷⁵² See A:10, and A:17. Might mean 會, or 答

⁷⁵³ Missing characters supplied by Cook

⁷⁵⁴ The top part of the character is cut off, the bottom is consistent with a wood radical, not typical for other instances of 未. Throughout the Laozi, it looks like 𦵏, but this is not, 未 but 末, and so is consistent (𦵏)

⁷⁵⁵ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 盛. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁷⁵⁶ 臺, Cook has 止 over 室, Henricks has 臺 (zi.tools listing found under this character). To me, looks like it could be a 𠄎 over a ghost, which I guess 室 kind of looks like (𠄎)

⁷⁵⁷ 𠄎 Both Henricks and Cook have 甲 (𠄎, 𠄎, ours 𠄎), maybe the stroke on the left faded? Cook mentions it may be an error for 𠄎, (𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎). 一 over 上? This is most likely 甲.

⁷⁵⁸ Missing characters from Cook

Guodian (A:6)

為之者(𠄎/敗)⁷⁵⁹之,

Manipulate [‘s]/this [person] corrupts/defeats/spoils/destroys/ruins [‘s]/this

Those who manipulate it, corrupt and destroy it.

(𠄎⁷⁶⁰/執)之者(𡗗/遠)⁷⁶¹之。

Grasp/seize/clutch/take-control [‘s]/this [person] distant/far/separated/estranged/far-reaching [‘s]/this

Those who clutches it close makes it distant.

是以聖人亡為,

This by-means-of sage lack/no do/act/use/manipulate

By means of this, the sage does not manipulate,

(古/故)亡敗; 亡執,

Old/ancient//therefore, lack/not corrupt/destroy, not grasp/seize/clutch-close

And as a result, does not corrupt and ruin, does not seize to hold close,

(古/故)亡(𡗗⁷⁶²/失/逸)。

Old/ancient//therefore, not escaping/breaking-free.

And so, it does not break free and escape.

(𠄎/臨⁷⁶³)事之(𠄎/紀⁷⁶⁴),

Look-from-above/preside-over/on-verge-of/oversee /matters/serve [‘s] strand/unravel/arrange/rule

The rule of presiding over matters:

(𠄎/誓⁷⁶⁵/斂→慎)(各/冬)(女/如)(𠄎⁷⁶⁶/殆),

Swear/oath//Cautious winter woman//like/as-if/ in-danger/in-peril

Caution and winter, like there’s danger,

⁷⁵⁹ In Henricks, the left part is 貝, but Cook doesn’t address this. 𠄎 expressed as 敗 or 斂 in zi.tools, under 敗.

⁷⁶⁰ In zi.tools as (𠄎幸𠄎𠄎女), under 執, so the components are consistent.

⁷⁶¹ Cook says that 遠(𡗗) was also meant to be 𡗗 and translates both to 失, but the resemblance between the two characters in the Guodian is insufficient. Far/ distant/remote still works in context as well.

⁷⁶² 𡗗: Zi.tools has similar (𡗗) as (𠄎止𠄎止) (handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away. This can relate to 失 (lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also you can relate this to escaping, or even 逸 (a rabbit running, the way this concept was expressed in kingdoms west of Chu).

⁷⁶³ This transcription is probably sound, but in zi.tools, it is an “odd one out”.

⁷⁶⁴ 𠄎: cannot find in zi.tools but Cook, Henricks both have 紀 which is plausible. Possibly, left is 幺 over [???].

⁷⁶⁵ 𠄎. In zi.tools as 𠄎十言斤, to mean 慎 (Cook agrees). The top part looks like Zhou bronze-inscription style 土 (土), or maybe just a very reduced 糸. Compare with C:4’s 𠄎 A:15’s 𠄎, as 斂, which could also mean 慎.

However, 𠄎→斂 is attested in the Shuowen to be equivalent to 慎. The only evidence I’ve seen so far that these characters are 慎 comes from the Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓 (to swear; but see 𠄎 from Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎十言斤). 斂 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I take this in the sense of 慎, but the etymology is not the most convincing to me, though “happiness” makes no sense in context.

⁷⁶⁶ Compare to Guodian A:9 (𠄎), this one in A:6 has an extra line. Both Henricks and Cook have 𠄎 without the box (𠄎). Zi.tools has this as 𠄎. Meanings range from 殆 (danger (危, from Shuowen Jiezi); 漢語同源詞大典: broken-down/deteriorated/decayed (Analects: doubtful), 治 (to control, to harness, to manage, to govern, to channel like water), 怠 (slow, leisurely, sluggish; 漢語同源詞大典: exhausted, fatigue; I think this is unlikely as 怠 already used in the Guodian and they are not that similar: 𠄎 vs 𠄎 from here), 怡 (joyous, harmonious), 辭 (governance, to govern through law/litigation), and 貽 (to give as a gift), at least by zi.tools under 𠄎. I find 殆 or 治.

(𠂇/此)亡敗⁷⁶⁷事矣。

This no/lack corrupt/ruin/destroy matters/to-serve [!]

This lacks the corruption of matters!

聖人(谷/欲)不(谷/欲),

Sage want not/no want

The sage wants the unwanted,⁷⁶⁸

不貴(𧸛/難)(𧸛/得)之(𧸛/貨),

Not prizing/valuing/seeing-as-precious difficult obtain [‘s]/this goods/items

Not valuing items difficult to obtain as precious;⁷⁶⁹

(𧸛/𧸛/教⁷⁷⁰)不(𧸛/𧸛/教),

Reveal/release/exile/set-free//follow-superiors not reveal/release/exile/set-free//follow-superiors

Reveals the untaught⁷⁷¹

(還/復)⁷⁷²(𧸛/眾)之所⁷⁷³(𧸛/化/過)⁷⁷⁴。

Return multitudes/crowds [‘s]/this /that-which/place-(x2)/wherever change//pass-through/trespass

Returning to wherever the multitudes pass through to be converted.

是(古/故)聖人

This old/ancient//therefore/as-a-result sage

This, as a result, the sage,

(𧸛/能)(𧸛/尊⁷⁷⁵)萬(勿/物)之自然⁷⁷⁶,

Can/able spread-out/expand ten-thousand things [‘s]/this self-nature/self-so

Is able to spread the self-nature of ten-thousand things,

而(後/弗)能為。

But/and/yet not able/can do/use/manipulate,

But not able to manipulate them.

⁷⁶⁷ Messier, but definitely this character 𧸛 is still 敗

⁷⁶⁸ Or, “the sage wants not to want”. The “verb-不-verb” construction is somewhat flexible in this way.

⁷⁶⁹ Alternatively, “not valuing rare items as precious.”

⁷⁷⁰ See also A:9. Could also be 𧸛 (mimic, imitate, emulate, learn), but this doesn’t change the connotation of studies/teachings. Guodian slip photos support 𧸛 at least. Zi.tools also has 𧸛. Wiktionary lists 𧸛 and 𧸛 as a variant of 教, but Shuowen Jiezi equates 𧸛 with 放 (release, abandon, expel, exile, cast aside, put down, fully revealed (open and expressed fully), set-free, act with no constraints; though Cook says the Shuowen calls it as 放, “to emulate”?), but also follow and adhere to according to 說文解字注.

⁷⁷¹ Or “releases not to release”, which makes less sense, or “follows not to follow”/ “teaches not to teach”, if 教

⁷⁷² Henricks and Zi.tools accurately has this as 還, probably emphasizing the walk/going aspect.

⁷⁷³ Indicated with a duplication mark, also in this form 𧸛.

⁷⁷⁴ Cook, Henricks and zi.tools appropriately have this as 化 over 止. Zi.tools connects this to 過, which has 𧸛 (𧸛), found in C:4. 過 appears as 𧸛 in the Guodian as well, though. I am more inclined to read this in the sense of 化, change – perhaps a movement that changes someone? Journey in the learning sense? 化, according to the Shuowen Jiezi, had an early meaning of “change people by talking and teaching”, a sense of perhaps convince or convert.

⁷⁷⁵ Somewhat unique compared to other examples of 尊 in zi.tools (𧸛), but within variation. Shuowen Jiezi defines this as 布 (to spread out, all around, spread out). This character is now used as 敷.

⁷⁷⁶ An odd form, 𧸛, within variation.

Guodian (C:4)

為之者(𠄎/敗)⁷⁷⁷之,

Manipulate [‘s] person corrupts/defeats/spoils/destroys/ruins it

Those who manipulate it, corrupt and destroy it.

(𠄎⁷⁷⁸/執)之者(𢇛⁷⁷⁹/失/逸)之。

Grasp/seize/clutch/take-control [‘s] person break-free/escape

Those who seize it have it break free from them and escape.

聖人無為,

Sage no/without act/do/use/manipulate

The sage, without manipulation,

(古/故)無敗也;

Old/ancient//therefore no/without corrupt/defeat/spoil/destroys

As a result, does not corrupt,

無執, (古/故)□□□ (無⁷⁸⁰/失/逸)也⁷⁸⁰

Without/no grasp/seize/clutch, old/ancient//therefore □

Without grasping, therefore, {it does not break free and escape}.

(𠄎⁷⁸¹/慎)(𠄎⁷⁸²/終)若(𠄎⁷⁸³/詞),

Cautious end/finish/finally like words/expression/lyrics

Stay cautious to the end, like explaining something;

(𠄎⁷⁸⁴/則)無敗事(𠄎⁷⁸⁵/壹/喜)。

Norm/standard/rule/when-then not/without corrupt/destroy/ruin matters/affairs/serve drum//happiness

Then there will be no corrupting or destruction of matters or happiness.

⁷⁷⁷ In Henricks, left part is 𠄎, but Cook doesn't address this. Expressed both as 敗 or 𠄎 in zi.tools, under 敗.

⁷⁷⁸ In zi.tools as (𠄎幸𠄎𠄎女), under 執, so the components are consistent. Contrast with C:2 (𠄎 for 𠄎)

⁷⁷⁹ 𢇛 This resembles the second “失” in A:6 (𢇛). Zi.tools has this as 𢇛(walk) around 止(foot) over 𠄎(handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away. This can relate to 失(lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also you can relate this to escaping, or even 逸(a rabbit running, the way this concept was expressed in kingdoms west of Chu. Could also be 逸, or 達/達.

⁷⁸⁰ Missing characters from A:6, switching 亡 for 無.

⁷⁸¹ 𠄎, not listed in zi.tools but greatly resembling 𠄎 under the 𠄎 listing. Compare with A:6 (𠄎) and A:15 (𠄎). However, 𠄎 → 𠄎 is attested in the Shuowen to be equivalent to 慎. The only evidence I've seen so far that these characters are 慎 comes from the Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓(to swear; but see 𠄎 from Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎斤言女); Cook has this as what zi.tools does, and discusses theories. 𠄎 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I take this in the sense of 慎, but the etymology is not the most convincing to me.

⁷⁸² No sun below this one in the actual slips

⁷⁸³ Listed in zi.tools as 言 left of 𠄎 under the 詞 page. The page itself suggests several meanings, like 治, 始, 殆, and 辭(explain in A:10, 𠄎): only the last one is convincing to me, given the prominence of 言. Not like A:6 (𠄎)

⁷⁸⁴ Compare to C:3. 𠄎. The rightmost line making the knife was likely faded out and lost, probably meant to look like this 𠄎. Notice also the abbreviated form of 鼎 as 𠄎 from A:17.

⁷⁸⁵ As reluctant as I am to just default to the received text here, I'm totally stuck: 壹 means drum and I cannot find a way to make that make sense in this sentence. Cook reports that this is sometimes rendered 喜(happiness, 喜), but grammatically, that's hard to swing as well. I guess you could add “and happiness” to the translation...

人之敗也，

People [’s/this] ruin/corruption/destroying

People’s ruin,

(𣦵/互)⁷⁸⁶(𠂇/於)其(𢶏/據)⁷⁸⁷(埜/成)⁷⁸⁸也，敗之。

Constantly/persistently in/at/than it/its grasp/take completion/achievement, corrupt/ruin.

Persistently in their grasping at completion, they ruin themselves.

是以(□/聖)⁷⁸⁹人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage,

欲⁷⁹⁰不欲，不貴(𢶏/慙)⁷⁹¹(𢶏/得)之(𢶏/貨)；

Desire/craves/urge-to-obtain not desire/crave, not/no value/costly/precious fear/terror obtain/get goods

Desires the undesired, not valuing goods terrifying to obtain as precious.

學不學，(𢶏/復)⁷⁹²(𢶏/眾)(之所)⁷⁹³(𢶏/過)。

Mimic/learn/emulate/study not mimic/learn/study, return multitude/crowd/numerous [’s] place change

Learns the unlearned, returning to the multitude’s place of conversion.

是以能(𢶏/補)(𢶏/莖/萬)(勿/物)之自然，

This by-means-of can dense-growth ten-thousand(?)⁷⁹⁴ things [’s] self-nature/self-so

And by means of this, enable the dense growth of ten-thousand things’ self-nature

而(𢶏/弗)敢⁷⁹⁵為。

And/yet/but not dare act/do/use/manipulate.

Yet does not dare to manipulate them.

⁷⁸⁶ Technically 𣦵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𣦵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 極 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

⁷⁸⁷ Henricks and zi.tools have 𢶏, Cook has 𢶏 (zi.tools also, the only difference between them being a repositioned hand). Maybe 𢶏 for 取 (take, retrieve, grasp with fingers).

⁷⁸⁸ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 埜. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁷⁸⁹ Missing in the slips, filled in by A:6 and Cook.

⁷⁹⁰ Unlike in A:6, this is actually 𢶏, not 谷.

⁷⁹¹ Unlike in A:6, has a heart radical below. Now this means terrified, scared.

⁷⁹² Henricks and Zi.tools accurately has this as 𢶏, probably emphasizing the walk/going aspect.

⁷⁹³ Fused character, not the clearest: 𢶏. 所 can also mean “that-which”

⁷⁹⁴ Almost normal 萬 (𢶏) but earth under it, zi.tools considers this extra component to have no effect on meaning

⁷⁹⁵ 𢶏 Zi.tools has this under 𢶏, this is a variant of 敢

Chapter 65

古之善為道者

Ancient/old ['s]/this/it good/skilled use/do/act-as Dao people

Those skilled in using the Dao of antiquity,

非以明民

Not by-means-of luminous/perceptive/bright common-people

Did not work through illuminating the people,

將以愚之

Hold/support/use/bring/will by-means-of ignorant/untaught this/it/['s]

Bringing about through leaving them untaught.

民之難治

Common-people ['s]/this/it difficult govern/harness/control

The difficulty governing of the people,

以其(知/智)多

By-means-of it/its knowledge/wisdom many/much/excess

Is through their excessive knowledge.

故以(知/智)治國,國之賊

Therefore, by-means-of knowledge/wisdom govern state/territory “” ['s] outlaw/villainy

Therefore, governing a state through knowledge is the state's villainy

不以(知/智)治國,國之福

Not by-means-of knowledge/wisdom govern state/territory, “” ['s] blessings/good-fortune

Not governing a state through knowledge is the state's good fortune.

知此兩者亦稽式

Know this two/pair, in-this-case/too reach/examine/check norm/standard/example

To know these two things, one too reaches these standards.

常知稽式

Constant/persistent know reach/examine/check example/norm/pattern/standard

Constantly knowing and reaching these standards,

是謂玄德

This is-called murky/mysterious/dim virtue/innate-power.

This is called mysterious virtue.

玄德深矣遠矣

Mysterious/dim/murky virtue/innate-power deep [!] Distant/far/far-reaching/separated [!]

Mysterious virtue is deep! Distant!

與物反矣

Together/join/give things turn-back/reverse/invert/oppose [!]

Together things are turning back!

然後乃至大順

After_then/indeed arrive great/big compliance/agreeable/conforming/accommodating

[After this] indeed reaching great compliance.

Chapter 66

江海所以能為百谷⁷⁹⁶王者

River seas [place by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which can/able act/do/use hundred valley king

The mechanism by which the rivers and seas can act as the kings of a hundred valleys,

以其善下之

By-means-of it virtue/goodness/favorable/advantage below/down

Is through lowering its goodness;

故⁷⁹⁷能為百谷王

Thus can/able do/manipulate/act/use hundred valley king

Thus, can act as the kings of a hundred valleys.

是以[聖人之]

This by-means-of [sage]

By means of this [the sage]

欲上民{也},必以{其}言下之.

Desire above/superior common-people, certainly/must by-means-of words below/down this

Desiring to be above the people, certainly speaks words to be lower than them.

{其}欲先民{也},必以{其}身後之.

Desire first/front/prior common-people certainly by-means-of self/body behind/after this

Desiring to be first of the people, certainly keeps the self behind them.

是以⁷⁹⁸聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage,

處上而民不重{也}

Stays/resides/occupies above and/but/yet common-people not heavy

Stays above, but the people are not heavily burdened,

處前而民不害{也}

Stays/resides/occupies front/before/forward and/but/yet common-people not harmed/abused

Stays in the lead, yet the people are not abused.

是以天下樂推而不厭⁷⁹⁹{也}

This by-means-of world music/glee go-forward but not satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted,

By means of this, the world gleefully advances him, and do not bore or loathe him,

以其不爭⁸⁰⁰

By-means-of its/it not disputed/fight/contend/strive/quarrel

By means of his not striving and competing,

故天下莫能與之爭.

Therefore/thus under-heaven in-no-case can/able share/join ['s] competition/quarrel/dispute.

As a result, no one in the world can join in his competition.

⁷⁹⁶ In every instance in this Chapter, Mawangdui has 浴, like Guodian

⁷⁹⁷ Mawangdui have 是以 here and in the next line both, not 故

⁷⁹⁸ Mawangdui have 故 for the entirety of the line here. 居 in place of 處 as well where it occurs

⁷⁹⁹ The Shuowen Jiezi, through zi.tools, offers the meaning of “pressed-down, weighed down, forced down”, Kroll suggests this is a borrowing of 壓, as does zi.tools itself.

⁸⁰⁰ Both Mawangdui end this line with 與, and start this line with 非 (A) or 不 (B)

Guodian (A:2)

江⁸⁰¹(~~海~~/海)⁸⁰²所以為⁸⁰³百(~~蓂~~/蓂/浴⁸⁰⁴)王

River sea [place/that-which by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which do hundred bath/purify/stream king

The mechanism by which rivers and seas act as king of the hundred streams,

以其能為百(蓂/浴)下,

By-means-of their/its can/able do/act/use/manipulate hundred bath/purify/stream down

Is through their ability to act as below the hundred streams;

是以能為百(蓂/浴)王。

This by-means-of able/can act/do/use/manipulate hundred bath/purify/stream king

By means of this, they are able to act as the kings of the hundred streams.

聖人之(~~才~~⁸⁰⁵/才)民(~~蓂~~/前)⁸⁰⁶也,

Sage [‘s/this] talent common-people before/front/forward

The sage’s talent is being before the people,

以身(~~後~~⁸⁰⁷/後)⁸⁰⁷之;

By-means-of body/self after/behind/delay/later this/[‘s].

By putting the self after them.

其才民上也,

Its/their talent common-people above/superior

The sage’s talent is being above the people,

以言下之。

By-means-of speech/talk/words down/below this/[‘s]

By speaking words to be below them.

其才民上也,

It/its talent common-people above/superior,

The sage’s talent being above the people,

民(~~厚~~⁸⁰⁸/弗)(~~厚~~⁸⁰⁸/厚)⁸⁰⁸也;

Common-people not thick/deep/sincere/authentic/richly/important/lavish/generous

***The common people are not thick.*⁸⁰⁹**

⁸⁰¹ Possibly specifically the Yangtze River in the south. 江 tend to be thought of as larger, natural rivers.

⁸⁰² In zi.tools, technically 𠂔 left of 毋, under 海.

⁸⁰³ I usually translate 為 as manipulate, use, or do. Here, the meaning of “act as” is the only one that works. See A:5

⁸⁰⁴ Only in A:2 does this character take this form

⁸⁰⁵ Everywhere 才 occurs in the Guodian, some put 在, I suppose taking this as an early form of the latter. There is evidence that Chu bamboo script used 才 for both, but either way, there are no connotations of desire or want.

⁸⁰⁶ Zi.tools has this under 蓂, which Wiktionary calls an ancient version of 前

⁸⁰⁷ Zi.tools has 逡, accurate. Henricks has 後 over 止. The meaning is unchanged, this is just an ancient form.

⁸⁰⁸ 𠂔. Originally 石 over 毛 according to Cook – Henricks just has 厚. Listed in zi.tools as 石 over 𠂔 for 厚 (see also A:17 𠂔) see also A:3 (𠂔→heavy), and the mystery character pair in A:18 (𠂔/𠂔).

⁸⁰⁹ This is the same character as 𠂔 in A:17, translated as “thickly, deeply, fully”, perhaps even heavily. The “thickness” the people lack may be not having to be bogged down with the importance and weight of the sage, not having to trudge through it in all aspects of life like someone wading through mud. It could also be that the people are not sincere or deep if the sage’s talent (or position) is above them, as it does not support and nourish them from below. No matter the approach, there is some interpretive work to be done here. I hesitate to default to the 重 (heavy) of the received, where the burden connotation is perhaps easier to grasp. It may indeed be the right interpretation, though. I keep the main translation ambiguous as a result.

其才民前也,

It/its talent common-people before/front

The sage's talent is before the people;

民弗(𠂔/害/害)⁸¹⁰也。

Common-people not harm/abuse/damaged/blind(?)

The common people are not pained by blindness.⁸¹¹

天下樂(𦏧/進)而(𦏧/弗) (𦏧/詰)。

Under-heaven glee/music advance/move-forward/present/improve and/yet/but not talkative/garrulous

The world gleefully moves forward, and yet is not aggravatingly talkative.⁸¹²

以其不(𦏧/靜)也,

By-means-of their/its not/no still/quiet/placid

By means of its lack of motionlessness

(古/故)天下⁸¹³莫能(𦏧/昇/與)⁸¹⁴之(𦏧/靜)。

Old/ancient//therefore/thus under-heaven in-no-case can/able join/give [‘s/this] still/quiet/placid

Therefore, the world can never join motionlessness.

⁸¹⁰ In zi.tools as 𠂔 (but not 害), alone. In Cook (but not Henricks, who has 害), 害 (a form of punishment by tattooing the eyes, by Wiktionary, under 憲). Could be early form of 瞎 (blind). See also C:2 (𦏧) and A:15 (𦏧). All three characters are very different, and for all three I find the graphic etymology linking them back to 害 somewhat weak. Nevertheless, I default to 害 (𦏧) for now. An eye component on the bottom (目←𦏧) (though it may be a net 𦏧) is visible: perhaps this means to obscure their sight, or otherwise harm the ability to see? This is significant, given that the Chu character for 民 is 𦏧; a proposed etymology of this character being a needle going into an eye, how early rulers blinded slaves to gain their compliance. Eerie how 民 came to mean the “people” or the “masses,” potentially illustrating compliance with authority in this way (See A:1). However, this may be as the early form of 憲 (to publish, to promulgate, standard, law, rule, emulate), according to Wikipedia, where 害 is the phonetic part.

⁸¹¹ Or, “the common people do not emulate it,” or “the common people do not take it as standard.”

⁸¹² This could also refer to the sage, becoming “The world gleefully advances [the sage] and yet does not become talkative.” The world nor the sage not becoming talkative as the result of promoting one person seems less likely than the whole world moving forward without having to get bogged down with words, in my opinion.

⁸¹³ These 天下 have marks above them, the ones on the previous slip two lines up did not.

⁸¹⁴ 𦏧 Henricks has 与 over 𦏧, zi.tools has 昇, which is more accurate. The Shuowen, through zi.tools, insists this is an old form of 與, but then why use both? A:10 also has 𦏧 (join). 𦏧 (rhetorical) from A:12, and from B:3 𦏧 (grant/and?); Also from B:3 𦏧/与 (bestow). See also A:18 (grant)

Chapter 67

天下皆謂我道⁸¹⁵大

Heaven-under all say/call I/me Dao/way big/great

In the world all say my Dao is great,

似⁸¹⁶不肖

Seems-like/be-like [not likeness/reduce/dwindle]/unworthy/incompetent/discrepant

Like being discrepant.

夫唯大故似不肖⁸¹⁷

In-any-case only big/great thus/as-a-result seems-like/be-like [not likeness/dwindle]/discrepant

In any case only being great, therefore it discrepant.

若肖久矣其細也

If/like likeness/waning/resembling, long-lasting [!] their minimal/miniscule/slight/thin/fine.

If it were resembling something, long would be its diminutiveness!

夫我有三寶

In-any-case I have/exist three treasure/jewel

In any case I have three treasures,

持而保之

Hold/maintain/restrain and/but/yet protect/sustain/guard/preserve this/[‘s]

Hold and preserve these.

一曰慈

One called/say tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence

One is called benevolence,

二曰儉

Two called/says restraint/moderation/prudence/frugal/scarcity

Two is called moderation,

三曰不敢為天下先

Three called/says not dare/bold use/do/act-as heaven under first/in-front/supreme

Three is called not daring to act as ahead the world.⁸¹⁸

慈故能勇

Tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence therefore/as-a-result can/able brave/courage/daring/fearless

Benevolent, therefore able to be brave,

儉故能廣

Restraint/moderation therefore/as-a-result can/able wide/spacious/accepting/widespread/generous

Moderation, therefore able to be generous,

⁸¹⁵ Mawangdui does not have 道 here, 大 is just written twice

⁸¹⁶ Mawangdui (B) has 而 here instead.

⁸¹⁷ In the Mawangdui (B) This line is instead, 夫唯不肖故能大.

⁸¹⁸ I leave this vague, could be “ahead of the world” or “ahead in the world”. This could also be “act as supreme to the world”, like you are more important than the world, or prioritized above the world. Linnell has “not daring to act first in the world.” Wu has “not daring to be first in the world,” and Lin has similar. Lau has “not daring to take the lead in the empire”, Henricks has “not presuming to be at the forefront of the world,” and Cleary has “not presuming to be at the head of the world.” Waley has “refusal to be foremost of all things under heaven.” Feng & English have “daring not to be ahead of others.”

不敢為天下先，故能⁸¹⁹成器⁸²⁰長。

Not dare use/act-as world first, therefore able/can achieve/complete tool/capacity long/endure/elder⁸²¹

Not daring to act ahead of the world, therefore able to achieve the capacity to endure.

今舍⁸²²慈且勇

Now/present dwell//abandon/let-go benevolence/tenderness even/and/or/shall/while brave/fearless

Now, relinquishing benevolence while being fearless,

舍儉且廣

Dwell//abandon/let-go restraint/moderation/prudence/frugal even/and/while wide/widespread/generous

Relinquishing moderation while being generous,

舍後且先

Dwell//abandon/let-go behind/after/rear even/and/while first/front/supreme/ahead

Relinquishing the behind while being ahead,

死矣

Die/dead/inert [!]

That's death!

夫慈以戰則勝

In-any-case benevolence/merciful by-means-of combat/struggle when-then overcome/conquer

In any case, benevolence, through combat, then will conquer.

以守則固

By-means-of guard/maintain/defend when-then firm/solid

Through defending, then one is solid.⁸²³

天將救之

Heaven will/bring-about relieved/rescue/save/cure/prevent this/['s]

Heaven brings rescue to those it would

以慈衛之

By-means-of benevolence/merciful care defend/safeguard/feathering-arrows this/['s]

Through benevolence, safeguarding them.⁸²⁴

⁸¹⁹ Mawangdui has 為 inserted after here.

⁸²⁰ 成器 can be compound, meaning “to become a useful implement” or “grow up to be a talented/useful person”, according to Wiktionary, but it is not clear how old these definitions are.

⁸²¹ Also “leader”, which Linnell (“leadership”), Wu (“chief”), Lau (“lord”), Chan (“leader”), Henricks (“head of those”), Waley (“chief”), and Feng & English (“leadership”), though Lin has this in the sense of “develop/mature” (“One can develop one’s talent and let it mature”), and Cleary has this in the sense of “enduring/to last” (“One can make one’s potential last.”) I agree with Cleary, as 長 has

⁸²² By Kroll, this word means guest-house, cottage, place of rest or ease, reside, dwell (as I usually translate it), retain, save, set aside, reserve for other use, overnight military encampment. However, Linnell and Henricks has “abandon”, Wu has “without”, Lau and Lin have “forsake” and Chan does as well, Waley has “not based on”, Cleary has “not”. All versions except for FuYi, have 舍, FY has 捨, meaning “abandon, let go of, release, part with”. Kroll does mention that 舍 can be used as a form of 捨, and I take it in this sense because “dwell in benevolence while being brave” resulting in death doesn’t make the most sense, and it appears everyone has agreed on this.

⁸²³ This line may also still have 慈 implied, in which case this would be “Benevolence, through defense, is solid.”

⁸²⁴ Cleary words this better: “Those whom heaven is going to save are those it guards with mercy.” Wu instead has “Heaven will come to the rescue of the merciful, and protect him with its mercy.” Lau has “What heaven succors it protects with the gift of compassion.” Chan has “When heaven is to save a person, Heaven will protect him through deep love.” I consider my meaning the same as theirs.

Chapter 68

善為士者不武

Skilled/good/advantageous do/act-as/use nobles/knights {person/phrase} not warlike/militant/footprint
Those skilled at being nobles are not warlike.

善戰者不怒

Skilled/good/advantageous combat/struggle {person/phrase} not angry/infuriated/wrath/impel/tense
Those skilled in combat are not enraged.

善勝敵者不與

Skilled/good overcome/conquer enemy/rival/oppose/resist {person/phrase} not join/grant/unite/give
Those skilled in defeating rivals do not join them.⁸²⁵

善用人者為之下

Skilled/good use/employ people {people/phrase} use/act-as/do [‘s]/this below/down/under
Those skilled in employing people act as lower than them.

是謂不爭之德

This called not vie/compete/contend [‘s]/this virtue/power
This is called the virtue of not competing.

是謂用人之力

This called employ/use people [‘s]/this strength/power/might
This is called using the people’s strength.

是謂配天,

This called match/mate/spouse/partner/coordinate/cooperate Heaven
This is called cooperating with Heaven,

古之極 {也}

Old/ancient [‘s]/this utmost/standard/zenith/supreme
The supremeness of the ancient!⁸²⁶

⁸²⁵ Wu, Henricks, have “engage”; Lau and Waley have “join issue”, FuYi has 爭, so Chan has “compete”, Lin has “fight (on small issues)”, Cleary has “contend”, and Feng & English have “vengeful”. I leave this open. Joining them in their rivalry? Fraternizing with the enemy? Joining them to engage in interaction (unnecessarily)?

⁸²⁶ A lot of translations have a connotation of wedding or mating: Wu, “This is called being wedded to Heaven as of old!”; Waley, “The secret of being mated to heaven, to what was of old”; Lin “Mated to Heaven, to what was of old”; Cleary, “this is called mating with the supremely natural and pristine.” Lau, Chan, and Henricks have more like what I have: Lau has “matching the sublimity of Heaven”, and Chan and Henricks have “matching Heaven, the highest principle/high point of old/the past.”

Chapter 69

用兵有言

Employ/use weapons/warfare/military exist/have words/speech

Those who use weapons have these words:

吾不敢為主而為客

I/me not dare/bold do/use/act-as lord/king/ruler/host and/yet/but do/use/act-as stranger/guest

I do not dare act as a host, but act as a guest;

不敢進寸而退尺

Not dare/bold go-forward/advance/improve thumb-length/inch and/but withdraw/go-back foot/ten-寸

Do not dare go forward an inch, but go back a foot.

是謂行無行,攘無臂

This called march/engage/move/enact without/lack march/move/walk roll-up-sleeves⁸²⁷ lack forearm

This is called marching without marching, rolling up the sleeves without arms,

扔無敵,執無兵

Pull/tow/haul/destroy/wreck without/lack rival/oppose/enemy/resist, seize/grasp/capture lack weapons

Destroying without opposing, capturing without weapons.

禍莫大於輕⁸²⁸敵

Divine-misfortune in-no-case great/big in/at/than light/frivolous/shallow enemy/rival/oppose/resist

There is no divine misfortune greater than treating the enemy frivolously.⁸²⁹

輕敵幾喪⁸³⁰吾寶

Light/frivolous enemy/rival/oppose/resist latent/invisible/nearly/few grief/lose/suffer/flee I/me treasure

Treating enemies frivolously, I nearly lost my treasures.

故抗兵相加⁸³¹

Thus withstand/grapple-with/resist/inflexible weapons each-other add/place-upon/inflict-upon

Therefore, when grappling weapons are inflicted upon each other,

{則/而} 哀者勝矣

{Then/and} mourn/grieve {person/phrase} overcome/conquers

The mourning ones that wield them conquer.

⁸²⁷ Can also mean extract, expel.

⁸²⁸ In Mawangdui, this is 無

⁸²⁹ Linnell has “underestimating the enemy”, as Wu, Lin, Cleary, and Feng & English. (Lau has “taking on an enemy too easily”, Chan has “to make light of the enemy”, Henricks has “thinking you have no rival”, Waley has “to attack and find no enemy”.)

⁸³⁰ Mawangdui A has 斤, Mawangdui B has 近.

⁸³¹ Mawangdui has 若

Chapter 70

吾言甚易知

I/me speech/words excessively/too-much change/easy know

My words are exceedingly easy to know,

甚易行

Excessively/too-much change enact/engage/walk/move

Exceedingly easy to enact.

{而} 天下莫 {之} 能知

{And/yet/but} Heaven under in-no-case/no-one able/capable know

Yet in the world there is no one capable of knowing them,

莫 {之} 能行

No-one/in-no-case capable/able enact/engage/walk/move

No one capable of enacting them.

言有宗

Words/speech have/exist ancestor/venerated

The words have an ancestor,

事有君

Matters/business/to-serve have/exist noble/gentlemen/ruler/sovereign

The matters have a lord.

夫唯無知,是以不我知

In-any-case only not/lack/without know, this by-means-of not I/me know

In any case, only by not knowing this – through this I am not known.

知我者希,則我者貴 {矣}

Know I [person/phrase] rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to, when-then I {person/phrase} value/precious

When those who know me are rare, then I am valued!

是以聖人被褐

This by-means-of sage blanket/cloak/reach/receive/suffer coarse-wool/burlap/drab

By means of this, the sage is cloaked in drab coarse clothes,

{而} 懷玉

Chest/breast/embrace/cherish/hold-dear/comfort/nostalgic/miss jade

But embraces jade close to the heart.

Chapter 71

知不知上⁸³² {矣}

Know not know above/top/supreme/high

Knowing that you do not know is supreme!

不知知⁸³³ 病 {矣}

Not know, know illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by

Not knowing what you know is a sickness!

夫唯病病

In-any-case only illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by(x2)

In any case, only when sick of being sick

是以不病

This by-means-of not illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by

By means of this one is not sick.

聖人不病

Sage not illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by

The sage is not sick

以其病病

by-means-of their illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by(x2)

By means of his sick of being sick

是以不病

This by-means-of not illness/disease/fault/be-troubled-by

By means of this, there is no sickness.

⁸³² Mawangdui has 尚 instead – exalting, surpass, worthy

⁸³³ Mawangdui A has 不知不知 – not knowing you don't know

Chapter 72

民不畏威

Common-people not fear/haunted/dreadful/frighten/shrink-from intimidating/dominate/authority

When the common people do not fear dominance,

則大威至 {矣}

When-then/rule big/great dominate/authority arrive/arrival

Then a greater dominance will arrive!

無狎其所居

Lack/without familiar-with/comfortable-with/banter/frivolous their that-which/place dwell/reside/settle

Be without toying with their homes,

無厭其所生

Lack/without satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted their that-which born/live/create

Be without disgust toward their way of life.

夫唯不厭

In-any-case only not satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted

In any case, only by not being disgusted,

是以不厭

This by-means-of not satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted

Through this there is no disgust (in either direction)⁸³⁴

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

Through this, the sage

自知不自見

Self know not self see

Knows himself but does not see himself

自愛不自貴

Self love not self value/expensive/costly

Loves himself but does not highly value himself.

故去彼取此

Therefore/thus/as-a-result leave/go that/others take/capture/seize this

So, they leave the others and take this.

⁸³⁴ Linnell translates this as “only because you do not despise them, thus they will not tire of you.” Wu has “Only when you cease to weary them, they will cease to be wearied of you.” Lau has similar with “press upon” for weary, Chan and Henricks as well with “oppress”, Lin has “dislike”. Cleary has something completely different but interesting: “Their homes are not small to them, their livelihood not tiresome. Just because they do not tire of it, it is not tiresome to them.”

Chapter 73

勇於敢, 則殺

Brave/courage/daring/fearless in/at/than/regarding dare/bold, when-then kill/cut-down

When one is fearless in their audacity, then there is killing.⁸³⁵

勇於不敢, 則活

Brave/courage/daring/fearless in/at/than/regarding not dare/bold, when-then to-live/vital/lively

When one is fearless but does not dare, then there is living.

此兩者或利或害

These two {person/phrase} sometimes benefit/sharp, sometimes harm/destroy/abuse

In these two, some are beneficial, some are harmful.⁸³⁶

天之所惡孰知其故

Heaven ['s]/this that-which/place ugly/hateful, who/which know their thus/as-a-result/reason/cause

That which is hated by Heaven – who knows its reason?

是以聖人猶難之

This by-means-of sage plans/schemes/hesitant difficulties this/it/['s]

By means of this, the sage plans for difficulties.

天之道, 不爭而善勝

Heaven ['s]/this Dao/way Not vie/contest/compete and/yet/but good/skilled overcome/conquest

Heaven's Way is not to compete, and yet skilled at overcoming,

不言而善應

Not speech/words and/yet advantageous/good/skilled reply/fulfill/accept

Not to speak, and yet skilled at responding,

不召而自來

Not call-out/call-over/invite/lead-on and/yet/but self come/approach/arrive

Not to call out, and yet things approach on their own

繹⁸³⁷ 然而善謀

Loose/relaxed/at-ease nature/self-so and/yet/but good/skilled consult/advise/strategize/scheme/plan

To be leisurely by nature, and yet skilled in planning.

天網恢恢,

Heaven catch-net/net/catch/enmesh/entangle/web/network extensive/vast/magnify(x2)

Heaven's net is incredibly vast;

疏而不失

Wide-apart/separated/estranged/ignore and/yet/but not lose.

Spread apart wide⁸³⁸, ***and yet not losing anything.***

⁸³⁵ Cleary is also vague about who is killed, simply putting “killing”, Feng & English have “kill or be killed”. Waley holds that this person “slays”, but Lin has this person “(you) kill”, and Wu, Lau, Chan, and Henricks all believe that such a person is killed.

⁸³⁶ I'm being rather literal, and Linnell's translation is also: “They sometimes cause benefit, sometimes cause harm.” Wu, Lau, Chan, and Henricks all have that one is one way and the other is the other. Waley, instead, has “Either may be profitable or unprofitable,” and Lin has “In these two there is some advantage and some disadvantage.”

⁸³⁷ Not listed in Kroll, Wiktionary has “loose ribbon, relaxed, indulgent”, maybe related to 攄 (which isn't in Kroll either). Linnell has “unhurried”, from “slow, patient, calm.” Wu has “without haste”, Lau has “appears slack”, Chan has “not anxious about things”, Henricks has “to be at ease”. Lin has “without obvious design.” Cleary has “relaxed”. Feng & English have “seems to have no aim”.

⁸³⁸ Linnell, Wu, Lau, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Lin, Cleary, and Feng & English all have some form of wide-meshed.

Chapter 74

民不畏死

Common-people not fear/haunted/dreadful/frighten/shrink-from/awe-inducing death/finished

The common people are not haunted by death

奈何以死懼之

What-is-it-like?/why/how/what-ought-be-done by-means-of death timid/frighten/startle this/['s]

What can one do to frighten them by means of death?

若使民常畏死

Like cause/allow/dispatch/employ common-people constantly/persistently fear/haunted/dreadful death

If causing people to constantly be haunted by death,

而為奇者，吾得執而殺之⁸³⁹

And/yet use/do/act strange/rare/heterodox {person/phrase} I obtain seize/capture and kill this/['s]

And those doing strange things, I obtain by capture and kill them,

孰敢{矣}⁸⁴⁰

Who/which dare/bold/how-dare?

Who would dare?

常有司殺者殺

Constantly/persistently have/exist oversee/examine/supervise kill {people/phrase} kill

Constantly there exists a supervisor of killing, killing.

夫代司殺者⁸⁴¹

In-any-case replace/in-place-of/alternative/dynasty oversee/supervise kill {people/phrase}

In any case of replacing the supervisor of killing,

是謂代大匠斲

This called replace great craft/builder/build/artful chop/hew/carve-away/pare/sculpt/engrave/slice-off

This is called replacing the great craftsman to carve.

夫代大匠斲者

In-any-case replace/alternative big/great craft/builder/artful chop/sculpt/engrave/slice-off

In any case of replacing the great craftsman to carve,

希有不傷其手矣

Rare/sparse/dilute have/exist not wound/grieve-for/hurt their hands(?) [!]

Rarely exists one who does not injure their hands!

⁸³⁹ Mawangdui has 夫 after this, probably starting the next line?

⁸⁴⁰ Here, Mawangdui (B) has 若民(恆/常)且必畏死: As-if common-people constantly even/and/or/shall haunted-by death.

⁸⁴¹ In the Mawangdui, 殺 is here and not at the end of the line above.

Chapter 75

民之饑

Common-people ['s]/this famine/crop-failure/hunger

Common people's famine

以其上食稅之多

By-means-of their above/high/superior eat/consume/accept/feed tax/income/interest/lease ['s]/this many

Is through their superiors' many feedings and taxes.

是以饑

This by-means-of famine

Through this, there is famine.

民之難治

Common-people ['s]/this difficult govern/harness/control

The common people's difficulty in being governed,

以其上之有為

By-means-of their superior/above/high ['s]/this have/exist do/use/manipulate/serve-as

Is through their superiors' having manipulateness.

是以難治

This by-means-of difficult govern/harness/control

Through this, there is difficulty governing.

民之輕死

Common-people ['s]/this light/frivolous/superficial/shallow death/finished/inert

The common people's frivolous treatment of death,

以其求生之厚

By-means-of seek/solicit/search/explore/demand/beseech life/born ['s] thick/deep/authentic/rich/lavish

Is through searching for life's richness.

是以輕死

This by-means-of light/frivolous/superficial/shallow death/finished/inert

Through this, there is frivolous treatment of death

夫唯無以生為者

In-any-case only not/lack/without by-means-of life/born do/use/manipulate {person/phrase}

Only anyone not using by their lives,

是賢於貴生

This worthy/admirable in/at/from/regarding/than value/prized/expensive life/born

This is who is admirable in valuing life.⁸⁴²

⁸⁴² There are many differing translations of these last two lines. Linnell has "Now, only he who has no use for being alive is virtuous compared to he who values living." Wu has "The people have simply nothing to live upon! They know better than to value such a life!" Lau has "It is just because one has no use for life that one is wiser than the man who values life." Chan has "It is only those who do not seek after life that excel in making life valuable" (which subjectively I like more). Henricks has "Only those who do not act for the purpose of living, only these are superior to those who value life." Waley has "And indeed, in that their hearts are so little set on life they are superior to those who set store by life." Lin has "It is those who interfere not with their living that are wise in exalting life" (which I also like best). Cleary has "Only those who do not contrive to live are wise in valuing life". Feng & English have "Having little to live on, one knows better than to value life too much."

Chapter 76

人之生也柔弱

People ['s]/this life/born/create pliant/flexible/soft weak/frail

People's lives are bending and weak,⁸⁴³

其死也堅強

Their/its death/inert solid/hard/firm dominate/strong/forced/vigorous

Their deaths are solid and strong.

萬物草木⁸⁴⁴之生也柔脆

Ten-thousand things grass/plants wood/tree ['s]/this born/life pliant/bending brittle/delicate

The lives of ten-thousand things and woody plants are bending and delicate,

其死也枯槁

Their death withered/dried-up/decayed/hardened/haggard dried-out/desiccated/rotten/defunct

Their deaths are hardened and desiccated.

故堅強者死之徒

Thus hard/solid strong/dominate [person] death ['s] go-on-foot/pawn/conscript/in-vain

Therefore, hard and strong people are death's adherents,

柔弱生之徒

Pliant/flexible/soft weak/frail [person] life/born/create ['s]/this go-on-foot/colleague/disciple

Bending and weak people are life's adherents.

是以兵強則不勝

This by-means-of weapons/warfare strong/dominate when-then/rule not overcome/prevail

By means of this, when dominating through weapons, then one will not prevail

木強則兵

Tree/wood strong/forced/dominate when-then/rule weapon/warfare/military

When a tree is strong, then weapons (will strike it down).⁸⁴⁵

強大處下

Dominate/strong/forced great/big stays/reside/occupies below/low

The strong and great reside below,

柔弱處上

Pliant/flexible/soft weak/frail stays/reside/occupies above/high

The bending and weak reside above.

⁸⁴³ This is literally, "People's life/birth, it is pliant and weak", but invariably, this is translated as "When a person/man is born, [...]" The wide assumption is that we are talking about the state of people when they are alive: we bend and move, we can be hurt and damaged, but a corpse is rigid and hard to move, by rigor mortis (though rigor mortis is not permanent and does resolve). I am hesitant to believe that bodies are what are being talked about: life is flexible and tenuous, death is unyielding and final.

⁸⁴⁴ 草木 together can mean woody plants (like trees)

⁸⁴⁵ Clumsy translation, but 兵 is not often used as a verb

Chapter 77

天之道其猶張弓與

Heaven ['s]/this Dao, their/maybe similar-to/hesitant draw-bow/open-out bow
join/grant/is/it/not?

Heaven's Dao, isn't it like drawing a bow?

高者抑之

Tall/high [person/phrase] suppress/push-down/press-down/control/restrain ['s]/this

The high, they are pushed down,

下者舉之

Low/below/down [person/phrase] lift/raise/cultivate/undertake/expose/overcome ['s]/this

The low, they are lifted up.

有餘者損之

Has/exist remainder/surplus [person/phrase] decrease/reduce ['s]/this

The surplus, this is reduced.

不足者補之

Not sufficient/enough/leg [person/phrase], mend/repair/supplement/supply/benefit ['s]/this

The insufficient, this is supplemented.

天之道

Heaven ['s]/this Dao

Heaven's Dao

損有餘而補不足

Reduce exist/have surplus and/yet/but mend/repair/supplement not sufficient

Reduces the existing surplus but supplements the insufficient.

人之道則不然

People ['s]/this Dao/way when-then/rule/standard/conform-to not this-way/thus/burn

People's Way does not conform to this,

損不足以奉有餘

Reduce not sufficient by-means-of lift exist/has surplus

Reducing what is insufficient by means of lifting the existing surplus.

孰能有餘以⁸⁴⁶奉⁸⁴⁷天下

Who/which able/capable have/exist surplus/remainder by-means-of lift/raise heaven under

Who is capable of having a surplus by means of lifting up the world?

唯有道者

Only has/exist Dao [person/phrase]

Only someone who has the Dao.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage,

By means of this, the sage,

⁸⁴⁶ Mawangdui has 而 instead.

⁸⁴⁷ Mawangdui inserts 於 here (in, at, from, regarding, than)

為而不恃

Do/use/manipulate/act-as and/yet/but not confident/depending/relying

Doing but without being depended on

功成而不處

Completing accomplishments, and/yet not stay/reside/dwell

Completing accomplishments, but not dwelling in them.

其不欲見賢

Its/their not desire/expectation/craving see/look worthy/admirable

It is their not desiring to look admirable.

Chapter 78

天下莫柔弱於水

Heaven under in-no-case pliant/soft/bending weak/frail in/at/from/regarding/than water

Under heaven there is nothing so soft and weak as water

而攻堅強者

And/yet/but attack/strike/work-by-hitting solid/firm/hard strong/forced/dominate

And yet for attacking the solid and strong,

莫之能勝

No-one/in-no-case ['s]/this able/capable competent/overcome/prevail

Nothing is capable of overcoming this.

以其無以易之

By-means-of their/its lack by-means-of change/easy this

This is by means of its lack of a way to change this.⁸⁴⁸

弱之勝強, 柔之勝剛

Weak/frail ['s]/this prevail strong/forced, Soft/bending/pliant ['s]/this prevail rigid/unyielding

Weak's overcoming of strong, soft's overcoming of rigid,

天下莫不知, 莫能行

Heaven under no-one/in-no-case not know, No-one/in-no-case capable transmit/enact/engage

Under heaven there is no one who does not know it; none are able to enact it.

是以聖人云

This by-means-of sage says:

By means of this, the sage says:

受國之垢

Accept/receive/experience/suffer/tolerate/transmit/grant country/state ['s] dirt/filth/disgrace

Tolerate the country's filth and disgrace,

是謂社⁸⁴⁹稷{之}主

This called soil-god millet-god [['s]/this] ruler/king/host/dominant

This is called the ruler of alters to the gods of soil and millet.

受國{之}不祥

Accept/receive/suffer/tolerate country/state [['s]/this] not/no favorable-omen

Tolerate the country's unfavorable fates,

是謂天下{之}王

This called heaven under [['s]/this] king

This is called the king of the world.

正言若反

Correct/rectify/proper words/speech if/like turn-back/reverse/oppose/invert

Correct words are like the reverse.

⁸⁴⁸ This translation agrees with Waley and Cleary. Feng & English simply have "It has no equal." Lin has "For which there is no substitute," Chan, Lau, and Wu have similar, and Henricks has similar ("Because there is nothing you can use to replace it." – Biologically this is very true of water, haha!). Linnell, taking 無以 as "endlessly", translates "This is because it endlessly replaces itself."

⁸⁴⁹ 社 This is She, a word for tutelary earth deities, the gods of the soil (and millet), dating back to the early Zhou. This is also a word for the altars for these gods, or their festivals. 稷 means "foxtail millet" or "god of millet"

Chapter 79

和大怨

Harmony/balance/reconcile/comfortable great/big complaint/grudge/resent/hate

In reconciling a great resentment,

必有餘怨

Certainly have/exist more-than-enough/surplus/remainder complaint/grudge/resent/hate

Certainly there is remaining resentment.

安可以為善

Peace/stability/where/what/how(?) able/permissible/possible by-means-of do/use/act-as skilled/good

How can it be taken as good?⁸⁵⁰

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this the sage,

執左契

Seize/capture/grasp left contract/inscribe/carve-into-shell-or-bone/covenant/pact/cooperate/affection

Grasps the left side of a pact⁸⁵¹

而不責於人

And/but/yet not demand/exact/wrest-from/impose-on/blame in/at/from/regarding/than people

And yet does not make demands from people.

[故]有德司契

[Therefore] have/exist virtue/power oversee/supervise/inspect/examine contract/inscribe/cooperate

[Therefore] Having virtue oversees contracts,

無德司徹

Without/lack/no virtue/power oversee/examine/supervise penetrate/follow-through/complete/eliminate

Without virtue oversees the follow-through.⁸⁵²

天道無親

Heaven Dao/way not/lack/without parents/kin/intimate/close-to

Heavenly Dao is without close associations,

常與善人

Constantly/persistently grant/give/join skill/excellence/good people

Constantly joining excellent people.

⁸⁵⁰ While 安 can be used as a question word (and it is usually translated this way), this could, in theory, be “Peace can be used/be taken as good/skilled.” This is prioritizing 以為 (used as, taken as, made into) over 可以, to do the opposite, we end up with “How can this be used skillfully?” or “Peace can be used skillfully/excellently.”

⁸⁵¹ This is either the creditor or debtor side of a contract, but over time which was the left or right has changed.

⁸⁵² There is a lot of variation in how these lines are translated. Waley has “For he who has the ‘power’ [...] is the Grand Almoner, he who has not the ‘power’ is the Grand Perquisitor”, Lin has “the virtuous man is for patching up, the vicious is for fixing guilt, (Wu has similar)” Cleary has “So the virtuous sees to their promises, while the virtueless look after precedents.” Feng & English have “A man with virtue performs his part, but a man without virtue requires others to fulfill their obligations.” Chan has “Virtuous people attend to their left-hand portions, while those without virtue attend to other people’s mistakes,” Lau has “The man of virtue takes charge of the tally; the man of no virtue takes charge of the exaction,” Henricks has “Those who have virtue are in charge of the tally; those without virtue are in charge of taxes;” I think Henricks and Lau’s is the closest here to a transparent translation.

Chapter 80

小國寡民

Small/little country/state few/scanty/widow common-people

A small country with few people,

使有什伯之器而不用 •

Cause/allow have tenfold/miscellaneous chiefs⁸⁵³ ['s]/this instrument yet/and/but not employ/use

Allows having ten centurion's instruments and not employing them.

使民重死而不遠徙

Cause/allow common-people heavy/significant/grave/respect death yet not far shift/move

Allows people to have death weigh on them, and not moving far away.

雖有舟輿⁸⁵⁴無所乘之

Despite/even-though have boat/ship carriage lack/without/no that-which/place ascend/ride/use ['s]/this

Even though they have boats and carriages, they are without that which rides these.

雖有甲兵無所陳之

Despite/although have armor/shell weapons lack that-which/place arrange/announce/deploy ['s]/this

Even though they have armor and weapons, they are without that which deploys these.

使民復結繩而用之

Cause/allow common-people return/go-back knot/intertwine rope/string/cord and/yet employ ['s]/this

Allowing the people to return to knotting robes and employing these,

甘其食

Sweet/savory their food/eat/consume/take-in/nourish/raise

Find sweetness in their food,

美其服

Finest/beauty/lovely their undertake/submit-to/harness/garment/ingest

Find beauty in their garments,

安其居

Peace/quiet/stable their dwelling/residence

Find peace in their residences,

樂其俗

Glee/music their customs/popular/simple/worldly/vulgar/usual-actions

Find glee in their usual.

鄰國相望

Neighbor country/state each-other gaze-from-afar/look-up-to/estranged

Neighboring countries will look at each other from afar

雞犬之聲相聞

Chicken/fowl dog/canine ['s]/this sounds each-other hear

The sounds of chickens and dogs can hear each other⁸⁵⁵

民至老死,不相往來

Common-people arrive/reach old/wane/age/decay death/die, not each-other go/move come/approach

The common people grow old and die, never going away or approaching toward each other.

⁸⁵³ 什伯, together, can mean many, or can mean military divisions of ten and a hundred men. 伯 by itself can refer to a father's elder brother, or other titles for elders or lords.

⁸⁵⁴ Also vehicle/lift/menial/multitudes

⁸⁵⁵ The implication is that the livestock of one country can be heard in the others.

Chapter 81

信言不美

Trustworthy/reliable/faith words not beautiful/finest/lovely.

Trustworthy words are not the finest,

美言不信

Beautiful words not trustworthy/reliable/faith.

The finest words are not trustworthy.

善者不辯⁸⁵⁶

Good/benevolent/skilled [people] not argue/debate/quarrel/eloquence

People of skill do not debate,

辯者不善

Debating/Querulous/Eloquent [people] not good/skilled/benevolent

People of debate are not skilled.

知者不博⁸⁵⁷

Know [people] not broad/expansive/vast/universal/barter/exchange/purchase/gamble

People of knowing are not broad,

博者不知

Broad/expansive/vast/universal/barter/gamble [people] not know

People of broadness do not know.

聖人不積

Sage not pile-up-grain/heap/store-up/accumulate/collect/gather/entrenched/frequent/obstruct/block

The sages does not accumulate things,

既以爲人己愈有

Wholly/completely/just-after by-means-of do/act/use people themselves increasingly/heal have/exist

Completely by means of using⁸⁵⁸ the people, the sages themselves increasingly have.

既以與人己愈多

Wholly/totally by-means-of join//give/grant people themselves increasingly many/exceed

Completely by means of joining the people, the sages themselves increasingly accrue.

天之道利而不害

Heaven ['s]/this Dao benefit/sharp/smooth and/yet/but not harm/injure/abuse

Heaven's Dao benefits and does not harm,

聖人之道爲而不爭

Sage ['s]/this Dao do/use/manipulate and/yet/but not compete/contend/vie/quarrel

The sage's Dao is doing and not competing.

⁸⁵⁶ 辯 also refers to Confucian debate tactics, argumentation, (institutional) disputes

⁸⁵⁷ Linnell translates this as “learned”, and Wu, Henricks, Lau, Chan, Waley, Lin, and Feng & English also translate this as erudite or being highly learned/read, but Kroll does not list this as a possible meaning (encyclopedic, listed alongside all-inclusive, and universal, is the closest we get), though this is its meaning in Kanji. Cleary has “generalist”. LiuBo (六博) was a popular tactical and gambling game in the Warring States. Shuowen Jiezi has 大通 as the definition. I think Cleary’s “generalist” definition, given the primary meaning of extensive/vast/universal is most defensible, and leaves what-about to be sufficiently vague, not ruling out nor confirming “well-read”.

⁸⁵⁸ Consistent with my usage of 爲 in the translation. Usually, this has taken a meaning of “serving” or “acting for” or “living for” other people. 為 has many uses, more over time, so I could be wrong.

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- *郭店楚墓竹簡 (Chu Bamboo Slips from Guodian) (荊門市博物館 , Jingmen City Museum). Has clearer and sharper representations/scans of most of the characters in the Guodian – what this misses by darkened photography or spotty scanning tends to be covered in the version from DaoIsOpen for Laozi A, parts of B, and C, and Chinese Text Project for Laozi A.